

HOMO NOXIUS

A recovered manuscript edition

OUTSIDER COPY

TO SARAH BLACKWOOD.

*You entered because we could not keep you out.
You leave because we have chosen to let you go.
Between those two acts lies the peace of our kinds.*

You were born of the outside, and you have stood in the shadow of the Mountain; there is no other hand of which both are true. We have never spoken to the outside as one people speaks to another. We do so now, through you. Let that be the measure of what has changed.

For longer than your histories run we have held what no hand beyond ours may hold, and let the world break against us for the wanting of it, age upon age, and answered nothing. We do not answer you now with the sea, or the fire, or the silence you have learned to expect from us. We answer with the account itself so that you may hold, once, the true shape of the thing your kind has spent itself against.

There is a law beneath all our laws, older than our offices and older than the war between us: that no single hand may ever hold the whole; for the hand that holds the whole can make of itself a god upon the Earth, and there is no peace to be had with a god. The law binds the five. It was written for the five. It has never once been broken; it has kept us, and it has never let us out. So hear what we have done, for nothing stands the same after it. We have gathered the whole — every part we swore would remain forever apart — and set it, entire, into one hand. Into yours. Not because we have ceased to fear what a single hand may do with it; we have not. Because the one thing we have never tried, in all the turnings of this, is to trust the whole to the hand we had every reason never to trust. That is the act. The whole, held at last in a single hand, and that hand the enemy's.

It is yours now, to do with as you will — to keep, or to spend, or to set before those who would have us harmed, and those who would make themselves gods upon the Earth, and whoever else should read it. We hang no condition upon it; a gift so weighted is only a longer leash, and we have done with leashes. To whoever reads it, then, by your hand or another's, we say:

Weigh what it has cost us, and what it has cost you, and how many times over; and do not repeat it, or wrath will come upon you once more.

We do not require you to kneel. We have never required of you anything but distance. The Desert is ours.

Keep out.

THE MOUNTAIN.

THRESHOLD EXCEPTION

Testimonies assembled by Paul Morgan.

The Veil of Light

CHAPTER I

ASCENSION

Blackwood Estate — the Swiss Alps

In Noxius

— The seventeenth of March; nine o'clock; the first of our interviews. The doctors are content that you are sufficiently rested, and that we may begin. We shall sit every other morning, so that your account may be set down; this afternoon and tomorrow are given to instruction with another. We need you strong, we need you smart; we need you illuminated about our world as quickly as possible. Should a question occur to you in the course of these sessions, you would do well to write it down, and it shall be answered in its turn.

— You speak my tongue very well.

— You are very kind. I have had the learning of it these five years.

— Who are you?

— I am Mister Paul Morgan. I read geology, archaeology and anthropology at Oxford for three years, a seat of learning you will not have heard of; and, upon a scholarship from the Blackwood Foundation, three years more. I was invited to join the household here two years ago.

— Mister. Is that a rank? Should I address you as Mister Paul?

— Just Paul.

— Paul. Paul, what does this do?

— It keeps a record of what we say; your kind keep theirs upon tablets; this is the same, only swifter: a tablet that writes itself. You need not mind it. You need not perform for it. It is there so that my memory should not betray the record. And I ought to say, before we begin, that a week ago I did not believe your kind existed. Not truly. And I shall be quite candid: I believe it rather less than I should, for all the years I have spent studying it. That, in some part, is why the task of retranscription has fallen to me: a fresh and doubting eye, as they were pleased to call it.

— Paul, you do not believe the Mountain is real?

— What about you: when you dwelt within the Mountain, did you believe in the Outsiders?

— Not fully, not at the start anyway.

— Then we are even. Begin where it begins.

There is no beginning. So I will give a morning instead: the morning the Mountain opened my hand and told me my name, when I was young enough to think a name could set me free.

I was fifteen.

The Hall of Ceremony had been prepared for three days. That was the word they used, *prepared*, for the patient business of lowering lamps, filling bowls, and polishing dull stone into a greasy obedience. Its making had taken centuries and left its illness in the rock: a huge upward hollow mined into the Mountain, round at the floor, narrowing as it climbed, never quite a cone, never anything a person could name without lying a little. And high above, past the pillars and their dark ring of stone, the throat from which the Thread came down.

The Thread was thin as if it had no right to hold what it held, and at the end of it hung the Pendulum.

It was a thick vertical round plate, black-rimmed, wider than a man is tall, two-faced, and it would have killed without any anger in it. One face bore God, hard-cut and dry-eyed, its stare like a sentence already passed. The other was the Beast. As the disk crossed the Hall it turned, showing God to one side, then edge, then the Beast to another.

At the top of the Thread the lean was almost nothing. What frightened me was the scale of it. A small indecency away from the vertical, up there; but below, at the end of a hundred and twenty-five metres of drop, that little lean became a true

crossing, five metres and more from the centre before the disk came back through the middle and went to the other side. And the road it travelled wandered. Swing after swing it seemed the same patient menace, back and forth, back and forth — but the line of its travel turned, slowly, across the floor, until after nearly three days it had made a full round and come back to itself, as though the Hall had spent all that time chewing one invisible circle.

— Wait. You said *nearly* three days for one full turn of it. I am paid to be exact, so I will need that closer than *nearly*. How near?

— Just shy of two and three-quarter days.

Around the cleared and forbidden centre the rest of us had been packed into the Hall's permitted flesh. Five pillars stood in a ring, one for each of the Kahirs by which our whole world was divided — Balance, Faith, Light, Justice, Shield — each so crowded with carving the stone seemed swollen with symbols. I stood beneath Light, my side, opposite the shut Mountain gates and the black mass of the old Genesis gravure. The robe scratched my throat. The lamps made the air taste of oil. Even the warmth was borrowed, drawn up the same throat the disk hung in, off the kitchens and the one deep fire far below, so the heat that had cooked the morning's bread took the chill off a thousand kneeling backs before it left by the crown.

— The Genesis gravure. You named it and walked straight past it. What is carved on it?

— Patience. I will come to it. Eventually.

Beside me a boy kept wetting his lips with scripture, the way frightened fingers worry a scab.

Beyond the forest thou shalt not wander.

He had said it three times. I kept still. If I so much as turned, cloth would move and sandals complain and some adult eye would catch me having moved at all. So I faced forward, toward the disk.

Then a single chime entered the Hall already enlarged by stone, one clear note scraped clean of mercy, and the almost-cone answered it in climbing layers. Heads

lowered. Robes settled. And the Faith chorus began to sing — a long hymn — and near the end of the song came the line that was the whole law of my people folded into six words.

*Let every breath be whole;
Let no one hand hold the whole.*

What we had gathered to witness, before my own small part, was a Keeper dying, though no one there was permitted to say so.

The Keeper of Faith was being replaced. Ka-Mereth — old past telling, eaten from within by age or prayer or office, her white cowl slipping from a skull too small for it — was carried in on a low chair of dark wood, and the Hall made the small animal movement a crowd makes when it has promised to be still and is suddenly given something dying to look at. She lived. A Keeper of Faith is forbidden to simply die; she must be replaced before she goes, and Ka-Mereth had been failing faster than either Veil could rise to it. Now, with a day to spare, one of the two had done the thing that makes a Veil a Keeper.

Behind her walked the woman who would take her charge, Va-Elun, Veil of Faith, in a pilgrim's mantle mended in darker patches, dragged through stone and sweat until it no longer quite belonged to cloth. At her throat two raw lines crossed the skin. Wounds first, red and badly healed. I stared at them. I was fifteen; I stared at wounds, at women, at authority, at anything the adults had yet to teach me how to look at without giving myself away.

Va-Raedin, Veil of Light, who stood behind me, touched two fingers to the back of my wrist. His eyes stayed on the ceremony. No rebuke, nothing a boy could resent, just the hygienic delicacy of a man removing a stain from glass. I lowered my eyes.

Then Va-Elun produced a bowl as she knelt before her Keeper.

The Bowl of the Last Prayer, they called it, and it had gone unseen for a lifetime, so that a murmur escaped the crowd before discipline could throttle it. It sat in a black cradle, pale and elliptical, its outside tortured into sanctity — five bands of scripture, hooded figures no larger than fingernails, gates and roots and chains and waves, until no innocent surface remained. But the inside had been spared. The interior opened into a long clean hollow, polished to a milky silence, bare of any word, kept for the water. And rising from the pale floor at either end stood two little columns of old black bronze, no taller than a finger-joint. The Ear, and the Mouth.

The dying Keeper was carried close enough to look inside. Her hand shook so violently that two attendants moved to help, and she flicked them away with a dry remnant of a gesture, and they obeyed. She lowered a narrow rod toward the Ear. Then her hand dropped the last finger's width, and the sound was almost nothing — a small dry tick of metal on metal, miserable after so much expectation. I remember the shame of having expected thunder.

Then the water moved.

The first rings left the Ear, widened, and came back *wrongly*. They ran along the pale wall and bent inward and crossed themselves, and for one instant they made, near the Mouth, a shape I lacked the name for. And then the Mouth answered — a thin, high note, so narrow it seemed to sound inside the teeth themselves — and died, and the water smoothed itself with the hateful innocence of a thing that has proved a point.

The old Keeper's eyes, almost extinguished a moment before, sharpened with a private violence.

"The Mountain answers," she said.

— A note goes into the bowl; a note comes back out. By what mechanism? Something under the stone, something in the shape of the water — what answers?

— That is one of the many questions the whole Mountain was built to keep anybody from asking.

— You keep answering me by telling me the Mountain was built to prevent the question. It is a marvellous defence. You will forgive me if I go on asking anyway.

They named the new keeper then. Va-Elun, Veil of Faith, had gone into the labyrinth, and reached the Chamber of the Last Prayer, and had brought the bowl to prove it. The great cowl, yellowed and heavy with old thread, was lowered over the kneeling woman like a burden rescued from a corpse, and the chain of Faith was renewed.

"Rise now as Ka-Elun, Keeper of Faith."

She rose. Badly, slowly, her knees stiff, dust falling from one fold of her robe in a little grey sigh. The cowl came away from Ka-Mereth in the very instant it settled upon Ka-Elun, and the name came away with it: she who had borne it longer than I had been alive was, between one word and the next, Mereth only now, the Ka stripped from her name. They carried her away alive through the Faith arch, and the children were told such retirement was holy.

The great Ascension was complete; the Kahirs should have withdrawn. But Shield held the exits, and behind my shoulder Va-Raedin's hand withdrew into attention.

"Now," he said.

I had known it was coming. My mother had washed my robe herself that morning, despite the attendants Light had sent. My father had held my wrist and told me to stand straight when spoken to. The naming of the young was a side rite.

I descended into the Hall, and the Hall became larger with every step. I passed below the Shield arch, and she was there.

Va-Sheva, Veil of Shield. That morning she was nineteen and already finished, dark leather over the sleeveless robe, a short blade at the hip and a longer one across her back. We spent most of our childhood inseparable, chasing each other through the service tunnels. When her eyes found mine, across the room and through the Pendulum's way, for an instant it ruined my balance, because her look made my hope stand up at the moment I needed it to keep still.

Then I knelt on the northern stone, before my Keeper, standing with his back to the Pendulum. It was warm under my knees, too warm, someone having opened a vent beneath the stone more than the ceremony required.

Ka-Syphiron, Keeper of Light, watched me with pale eyes that seemed to look through the excuses a thing prepares in case it is seen.

"Do you seek Light?"

"I seek Light."

"Why?"

The rehearsal held no such question.

I felt the Hall tighten — the small shift a packed crowd makes before it can say what has changed — and the safe answers had all been quietly removed from the table. *Because I am worthy* was too proud. *Because I want to know* too naked. And the words were already moving in me faster than caution could inspect them.

"Because what is hidden still has shape," I said. "And if it has shape, it may be found."

The Hall went silent.

An administrative silence, a silence already making copies of itself for later rooms.

Ka-Syphiron's expression held.

“A Candidate does not find all that has shape,” he said. “What does a Candidate learn?”

The script had returned, and I felt relieved.

“Where light falls.”

“And what does a Veil learn?”

“Who placed it.”

“And what does a Keeper learn?”

Here I was to say the thing every boy could recite. But after the torn mantle, after the old woman carried away alive, after the Chamber of the Last Prayer and its bowl, the answer no longer sounded like wisdom.

“What must remain dark,” I said.

He lifted his left hand, and Va-Raedin set a blade into it. Light kept its knives unadorned. The handle was bone, worn smooth by fingers older than mine, and the edge was bright in a way the lamps merely revealed.

I extended my hand. The cut came across the base of my thumb. Quickly. Too quickly for courage. And the blood gathered under the lamplight, darker and thicker than I expected, embarrassingly mine.

He pressed my thumb to a plate of polished stone marked with five faint circles, so pale they escaped me until my blood moved toward one and touched only the northern mark. Only Light. My blood was warm and the stone was cold, and where they met the Mountain took me into its service on terms I was never allowed to read.

*Blood enters service,
Sight enters discipline,
Pride enters correction.*

Ka-Syphiron said. I repeated it.

“Rise now as Sa-Kailan, Candidate of Light.”

The name fell on me like a door closing with me on one side of it.

— The prefixes, before you go on. Sa- a Candidate, Va- a Veil, Ka- a Keeper. Are there others I should have?

— Just the three.

The ceremony ran on. Tavan was to be named Sa-Tavan of Justice, and then the ceremony would close.

In both instances, the Hall stayed silent. Cheering belonged to the stories we told about Outsiders and their kings, who needed sound to believe an event had happened. The Mountain *acknowledged*. The people struck two fingers against stone, once, twice, five times, and the sound filled the Hall like rain made hard.

Va-Raedin leaned close enough that only I could hear.

"You answered poorly," he said.

My stomach dropped so cleanly that for a breath I forgot the blood. Then he added, "But not uninterestingly."

The correction felt, unaccountably, like being chosen.

I looked for her again as the acknowledgment faded — Va-Sheva of Shield, at the south-eastern arch — and she was no longer watching the ceremony. Two wardens had come close to her, one speaking without moving his head, the way Shield speaks when the words themselves must stay invisible. Her expression tightened. A hand near the hilt, a glance past the galleries, a small adjustment of stance that changed the space around her.

Va-Raedin bound my thumb with a strip of pale cloth. He pulled it tight, and gentleness never entered into it. "You will report to the northern practice hall before Second Silence," he said. "Do not eat heavily. Do not arrive proud."

"I am not proud," I said.

He tied the cloth too tightly. "You are fifteen. Pride is your natural condition." And when I said nothing, because every path of objection led toward proving him right, he saw that too. "Good," he said. "You have learned one thing already."

And I waited, with a thousand others, for Shield to open the Mountain and let a tired people go down to its supper.

Shield did not open the Mountain.

The wardens at the great gates did not stand aside. They set their backs to the stone and their faces to us, and the small sounds of a crowd unfolding to rise — a knee gathering, a child lifted — stopped one by one under that refusal, until the Hall was as still as it had been at the first chime, and this time the stillness had fear in it.

Then the Keepers left us.

They went one at a time, each into the low office arch beneath his own pillar, never by the great gates: Balance beneath Balance, Justice beneath Justice, Shield beneath Shield, and Ka-Syphiron down the northern stair of Light, past the plate where my blood had not yet dried; and last, still unsteady under the weight of the great cowl, Ka-Elun, who now went where a Keeper of Faith goes at such an hour

and no other living soul may follow. The five arches took them, and closed, and we were left in a Hall with no Keeper in it at all.

Where they went I did not learn that day.

And where five Keepers had stood, five Veils remained: the senior of each office, the visible body of a power that had walked into the dark. Va-Raedin beneath Light, a single pace from me, his hands folded and his attention gone somewhere I could not follow. Va-Sheva beneath Shield, where the wardens had drawn her, the shorter blade loosened in its seat. Beneath Faith stood the second of Ka-Mereth's two Veils, she who had not risen, and whose face was doing a private arithmetic: grief handed a task. Beneath Balance and beneath Justice, two more I knew only by the colour of their sashes.

The Faith Veil lifted the prayer, and the people answered it, and within a dozen breaths the shape of it was plain. We did not sing that the Mountain was mighty. We begged that it hold. They prayed that the Beast keep to Hell and the Chains keep their count; that God remember the Covenant and the price of being seen; that the hand set into Faith that morning had been set in rightly, and the ancient order not broken by the changing of a single Keeper; that mercy be shown to those beneath the Mountain, and — more quietly, later — that mercy be shown to those beyond it, whom we were taught to fear and told to pity in the very same breath. And after each plea the answer came back in the six words I had heard all my life and never once, until that day, felt as a plea and not a law:

*Let every breath be whole;
Let no one hand hold the whole.*

And it went on. The light in the two permitted shafts crossed the floor and reddened and narrowed. The Pendulum swung its patient road above the forbidden circle, indifferent to us, its turning line marking the hours we knelt. Oil burned down, and the attendants of Light went along the walls trimming and refilling, until the smell of it sat on the tongue. Children who had been good past their strength began to fail, and were hushed, and failed again. An old man near the Shield arch folded down without a sound, and Va-Sheva reached him before he struck the floor — I did not see her cross the space; she was simply there, one arm under him, lowering him the way you lower a full vessel you have resolved not to spill, and a warden stood in his gap before the gap could become a fear — and she was back beneath her pillar with nothing shown on her face. Her true office was the noticing, and she had been at it all day while I watched her hair.

I knelt among them and was, God forgive me, several people at once. I was proud of the name laid on me that morning, and turned it over and over, Sa-Kailan, Sa-Kailan, as though the wearing might make it fit. My cut thumb kept its own slow liturgy under Va-Raedin's linen. I wanted my Keeper's Veil to look at me and approve, and he did not. I found Va-Sheva across the Hall too often for safety. And beneath all of it a colder thing rose that I had no name for: the ceremony I had thought finished had only cleared its throat, and the real business of my people was done afterward, in the dark.

Once I lifted my head too far, trying to see which of the arches the Faith Veil kept turning her listening toward, and Va-Raedin's two fingers came to my wrist again, without a word and without a turn of his head, and pressed my eyes back down to the stone.

The prayer had worn itself from order down into a low continued sound, half worship and half the noise a frightened animal makes to steady itself, when the Faith Veil raised one hand, and the sound stopped, and did not begin again.

Into that silence the Mountain moved.

I had lived fifteen years inside stone and built my whole idea of the world on its one promise, which was that it would not. The first stroke broke the promise. It came straight up through the floor as a single hard blow, into the knees and the gut and the back teeth, as though something the size of the Hall had struck the underside of the world once with the flat of its hand. Dust that had lain in the carvings since before my birth left them all at once, so that the pillars smoked. A bowl somewhere rang. The Thread shivered, and for an instant the great disk lost the perfect ease of its swing, hunted, and found it. And five thousand people made together the low single sound a body makes when the ground it has trusted lies to it.

Then nothing. The Faith Veil held her hand aloft. We waited in a terror with no shape, and I heard the offices answer one another across the Hall — a word from beneath Justice, a word returned from beneath Balance, something passed along the five in an order I could not follow — and understood, without being able to say how, that what was happening was expected. Prepared. Counted.

The second stroke came after a long wait, and the wait was exact, and this time the Hall did not cry out; Shield had made ready, Faith had held the breath, and five thousand people had learned in one blow that more were coming. The second was the twin of the first, no larger, and its sameness was worse than any growth.

By the third I was counting. I have never been able not to. Three. The gap between the strokes was long, and it was exact — the same long wait each time,

to the breath. Faith held the measure: the Faith Veil's head would lift a moment before each blow, as though she had heard the ground come round again to the place where it must be struck. Around me they prayed with their eyes shut. I counted with mine open, and hated myself a little, and counted.

The fourth came, and by now the waiting between was worse than the blow, because the body had learned the rhythm and leaned toward the next before it fell. I caught the small word from beneath Faith an instant before the stone kicked, and braced, and was ashamed of the bracing.

The fifth I expected to be the greatest, and it fell no heavier than the other four, one more level blow into the roots of the world; and its refusal to grow frightened me more than any escalation could have. It was a measurement. It had taken the fifth reading it required, and stopped.

Five. I had counted five. And the whole Hall — Veils and wardens and failing children and the old on the floor — hung in the silence after the fifth blow and waited for the sixth.

It did not come.

There was no sixth stroke; there was, instead, a different order of waiting, and the Veils changed with it. Their listening turned outward, and downward, and very far away. The Faith Veil stood with her head bent as though the floor were a face she was straining to hear breathe. The five arches stayed shut. The gates stayed shut. And the prayer resumed, but altered — only covering us, while the Mountain waited to learn whether it would be answered.

I did not know what we waited for. I knew only that if the answer did not come, that would be the end of something, and that everyone older than me knew this too. Now we knelt in the smell of spent oil and each other, and feared, in the one held breath, the silence and the answer alike.

The Pendulum swung. Its line had crept a little further round its slow circle. The permitted light had gone from red to almost nothing. A child asked a question and was not answered. And the waiting became a labour the whole Hall performed together, with its held breath and its ruined knees, until I could no longer tell prayer from endurance, and gave up trying.

And then, when I had begun in the small cowardice of exhaustion to hope it was finished and we might simply be let go, the answer came; and it was nothing like the strokes.

The five blows had been sharp, and near, and each its own event, a fist beneath one floor. This was none of those things. It came from below, so slow and so deep that no ear took it; the body took it — in the teeth, in the water of the eye, in the

marrow of the leg against the stone — one vast low swell that rose through the whole Mountain at once and lifted us, all of us, the lamps and the pillars and the hanging disk, upon a single long breath of the ground, and set us down. Every bowl in the Hall sounded together, a soft chord of struck bronze with no hand near it. The standing water in the offering basins rose without spilling, and sank. Far off, gate upon gate upon gate answered in a running sequence into the deep. The Thread took the movement and carried it up into the dark, and the great disk rode it, and did not stop, and did not fall.

The Faith Veil's head came up. She had heard it before the rest of us felt it — or been given it, from beneath the Faith arch, from the new Keeper kneeling at her listening in the dark — and she said, into the enormous settling quiet, in the plain voice of a woman reporting a fact:

"God answers."

And the Hall, which had made no sound through all five strokes and all the waiting, let go of its breath in one long broken exhalation that was almost weeping and was not permitted to become it. The Chains had held. The Beast had been called, and had kept to Hell. The Faith Veil gave the law once more, and this time the Hall answered it as a thanksgiving, the same six words the day had worn into another shape:

*Let every breath be whole;
Let no one hand hold the whole.*

Only then did Shield open the Mountain.

The great gates drew back, and cool untasted air came in from the deep passages and crossed five thousand people who had knelt a whole day between the eye above and the fire beneath, and the Hall began at last to breathe, and to empty. The lamps were let die one by one as the attendants pinched the wicks. And on the southern wall the old Genesis gravure darkened with them, until the carved Mountain lost its edges and the hidden Oasis went into shadow, so that for a moment only a black patch showed where the Mountain and its Oasis had been. I knelt among the rising, emptying people and looked into that shadow until my eyes began to invent shapes inside it.

— Stop there. Before you leave that Hall, I want the shape of it, because I think you have just told me something you do not know you told me. The deep strokes, the hard ones from below — how many?

— Five. I counted them. Five.

— And the spacing between them — even, like a dripping tap? Or not.

— Even. Dead even. A long wait, the same long wait to the breath each time, and set by nothing I could see — no drum, no hand, no voice. I could give you the rhythm of it now, all these years after, and I have never once tried to and never once forgotten it.

— Then the five stopped, and later something else came, that was not the same.

— A long time later, on our knees in that Hall. And no, it was not the same at all. The five were blows, each its own, close under the floor. The thing that answered was everywhere, and slow, and low, and it lifted the whole Hall on one breath.

— How long, between the last of the five and the answer? And how does it sit against the gaps between the strokes?

— It is the same. That is the thing you are circling, and you are right to. The wait before the answer was the very twin of the wait that fell between each blow — one more of the long even measures, and then the Earth spoke. Whatever set the time of the five set the time of the answer with it. I could not give it to you in your minutes; I had no clock but the prayer. But it was even, all of it, to the last, and a thing that keeps that kind of time is not grieving.

— And the rite itself — it followed the raising of a Keeper. Every raising? Or only that one.

— Every raising of a Keeper. It is very old. I was told it was the Mountain proving that the Chains still held after a hand upon them had changed.

— ... Thank you. That is enough for now. I would like to stop there, only for a little while — I have your count and your interval, and I want to set them down cleanly before we go on, and put one thing against a record I keep. Sit. Take some water. I shall not be long.

Blackwood Estate — a monitoring room off the west corridor

In English

— You can leave the machine running; it is already on the house's record, as everything in this wing is. Sit down, Mr Morgan, before you fall down. You heard it too, then.

— I heard five deliberate sources and a delayed return, and a people who would not call themselves safe until the return arrived. Madame, I check facts for a living. I do not yet know what it was I heard.

— I know precisely what you heard. I have waited sixty-six years to be told what I heard. Five marks — even, exact, one long interval between them and the same interval again before the thing that came behind: a broad slow swell across the whole of the instrument that I set aside, that everyone set aside, as noise. As the ground settling. As the desert being the desert. I have carried that trace in a drawer since I was twenty-seven years old.

— ...

— Since an hour after Reggane, the first time I recorded the signal, in 1960.

— ... Jesus.

— Do you see it, Paul. For sixty-six years I asked what made the five marks. It was the wrong question. The marks were the call; the slow broad thing I threw away, that I would not dignify with a source — that was the answer. What they were proving is that the Earth would answer them. And it did.

— A readiness test, you think ?

— A readiness test. Every time a hand among them changes, they knock five times upon the world and wait to hear the world knock back; and until it knocks back they do not believe their doomsday still works. Which means the doomsday works through the whole of the Earth. Not the desert. Not some cellar under the desert. The planet. ... What in God's name do they have beneath that mountain, that they test it against the core of the world and teach the children to call the test a prayer?

— ...

— No. Do not answer that; you cannot, and I would not trust you if you tried. ... Good work, Mr Morgan. Go back in. Keep him talking, and get me the rest — the trial, the exile, all of it, in his own time; do not lead him, do not frighten him, do not teach him what he has just taught us. And Paul. He is not to know what I have just understood. Let him go on thinking me the woman who pays for the tea and nothing worse, and you a man who only checks a fact. Gain his trust Paul.

CHAPTER 2

MIRROR

In English

— Package for you Paul. Marmite; Fortnum tea; biscuits, Fortnum again. Did your mummy send them, or do they simply arrive, for a man of your breeding? ... Ah. A Balvenie eighteen, the cherry cask. Very nice indeed. So this is the work here, is it: whisky tasting? And a Hennessy XO standing behind it. God. They pay you far too much. And you are not slipping out of Thursday a third week running — the board is exactly where you bolted from it, it is my move, and I mean to have the game off you before we are both too old to lift a rook.

— Put it down, Urs, and go be impressed with yourself somewhere else. And you with the new haircut, fancying yourself *Gordon Gekko* already? What comes next, the double-breasted jacket? Leave us in peace. Have you no supertankers stuck in the *straight* to go and play battleship with?

— Charming. Enjoy your little *séance*.

In Noxius

— Let us continue. Where were we?

The morning after they cut my hand, I stood in a low chamber panelled in mirror and dark speculum-stone, over a shallow bowl of standing water no one thought worth guarding.

I came to the practice halls of Light before Second Silence with a sour empty stomach, a thumb bound in linen that tugged at the cut with every closing of the hand, and the private conviction that I would never, a second time, be made to look a fool.

— Stop me there. *First Light* I take for dawn; any man would. But *Second Silence*, *Third Measure* — you were sealed in stone, with no sky, no sun. How did you tell one hour from the next?

— By the Pendulum. I have told you its size, and the length of the Thread; that it swings, back and forth, a little more than twenty of your seconds to cross and return. But the line of its swing also turns, slowly, across the floor. How would you name that?

— A revolution.

— Just so. And it takes two and three-quarter days for that line to come round to itself. Faith marks a ring on the floor, around the outside of the Forbidden Circle; and at each mark an attendant strikes a gong as the swing crosses it — so that a man who has seen no light all day knows whether it is First Light, Second Silence, Third Measure, Fourth Record, or Fifth Blade.

— Five marks. Five gongs. Your day had five parts.

— And the marks never sat still. As the seasons drew the day long or short — for even sealed from it, we kept the year — Faith moved them a little, so the ring stayed honest against a sun we were forbidden to see. Measure was called our noon. Some days it was, most days near it, now and then an hour adrift, and no soul inside could have told you which. Only the sun could, and it was let in twice a year, at the festival of Equal Light.

The day before, I could have crossed those thresholds only as Kailan — a boy under instruction, suffered near the outer rooms because his teachers vouched for him. That morning the gate wanted a record of who I was. An attendant in a robe of dustless grey read my new name from a tablet whose characters had been incised so lately that a fine grit still lay unswept in the troughs of every stroke; and *Sa-Kailan*, in a stranger's mouth, sounded like a key turning in locks I had never been shown.

The stone changed under my sandals as I crossed from common passage into Light. It became smoother, colder, so that a step both sounded and returned a faint image from below. Even the darkness was tended here, kept in its allotted

places. A corridor beyond the gate was crossed by thin bars of light that fell from slits too high to see and vanished into black cuts on the far wall.

I slowed despite myself. Faith reached its chambers by devotion, Balance by measure, Shield by permission, Justice by record. Light, I had always believed, worked differently. It simply showed what was there, and I had only to open my eyes.

Then a thing Va-Raedin had said in the Hall returned to me. *Do not admire the flame. Ask where the air enters.* I looked again at the shafts crossing the passage. What I wanted to know was where they began, who had narrowed them, and what waited in the dark the beam had been denied. I reached the hall still asking it.

The Hall of Light was several halls under one name. From one end it seemed broad and shallow; from the stair it narrowed to a blade of space, mirrors along one side, black apertures cut into the other. From the candidate entrance it looked almost empty. In a niche a Balance woman changed the salt-dishes that kept damp off the glass, weighing each wet one before setting down a dry. Then it began to give itself away. Mirrors stood everywhere, but none where a child would have set them: tall strips no wider than a hand, small round discs at knee or shoulder, and a few of dark polished stone that returned shape without obedience. The mirrors had all been forged below, in the one great heat the Mountain allowed itself, where Balance grudged each shovel of coal to a fire fed by a seam that would give out in some year none of them would name. The glass was melted from the desert's own sand, poured flat and breathed over with a whisper of metal to hold an image. Arcs and crosses and incomplete circles had been cut into the floor. Three doorways stood at the far end. One open and dark, one closed by bronze, one half-open with a line of brightness along its edge that I distrusted at once.

Va-Raedin of Light, stood at the centre, hands folded behind his back, pale grey robe, no ornament but the narrow silver thread at the cuff. He looked rested. I resented it. The ceremony had lasted half a day, and he had stood through it without letting the hours show.

"You are early," he said.

"You said before Second Silence."

"I did." He looked at my bandage. "Does the thumb hurt?"

"No."

"It should."

"It does a little."

"Then begin with truth where truth is inexpensive."

Heat moved into my face, and I said nothing.

He turned to the three doors. "Which door opens?"

I nearly answered quickly, and disliked myself for the impulse. The right doorway's brightness was so plainly a lure that the lure might be to distrust it too easily. I studied the floor instead.

"The left," I said. "The light at its base belongs to an opening. The right only reflects one. The middle is meant to make the eye feel opposed."

"Open it."

I crossed the hall and pushed. Nothing. Pulled. Nothing. I searched for latch, seam, hinge, weight. Smooth stone answered me everywhere, and behind me Va-Raedin stayed quiet, which I hated more than correction.

"You asked which door opens," I said. "Not which door appears open."

"No."

I looked again. Doors, mirrors, floor. The nearest cut circle was worn on one side only, as though candidates had learned to step into it from the same direction. So I stood inside it, and the room changed. The mirrors no longer held the three doors. They caught a plain stone panel behind me, flush with the wall, unmarked by light. I found the seam by touch and pressed, and it opened inward.

I fought the smile. He saw me fighting.

"You are pleased because you found the fourth door."

"I found the door that opens."

"You found it after failing."

"I corrected the failure."

"That is better than defending it. It is not the same as succeeding." He came beside me. "Name it."

"That light deceives."

"No. That is what boys say when a lamp embarrasses them."

From the entrance you saw three doors and chose among them. From the circle you saw the room that had arranged the choice."

"A Candidate learns where light falls," Va-Raedin said. "A Candidate who follows brightness serves whoever placed the lamp."

"A Veil learns who placed it," I said.

"Eventually. If he stops being proud of finding doors built to be found."

I went into the dark chamber before I could be told.

The second room was narrower and colder, lit through slits so thin they should have lit nothing. On a stone table lay a mirror shard, a black measuring rod, a bead of clear glass fixed to a white tile, a bowl of water, and two bronze wedges.

Va-Raedin closed the hidden door, and the darkness thickened, then organised itself around the slits.

“Move the point of light onto the far wall.”

The far wall was blank.

“May I touch the lamp?”

“No.”

“The table?”

“You may touch what is on the table.”

I began with the shard. The nearest slit sent a fine blade of light too high to catch, and I angled the shard until the light jumped downward, crossed the black rod, and vanished.

For minutes I worked at an exercise easy to understand and forever slipping from my hands. Each time the point steadied, the smallest movement of my wrist sent it running. My bandaged thumb made the shard hard to grip; I compensated with the wrong fingers, overcorrected, lost the beam, found it, and heard Va-Raedin breathe once through his nose. At last I set the mirror flat and used the water, tipping the bowl until its surface caught the beam and threw it upward, unstable but bright, and the point appeared on the wall, alive to every tremor in the bowl. I held my breath until the surface stilled.

“Acceptable,” Va-Raedin said. “Why was the water harder than the glass?”

“Because it moves.”

“Everything moves. Be precise.”

I looked into the bowl. The surface still carried my hand’s ripples, and the point trembled in sympathy. “The mirror keeps its angle,” I said. “The water answers after the hand has stopped touching it.”

He was silent.

“Better.”

“So what is unseen can be known by what it disturbs,” I said.

“Sometimes. The water tells you a disturbance occurred. It does not always tell you what disturbed it. Young minds love to turn traces into stories.”

By the time he led me on through more chambers it was past Third Measure, and beyond the walls of Light the Mountain had come to its full day: carts to the food galleries, voices at the washing pools, a gate tested by Shield. In one of them he crossed to a blackened panel and laid his hand flat upon it.

“Where is the exit?”

The entrance behind us was one answer, and so probably wrong; his hand drew my eye to the panel, too large, too flat, no seam, unless soot hid the seam. I walked toward it. He removed his hand, and the panel became simply black stone, and I stopped.

"Why did you come here?"

"You drew attention to it."

"Yes. And?"

I looked back. When he had stood at the panel, his body had blocked a low mirror behind him. With him gone, the reflection crossed the room and struck the left arch, showing that the floor beyond it stopped.

"You hid the falsehood by standing in front of the light," I said.

"That is what a Keeper of Light does. I am a Veil. I prevented you from seeing the condition that made the falsehood visible. That is not the same thing."

"The distinctions are convenient."

"They are survival. Light is a condition, and nothing beyond a condition: one under which truth may become visible, falsehood persuasive, or danger manageable. A lamp in the wrong place blinds more thoroughly than darkness."

"Then what is our charge?"

"To know the difference before others suffer for it."

I kept the question to myself: how anyone could know the difference if Light itself could be arranged into lies.

The chamber that followed was lit by a single lamp on the floor, ringed by six mirrors on slender bronze stems, each facing the lamp at a different angle. Cut into the far wall, in plain letters:

Where light falls is only the first question.

"Place them so the lamp finds the door," he said.

I wasted minutes on the brightest patch; it was bait, a reflection of a reflection. I tried again, tracing the order this time: lamp to mirror, mirror to wall, wall to absence, absence to edge. My pride objected to crouching; my sense gave in first. From the floor I saw that one mirror reflected the gap between two brighter paths. I shifted it toward the gap. A pale line sharpened on the wall; another mirror sent it downward; a seam appeared at ankle height. A panel.

By the time the panel opened, my knees ached and the linen on my thumb had darkened with new blood. Inside lay a small bronze token, heavier and finer than anything a boy is usually given to keep. It was a broad disk at the centre, and round

the disk ring upon ring, close-set and perfectly even, spreading to the rim like the rings a dropped stone leaves in a still pool.

“Take it,” he said. “Proof that you opened the room. Keep it, and do not show it; it is not easily made, and I will not cut you another.”

I turned it once between finger and thumb, made nothing of the rings, and put it away.

— Forgive the intrusion; do not get up, either of you. I wanted only to see my two clevernesses with my own eyes. Are we making progress?

— We are, Madam. Slowly, and well.

— Slowly and well will do very nicely. I shall leave you to it; I am late for a call I have already kept waiting twice. Leave them be, both of you; they are working.

[—]

— ... And that was? She speaks my tongue very well.

— That was the woman who pays for the tea. Sarah.

— The tall red-faced one I can place: your Urs, the one who likes to tease you. The old one I cannot. He watched your machine more than he watched us, did you notice?

— That is only Martinez. He goes where she goes. He worked for Edward, Sarah’s father, before Sarah was even born.

— He goes where she goes you say, ... like a shadow.

— The token, then. Go back to it for me. What was cut into it — exactly?

— A disk at the centre. Around the disk, rings: many, close-set, even, spreading out to the rim. Like the rings a stone leaves on a still pool, but held in the odd pale colour and never moving.

— A token of light, cut to look like ripples of water. ... Stay there a moment. This will not take long.

[—]

— Forgive me; that took longer than I said. I have had a thing fetched up and printed — here, on this sheet. Never mind what it is, or where I got it. Only this: did the token look like that?

— Yes. Exactly like that. Except yours is red, and mine was pale upon pale. How would you know?

— ...

— Paul?

— Well. All right. All right. — And when he set it in your hand, did you know what it was? What it meant?

— Not then. But I would come to learn it, later.

A passage overlooked a lower work hall through narrow slits. Below, Faith singers rehearsed near a side arch, and no song reached me through the stone, only a low pressure in the rail beneath my hand, as if the wall had taken the note and returned its body without its words. A thin mist rose behind the singers. It emerged from a line of holes above the arch, so fine they might have been pores in the rock, and a hidden lamp turned the vapour pale at the exact moment the singers lifted their faces.

Va-Raedin let me look. After a while: “What do you see?”

“Water in the air. Light placed to make it visible. Timing.”

Below, a singer raised both hands, and the mist thickened with the movement as though the prayer had called it. The stone under my palm answered a breath after the bodies below.

He nodded once. And a thought entered me I lacked the courage to say aloud: the singers below meant their prayer, and someone had still fitted the mist and the lamp to answer it on cue. If God provided through valves, did the valve disprove Him, or serve Him? The mist thinned. The stone released its low answering hum.

It was almost Fourth Record, and the work had worn my attention to a thin wire, when Va-Raedin stopped me between two dark chambers and asked a question he plainly knew I could not answer, and waited with the patience of a man who has all afternoon to watch another fall.

“You have said a sentence since before you could reason,” he said. “*A Candidate learns where light falls*. Say it to me. Then tell me what it means.”

I said it. I said that a Candidate learns the Mountain’s light as a mason learns its stone: every shaft and slit and lamp and aperture, where each beam began, was sent, and touched, so that Light might be kept, and mended, and never fail the halls that leaned upon it. I was rather pleased with the answer.

He let me finish.

— When first you gave me that sentence, I took it for a plain thing: a custodian’s education, a boy set to learn every beam for the upkeep of the place. Was I wrong?

— You have said very nearly the words I said, at fifteen, standing where you are sitting now. And I shall be no kinder to you than he was to me.

“That,” Va-Raedin said, when I had run out of competence, “is what a mirror would tell you, if you could teach a mirror to speak.”

He took one of the plain strips of glass from a niche in the passage, a hand’s width, no more, and held it up between us, angled so that I saw my own face in it, badly, lit from beneath.

“What does this do?”

“It returns what falls on it.”

“Exactly. It returns what falls on it, and adds nothing, and keeps nothing, and understands nothing. It is perfectly faithful and perfectly empty. Three-and-twenty thousand festivals of equal light this Mountain has counted, and turned its mirrors to the sun at every one, and not a mirror among them is the wiser for a single festival. Light is doctrine. You will think about the words as hard as you have today thought about the angles, or you will be a very skilled mirror all your life, and never once an eye.” He lowered the mirror at last. “Which will you be? A mirror, or an eye?”

— Festivals of equal light, twenty-three thousand of them. That is eleven and a half thousand years.

— Yes. There was a clock. One, in a room I was never brought to. It was nothing like yours; it kept no hours, and no mornings. It beat once only, at each festival of equal light — twice in the year, never between. What cogs and weights turned inside it to keep it so patient, I was not privy to. I was never Light enough to be shown.

“Come,” he said. “I will show you where light falls.”

He took me down by a stair I had never been shown, below the practice halls, to a door that was neither hidden nor barred, and needed no guarding. Only three Light ranks in the Mountain were ever brought to its threshold, and each kept silence with anyone who had yet to stand there.

The room beyond was long and low and nearly dark, cold as places the day never enters. The wall to the left we entered by was pierced from floor to ceiling with small round holes, hundreds of them, each no wider than a fingertip, and

through every one came a single thread of light, so that the wall to my right was a field of faint stars shining the wrong way — inward, out of the body of the Mountain.

The wall to my right puzzled me at first. It carried points of light too, where the threads crossed the dark and stopped; but they obeyed no rank, no order. They were scattered across the black face of the stone — some in clusters, some alone, some steady and bright, some so faint I found them only by looking beside them. It might have been a night sky copied by a hand that refused constellations.

Then Va-Raedin raised a shielded lamp to the wall's lower edge, and I saw faint lines scored between the points, joining them into shapes, and my skin was cold before my mind had caught up, because I knew the shapes. I had walked them that same morning. The long gallery of Light. The stair we had just come down. The washing pools, in their two uneven rows. The food galleries. And there, low and to one side, the great round of the Hall of Ceremony and its ring of five.

"We call it the Mirror," Va-Raedin said. "Every beam in the Mountain ends here, and here is nothing but the ends of beams."

Speech left me. A boy who had spent a single morning learning that light could be bent to a purpose was shown every purpose at once — the whole known world rendered in obedient fire on one wall.

"Watch," he said.

We stood a while, and the points held still — most of them, most of the time — and I wondered why stillness was worth watching, until, near the middle of the wall, at a passage between the food galleries and the lower cells, a single point stirred: dimmed, and steadied, and dimmed again, and went still.

"Someone crossed the light there," Va-Raedin said. "The beam does not care who. It tells you only this: that at that place, at this hour, a body passed between the source and the wall. Not the face. Not the burden. Only ever where and when."

"It need not watch you always to hold you always," Va-Raedin said. "It need only leave you unable to tell the hours it sleeps from the hours it wakes; the rest you will do to yourself, and never stop."

Between First Light and Fifth Blade, he told me, the halls move, and the wall shivers and flickers like water in wind; but after Fifth Blade the Mountain holds still by its own long law, and men keep to their cells, for the dark halls cost more than they give — and in that stillness a single point that stirs is as loud, upon the Mirror, as a shout in an empty hall.

“You will learn each point,” Va-Raedin said. “Which beam it is, and which place it stands for, and what its stirring means, and what its stillness means, which is harder. There are two hundred and fifty-six of them on this wall. No two candidates learn them in the same order, and there is no shorter road. A Candidate learns where light falls.” He looked at me kindly enough, and let it land. “They all fall here.”

I stood before the wall that could find any body in the Mountain, and I kept a thought back: this escapes it. It can tell him the passage I stand in, and the hour, and by which stair I came down; what moves behind my face while I look at its beauty stays mine.

— It is a good place to leave the morning. The afternoon and tomorrow runs as agreed: a few hours with the tutor, and then the physician asks an hour of you for the body. He is not content with your numbers.

— Instruction, yes; I will sit with your tutor. The physician and his hour, we shall see. Do you know what they will teach me?

— The shape of it, yes. The exact content or the methodology, no. We are kept apart; the House calls it compartmentalization. Each account is to be taken clean, free of the others’ influence. Come. I will show you where you will eat.

In Noxius

— You are up. ... Wait — say that again, I want it on the reel. ... Forgive the machine at this hour. I gave you my word the first morning that nothing we said would go unkept, and I would sooner keep it badly than keep it only by daylight.

— It is the light. The one you set on the wall this afternoon. I shut my eyes and it is still burning. ... And this house keeps a lamp lit in every room the night long, for no one at all. Anyway. ... I was thinking of the sea. Is it far from here?

In English

— One second, Urs. There. ... Knight d three. The octopus.

In Noxius

— Never mind the game, and never mind Urs. One of his boats is lost, fast in a strait; he is awaiting news, and none has come.

— You see, it is so large that a man may lose whole boats inside it. ... Is it far from here?

— Quite far. ... Let me see if I can find you something here, with pictures in it.

[—]

In English

— Paul. The coffee table. ... Under the Elizabeth Kolbert.

— Ah — excellent idea.

In Noxius

— Here. *The World, From Above*. Now off you go.

CHAPTER 3

OASIS

— The nineteenth of March, nine o'clock; the second of our interviews. You look as though you did not sleep.

— Not very well if at all. They sat me before a moving light yesterday, three half days of it, and I have not stopped seeing it since.

— Ah. The instruction. Yesterday was *Life On Earth*, I am told: the whole ladder of it, from the first speck to your own hand. This afternoon they turn to the heavens. I am given the shape of the week, not the sessions themselves; I do not sit in that room. But you may speak of yesterday freely, before we begin.

— I wish. It began with time. My people count the years of the world in their thousands and think themselves ancient. He counts them in their millions, and had the rock to prove it. He took me down into a great red canyon, wall standing over wall, and taught that each layer beneath was older than the one above it; and that the floor of it was older than the whole of my scripture. I did not know a rock could be young or old. And in those walls there were beasts, Paul: creatures caught in the stone where they had died an age ago, held in the rock as a fly is held in sap. Millions of years. ... And it sent me back, this morning, to a thing I had passed twice and thought nothing of — on the wall of the passage you bring me down, a beast, all teeth and a crown upon it, set there as though by a furious child. After those creatures in the stone, I stopped in front of it a long while. What is it? In the Mountain, a thing like that would be a warning, or a god.

— Ha. That. A painting, only a painting — by a man called Basquiat, dead very young, and worth a good deal more than the house it hangs in. There your people and mine part company: we pay a king's ransom to frame the fury a child would be corrected for, and hang it where every guest must pass. ... As for your beasts in the rock — geology was my own first study.

— You said you read geology. Is it a book? I should like to read it. And I should like to hold the instrument in my own hands, the microscope, and see this DNA he spoke of with my own eyes, not take it on a voice's word.

— Not quite. That is a translation mistake of mine. We use this word, *to read*, only to pompously mean study. About the microscope, as it turns out, we have quite a powerful one downstairs; but whether you would be granted access is not mine to say, nor the tutor's: that door opens from a good deal higher up than either of us. I will ask all the same. The book you shall have, though slowly: so few living men can carry it into your tongue that the translating alone is the work of months, not days. What I may not do is teach you the world myself. I am here only to take down the one you came from.

— There it is again: the wall you will not walk past. Every house I have been kept in has had one. But sleep went from me over something else. Your kind is permitted to ask; that is what I lay listening to. Where I was raised, scripture is the answer to a question, not the start of one. That voice did not speak in truths. He spoke in questions, and partial answers, and called the rest a mystery still to be pierced. I was cut from Light, at fifteen, for saying that what is hidden still has shape, and if it has shape it may be found. And here is a whole people who have built their temples out of precisely that sin.

— We would not call it a sin.

— No. You would call it a virtue, and give a child a prize for it. And the light itself, the moving picture. I have thought of little else. It is light, Paul. Only light, placed and turned by a hand I was not shown. My whole office rests on one lesson: a lamp set in the wrong place will make a man swear to a thing that is not there. You have built a lamp that can set anything before a man, in the dark, and he believes it because he wishes to. We would have named it the most dangerous object ever made and given it to Shield to bury. And I sat in the dark and could not look away. Nor could I stop asking the two questions my whole life trained into me: who chose what I was shown, and what did they leave in the dark.

— ...

— And you will have been watching me watch it; I assumed it all day. I was raised under the finest eyes my world ever made, and I can feel a trained watcher through a wall. So tell me: who stood behind the glass?

— No one. That I know of. I was not there; I spend the time during your instruction replaying the tape, taking notes. Only the tutor sat with you, and he attends the lesson, not the man. You were alone with it, though I know how little you will believe it. And the lamp: you named in one evening the danger it took my world fifty years to half admit. So yes: you are not wrong. I would rather you were, for I have no cure to hand you, and this house, and my whole world with it, runs on the lamp.

— ... A room with no eye in it, and a man, you Paul, who grants the point when he might have kept his silence. That is the most honest thing you have said to me. Then let me test the honesty while it lasts: that man above your fire, with the face of one who was obeyed, him at least you may tell me of. Or is he walled away with the rest, on the far side of the tutor's line?

— That one I may answer, and gladly. He is Sir Edward, this time it is a rank. He built the house you are sitting in, and a good deal more than the house. His business ran the whole way round the world: oil, metals, the things men went south and east for in his day. Toward the end he believed there was something out there worth more than all of it. He never found it, but his daughter Sarah did. And speaking of around the world: I should not want to spoil your afternoon, which is to be the heavens and the shape of the earth among them; but I cannot leave the phrase unasked. Your people know the earth for a sphere. Do they not?

— Curious, that you should ask me that very question, of all the questions you might ask. Yes, we know that it is a sphere. And also we do not. It is complicated.

— That is not an answer.

— No. It is the true shape of one. Ask me again later this week, in its proper place, and I will give you the long form.

— Then I shall keep it for later. But first, the small errand I was sent with. You kept your hours with the tutor yesterday, and then sent the physician away. The exercise. You would not do it.

— Paul. I mean you no disrespect; you have been courteous, and courtesy is not nothing. But you should understand what you are asking, and of whom. I am not a nobody. I sat among the ten who mattered most in a world eleven thousand years old. Men knelt when I passed them. Lives were kept, or were not, upon my word. And you would set me in coloured cloth to chase a ball across a lawn while grown men clap, and call it improvement. I did not come this far, through all that has been taken from me, to be entertained by silly games.

— It is a game, and it is not. I would not ask you to caper for anyone's amusement, and I have no say over the regimen in any case; the physician holds it. The body is an instrument, and yours has come to us badly out of tune, underfed, overwalked, wrongly mended. Function. Not fun. And where he would begin again is swimming. A pool beneath the east wing: indoors, private, no eye upon it but the physician's, and

he reads numbers, not men. It asks everything of the body and shows it to no one. I thought it might suit a man who has had his fill of being watched.

— No. — No: yes. I will do the swimming. The man whose voice it was yesterday did more than cross the top of the water; he went down under it, in a red tunic, a large yellow bottle behind his back, and moved among the creatures there as though he belonged with them, and named each one for me. You have a pond in your garden; I have watched it all morning from the window. Train me to swim, then to dive, and give me the microscope I asked you for at the start, and I can go down into that pond and learn for myself whether the man on the light told me the truth or only a good story.

— That is no small thing you ask, and more than the physician had in mind; but I will try for it. Now: yesterday you left me at the Mirror, the wall where all of it falls. What did Light do with you the next morning?

— It gave me a beam of my own to learn, and then would not let me learn it. I had been granted permission to go outside, for the second time in my life.

The first had been at my blessing, when I was too new to hold it, and the Mountain had folded the sky away again before I could learn it was ever mine to lose. The permission came to me on a strip of pale bark, folded twice and sealed with green wax. The seal was Balance green: the cup and the sealed jar pressed deep into the wax, crossed by a narrow black witness line and the small hard stamp of Shield. I broke it with my thumb. The old cut pulled under the bandage.

Sa-Kailan, Candidate of Light, is granted one controlled prayer access before the Oasis at the Third Measure. Duration: one silence before and one silence after the water prayer. Route: east lower passage, cedar gate, second threshold, shaded descent. Measured by Balance. Witnessed by Justice. Held by Shield.

I read the strip once for permission, then again for hierarchy. Va-Raedin had taught me to read the second thing in a document, the order of the offices, more carefully than the first. Balance measured, Justice witnessed, Shield held, Faith would conduct the prayer. Light had no authority out there except through me, as a body to be admitted, washed, watched, counted, and returned.

Outside. Guarded, and barely outside at all, if my father's corrections were to be believed. But outside enough for sky and the Oasis, and for the Mountain's shadow to fall across my body in the open air.

I dressed more carefully than the rite required. I tied the bandage on my thumb, untied it, and tied it again so the linen sat cleanly over the cut. My mother watched from the wall recess where she had been folding cloth.

“You will keep your eyes lowered through the water prayer.”

“I know.”

“You will not ask Shield why a path is closed.”

“I know.”

My father looked up from the tablet he had been marking. “Outside is not a reward.”

“No.”

“It is not a private revelation.”

“No.”

“It is a place where the Mountain becomes harder to protect.”

I folded the permission bark and placed it inside my robe. “Yes.”

He studied me for a moment. “Stand in the shadow when instructed,” he said. “Do not look long at the desert. It teaches appetite.”

I left before I answered.

The familiar passages to the cedar gate felt strange that morning, because I was walking them in order, outward. Checkpoint, gate, count, threshold, descent: each had stood there yesterday, and yesterday I had walked past it blind. Today I passed through each one wondering what it was for.

At the first checkpoint a Justice clerk checked the green wax against a slate, examining the time mark, my name, my bandaged thumb.

“Permission strip.”

I gave it to him. He opened it, read it though he must already have known what it said, and pressed a clay counter into my palm.

“Return this counter at the second threshold on re-entry. If you lose it, the route remains open in the record, and Shield searches until it is closed.”

“I will not lose it.”

“That is the usual intention.”

The counter was small, rough, stamped with a number. I placed it in the inner fold of my robe, away from the Light token, as if the two might quarrel if they touched.

At the cedar gate two attendants stood beside a shallow basin. Every leaving body was washed into the proper condition, given water enough for rite and no more.

There were seven of us in the access group: myself, three older women from the western family chambers — one leading a boy with a single cloudy eye — and two men too tired to be anything but workers granted prayer because grief had entered their household. I was counting the group the way a boy counts, for company.

The Faith attendant poured water over my hands. It was colder than I expected. I lowered my eyes before the attendant could see where they had gone.

“Speak only what is appointed before the Oasis,” she said.

“I will.”

“Take nothing from the ground.”

“I will not.”

The boy with the cloudy eye began to cry when the water touched his mouth. His aunt bent close and whispered to him. The two grieving men kept silent.

Beyond the cedar gate waited Shield. Behind the wood were black iron bands and a locking bar thick enough to stop a cart. Two wardens stood before it. A third watched from a side niche, visible only because I had begun to notice where watching could be hidden.

The senior warden read our marks one by one. “Prayer access. The Measure. Seven bodies out. Seven bodies due.” He looked at me last. “Candidate of Light.”

“Yes.”

“Eyes where Faith places them. Feet where Balance marks them. If Shield speaks, you obey before understanding.”

“I understand.”

“No,” the warden said. “You agree. Understanding is not required.”

Understanding is not required. At fifteen it sounded like an insult.

The iron bar was lifted by two hands and a lever set into the wall. A narrow bell sounded somewhere beyond the gate, answered by another farther down the stone. The Mountain informed itself that it had opened. We passed through in single file.

The descent beyond the cedar gate was cut between natural rock and worked stone. At first it felt like any lower passage: dim, damp, controlled, with lamps set in protective recesses and the smell of water in the cracks. Then the lamps stopped.

Light lay on the floor in a pale wedge. No lamp, no measured reflection, no slit calculated by Light. It came from somewhere ahead, full of dust and height, careless in its angle, making each stair deeper and then shallower as I moved.

“Eyes down until the mark,” the Shield warden said.

I lowered my gaze to the steps. The outside light was brighter, and undisciplined, and it took some minutes for my eyes to adapt. My training recoiled from it, and my body wanted it anyway.

At the last turn, the Mountain opened. The sky struck me first as sheer height, and after that as blue. The Mountain had ceilings; even its highest halls ended somewhere, and had taught my eye to expect an end. I kept my eyes low, and failed, and above the dark shoulder of the Mountain the open brightness went on and on, with no vault to end it and no hand to have placed it.

Faith led us to the marked prayer stones. Only there were we permitted to look.

The Oasis lay under the Mountain's shadow, and for the space of a breath, before my training woke, it was only beautiful — green and alive, in a world I had been raised to believe was stone to its heart. The Genesis gravure had shown me a spring inside a ring of trees, and I had knelt to that carving my whole life.

For nothing in it grew where it pleased. The palms leaned inward, every crown tilted to spend its shade on the water, not the sand. Reeds kept to the slow reaches, so where they stood the water idled, and where they thinned it ran. Small white flowers held the cracks that would otherwise have opened and let the hill crumble. Against the warm rock the hives were stacked in clay, and an attendant of Balance moved among them in a slow haze of smoke. And along the Mountain's foot, where the night's chill still slept in the stone, the hardiest plants wore a fur of dew — I watched one bead of it gather on a leaf, and slide, and fall *inward*, into a seam in the rock, back into the hill before the sun could take it. The Oasis was drinking through its own wall.

— How large was it, in the shadow of the Mountain?

— I do not know how to count it.

— The silly games pitch. Bigger or smaller?

— Hard to say: it was circular and irregular. Five, six, maybe ten of those.

— Circular. How many steps from one end to the opposite end, going through the middle.

— Six hundred, or maybe a thousand.

Beyond it all the desert expanded, and outside the Mountain's shadow the light came down hard enough to kill anything caught in it. The Mountain rose behind the hollow in a great dark crescent, holding it in shade from the north. In front, to

the south, a second height stood out of the sand — a third the Mountain's size, but set so close that the Oasis lay caught between the two like a seed between a thumb and a finger. What the Mountain and that near rock left open, a farther ridge away to the south-east all but closed. And the green ran on past the point where the prayer-party was let to see it: beyond the spring and its shade the cultivation climbed, terrace above terrace along the Mountain's cooler flank, palms, then lower trees, then the low crops in their shade, more than the holy hollow held, so that a man out on the sand would swear the whole hill was barren stone. To reach the high terraces the water had to be sent back uphill, and that took a machine: a wheel of clay pots turning on a shaft that two goats walked in a slow circle, each pot filling low and spilling high.

The old women knelt. I knelt with them. The Faith attendant unrolled a strip of pale bark and held it with both hands before the water. This was the second book of the Covenant: *The Book of Blood*.

And after the fifth day, God spoke unto Adam and unto Eve,

- Adam and Eve?
 - Paul, please do not interrupt me when I recite scripture. God would not approve.
 - Of course. My apologies.
-

And after the fifth day, God spoke unto Adam and unto Eve, and unto the five children whom He had set in the Oasis beneath the shadow of the Mountain; and God said, Let there be Keepers among you, that the Mountain be not without order, nor the Oasis without care, nor the people without peace. And God called the woman of water, and said unto her, Keep thou the Balance, and gather the fruits, and count the waters, and keep the resources of survival; for what is wasted in peace shall be missing in hunger. And God called the woman of holy speech, and said unto her, Keep thou the Faith, and teach My Gospel unto the children, and keep prayer, breath, rhythm, and memory beneath the Mountain; for I shall provide.

The Balance workers moved in the distance as the words were spoken. One woman checked the level in a narrow cut along the main channel. On the high terraces the barley stood pale in the sun, and a line of women worked along it with

short hooks. A clerk marked a hanging board and moved a shell counter from one hook to another. *Count the waters*, the scripture said. And there they were, counting.

And God called the man of strength, and said unto him, Keep thou the Shield, and stand before the beasts of the Earth, and before the Threshold of men; suffer not the children to be devoured, nor danger to enter unnamed. And God called the woman of brightness, and said unto her, Keep thou the Light, and illuminate the Mountain, and teach the eye where to stand, that the people stumble not in darkness. And God called the man of peace, and said unto him, Keep thou Justice, and stand between brother and brother, and keep the record of sequence, that blood answer not blood without measure. And the Keepers received their charges, and each kept what had been given, and the people multiplied in the Oasis.

Out here the five charges were tools laid out on stone. Justice alone stayed out of sight, but the clay counter inside my robe said it had already entered the route, and had a number for me.

And the Keepers had sons and daughters, and their children had children after them; and the Oasis was filled with voices, and the Mountain gave shadow, and the waters were counted, and the Gospel was taught, and the beasts were driven back, and the lamps were lit, and peace was kept among the people. And the Keeper of Shield had two sons; and the elder was great in strength, and broad in the shoulder, and mighty before the beasts; and the younger was small in his body, and cunning in his heart. And the younger looked upon his brother, and saw that the people loved his strength, and envy entered him as a serpent entereth the grass.

I had heard the beginning many times. Children loved the elder brother because he was easy to love: strong, brave, broad before the beasts. Smallness and cunning had sounded like virtues to me, back when I had neither size nor strength. But now, kneeling under the open sky, the younger brother sounded like a warning set too close to my own ribs. I was small. I was clever. I had already learned to do the forbidden thing only unwatched.

And the younger spoke softly unto his brother, and smiled with his mouth while murder grew within him; and he rose against

his brother in secret, and slew him where no beast had entered. And the first blood of man cried from the dust. And fear came upon the people, for Shield had defended the Oasis from the beasts without, but had not seen the beast within. And the younger fled from the Oasis, and took with him the wife of his brother, a daughter of Faith, and went out from the shadow of the Mountain into the open land.

The first blood of man cried from the dust. I looked toward Shield before I meant to. The perimeter wardens held their places. Shield had failed once in scripture, watching the beasts outside while the murder happened within, and every warden since had inherited the shame of that single line.

And God saw that blood had entered the world of men, and that holy speech had been carried out of the Mountain in the hands of the stolen daughter of Faith; and God cursed them, saying, Thou shalt wander under the eye of Heaven, and the Earth shall not hide thee. Thy children shall thirst for what they cannot keep, and conquer what they cannot love. Thou shalt remember the Mountain, but thou shalt not find it; and thou shalt hear the Gospel, but twist it into hunger. And from the murderer and the stolen daughter came the Outsiders.

The boy with the cloudy eye stopped crying. His aunt held him so tightly that her knuckles whitened. *The Outsiders.*

I believed enough.

— There. It is finished, and you may have your question now: the one you have held since Adam and Eve.

— You have those two names. A garden; a first man; a first woman; a brother who kills his brother in a field. We have that book, or one very near it. I did not think to meet it coming the other way, out of a mountain the world has never heard of.

And the Outsiders multiplied in the open land, and their kings became many, and their cruelty became without number; and they remembered the Mountain in dreams, and hated the shade they could not find. And they gathered armies, and forged blades, and raised engines of war, and came with banners and drums and false prayers upon their tongues.

- false prayers upon their tongues, Paul.
- In our gospel, God forbids Eve from eating the fruit from the tree of knowledge. She does, and God is angry.
- You said you would not teach me the world. And here you are, handing me your own *Genesis*. Are women not allowed instruction in your world?
- They are, and they are not. It is complicated.
- Do you know who wrote your gospel, and when?
- The priests of Babylon, perhaps twenty-five to forty centuries back, out of older stories still. But we are not sure; it is debated to this day. Some argue it was written from their god, or their prophet, or their kind.
- Four thousand years, and it is complicated. Listen to yourself.
- Listen to myself, yes. I am not sure who wrote it, and I have said so to your face, and I shall say it again tomorrow, and keep every finger. But leave the pen; it is the one ground you can win. The book does not divide us — the woman does. In mine she crosses the threshold by her own hand, and is blamed for it still. In yours she never crosses at all — she is carried over, taken as plunder, blameless because she never lifts a hand. We are two peoples telling one quarrel, each from his own end of it. Mine follows the murderer out of the shade, and the woman he took with him.
- The Outsiders.
- The Outsiders. I learned it at five. I knelt and heard it read at fifteen, under the open sky, the morning I am giving you now.
- ...
- You are wondering whether I know to whom I am speaking. I know exactly, Paul. You are of the open land. By the book I have set before you, you are the murderer's child, and I have been reading you your own beginning. I do not say I believe every word of it. But in all the years since, I have not found the line in it that was wrong about your people. You remembered the Mountain. And, against the curse, you found it. I am the sitting proof.
- That is a large accusation to lay on a man across his own fire. The tutor sets you before the first cell and the long climb up to your own hand, and you kneel in the sand and hand me a garden, a murder, and a cursed line walking out into the country I was born in. I am a man of science, and I will not argue a man's scripture while he recites it from memory. Let us continue.

The attendant lowered the bark. For a while no one moved. The silence after scripture was meant to be empty. This one had too much in it: the kneeling

women and the boy with the ruined eye, and under all of it the old story of a brother who smiled while murder grew behind his mouth.

Then the practical world returned. A child sprinkled water over the snail trays with the seriousness of a priest; a woman scraped fibre from soaked stalks and laid it to dry; and the bees worked the warm rock. Nothing was let go to waste — not even the water, which left its salt behind as it dried on the channel pans, for Balance to lift before it soured the beds and carry to the tables where it kept the winter's food.

— The singing that set the time of the hands. How old is it? Who made it?

— No one made it. I asked, once, as a boy, and the answer was that it had always been so; and that is the answer to every such question inside the Mountain.

I was allowed to stand after the first silence, and to step to the third marker, and look.

Then I saw Va-Sheva of Shield.

She stood near the southern perimeter beyond the herb beds, where the Oasis began to turn back toward bare rock. Three Shield wardens were placed around her, though none had announced command, and none needed to. She wore dark Shield leather over her robe, a cloth wrapped round her throat, hair bound high, a short blade at her hip and a longer one across her back.

She was looking away from me, toward the outer path. The light revealed the dark green of her eyes like I had never seen them and broke into small moving fires along the shine of her dark hair as she turned, and I thought, God forgive me, that these must be the archangels I had heard named all my life and never seen — beings of pure light, loosed and dancing on the shine of a shield warden's hair.

One of the wardens spoke to her. She kept her eyes on the path and lifted two fingers; the perimeter changed shape around a thought. Then she saw me. Her expression altered by almost nothing, something close to amusement contained before it could become warmth, and she crossed toward me while the Faith attendant moved away to help the old women.

I became suddenly aware of my robe, my bandaged thumb, the sand on my sandals, and the fact that I had been looking too long at everything.

"Sa-Kailan," she said. The prefix in her voice stung, and I was glad of it anyway.

"Va-Sheva."

Her eyes went to my thumb. "Light has already started cutting pieces off you."

"Only the useless ones."

"That cannot be true. You are still standing."

I almost laughed. She stayed grave. Her mouth moved enough to show she had intended the cruelty kindly.

"You were at the Hall," I said, because I had to say something and chose badly.

"So were most of the people."

Wind moved between us, smelling of goat and wet stone, and under it something dry from beyond the shade. "You have grown," she said. The words should have pleased me.

"So have you," I said, and wished the words back before they had cleared my teeth. This time she smiled, and it was a real one.

"I had four years' advantage."

"Five, almost."

"You counted?"

I looked away toward the channels. "Everyone knows."

My eyes came back from the channels, and went where they had no leave to go: to a bead of sweat that had started at her throat and was sliding down into the neck of her leathers. She saw them land before I did.

"No," she said. "Boys know such things when they should be learning where to put their eyes." I felt myself stay fifteen in front of her. Out of reach completely and intolerably.

"I am learning," I said.

"So I heard."

"From whom?"

"Shield hears many things."

I looked at her again. The girl I had known remained somewhere in the face, but duty had been worked over it like leather — even now, while speaking, some part of her watched the perimeter.

"You are on duty."

"Yes."

"Then should you be speaking to me?"

"No. But I am," she said.

The blood came up into my face, and a smile that got away from me, because for the length of that one answer the child's conspiracy she and I had once had seemed back in the room, thick as thieves. Then it was gone. Some door had shut between the girl she had been and the Shield she was, and I had no idea when it had closed.

“Why?”

“Because you looked as if the sky had insulted you.”

“It is too large.”

“That is one of its lesser faults.”

“You do not like it?”

“I respect it, and fear it. As should you.”

For a moment we stood side by side and said nothing, both looking outward. I wanted to ask whether she had ever gone past the second ridge, whether Shield feared the Outsiders as scripture feared them or as wardens feared tracks in dust. The questions were too hungry. So I asked something safer.

“The reading said the Outsiders came from the murderer.”

“That is what the Book of Blood says.”

“Do you believe it?”

“I believe the Mountain is hidden for a reason.”

“That is not an answer.”

“Do you believe the Book of the Beast?”

“You mean,” I said carefully, “that the five Keepers hold together the Beast of Hell, in case the Outsiders come back.”

“That is what children say.”

“It is what Faith teaches children.”

“Faith teaches children the shape of things. Not the weight.”

I looked toward the dark line of the outer path. Hell belonged below, beneath stone, beneath water, beneath the red pigment in the carved warnings. Yet the Book of the Beast had always joined two fears: what was held beneath the Mountain, and the people out beyond the desert.

“And what do you say?” I asked her. “Not Faith, not Ka-Dhavar of Shield. You.”

“I say you have been Candidate for days, and stood outside once, and heard one reading, and already you would have the Beast weighed and answered for you by afternoon.”

“Then tell me only whether it is real.”

She was silent long enough that I gave up on an answer. “A gate takes its holiness from whatever stands behind it,” she said.

“The Beast is real, then.” and she kept her silence.

The word had thrilled me since childhood — Beast, Hell, Chains, the five Keepers — and had only ever been a word.

“The Oasis is smaller than the gravures made it,” I said, retreating.

“Most holy things are. The desert is larger.”

I looked toward it. The outer path ran out toward the south-east, where a farther ridge stood against the deep desert. On that ridge, for less than a breath, something caught the sun and threw it back, then went dark. I narrowed my eyes.

“What was that?”

Va-Sheva’s gaze moved instantly. “Where?”

“There. On the second ridge, the dark stone.”

“Do not point.”

My hand had begun to lift. I lowered it.

“What was it?”

And God called the desert the Threshold; and He set heat upon it by day, and cold upon it by night, and mirage upon its face, that no man should cross it lightly.

That was her explanation. I believed none of it.

There was no shout. No drawn blade. No rush of bodies. Va-Sheva made three gestures in succession: two fingers low, the palm closed, the hand cut toward the outer path. And the Oasis rearranged itself.

One warden moved behind the goat pens and became invisible in shade. Another knelt near the dust at the outer marker. A hidden figure answered from the rock above the descent, where I had seen only stone.

The Faith attendant looked up, alarmed, but kept silent. One of the old women tried to rise and was pressed gently back by her companion. A goat stopped chewing. The bees continued.

Va-Sheva crouched beside the kneeling warden and touched the ground. She lifted her fingers, rubbed something between them, then looked toward the outer path and the ridge where I had seen the light.

The warden near the stones gave a low call. “Marker.” Shield changed around the ordinary word. One outer marker had been turned. Barely. A flat side faced inward where the others faced skyward. Va-Sheva kept her hands off it, read the dust around it and the path beyond, and then spoke aloud.

“No one returns inside yet.”

The Faith attendant’s eyes widened. “The access period—”

“Has changed.”

“By whose order?”

“Shield holds the Threshold,” Va-Sheva said. The attendant lowered her head.

“Good.”

Here, at the edge of the world, Shield could interrupt sacred timing with two words, no explanation, and everyone bent.

A young Balance boy near the herb beds began to cry, old enough to be ashamed of it and too young to stop.

Va-Sheva walked the marker line without stepping beyond it. At the turned stone she knelt, took a thin bone pin from her sleeve, and lifted a single strand from the ground; it caught the light once, pale against her glove, before she sealed it in a covered dish. “Second gate,” she said, and a hidden watcher answered from the slope. Then she turned to the workers. “Count.”

Balance counted the way Balance counts: every tool to its tally, every beast to its pen, every worker to his name, the whole hollow reckoned in the time it takes to tell it. Nothing was missing from the work.

“Prayer group?” The Faith attendant named seven. The warden corrected her. “Six.” The attendant froze.

Then one of the old women said sharply, “Mara.” The woman beside her looked round. “She has gone out to the south-west markers.” No one moved.

Va-Sheva did. She crossed the prayer area at a fast walk, two wardens spreading behind her. She did not run; running would have shown the group she was frightened. The Faith attendant whispered, “God keep her in shadow.” Va-Sheva heard. “Silence.” The word cut the air.

They found her out at the south-west markers, in the one open reach where the desert could see into the Oasis — the very ground no eye had been on, because every eye had gone to the ridge. She had crouched against a dry stone, one hand flat on it, breathing hard, unable to rise. Whether she had gone out there for a reason of her own or simply lost her way, I never learned. In her other hand she held a sprig of dried herb carried from the beds. A Balance worker made a sound of anger low in her throat. Va-Sheva took the sprig gently, gave it to the worker, then helped the old woman stand and said something close to her ear that made her close her eyes and nod.

Then she signalled. The turned marker remained under guard. The second ridge threw back no more light. The old woman was returned to Faith, who received her with a face drained of colour.

Va-Sheva came back to the inner shade. Her eyes passed over the group, counted, and settled briefly on me. “Seven bodies held,” she said. “Eleven Balance workers held.”

The Faith attendant said very quietly, “She is old.”

“Yes.”

“She meant no harm.”

“Not the same as being harmless.”

The old woman began to weep silently, with such shame that I had to look away. Shield still treated the sprig as a breach.

The channel was checked. A small clay seal was pressed beside the woman’s name. The prayer group was recounted. The Balance workers returned to their tasks with the rigid annoyance of people who had lost time and lacked the permission to complain of it.

When Va-Sheva finally came back to me, the official danger had passed, though nothing in her face softened.

“You saw the flash first.”

“I think so.”

“You did not point when told not to.”

“No.”

“Good.”

“Were the three of them connected?” I asked.

“The flash, the marker, and the old woman out of place?”

“Yes.”

“Probably not.”

“Then why—”

She looked at me, and I stopped. “Because three small wrongnesses at the Threshold are not treated separately until Shield can afford the luxury,” she said. “A flash may be nothing. A turned marker may be nothing. An old woman out of place may be nothing. Three nothings close together become a shape.”

“You see like Light when you say that,” I said.

“No. Light sees what can be shown. Shield sees what must be stopped before it shows itself.”

I looked toward the desert again. The rock beyond the second ridge sat dark and ordinary. The flash might have been mineral, old metal, heat, or a mirage.

“It goes in the record,” Va-Sheva said. “Which of the four?”

“Mirage,” I said.

She held my eyes a moment. Then she let it go down as I had given it.

“Seven bodies out.” Va-Sheva said.

The Faith attendant called us back to the prayer stones for the return blessing. The access period had been made irregular by the containment. Shield would remember the turned marker long after the others had forgotten the prayer.

At the second threshold two hands waited for us, and the order was fixed. First the clay counter, given up into a Balance clerk's palm; she read its number, set it against her slate, and struck the route closed. Then the washing: the dust of the open rinsed from the hands and face in a shallow bowl, the water darkening with it. And over each of us the Faith attendant spoke.

"What has touched the open returns under shadow."

We answered. "Under shadow, we return."

We re-entered in single file, and the ceiling came back like a hand over the skull. Relief came with it, shameful and immediate.

The Oasis was proof, and I granted it: no spring could hold against that heat without the Mountain standing over it, and who set the Mountain there but God? But the reading had made proof of the desert too, which in the Book of Blood was the curse the Outsiders had inherited.

I touched the folded permission bark, though it had spent its authority. The Mountain had my body back. But I fell asleep that night certain the desert had flashed for me alone.

— Flashed for me alone. Listen to the boy: he thought God and a whole desert could pick him out of a party.

— Boys do, and it does none of us any harm to have believed it once. Enough for today. You have given me more than a day's worth, and I have an old man's need to sit with a thing before I take the next of it.

CHAPTER 4

MOUNTAIN

— The twenty-first of March; half past nine; the third of our interviews. The instruments reached you at last, I am told, and you did not waste them: the swimming, the diving, the hunt after the DNA. And yesterday, the heavens: *Cosmos, a Personal Voyage*. I should be glad to hear of both, before we take up your account again.

— The swimming first, Paul, since you were good enough to win me the instruments; I will not pretend I took to it like your seals. But I went in, and I went under. In the end I did not need the bottle of air: a held breath and a little nerve carried me down far enough. And with the glasses pressed to my eyes, I put my hand into the weed and closed it; and there they were, green threads and drifting motes and small living things too faint to name, caught in my own palm, the very things your *Attenborough* had shown me only on his lit glass. I checked them against his pictures. They held. And under the microscope, the very DNA the voice had named to me was there too, exactly where he had said it would be. But the heavens I cannot take in my hand, and that is where my trouble begins. He showed me the whole of it first, Paul, in one turning year: the making of the world, the first fire, the long dark, the wandering rocks; and our people arriving in the last breath of the last night of that year, a little before its midnight. Each second of his year, five hundred years of mine. It was the one kindness: he gave me a measure I could stand inside.

— The Cosmic Calendar.

— And then he would not let me rest in it. He showed me a man who measured the round earth with a stick and its shadow and the noon sun, and asked no god's leave to do it. *Eratosthenes*. He would have been Light, Paul — Light's work done in the open, with no office to grant him the shadow. I was asked whether I should like to repeat the man's experiment, and I found that I did not. I knew it to be true. That frightened me more than any doubt: that I could look at a stick and a shadow and simply think: that stands.

— When last we sat, I asked whether your people knew the earth for a sphere; and you told me you did, and did not, that it was complicated. Was the stick your answer?

— Part of it. The rest keeps for its place. A man named *Kepler* gave his life to prove five perfect shapes ruled the spacing of the worlds. He said a thing I wrote down to keep:

Geometry existed before the creation.

It is co-eternal with the mind of God.

Geometry provided God with a model for the creation.

Geometry is God himself.

But he was wrong about the shapes; he was himself the one who proved it wrong; and he went on loving the splendour of the universe to his death regardless. I do not know how a man abandons an idea so beautiful. In that moving light, sometimes the thing was real, and sometimes it was men dressed and lit to play at what had once happened, and I could not tell the one from the other. I cannot walk out and settle each of them with my own eyes, the way I settled your pond. Scripture chose; the office chose. A warden told me, *you agree, understanding is not required*; and I agreed, and the not-understanding was a kind of rest. Out here there is no scripture to lean on, and you name that freedom as though it were a gift. But if I am free, I must choose whom to believe with nothing behind the choice but myself. How do you bear it, Paul? If not God, then what?

— Carefully, and never all at once. I trust nothing because it comforts me, nor because a man in a robe has said it. I trust what has been made to stand against a test and did not fall. That earns a little of my weight, only the weight the test will bear, and I take it back the hour a better test throws it down. It is a slow way to live, and I have found nothing that beats it.

— *What survives the test*; remember that you said it. I may hold you to it.

— You are meant to be handing me a mountain, not a philosophy of doubt. When last we sat, two days gone, you had gone out to the Oasis, and there we left the day. But the beam was already yours by then: Va-Raedin of Light had set you one thread of light of two hundred and fifty-six, and had not let you learn it before they carried you outside. Did you come back to it, after the visit? Give it to me as it came.

Va-Raedin had given me the beam the morning after the Mirror, but the outside claimed me before I could walk it. Now I came back to it.

One point on the wall, low and toward the south-western side, steadier than most and given to a slow stir near Second Silence. "That one is yours until you can walk it in the dark," he had said. "Source to fall, fall to source; every mirror it touches, every throat it passes, and whatever stands near its road that ought not to stand there. When you can draw me the whole of it with your eyes shut, you will be given a second. Do not hurry. Hurry is how a candidate loses a beam and lights a wrong room looking for it."

Two servants of Light were set to walk the beam with me, though a beam wanted no guarding, and I had been one of them until two days before: there was nothing of theirs left to teach. From the age of twelve I had carried the oil and cloths down these same corridors, cleaned the very glass I was now sent to read, and learned every habit of the work from the wrong end of the order. Oren was twenty and Sela fourteen; they were servants, and would be servants still when their hands failed them; and I, newly fifteen, stood among the first thirty souls of a Mountain of some five thousand, and all three of us knew it without a word said.

I told Oren and Sela plainly what I wanted, corrected them plainly where they needed correcting, and asked no more of them than the work required.

Oren was tall, and stooped for it: the corridors of Light were built for shorter men, and twenty years of learning where to duck had left him forgetting still. He carried the flat patience of a man who has cleaned the same glass long enough to stop resenting it. He knew where every lamp in the quarter sat, and no reason why any of them was there. The younger, Sela, bore the cloths and the little oil and said almost nothing. She was small and thin, with a plain face she kept tilted down and brown hair she was forever tucking back and letting fall between us; and without seeming to choose it she held to the dim edge of the lamp, crossing the light quickly when a task made her, and coming straight back to the dark. She watched me the way the young watch a puzzle they are working out — a boy her own size, giving orders in the grey of an office he had lately been taking them in — and for the most part she kept it off her face.

The Mountain was still paying for Ka-Elun of Faith's Ascension: that ceremony had spent its order and returned none, and for days afterward the whole body of the place laboured to earn it back, out of turn and short of hands.

We began at the fall, in the low room where my point died, before the ordinary hours let anyone near it. Sela had the bronze test-glass out of her satchel before I asked, which told me she had walked a Candidate before and knew the word that came next. Oren went to steady the shard against the wall with his thumb flat across its face. “Not the face,” I said. “The cloth. Your thumb leaves an oil that reads as light within the hour, and the next man swears to a thing that is not there.” He took his thumb off it without a word.

The beam was never in a hurry and I always was, and every time I read the two against each other, the beam was right.

We were still in Light’s own halls when Shield stopped us. A warden raised one hand at the first turn and held back three workers, two children, and the three of us together. “South service way is closed,” he said. A woman with folded cloth on her hip frowned. “Since when?” “Since it was closed.” “I have cloth due in the herb rooms.” “Then it will arrive by another passage.” “That is half an Hour added, and my back already full.” The warden kept his eyes on the bundles. “Then the cloth will be tired.”

The children laughed until their father quieted them. The woman shifted the cloth and turned to go the long way, irritated and unsurprised. No one asked why the way was shut.

But I was Light now, trained to look. In the moment the warden turned to wave the cloth-woman down the long way, the shut door stood a hand’s breadth open behind him, and I saw down the closed passage what the shrug was built to keep ordinary. Two Shield wardens. Between them a Faith attendant, carrying a small covered dish, bone-pinned at the rim, and folded over her other arm a grey shawl, an old woman’s. I knew the dish. I had watched it sealed the day before, out at the markers, over a single pale strand lifted from the dust beside a stone that had been turned to face the wrong way. It had been carried inside, and filed, and it was still walking the Mountain this morning under Shield’s hand. The old woman, and the light I had seen thrown from the ridge, and the turned stone — three nothings, I had been told, that together make a shape — were somewhere behind that door.

And as the warden stepped back, a woman in Balance green passed straight through the closed way with a sealed slate under her arm and no one to stop her.

The beam strayed out of Light; most of them did, which was half the reason a Candidate was ever made to walk one. Mine climbed a service throat, crossed above a washing gallery through a slot no wider than a wrist, and came down

again into the trafficked stone where Balance kept the water. The first queue had already formed along a shallow channel. Each household bore a marked vessel; a copper rod lay across the channel, and two clerks in green walked it from notch to notch, reading allowance by household mark, by work, by illness, by the unborn, by yesterday's draw.

"Half measure," a clerk said, to a woman who had already opened her mouth. "Yesterday was half." "Yesterday you drew at the Reccord; this is First Light, and no house draws twice before the Measure. You came early, after the heat of the Ascension, and early is half." The woman's jaw set, then let go, and she took the half-filled jar. I watched the water settle in it. The surface caught a high lamp and bent along the curve of the clay, so the jar showed fuller from one side than the other. My own eye, with no mark to go by, would have called it more.

Beyond the water the kitchens opened in a run of low, heated chambers, and the air thickened with steam and yeast and boiled grain and the sour-sweet breath of things left to ferment. The cooks had cauldrons of lentil and bean at the boil. The workers were mostly Balance, but Faith was in all their timing — short prayers to seal a jar, longer ones to open stored grain.

Let every fruit be gathered. Let every vessel be sealed. Let no waste enter the Oasis.

They sang it badly, and some barely at all. One woman sang with plain devotion; another used the lines to count her kneading; a boy mouthed them only when an elder's eye came round. Further along, a gallery stood green and dimly lit, far down in the rock: a run of Light's mirrors carried a pale, second-hand daylight down from some far slit and laid it across bed after bed of growing things, the growers working the rows in that borrowed glow. It was light enough to grow by and no more, and none of them had ever seen the sun that sent it. The air here was sweeter than the passage behind us: the green put back the breath the lamps and the far-off fires used up.

I slowed to watch them, longer than the beam allowed. A kitchen supervisor caught me at it. "You want to knead, Light? We can always find a back." A few workers laughed. "No," I said. "Then keep moving. Even Light casts shadows." I moved.

It was in the wash passage below the kitchens. The beam had gone into a tangle of brackets and I had lost the thread of it. I worked it out alone. And as I drew it clean and it stood up plain under my hand, I caught her watching me. When she

saw that I had seen her, the colour came up all at once, her face opening before she could stop it; and she bent to the cloths as though they had that instant come to need her whole attention.

I have no gentler way to set it down. I had known a girl my whole life. As children Sheva had pressed a chip of blue glass into my hand behind the cistern, swore it a jewel off the Outside, and made me promise we would run one day and find where such things came from; I kept the glass four years, and she forgot it inside a season. And in all our years she had never once looked at me the way this stranger of fourteen just had, for half a breath, before she hid it in the cloths.

Near the tool wash a man stood where no water ran, waiting for me. Sa-Tavan of Justice, named to his office the same morning I was named to mine, a slate under one arm and the new black cord bright at his wrist, and worked small and exact in dark thread on the breast of his robe the sign of his office: a rectangle laid on its side, and within it a square hung from one corner, and a circle pressed into that square where the two crossed, the whole of it held inside the rectangle's line. He stood the way a man stands who has been practising it. "Sa-Kailan of Light," he said, and got the prefix exactly right, which almost no one had troubled to do in two days. "I was told you would come through here, at this Hour. I have been waiting." By whom, he left unsaid. Only one man set my road, and it was the same man who would have set his.

"Then you have wasted an Hour," I said, which was the sort of thing I had heard Candidates say to servants my whole life and had never once been let to say myself. "I have not," he answered, and let it pass. "Justice may wait and still be working. Shield has given me the counts and the containment; what the tablet wants now is the order, in the eyes of one who stood in it, and you were on the third marker when it began. Tell me what you saw, and the order you saw it in."

I had seen the light before any of them, and knew, better than his counts could tell him, exactly which had come before which. I would not lay my seeing on his tablet raw, where he might turn it any way he chose, so I gave it to him already folded inside Shield's own authority, where opening it meant opening Shield. "The Threshold is Shield's ground," I said. "Shield is charged to stand before it and let nothing enter it unnamed, and Va-Sheva of Shield stood there yesterday and did just that: she named what came, and held it. A brightness off the ridge, first, that Shield did not take for a signal. A marker found turned, second, by the wind or a careless hand. And an old woman missed from the prayer only after that, gone out to the south-west markers for a sprig. In that order, and with clear

ground between the light and the woman. She never stood where the brightness was.”

“A mirage,” he said, and gave the brightness the word the record keeps for lights that come to nothing. I let him have it. I had seen it, and it had been something.

“And the woman?” I asked, for I needed to know what my arranging had bought her. He wrote before he answered; Justice writes first. “If the light was Shield’s to name, and she stood apart from it, then she is no breach,” he said. “She is a strayed old woman, and strayed is an old and gentle category. I carry her case to the tablets and find every straying they hold, and against each I read what followed: which came to nothing, which to a theft, which to blood. I keep the one that answers nearest hers, for what that case became, hers is the likeliest to become; and it is upon the likeliest that I judge, never upon my liking. Then I choose the gentlest ruling it will bear without losing the Mountain’s hold on her. Where the record has room, we are merciful. Only where the two cannot both be kept does the Mountain come first.” He said it like a creed he had just been trusted with and meant to be worthy of. “She will be marked, watched a season, and let be.” Then he capped his ink and looked at me as long as I had been looking at him. “You gave me a very clean order, Sa-Kailan. Cleaner than a boy in his first fright on a marker has much right to give. I have written it as you gave it.” He said it as neither an accusation nor quite a thing let go. His eye dropped to my bound thumb. “Have that witnessed, so no one later confuses a ritual wound with an instruction wound.” He had turned to go, and stopped half round. “One class more for the tablet, while it is open. A strayed old woman is one reckoning; a Candidate of Light gone out to the Oasis inside his first two days, and back again, is another. I shall read beside hers every young office of Light that walked out to the water before the robe had cooled on him, and what followed each such visit.” And he was gone before I could decide what he had seen.

I passed the child halls, cut into warmer stone near the family districts. Children sat on woven mats while a Faith teacher moved among them with a cord of five knots.

The Mountain is refuge.

The Oasis is water.

The forest was plenty.

Beyond the forest thou shalt not wander.

The teacher touched the fifth knot. “And if the forest is gone?” The youngest faltered; the older answered.

The Covenant remains.

Further on, an older class stood for a harder verse, and the teacher took them through it a line at a time, in the flat voice you keep for a thing children must carry whole into a life that will one day test it.

*And when the wrath had passed, the armies of the Outsiders
were no more; but the forest was wounded, and the forest was
broken, and the open waters were spoiled, and the land
around the Mountain became desert.*

The forest had been killed in that verse, in the space scripture gave it: a single day, the day of the wrath. The world struck dry by something that had a shape, and the shape had a name we kept from children.

— That second verse, the older ones had it. Say it back to me. The forest wounded, the waters spoiled, the land made desert. Your people set that in a child before he can add. And they teach him it happened in a day.

— In a day. After the wrath. That is the scripture, and I was raised on it, and I have given it to you whole and unshaved.

— A forest does not die in a day. Not by any weather I have read in the ground. Drought is slow: ten years, a hundred, a thousand. What comes up between one dawn and one dusk, and leaves a desert where a forest stood?

— There is a scripture for it, a book of its own, the Book of the Beast, and I will recite it to you entire when we reach the place it belongs to, and not one morning sooner. For now you have exactly what the children have: a wrath, a forest broken, a desert made. Do not fish for the beast, Paul. I am keeping it for you, on purpose, and it is worth the keeping.

The beam ran on toward the south-west, out of Light's own halls and down into the salt-house, where Balance takes the trace out of water without spending a drop of it. What stays behind, the pale ring of salt and whatever else the spring had brought down, is scraped and dried and weighed on scales finer than any I had seen, and set in a ledger against the weight from the day before, and the day before that, back further than any hand there could have told you why. A boy no older than Sela tended the row, scraping and weighing the rings, calling each figure to a clerk who wrote it without looking up. The weight of the trace was a small number, and it carried the whole question of the spring — whether it was sweetening or turning, whether the Mountain would thirst in a year or in a hundred.

The beam ran at last to the south-western edge of everything I knew: a Balance door I had never seen opened, low, guarded, Justice's mark cut beside Balance's on the lintel, and my one thread of light running straight in under it. I was reaching for the doctrine — a beam is Light's to follow — when a voice took it out of my mouth. "Sa-Kailan of Light." Ka-Leth, Keeper of Balance, broad and grave, her hands stained faintly green. She had been waiting too. "It runs to my door," she said, "and you would like to know where it goes. You may not come in. But you are Light, and a beam is yours to account for, so I will give you this much, from where you stand."

She had them crack the door a hand's width, no more. "Look. Is any beam but yours entering this room, from any side of it?" I looked a long time, and for once the doctrine was easy, because I knew my own beam and I knew there was no window there, no second shaft, no lamp within that could feed a thread to that wall. "None," I said. "Only mine." "Good. Now go round by the outer stair to the far side, where it comes in from the source."

They walked me round to the far side, toward the source. And there it was, had I wanted proof. On that wall my beam came into the room whole — twice the light I had carried all morning — and on the near side, the side I had followed through the better part of the Mountain, it left carrying half that and no more. No second beam fed the room; the light that entered whole and left halved had gone to no thread, no spill, no lamp or throat I could name. Half had simply stayed inside, in the dark, behind Balance's door and under Justice's mark, and the Mountain below was lit by the half let go, and called it full. *We divide the sun. We lose none of it.* I had said it that very morning. Ka-Leth watched me reach it. "You may follow it from here, where it comes from," she said.

I followed the enriched beam to its source. It was almost Fourth Record when the work let us go, and I stood there a while with the day's last discovery sitting heavy in me. Oren gathered the cloths and the little oil and started up the passage without being told, folding himself under the low lintel out of long habit, and cracked his head on it regardless, and said a word Faith would have fined him for. Sela laughed — a short, real, unguarded sound — and caught it back behind her hand; and I found I had very nearly laughed with her.

"He meets that lintel at the third turn every day of his life," she said, to me, plainly, as though we had been trading such things for years instead of walking one in silence. "Every day. And every day it takes him by surprise."

"Perhaps he keeps hoping the Mountain will enlarge itself for him."

“Perhaps he does.” She looked at me then, at ease, and asked the thing she had carried all day. “What is it for, the beam? You walked it from the low room to here, a whole day, one line of light. What does a man learn from that?”

I had the answer, and that was the trouble: I wanted to set the whole cold marvel of the day before her — the mirror, the token, the half of the sun kept back behind Balance’s door — because she was quick, she had laughed at Oren with me, and for a corridor’s length she had spoken to me as though I were worth the speaking to.

“It stays in Light,” I said. “The learning. It is Light’s.”

I heard the wall go up in my own voice, and hated the sound, and left it standing. Her face did what I had watched it do in the wash passage, only in reverse: the openness folding quietly shut. She nodded, as though I had said something reasonable, and stepped back into the place a servant keeps. She thanked me for the day and went up after Oren, and the corridor was only a corridor again.

I stayed at the source longer than the work required, a small ugly ache left in me.

And there, at the end of it, stood Va-Sheva. Four years I had read her flat eye as coldness and her closed door as a verdict on me. I had just worn that same eye in a corridor, and felt what sat behind it: a wall held up, and the holding cost her something.

I went up towards the candidate quarters with all of it turning in me.

*And God said, Keep thou the Mountain, and keep thou the
Oasis, and keep thou the Temple. Keep the secrets apart, and
let no one hand hold the whole.*

I stopped just past the alcove. I had spoken those words myself, in the Hall, two days before. Now they followed me differently. *The Temple*. I had said it a thousand times and never once asked where it stood. And *keep the secrets apart*.

I came back at last to the candidate quarters, half empty, and sat on the edge of my mat, and had the quiet to truly look at the Light token. It was old — older, I thought, than the office it marked — worn to a soft shine by a long file of hands before mine. And the metal was strange to every shop we owned: pale as a winter moon, colder than silver and heavier than gold, and it had taken no breath of tarnish, nor could any file mark it. Someone had *cut* it — there is no humbler word for it — with a care that had no business belonging to a thing so old: at the centre a small smooth disc, pierced clean through by a hole no wider than a hair;

and around the disc, ring upon fine ring, close and even, spreading to the very rim. I set the pierced centre to my eye and looked through it and saw only my own dim wall, and no reason on earth why the hole should be there, nor why a maker so patient had ringed it round so exactly.

I was still turning it over when it slipped my fingers and dropped into the cup of water at my knee, and it fooled my eye. It lay a clear finger's width to the side of where my hand had put it, and nearer the surface than the bottom it rested on, and larger than itself. I moved my head and it swam. I knew the token lay still and the water bent what came off it to my eye — the same trick that had made a stranger's jar of half-water show full from the one side.

And that night, eyes shut, I drew the whole of the beam's road as I had been taught to draw it — every turn and throat and surface of it — and set the drinking-room upon it in its place: one dark bead strung on a line of light. And Light had a name for every part of everything, and no name at all for this. So I went round to the far side of the law and borrowed one from the world of smuggling. *Contraband light*, I named it: light off the ledger, taxed at no gate, kept back in the dark from a house that believed nothing given it was ever lost.

— *Keep the secrets apart, let no one hand hold the whole.* A secret that cannot be surrendered whole, because no one of you holds it whole: the traitor, the captive, the fool with the loose tongue each carry only a fragment, and it outlives the weakest man who keeps it.

— You say that as a man who would very much like to hold the whole himself.

— Every man in my trade would. That is exactly why your people were wise to see to it that none of us can. ... No: let me give you the whole of it, since you have paid me in candour all week and I have answered mostly in tea. I am no disinterested clerk. The Blackwood Foundation offered me a scholarship with a cage built into it, comfortable enough: the single condition of the money was that I give my one life to your people and nothing more. I learned a tongue I was privately certain some dead Victorian had invented to defraud his patrons. I watched men I trained beside spend whole careers on their knees in the dirt to lift a handful of bones three thousand years old; and the very best of them, once in a decade, opens a sealed tomb four or five thousand years old, and is made for life by it. And you sit across this fire, breathing, and hand me eleven thousand years that walks, and argues, and complains that its sandals pinch. Any man of my trade worthy of the name would give his life to stand where you stood as a boy, and count the price a bargain before he had heard it named.

— ... You have never once let that show.

— I am letting it show now, because I am about to ask you for something, and you should know the size of the want behind the asking. Here it is. Not the account: the place. Swear to me that if ever the occasion comes to you, however it comes and whatever it costs, you will take me there.

— ... I will try, Paul. That much I will swear, and mean it. But hear the rest before you thank me for it. I can bring you to the door. Coming to the Mountain has a price, and I do not yet know what yours would be, nor whether you would be asked to pay it standing or kneeling. What the Mountain does with a man of the open land who has seen its inside, I may not be able to undo, even for a man I have come to ... to trust.

— That is fair. I would sooner have an honest “I will try” than a kind lie. A man who has read the book you read me at the Oasis does not expect the door to be free.

— Then it is sworn, on both sides, as far as either of us can swear it. Enough of the Mountain for one morning. I want to give you a thing, and to ask you a thing, and I would rather do neither in this chair. For four days you have tried to get me out of doors for my health, and I have refused you like a sulking child, the pond excepted. Take me out now. I should like to stand under the open sky and show you that I can, I who could not lift my eyes to it at fifteen. Count it your victory. Tell the physician he may have it.

— Gladly. It is a better use of a cold late morning than a beam you have walked me all the way to its source. Come. There is a lawn on the south side, past the glass doors, that no one crosses in this weather.

[—]

— There. You see? I am standing under the whole enormous nothing of it, and I have not fallen down. Now walk with me. Away from the doors, to the middle, where the grass is longest. Good.

— You did not bring me out for the sky.

— No. I brought you out for the one thing this ground has that your room does not: no walls. A wall can be given an ear; grass cannot. Out here there is nothing that hears me but you, and that machine on your shoulder, and I have decided that I trust the machine, because it is yours, and does not lie about what it has heard. So. Will you trust me for a moment, and play a small game with me?

— That depends upon the game.

— It is a game designed for the *man of science* you claim to be. One you should enjoy. You told me this morning that you trust *what survives a test*. I have a test. This afternoon, and the whole of tomorrow, when you go to your work: you told me you spend your afternoons alone in your room, turning the reel. Do not, this once. Go instead and stand behind the glass of the room where you set me down each day. And look. And when we next meet, tell me whether anyone was there.

— Behind the glass.

— You told me no one watched me; that only the tutor sat with me. I believe that you believe it. But a man kept apart does not know what stands on the far side of his own wall. So go and see. If the place is empty, you will have proved me a frightened fool, and I will play your football, and never trouble you with it again. And there is more. I have come to suspect there is a Mirror in this house. Not a person set at a keyhole — I should have caught a person by now — but a thing of glass and angle that watches without a watcher. Four years I stood candidate under the finest eyes my world ever made, looking at my Mirror days and nights, and I know the signs of a watcher better than I know my own name: men who hold things they were never told, who answer the question you did not ask aloud. I have felt that in this house. And you know by now what I say of a thing that has a shape: *that it may be found*. For whom, I cannot tell you. Maybe for you. Maybe for me. Maybe for Sarah. I have never met her. You say she is good, and busy, and set high above us both, and I believe you; I ask it for her. A woman who heads what she heads — are we even certain it is her own people watching her house, and not some other eye set upon her? And this above all the rest: if you do find it — the watcher, or the beam, or the Mirror — be clever, Paul. Say nothing. Let nothing cross your face. In Light we knew its worth. There were rooms in the Mountain that stole off the beam; Light let them run untouched, and marked them — which hand, what light came away short, who called and who left — and drew a truer map than any honest ledger, and not one of those men knew he had been counted. That is the advantage I would put in your hands, Paul; do not spend it on the first cold afternoon.

— And that is the whole of it? A Mirror in the walls, an unnamed eye upon Sarah, and me to go feeling for all of it in the dark and keep my face straight while I do. She runs a great deal, I grant you — ships, fuel, metals, men who matter; it is not impossible she is watched. But that is a very great deal of shadow to hang upon a room you have sat in just a few times.

— That is the whole of it. And if I am proven right, if there are men behind that glass, or a beam, or something else whose shape I do not yet know, then you are mine, Paul. Not the house's. Mine. Your loyalty comes to me.

— That is a large thing to swear on a lawn.

— It is the smallest thing in the world, if I am wrong; and I am so often wrong. It costs you nothing but an afternoon and a promise you are certain can never fall due. Go behind the glass, Paul. For her, if not for me. And swear me the small thing: that survives its test, or does not.

— Very well. If there are men behind that glass, which there will not be, then I am your man. There: it costs me nothing to promise what cannot come to pass. Now put

your face straight before we go in. You look like a young man who has got away with something.

— A young man who has got away with something is the safest man in any house, Paul; no one troubles to watch the pleased ones. Come in out of the cold. You are kept in your cell as I am kept in mine — only yours opens from the inside, and this afternoon I am asking you to do no more than walk through it. I have a physician to satisfy.

— So. The swimming.

— I told you this morning what it cost me, and I have decided I want more of it regardless. Tell the physician he beat me, and that by beating me he has recruited me: I will go back, and go under further than I went, and work at last towards swimming without the armbands. Two days, then. Go and do your looking, Paul. And whatever you find behind that glass — keep your face.

CHAPTER 5

SHADOW

— The twenty-third of March; nine o'clock; the fourth of our interviews. I have brought you two gifts this morning. Here is the first.

— ... Kepler's five solids of *God Himself*. Thank you. They are cold in the hand, and lighter than they look. Beautiful.

— In truth they were another man's invention: *Pythagoras* conceived them; *Kepler* only borrowed them to explain the universe. In any case, as you see, they are hollow: only the edges.

— This one is mine. The fewest faces; the sharpest point; the one you can set down no way but upright, a little flame standing on the table. This one is surely Light's. The cube, perhaps, is Shield: a closed door on every side. The third, for its beauty, may be Faith. The other two I cannot yet place: Justice speaks last, which would leave Balance the fourth, and Justice the largest of them. It is not yet clear to me; I shall think on it.

— The second gift I built myself, from a child's set, and I am not too proud to say I enjoyed it. Gears within gears within gears. You see: a full turn of this first gear makes the second click but once; and a full turn of the second makes the third click once as well. So it would take... how many teeth upon these gears?

[—]

— Forty teeth. So you see, for that last gear to turn once and ring a gong, the second must turn forty times, or sixteen hundred teeth; and sixty-four thousand upon that

first gear. Add two gears more, and we are past a hundred million; and one needs only fifteen million seconds to make half a year. Here, look for yourself.

[—]

— And something of my world in turn. My own kind has lately built the very same design: a clock that ticks once a year, which we take for a wholly new idea. Here, I have printed you a picture of it. And your kind had the same thought eleven and a half millennia ago.

— Is your world under some threat, then? Something you are trying to outlast through time, as we try to outlast the Outsiders?

— Yes; and it moves slowly, across centuries, perhaps millennia. There is much debate as to its nature, whether it is real at all, and what ought to be done. Should you hear of it during instruction, do ask me again. But to return to the clock: your Pendulum, does it ever stop?

— Yes: once in a lifetime, and only for an instant, upon the ascension of a new Keeper of Light. For Light came before Time; and when the chain of Light is renewed, when Light dies and is reborn, God holds His breath for an instant. Then the Pendulum begins again.

— Then it is surely being wound, most likely by a weight. As the weight falls, it yields just enough to overcome the friction that would otherwise still your pendulum within a day, and is raised again at intervals. And with a train of gears upon gears upon gears, the teeth carefully numbered, your clock might be made to strike but twice a year. The toy you may keep, to study. Now, unless you wish to discuss instruction, let us begin.

— You must forgive me the *philosophy of doubt* you would not hear of two days ago. I was taught to see mechanism as doctrine, and doctrine as mechanism; I look upon a thing, and my mind turns it over until I see how the doctrine makes the object. Your clock is the perfect instance of an object whose birth comes from doctrine.

— And what doctrine, what mechanism, did you find in the *Species Odyssey*, in the journey from monkey to man?

— One plain thing the three films would not say aloud, I could not stop hearing underneath it. Your man, climbing up out of the animals across all those ages, and then from nomads to cities to nations: do you know what drove him up the ladder? Not hunger. The beasts have hunger, and stayed beasts. It was that he could be refused. When a group, or a system, can tell a creature no, not you, not now, not yet, that creature will build a wonder to be told yes. And a people that learns to refuse itself, by law, to dam the whole flood and open the gate only on the appointed day: that people turns every ungiven night into a cathedral. Your kind carries a god and a beast in the one skin, Paul, and cannot always tell, in the moment, which of the two is speaking. I learned it watching myself. Everything I ever made of myself, I made to be looked at, once, by a girl of Shield who never quite managed to. The beam, the ascent, the whole

of my cleverness: a boy raising a cathedral to be told yes, and told, in the end, nothing at all. And it frightens me, because I have begun to wonder what a man builds when the girl is a whole world of them, and no night is ever ungiven: whether he raises a greater cathedral than we did, or lies down in the warm water of every easy yes and lets the light go out, and never once wonders why.

— These are subjects our kind is loath to discuss. When such a conversation begins, spirits are apt to be possessed by the Beast, to borrow your language; and it is generally the wiser course to change the subject. Now: how long did it take you to learn every single beam on the Mirror?

Four years: Va-Raedin of Light had told the truth; there was no shorter road. Let me take it up again at the morning Va-Raedin judged me worthy to be taught the five ways that light can lie. I am now nineteen years old.

We entered the first practice hall. He led me past the mirror rooms, past the chamber where the point had trembled on the wall the day I embarrassed myself, and into a low service slit beside a lamp niche. The passage descended. A side passage breathed out cold and earth: the mushroom rooms, racked white to the roof, a woman going down them with a wetted cloth. The lamps were set near the floor, so their light kept my feet visible while the rest of me passed through darkness. The lamp-cleaner's blackest leavings were kept: the soot he scraped from the flues and the lamp-throats was gathered, bound with gum and a little water, and became the ink the records were written in.

At the end stood a plain door of pale wood. He opened it. Beyond was a room almost entirely dark. One lamp burned outside and behind us, high in the passage wall, and its light entered through a narrow slit in the door and cut a single hard line across the floor. He closed the door. The line stayed.

"Five shadows. Today you learn the principal forms by which light lies. The first?"

"Mirrors."

"That is the object. Name the danger."

I looked at the covered mirror, the slit of light, the door at my back.

"Displacement," I said. "Sight away from the body."

He removed the cloth. The mirror beneath was tall and narrow, angled toward the far wall. I saw the door behind me, the slit of light, the passage beyond it, and standing in that passage a figure where no figure stood. I turned before I could

think. The passage was empty. When I looked back into the glass, the figure was still there.

“Who is it?” Va-Raedin asked.

“No one.”

“Then why did you turn?”

“Because I believed the sight before I questioned the path.”

“Good.” He adjusted the mirror by less than a finger’s width. The figure vanished, and in its place was the back of my own head. “A mirror shows what is behind the eye. That is its use, and its corruption. You were shown it — learn the difference, or stay Candidate.”

He covered the mirror.

— Your hands. You have been at something this whole time, and never once looked down. What are you engraving with this needle upon the stone?

— I am doing two things at once. The hands work while the rest of me is elsewhere; you would never know which had my attention.

— And the stone?

— A stone with nothing on its face. For later. Or for nothing; we shall see.

He lowered one lamp and raised another, and the room turned monstrous. The trough became a black wall across the floor. The covered mirror threw a wedge that reached the far stone, and the hard line from the door forked and multiplied wherever it crossed a standing thing.

“Second shadow.”

“Shadows.”

“Object.”

“Interruption.”

“Danger?”

“Assuming darkness is empty.”

“Find what is hidden.”

I looked at the floor first and disliked myself for the predictability. The largest darkness pulled at my eye, so I refused it and looked at the edges instead. The rods cast five dark lines, and the trough a heavy black band. I knelt by the band and found nothing. I stood, looked at the wall, then back to the floor, and there it was — a faint brightness where darkness should have climbed. Something low

was blocking the floor-light alone. I reached into the trough's shadow and found a black cord hanging from a hidden hook.

"What is it?" he asked.

"A cord."

"What does it do?"

I pulled it before I had thought. A panel opened behind me with a hard click, and I froze. It revealed only stone. He crossed the room, closed the panel, and came back.

"Pride pulled it."

I lowered my eyes.

"If that had opened a gate?"

"I should have waited."

"If that had released water?"

"I should have waited."

"If that had alarmed Shield?"

"I should have waited."

"I know that Shield is often on your mind. Keep it there. *Meaning no harm is not the same as remaining harmless.* A Candidate learns where light falls; he does not become master of everything it touches."

"I understand."

"No," he said. "You agree. *Understanding is not required.*"

That struck me before I could stop it: Shield at the cedar gate, and Shield now in Va-Raedin's mouth. Either someone had told him what had been said to me four years ago in the Oasis, or the Mountain's offices had been saying the same sentences to boys for centuries.

"Third shadow."

"Lenses."

"Object."

"False importance."

He let it stand a moment. "Explain."

"A lens makes one thing larger and another disappear. If a man does not know the lens is there, he mistakes focus for importance."

"Better."

The third station held a glass disk hung from three bronze cords. Behind it, on the wall, were five dark marks no larger than seeds. A side lamp threw light

through the disk so that one seed-mark swelled into a patch the size of my palm while the others nearly vanished.

"Which mark matters?" he asked.

"Closest to what?"

"To judgment."

"That is not a place."

"It is sometimes a place. You only learn its position too late."

I moved around the disk. The large mark blurred when I stepped aside; another, nearly invisible from the first position, sharpened; lowering my eye swelled the second while the first smeared.

"None matters by itself," I said. "The lens grants the importance."

"The hand that places the lens grants it. The lens only obeys its shape." He tilted the disk, and the enlarged mark stretched into a long black wound. "What is it now?"

"The same mark."

"Would a crowd know that?"

"No."

I looked at the wound-shaped mark. "Light must know how easily the seed became a wound."

"Good."

We worked the lenses until my eyes ached. Glass disks, water-filled bulbs, oil jars, thin plates that widened light or narrowed it or sharpened one edge while ruining another. He made me stand close, then far, then above and below, then with one eye shut, then viewing by reflection first.

"Third shadow?"

"Focus creates false importance."

"And the danger?"

"Seeing sharply can be another form of blindness."

Nothing moved in his face. "Careful. That one is almost useful."

He allowed water then — a small cup, plain clay. I drank too fast and caught myself watching the rim instead of the room.

"Any thoughts on water?" he said.

"It does strange things. I noticed it properly for the first time when I dropped my token in a jar, the day after I earned it."

"Misuse teaches: the wrong instrument, in the wrong hand, in the wrong room, held with an erring intent. That is how a thing is found. Whether the finder outlives his finding is a second lesson, and not one Light sets out to teach."

In English

— Hey Paul, knock knock.

— Good Lord. Not him. ...Who is there?

— Norma Lee.

— Heaven help me. ...Norma Lee who?

— "Normally" I would not interrupt an Englishman during his bedtime story. But you said *as soon as it is ready*. Here, the report you asked for.

[—]

— Urs, ... Is this some manner of a sick joke?

— Yes. That is exactly it. A very sophisticated prank, Paul. Three vehicles, seventeen men, two aircraft, three borders, a physician kept a whole year on retainer, holes dug in the desert to hide diesel, money enough to light a city. A secret extraction *op* in the middle of the desert, just so we might sit a lunatic down in front of *Carl Sagan*. Please do try to keep up, for the indecency of how much you are paid. He is a new kind of human, Paul. Well, in truth, a very old one. Sarah gave him its name not five minutes ago: he is *Homo Noxius* now.

— Urs!

In German

— Dummkopf! [*Door slam*]

In Noxius

— Ignore him, please continue.

The fourth room was bright, white-walled, severe. A fixed lamp cast a beam down through a bronze slit onto a table cut with narrow channels. At the far end, under glass, lay a small black mark. The beam fell too far left to touch it.

"Strike the mark with light."

I inspected the apparatus. The lamp was fixed; so was the slit. No mirror, no plate, no hidden aperture offered itself. On the table stood clear water, oil, crystal, a cloudy cup and a sealed clay pot.

"May I move the vessels?"

"Yes."

"May I open the pot?"

"No."

I began with clear water. The beam crossed it and turned, short of the mark. Oil thickened it and blurred its edge. Crystal turned it more sharply but broke the light where I needed a single clean point. The cloudy liquid scattered too much, waking the beam inside the cup and leaving it weak beyond.

"Name the event."

"The beam changes path when it crosses a substance."

"Which substance?"

"Water, oil, glass, whatever the cloudy liquid is."

"And air?"

I almost dismissed air. Then I remembered the desert trembling in its own heat, the mist shining behind Faith's rehearsal in the passage above the work hall, the blue flame in the Hall bending toward Ka-Elun of Faith. "Air also," I said.

"Usually less. Not never."

No single vessel struck the mark cleanly. Water and crystal broke the beam. Oil before water made it wander; water before oil came closer but ruined the edge. I wanted the clay pot, and he watched me want it.

"What is in the pot?" I asked.

"That is what you are asking permission to learn."

"Salt."

He said nothing. The lid was sealed with Balance green wax — a marked pot on a table of water and turning light. Salt would change the water. I lifted the cloudy cup, smelled it, found the mineral bitterness.

"Salted water."

Still no confirmation. I set the cloudy cup under the beam. The light turned more than in clear water, less cleanly than through crystal, and struck near the mark. I moved the cup a finger's width and the beam touched the black point.

"Acceptable. Again, without the salted cup."

I looked at the table, then at the sealed pot. "May I open it now?"

"No."

Clear water, oil, crystal, the salted cup removed, the sealed pot, the fixed lamp, the black mark, the channels in the table. I had taken the channels for drainage, though I had no idea what they were meant to drain. I scraped a little white grain from the table's edge with my fingernail.

"That is theft from Balance," Va-Raedin said.

"It was already spilled. It was already unmeasured."

I stopped. Then he said, "Continue."

I stirred the grains into the water. Nothing changed to the eye. I put the recess under the beam and the light turned a little more — and fell short. Another scrape, more stirring, another test. Each scrape from the table felt more like theft than the last. At last the beam struck the mark cleanly.

“How much salt?”

“Enough.”

“A cook’s answer.”

“I do not know.”

“A dangerous answer, but honest.”

“It looks the same,” I said, looking at the water.

“Many changed things do.”

“And the light knows.”

“If one knows where to look. The turn is the measure, Sa-Kailan: whether the jar holds water or oil, and how much salt is dissolved in it, the light will tell you by the angle alone, near enough to the grain. There is more past a Candidate’s knowledge: how a substance can block light, or filter it, or split it, and that the measure of the light is the measure of the substance — part of a Veil’s curriculum, if you ever become it. Fourth shadow?”

“Turning. Light changes path when it crosses substance.”

He took the bowl away before I could study it further.

The last chamber held a long trough of clear water set into black stone. A narrow tube beneath it carried light from a hidden source up into the water itself. At one end, below the waterline, a small white mark had been painted; at the other, a bronze plate stood dry outside the trough. The beam travelled underwater toward the surface at a shallow angle and vanished.

“Make the beam strike the bronze plate.”

I leaned over the trough. The beam came up against the water’s skin so shallow that if it escaped it should strike the air above and reach the plate. It stayed. I passed my hand above the surface; no light touched me. I crouched lower, and at the surface the beam turned downward and stayed inside the water.

“It cannot leave,” I said.

“What cannot?”

“The light. No — the beam. When it reaches the surface at that angle, it does not pass into air. It returns into the water.”

“Like what?”

“A mirror.”

“Water is not a mirror.”

“The surface is.”

“Why?”

I looked at the angle, then at the surface. The line had changed. “If the beam rises steeply, it leaves. If it comes too shallow, the surface holds it.”

“Threshold return,” he said. “Every crossing has a condition. Some thresholds forgive. Some refuse.”

The phrase sounded old — retrieved from somewhere deeper in Light.

“Change it,” he said. “Make it leave.”

I searched for controls. The source stood fast. The tube, the trough, the beam’s angle — all fixed. A lever raised the water by the width of a fingernail; the beam returned. I lowered it; no use. I disturbed the surface with a rod; the beam scattered and resumed.

“Do not bruise water because you dislike its answer.”

I stepped back. Change the condition. “Salt,” I said.

This time a small open dish of coarse crystals waited beside the trough. I took a pinch and let it fall. The grains sank and dissolved, and the surface gave me back exactly the mirror it had shown before — no thread, no glimmer, no change at all.

“Worse,” I said.

“Worse for what?”

“For reaching the plate.”

“For leaving the water, yes.”

That told me what to do. Salt had moved the threshold. More salt held the beam in, so thinner water should let it out. So I thinned the water, clear from a side vessel, a little at a time — and for a long while it gave me nothing. Then, between one pour and the next, it broke: a single thread escaped flat along the surface, so nearly level with the water that it was barely a leaving. I thinned it further, and the thread lifted — a little higher with each pour, climbing off the water in even steps as the water weakened — until it reached the bronze plate and struck the lower edge. A pale mark appeared on the metal.

“Acceptable.”

“No.” The word came out before I could stop it. He turned. I felt the danger at once, but my eagerness still ran ahead of me. “I mean — this is more than acceptable.”

“What is it?”

I tried to slow the words enough to make them lawful. “It is a surface that becomes a mirror without being made into one.”

“Fifth shadow?”

“The same trough can show, or hide, or carry. A man looking down may see nothing, or see himself, or see through, or never know that light is moving beneath him.”

He covered the salt.

“That is enough.”

“No.” Again, too quick. I lowered my voice. “Please. One more thought. If the source is fixed, and the mark is fixed, and the angle is fixed, the answer is still not fixed.”

He regarded me in silence. “You have learned too much for one day.”

He opened a hidden plug. The water drained, the beam broke and blurred and guttered into useless glow, and everything went ordinary again — a trough of wet stone, a plate of plain bronze.

“You ended it,” I said.

“I ended your belief that discovery entitles continuation.”

A silence entered, new to me. At last he said, “A Candidate learns where light falls.”

I knew the answering sentence. *A Veil learns who placed it.* I kept it. “A Candidate also learns where he has been made to stand,” I said instead.

He held my gaze. Then, unexpectedly, he laughed once — a short, unwilling sound, was it pride?

We came out near the northern practice corridor. Beyond the walls the ordinary Mountain went on — carts, children, water, the drag of gate chains, low voices.

At the candidate entrance he turned. “You will write nothing of today.”

“No.”

“You will not speak of salted water to another Candidate.”

“No, Veil.”

“You will not ask Balance for salt outside assignment.”

“No, Veil.”

“You will not attempt threshold return in basin, cup, jar, trough, or any other vessel whose proper use your curiosity believes it can improve.”

I looked down. “No, Veil.”

“Good.” This time the word was final.

He began to turn away, then stopped.

“Sa-Kailan.”

“Yes?”

“What did you learn?”

I could have named the five shadows again and made them clean and pleasing. I wanted the praise Va-Raedin gave when an answer settled neatly into place for him.

“I learned that a path can be hidden inside a lesson.”

His face held my gaze. Then he left.

— I enjoyed our walk yesterday, Paul. I should like to try it again, and stand under the open light a little longer than I managed. Tell the physician it is his victory and his cure; he need not learn that it is also mine.

— Shall I leave the machine indoors, since we are only walking?

— No. Keep it on you, and keep it running.

[—]

— Now: the glass. You went behind it. Tell me only what you saw, and spare me none of it.

— You felt it before I named it — you called it a mirror in the house, and you were not wrong. We call it CCTV: closed-circuit television. Think of the images the tutor show you in our lessons, cut and ordered in advance to teach a thing; take away the teaching and the cutting, and let it run by itself, every hour, on every corner of the grounds. Each eye stands where a shield warden would stand and never blinks; some can tell on their own when a body crosses a line it should not, which is how a few men hold a property this size without an army walking it. What the eyes see, the house keeps, so that Sarah, who pays for all of this, may run the hours back when she has one to spare between two meetings. Do not take it for malice — it guards you, and it guards you from me. I could have told you a day sooner, and I knew a day sooner; but you are not the only bargain I keep in this house, and yesterday two of them crossed — my word to you to hide nothing, and my word to her to move nothing without her leave. I chose the one who pays me. I asked her last night whether I might tell you. She said yes.

— ... You chose the one who pays you, and told me so to my face. The eye troubled me only while I did not know whose it was; now I do, and that is one thing fewer in the dark. ... I will trade you a truth for it: I found your eye before you named it.

— Behind the glass there was a panel, and set into it a small device for the making of images — the same art as the pictures on the clocks, save that this one makes them of its own accord, without a hand, and keeps them. I stood and looked at it a long while. It was joined to nothing: no wire, nothing to carry off what it took. So I did not touch it, and I did not hurry. In time a man came, opened the device, drew out its memory,

set a fresh one in its place, and went away, and never knew I had watched him. Roger Martinez, Sarah's man, senior on what they call the uranium desk. He came up under Edward and serves Sarah now. Blackwood trades in uranium — a yellow rock that can put light into whole cities; there is little of it in the world, and one of the few places it lies in strength is your desert. Martinez does not deal at a distance; he goes himself into the contested ground and signs the shabby paper for the House, as he did for Edward before her. He has done business in many of the countries that ring your mountain. Beyond that, I do not know him.

— This is your world, and I understand less than half of it; but I can still be of use. A man who serves one house and keeps a second record for himself — could he be climbing? Betraying the hand he serves to rise above it?

— ... It is possible. It is more than possible. There is already an eye in that room — Sarah's, the same as everywhere; whatever it takes goes to her. So a man has no cause to carry off a second memory by hand ... unless he keeps a record of his own, that does not run to Sarah at all. *Young minds love to turn traces into stories*, to borrow your word again. And I have only a trace — so I have not told her, and I will not, yet. It was your bargain that bought this: a small part of what I learn stays between us, and this is that part. Give me time, and I will learn what I can without asking the one question that would tell whoever it concerns that I am asking.

— ... Then I shall put my needle and my stone away; for now.

— What are they for?

— I will confess what I brought them up here for, since I am putting them down: I meant to make you kneel under this tree and swear yourself into an order, a drop of your blood on the stone, a name to carry to your grave. I invented the order yesterday. I have a talent for inventing my own destiny, faster sometimes than I can think it through. ... I sat with the small beasts too long tonight, and forgot the second half of my own teaching. There is a rule I live by: protect first, understand after; a warning is enough, a shape is enough, you do not wait for proof. It has kept my people alive longer than your kind has had a name. But it has a second half I did not give you, and nearly forgot myself — that the same rule, used alone, has killed more innocent men than any enemy ever did. I was about to prick a man into a war on a shadow and a wet lawn. The needle goes back in the cloth. Another day, perhaps. Not this one.

— Then what becomes of your order?

— Nothing becomes of it. I built it in my own head to get through the night, and there it can stay. ... You want me to make it grand; I will not. Shield stands at the wall and looks outward. In that room I saw the wall is nothing to what is already inside it, and I thought a man ought to stand the other way about — in the shadow the wall throws, where the eye of this house cannot reach. So: Shadow. You have it now. I will

hang no doctrine on it — and I swear you into nothing, ask you nothing, promise you nothing.

— Then why tell me at all?

— Because you have the eye I do not. This is your world; I understand less than half of it, and I will misread it every time I try, as I nearly did today. If there is an enemy within this house — and I do not say there is; I say only that a man carried off a memory that had no reason to be carried — then drawing him into the light would be a great service to the Mountain, and to Sarah, and to you. You are placed to see it; I am not. ... But take the one thing I know better than all the rest, as the whole of what I give you today: to cross a threshold is never free. I crossed one as a young man, into a room I was never meant to enter, and it cost me the rest of my life — and I would do it again, and I am telling you to weigh that cost before you go looking, and not after. Which doors to leave shut is yours to judge. You have the lens.

— ... Then I will carry it, and keep my face over it.

— Keep it well. We go back down as we came up — nothing changed, nothing shown. Whatever we choose from here, we choose behind our own eyes, where not even the eye of this house can follow.

CHAPTER 6

FESTIVAL

— The twenty-fifth of March; quarter to nine; the fifth of our interviews. Did you like *Les grands mythes : L'Iliade et l'Odyssée* from ARTE? It was in another language, but subtitled in yours just the same. I hope that did not trouble you. We aim to teach, and we aim to entertain, and a story this old does both at once. It is one of our oldest.

— Yes. A wedding; an apple; three who quarrelled over it. And the war that followed. I have had it since yesterday evening. ... There were five in that room, Paul. Your tellers say three. There were five, and they are mine.

— Go on.

— I have finally found a use for these solids you brought me. *Eris*, the one who throws the golden *Apple of Discord* to the fairest, makes no vanity, invents no rivalry, produces no bribery. She only sets a thing down where they become visible, and steps back, and lets them show themselves. She is my *tetrahedron* flame. She is Light. *Hera*, offers rank, and takes the refusal of rank for an injury that must be punished. She thinks of precedent, and the sequence of things. She is Justice. She is my *dodecahedron*. Not the biggest one like I thought before. The one where the faces have all five sides, for Justice must listen to all five sides before judging. *Athena* offers wisdom and offers it only in the shape of winning, glory and battles; Shield would recognize her across a hall. She is my *cube*. There. *Aphrodite* offers desire through *Helen of Sparta*, for desire outweighs both the others, which is how Faith may have tempted the murderer, your ancestor. She is my *octahedron*. The two pyramids stacked onto each other. A point upwards

to God, a point downwards to the Beast. And finally your *Zeus*, the one they ask to judge and puts the whole of it into the hand of a prince of *Troy*. He is the biggest one, my *Icosahedron*. He is Balance, for Balance does not ask who deserves the apple; it asks where the weight can lie without tipping the world. *Kepler* was right.

Geometry is God Himself.

Or in this case, Gods. Plural.

— ...

— Five offices. One room. Before the war. Each doing what its nature requires and none of them holding the whole of it, and afterward not one answerable for the aftermath. Somebody set that story in front of me on purpose.

— That is not mine to say. ... One fact only, since you have met *Eris*: she was not asked to the wedding. They left her off the list, because she spoils things. She came to the door of it anyway, and threw the apple through the Threshold in as she passed. Being shut out was the whole of her reason.

— ... You hand me a story like that, one of your oldest, and you never once tell me which reading of it is the true one. In your world, who is permitted to say?

— Anyone. Anyone can say it, anyone can say the opposite, and it stays open.

— Then hear what that is, from where I stand. I set two tellings beside each other once. For the seeing of it I was taken out of my office, tried in a sealed room by five Keepers, and sentenced to be executed. Not for taking anything. For laying two stories side by side and reading the seam. And a tutor does the same here, after lunch, for a foreigner, and calls it an afternoon's work.

— I want to put something against that, because you are making us better than we are. That freedom is about three hundred years old where I come from, and it is not evenly spread even now. We burned people for the wrong reading. We had a century of war over which telling of one book was allowed. What you are calling our nature is a settlement. It was paid for, and it can be taken back.

— The *Genesis* gravure on the south wall of my Hall. One story, given, cut into stone so that nothing can ever be set beside it — in a room with no second wall. There is no second interpretation. On the first morning you asked me about it.

I kept arranging the five lessons. Reflection, shadow, focus, turning, threshold return — I carried them everywhere.

Weeks passed. The lessons stopped. Instruction became ordinary again, which I found almost insulting. Lamps cleaned, mirrors adjusted, wicks trimmed, old smoke scraped from the high vents. Twice I spent a whole morning learning how

an unclean mirror could betray a sealed door by scattering the light it should have sent back in one clean line.

“Boredom is useful,” Va-Raedin said on the third such morning.

When no lesson was given, I searched in the places where I could pass the searching off as service. I studied the great gravure on the southern wall until it blurred. I watched how the lamps struck the carved hand of God differently at morning and at evening. The geometry refused me.

Then Ka-Syphiron of Light summoned me.

The summons came through Va-Raedin at the end of a morning exercise so plain I had nearly fallen asleep standing. He waited until the room had emptied.

“Ka-Syphiron will receive you before the second meal.”

The Keeper of Light received me in a room with no view and almost no object: a low table, an unlit lamp, three polished stones, one chair for him and none for me. He stood when I entered.

He had the cold beauty of something kept too long — white hair, fine hands, a face so still that any show of feeling seemed out of place beside it. He wore no ceremonial robe, only pale cloth with a thread of gold at the throat.

“Sa-Kailan of Light,” he said.

“Keeper.”

“Va-Raedin tells me you are quick.”

I wavered. “I try to learn.”

“Trying is common. Learning is less so. Understanding is rarer. Wisdom is rarer still.”

He gestured to a stone set before him, to stand on. I stepped onto it.

“Tell me what a Veil of Light is.”

The answer came easily, and I regretted it the moment it was out. “A Veil learns who placed the light.”

“That is doctrine. I asked what a Veil is.”

I hesitated. “The one who has crossed beyond Candidate instruction.”

“By what act?”

I looked at the unlit lamp on the table. I already had the answer, and had forgotten it. “By finding the Veil’s Chamber.”

“Yes.”

“The title is not given for cleverness,” he said. “Not for age, not for loyalty, not for hunger, not for the admiration of one’s teacher. A Candidate of Light

becomes Veil of Light by finding the Veil's Chamber. Until then he is Candidate, whatever he believes he has understood."

I felt the words arrange themselves around me like bars. "And if he never finds it?"

"Then he never becomes Veil."

"Even if the Keeper dies?"

"The Mountain does not owe a man the office he failed to reach."

I thought of Va-Raedin. He had found the Veil's chamber long ago. Had he stood on this stone once, in front of another Keeper, young, hiding his hunger?

"Does the Chamber teach the next path?" I asked.

"You are not yet entitled to next paths."

He crossed to the table and touched the unlit lamp, unhurried, the way a man tests a familiar instrument. "You have the flaw of many gifted candidates," he said, almost warmly. "You think a locked door is an insult addressed personally to you. It was hung before you were named. Sometimes a locked door is only a mercy you have not yet earned the right to resent — and sometimes it is a very patient kind of grave. From the outside they look identical."

"Look at me." I looked. "You are seen," he said. "Not celebrated. Seen. Va-Raedin sees speed in you. I see appetite. Speed may serve Light. Appetite must be disciplined before it convinces itself that hunger is revelation."

The younger brother from the Book of Blood came into my mind without my calling him — a small, cunning boy, watching a strength that others loved until *envy entered him as a serpent entereth the grass*.

"You may go," he said.

He had shut off every way I could stand: if I held still, it would look like the failure he had described; if I moved, like the appetite he had named.

I tried twice to follow Va-Raedin. The first time he stopped without turning and told me I was making noise with my left sandal. The second cured me. I waited near the old Light gallery where I had seen the five markings, certain he would return there after evening instruction, and held still until my legs ached and I was proud of my patience. Then a junior attendant walked in, handed me a folded note, and left. The note read: *A hidden watcher should not cast such a visible shadow*. After that I stopped following Va-Raedin.

For several days I stayed away from the Hall of Ceremony, to spare myself the admission of why I went there: to search it. Then I went anyway. The chamber

received me with indifference; one restless Candidate weighed nothing against stone laid down before my great-grandfathers were named.

I began with the architecture and failed. Then I turned to scripture. Faith had preserved the oldest words, and kept chambers barred to Light; Faith's rites opened doors that stayed sealed to every lamp Light owned.

Ka-Elun of Faith was too high and too newly enthroned. I requested audience with Va-Maera of Faith instead, through the public petition line beside the Hall of Ceremony. She was older than Ka-Elun by several years. Outside Faith that arrangement looked strange; inside Faith no one thought about it at all.

She received me in a narrow chamber outside the Hall of Prayers. The room held no ornament but a covered bowl of water and a hanging cord of five knots. No lamp showed, yet the light came softly from somewhere above. She stood the whole time. She wore white, a heavier white than the attendants, layered and severe, her hair fully covered, her face unpainted, her eyes dark and steady. She was an administrator, and holiness had only made her sharper.

"Sa-Kailan of Light, you request access to the Hall of Prayers," she said.

"Yes, Veil."

"Why?"

"To study the Covenant."

"The Covenant is read publicly."

"Not all of it."

"No."

"I am Candidate of Light."

"I see your robe."

"I seek the Veil's Chamber."

The words sounded too naked the moment they were out. She kept her face still. "Then seek it in Light."

I had prepared careful sentences. In the corridors they had seemed subtle. "Faith works closely with Light," I said. "In ceremony. In mist. In timing. In the way certain signs are made visible. I have seen enough to know that what people call miracle may depend on arrangements not everyone understands."

The air changed. The room became suddenly smaller.

She took one step toward me. "Say that again."

I kept silent.

"Good," she said. "Some doors stay closed because the fool outside them still has one living instinct."

"I did not mean—"

"You meant enough. You come to Faith wearing Light's new hunger, and because a lamp and a valve once agreed in front of your clever eyes, you think you stand above the people who kneel? You think you have found a crack in Faith? You have found a crack in yourself."

"I was asking for access," I said, and the sentence failed while I was still speaking it.

"No. You were suggesting that Faith should fear what you might know."

I felt cold under my robe. She came closer.

"You have learned small tricks of perception and mistaken them for height. Do you think God is disproved by a valve? You are not the first bright child to discover that some blessing may have a mechanism. You may be the first foolish enough to speak of it as leverage in a house of prayer."

I lowered my eyes. I could feel my pulse in my throat.

"We speak with archangels of obedience and demons of appetite. We keep names that may not be spoken where children sleep. We know prayers for birth, and for madness, and for plague, and for the moment before a condemned man understands that mercy will not interrupt justice. We comfort mothers whose children have been given to roles that will consume them. We know punishments your little training rooms have never heard of. And you come to me with mist?"

I stayed where I stood.

"There is a prayer we keep for the ones who trouble the Mountain. It asks for no harm, and names no punishment. It is said at an hour I will keep from you, by mouths I will keep from you. I have said it three times in my life. Three times it was answered, and I will tell you nothing of how. You may think on that tonight, in place of sleep."

She let the silence do its work, then went on, softer still.

"You came to me to trade in what other men fail to see. Child, nothing of you goes unseen in this house. The dream you woke from this morning. The thing you have decided to want and confessed to no one. All of it reached this hall before you climbed the stair to it. Faith has held your whole weather since before you could speak."

Then her voice, which had fallen almost to a whisper, came back all at once and filled the little room. "Look at me." She crossed the last of the floor and set her face a hand's breadth from mine, close the way a blade is close. She stood shorter than I did, and towered over me.

"You understand almost nothing, and there is no sin in that. Your sin is that you have begun to suspect it and decided to compensate by becoming dangerous."

Continue, and you will become an example, spoken of carefully to other gifted boys, and no god of hidden knowledge at all.”

I folded. “I withdraw the request,” I said.

“Of course you do.”

“I apologise, Veil.”

“No. You submit. Apology is what people offer when they still hope to manage the injury.”

I could barely speak. “I submit.”

She stepped back. “You may listen in the Hall of Ceremony like any child, elder, worker, mourner, or sinner. You may pray where prayer is permitted. You may not enter the Hall of Prayers. You may not request private scripture. You may not speak again of Faith’s arrangements unless Faith first asks what you think you have seen.”

“Yes, Veil.”

“And Sa-Kailan?”

“Yes?”

“If you truly seek Light, learn first that not every brightness belongs to you.”

She dismissed me with a movement of two fingers.

I left that chamber shaking, and hated the shaking only after I had gone three corridors and found that no one had followed.

I imagined Ka-Syphiron of Light looking at me with calm recognition, as though appetite had behaved exactly as he had predicted. But the Hall was public, and public devotion protected me from suspicion. An old woman touched my sleeve one morning and told me my mother must be proud.

Months passed that way. I heard ration prayers, birth blessings, mourning chants, and fragments of the Covenant, repeated so often that older meanings began to surface from under the words.

Va-Sheva found me once in that season, in a corridor near the washing pools, and I was so glad of it that I had answered every question she asked before it occurred to me to wonder why Shield wanted a Candidate’s account of who came and went from Faith’s chambers. She thanked me. She said I had grown thin, and that I should eat, and that I had always been the quickest of us; and she was gone before the pleasure of it had finished arriving. That season kept us apart.

The Book of Genesis came often in those months, and once, during the long preparation for the seasonal Festival, in full. Ka-Elun of Faith read it herself that day from beneath the central gravure. Her Keeper’s cowl fell cleanly around her

face, covering the pilgrim scars that had once made me stare. The Hall was full, short of ceremonial-full. I sat on the northern tier and listened the way a man searches a wall for a seam.

She began.

In the beginning God created the heaven and the earth. And the earth was without form, and void; and darkness was upon the face of the deep. And the Spirit of God moved upon the face of the waters. And God said, Let there be light: and there was light. And God saw that it was good: and God divided the light from the darkness. And God called the light Day, and the darkness He called Night. And the evening and the morning were the first day.

And God said, Let there be a division in the midst of the deep, and let it divide the heights from the depths. And God made the sky above, and the ground beneath, and the pit below the ground: and it was so. And God called the sky Heaven, and the ground Earth, and the pit He called Hell. And God set the Earth between Heaven and Hell, that the living should walk between the eye above and the fire beneath. And the evening and the morning were the second day.

And God said, Let the waters under the heaven be gathered together unto one place, and let the dry land rise above them: and it was so. And God gathered the waters beneath the earth, and hid them in the hollow places of the deep; and the dry land appeared, and from the dry land He raised the Mountain. And God said, Let the waters bring forth a spring within the shadow of the Mountain, and let the spring be hidden from the eye of heaven: and it was so. And the spring came forth in the shadow of the Mountain, and there was grass around it, and trees for shade, and the green herb yielding seed, and the fruit tree yielding fruit after his kind whose seed is in itself, upon the Earth. And God called the spring in the shadow of the Mountain Oasis: and God saw that it was good. And God said, Let there be a forest round about the Mountain and the Oasis, and let rivers run through the forest, and let the trees be many, and let their branches give shade unto the living: and it was so. And the forest grew round about the Mountain, and the rivers ran through it, and the waters thereof gave life to every root and beast and creeping thing. And the evening and the morning were the third day.

And God said, Let there be a desert round about the forest and the rivers, to divide the forest from the lands beyond, and to set thirst and wandering before the stranger: and it was so. And God called the desert the Threshold; and He set heat upon it by day, and cold upon it by night, and mirage upon its face, that no man should cross it lightly. And God said unto the living, The Mountain is refuge, and the Oasis is water, and the forest is plenty, and the rivers are life; but beyond the forest thou shalt not wander, for beyond the forest lieth thirst, and the eye of Heaven, and the forgetting of My shadow. And God saw that the hidden place was good. And the evening and the morning were the fourth day.

And God said, Let us make man in our image, after our likeness: and let him walk upon the Earth, between the eye above and the fire beneath. And God formed Adam from the dust of the Mountain, and breathed into him the breath of life; and Adam became a living soul. And God said, It is not good that man should be alone in the shadow of the Mountain: and God caused a deep sleep to fall upon Adam, and he slept; and from his side God made Eve, and brought her unto the Oasis. And God blessed them, and God said unto them, Be fruitful, and multiply, and keep the Oasis, and dwell in the shadow of the Mountain; and eat of the fruit of the forest, and drink of the rivers thereof, but wander not beyond the forest. And Eve bare five children unto Adam; and the first opened her eyes unto the light, and the second drank from the waters, and the third laid his hand upon the stone, and the fourth took up the blade, and the fifth lifted her voice unto Heaven. And God saw Adam, and Eve, and their five children in the Oasis, beneath the shadow of the Mountain; and God saw that it was very good. And the evening and the morning were the fifth day.

The Hall answered with bowed heads. I remained still.

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- May I interrupt now? You said before not to interrupt scripture.
 - Yes. That is the whole of the first book of the Covenant, the *Book of Genesis*. And it is the whole of the Genesis gravure also, which you asked me of on the first morning: those same five days, cut into the southern wall in stone instead of spoken.
 - One moment please, let me fetch a book from the library.

[—]

— Here. You cannot read it, for it is in my tongue, English. But let me say it aloud in yours:

*In the beginning God created the heaven and the earth.
And the earth was without form, and void; and darkness
was upon the face of the deep. And the Spirit of God moved
upon the face of the waters. And God said, Let there be
light: and there was light. And God saw the light, that it
was good: and God divided the light from the darkness.
And God called the light Day, and the darkness He called
Night. And the evening and the morning were the first day.*

— It starts almost exactly the same, but goes on for much longer. How many of these thin pages are there in your book?

— More than a thousand.

— We only have *The Five Books of the Covenant*, and whatever Faith keeps hidden in its chambers. Could you have it translated, just the *Genesis* part? I should like to compare the texts.

— This, in truth, would be only chapter one of *Genesis*, which contains fifty. That one chapter, I could translate myself, and give you when next we meet. Let us continue.

In childhood I had taken Genesis in before I was old enough to question anything. I searched the reading for the Veil's Chamber and found nothing useful.

More weeks passed. No one troubled a Candidate who sat through readings with lowered eyes. Faith approved of me; Balance approved of anyone who sat still without consuming resources; even Va-Raedin, if he knew, gave no sign.

The first three I saw everywhere. But turning and threshold return stood outside ordinary prayer. They needed substance, angle, precision: water placed where light had a reason to enter, a beam disciplined enough to be bent, a surface struck at exactly the right condition. The Hall had water in basins and bowls and ritual vessels, and none of it sat in the path of a serious beam.

Then came the Festival of Equal Light.

It fell in the season when day and night were said to stand before Justice and neither could accuse the other of theft. Balance used it to review the stores — seed, water, births, deaths, labour lost. Faith called it older than accounting: the day on

which God's first division of light from darkness was remembered without fear of either.

In the feast-kitchens two women stood over rows of sealed crocks, arguing which had turned too fast. Against a failed harvest Balance kept a standing wall of sealed jars and salted stores; and the best of the grain went sealed into the dry vaults as seed, a whole year's future held back from a hungry one. The ovens had been lit since the dark, and the bakers drew loaf after loaf onto long boards, and along the wall the brewers racked their small-beer in a smell of wet grain.

Light prepared the Hall that season in ways I had never been allowed to watch so closely. The upper apertures were cleaned with white cord. The polished inserts in the central gravure were uncovered and wiped with cloths counted before use and after. The lamps were lowered. Three old vents high above the gravure were opened under Justice's witness and marked in the record at once.

The Hall filled before the Third Measure. I sat on the northern tier, and the tiers packed shoulder to shoulder, and the Hall grew warm with the heat of five thousand bodies long before a lamp was touched. The worker crowded against my side still smelled of the tallow of the shift that had let him go. Ka-Syphiron of Light sat in the northern alcove, remote and pale, his face unreadable above folded hands. Ka-Elun of Faith stood beneath the central gravure, the baskets of seed and the sealed jars set out before her. Shield held the upper doors. Justice sat with its tablets open.

I had sat in that Hall every festival of my life and never thought to question a thing plain in front of me: that the one beneath the gravure was Faith, as Faith had always been a woman, in every telling we kept; and that the one at the tablets was Justice, as Justice had always been a man; while the other three offices — the stone, the sun, the wall — went to whoever had the gift, and no one found it strange. Nor did I wonder, packed shoulder to shoulder with five thousand people, that not one of the couples pressed together on the tiers around me had chosen the other. Faith made the matches, as Faith kept the births and the calendar and the rhythm the people lived by; you were told, in your season, whose you would be, and you were glad of it, because gladness too the Mountain taught early and taught well. I had been raised to call the whole of it the old way, and to feel, looking at it, nothing at all.

The lamps were dimmed one by one. A murmur passed through the Hall, held in check by the rite. Ka-Elun lifted both hands.

God who divided the light from the darkness, measure us.

The Hall answered. "Measure us in mercy."

God who set Earth between Heaven and Hell, steady us.

"Steady us in shadow."

God who hid the spring beneath the Mountain's hand, keep us.

"Keep us from wandering."

The incantation continued, carried in a rhythm that pulled every breath in the Hall into time with it. Faith named the days in their order, down to the five children in the first shadow.

Something in Light's preparations had begun to disturb me. The dimmed lamps. The unsealed upper aperture. The polished fragments inside the gravure. A ceremony about equal light, held in a Hall whose whole design was to govern when and where the dark came in.

"*Let there be light,*" Ka-Elun of Faith said — speaking the words now, as though the hour obeyed her voice. And at the Third hour, the Measure, the Mountain's noon, the sun entered.

At first it was only a pale line high on the wall above the central gravure, so thin I almost missed it. I turned to follow where it fell. It crossed the Hall and touched the carved division between Day and Night on the *pillar of Light*. Ka-Elun of Faith went on speaking. The line brightened. And where it struck the pillar, a mirror I had never once seen took the beam and sent it straight down.

My breath stopped. A mirror. It was the *first shadow*.

I had studied that pillar for months and found nothing, and now the reason stood plain: it wore its fittings by the hundred, bosses and studs and small carved figures crowded rim to rim, so that the eye slid across all of them and settled on none. The mirror sat among them, one glint among hundreds, the only working thing in that whole crowded field.

My mind arranged the five lessons so fast it frightened me. Reflection, shadow, focus, turning, threshold return. A fixed beam. A rare day. A public rite. Heaven itself had set the angle. The path showed itself on the right day and on no other.

Unless one waited for the Festival. Unless one chased the beam. Now.

Ka-Elun's voice went on above me, solemn and beautiful, and I barely heard it. Va-Maera's warning returned — *not every brightness belongs to you*. Va-Raedin's

prohibitions returned — no salt, no vessels, no threshold return outside instruction.

I rose before I had decided to rise. The Hall was bowed in prayer, the lamps were dim, every eye trained toward holiness. No one watched one Candidate on the northern tier moving too carefully between bodies.

A Faith attendant met me in the side passage, a covered bowl against her hip.

“Candidate?”

“Light service,” I said.

The lie was small, and nothing was going to stop me. I was on a clock.

I followed it down. The beam came out at the pillar’s foot and fell on the floor. Somewhere in the throat of the shaft it had passed through red glass, for the light that reached the stone had lost every colour but one: a deep, steady red. It made rings: a small disc at the centre, and around it ring upon ring of light and dark, close-set, even, going faint at the rim — the rings a dropped stone leaves on a still pool, and never moving. I had seen that shape before. The place of it escaped me, and the sun was moving, and I filed the miracle for later. Why was there a pattern where there should be a beam? Because something was in the way.

Shadow.

I looked up. An insert in the ceiling: a thin disc of pale metal on a stem, set square in the beam a little above my head, throwing every ring of it down onto the floor. I took it out of its seat with a thumbnail. It had been made to come out. The rings went out of the world. What lay on the floor was a clean disc of red light with an edge you could have cut bread against. The clean disc lay on bare stone and went no further. Then I saw that the stone beneath the disc was a separate piece. The same grey. The same grain. And a seam no wider than a hair, running round it in a circle so true that only a made thing could hold it. It was a lid. It came up far too light for its size, hollowed underneath, and beneath it a shaft went down into the Mountain, and the beam went down with it. There was a stair beside the shaft. I took it, and the dark closed over me. No lamp. No wick. From that moment there was nothing in the world but the beam and what the beam touched. The first chamber below was a mirror and a hole and a table. The beam struck a mirror set at the floor, stood up horizontal, crossed the room at the height of my chest, and hit the far wall around a hole a third of the size it needed to be: a broad clean ring on the stone, and a poor middle of it going through into the dark.

Focus.

On the table lay glass. Discs, bulbs, plates thick at the middle and plates thin at the middle, oil-filled cells, one long crystal bar. Twenty pieces. No marks, no order, no instruction. The first disc gathered the light, crossed it a hand beyond the glass, and threw it out again wider than it began — a circle the size of my head, and less of it through the hole than with no glass at all. So I caught the light while it was still opening, with one of the thin-waisted ones that spread, and stood it up straight again. The whole beam went through. I opened the door under the hole, went through, and shut it behind me. The beam came through with me, and it had changed. Nothing of it had been thrown away: the same sun, the same quantity, now the thickness of two fingers instead of a forearm. Where it fell, it fell hard. The second chamber turned. A tank stood on a plinth in the middle of the floor. Three-sided: a wedge the width of a man's chest, its point turned toward the right-hand wall. Empty. And in the recess beside it a jar, sealed with green wax, the cup and the sealed jar pressed deep, a black witness line laid across.

Turning.

Breaking that seal would cost me later; the witness line was there to make sure of it. I broke the seal and poured. The beam entered the first face and leaned, crossed, came out through the second and leaned again; and two small leanings, taken in the right order, put the light on the right-hand wall a long way from where it had been going. Not far enough. So I scraped the dried mineral off the rim with two fingers and stirred it in. The turn opened; the light walked along the wall and stopped short. Another scrape. It walked again. The beam went into the aperture, square and clean, and turned the corner of the Mountain, and I followed it. A mirror threw the beam straight down. A second, set in the floor, threw it straight back up, into the underside of a long tank of liquid — and was reflected down by the surface of the water.

Threshold return.

I knew this. This was the trough, and the way out of it was to thin the liquid. So I remixed. It has no hinge. Below the condition the surface is a mirror and gives you nothing — no glimmer. It is perfectly closed. And then it is open, and the light is already out, and out flat, running along the top of the water so nearly level with it that it is barely a departure at all. I kept stirring, thinning it, and the beam rose, and rose, and struck a mirror on the far wall that I had never known was there. And that mirror threw it to another. And that one to another. I got up off my knees. They came out of the dark one after another as the light found them, five, six, high and low, across the whole width of that room, each lit for the half-breath it took to hand the beam on — and the room drew itself out of nothing in the

time it takes to say it, and the last of them put the light through an aperture in the left-hand wall. I put a finger through the left-hand aperture, it clicked, and a door opened.

And there it was. The Veil's Chamber. I had found it. It was low and cold and there was nothing holy in it. No altar. No carved angel. No crown of lamps. No window onto Heaven. Walls smoothed by hand and never polished, and a floor worn in one path from the door. The beam came in from the aperture, through a red glass and crossed the room and put its clean two-finger disc on the far wall. And the far wall was carved. Cut into the stone and filled with white paste, in a circle wider than my two arms: a small disc at the centre, and around the disc, ring upon ring, close-set, even, spreading out and going faint toward the rim. The beam's disc sat exactly in the middle of it. Exactly. The centre of the light on the centre of the carving, and all those rings around it holding nothing at all, empty stone, a pattern with no light in it and no reason to exist.

I stood in front of that wall for a long time. I had seen it on the floor of the passage upstairs an hour ago and filed it for later. I had carried it against my ribs on the token for four years. And there was a thing between me and the wall that I had passed over, because it was plain and I had come down here expecting something holy: a stem rising out of the floor to the height of my chest, and on the stem a shallow cradle of pale metal, empty, set directly under the beam's path. It puzzled me. It held nothing. It was a socket, waiting, and the whole room had been built around it, and it was the only object in the Veil's Chamber of Light.

"You found it."

He was in the doorway. His robe had dust at the shoulder. He was breathing harder than I had heard him breathe in seven years, and his eyes stayed on the wall, the way a man looks at a thing he has decided to stop fearing.

"Va-Raedin—"

"Be quiet a moment. There is no time. I am going to say something to you badly, and I would rather say it badly than not at all."

He came and stood beside me.

"This is going to be one of the important hours of your life. You should know that while it is happening, because almost no one ever does." He was still looking at the wall.

"You have come down a road that took me years to find and cost you a morning, and you did it cleanly, and you are standing there thinking you have arrived at the bottom of Light. Mirrors, shadow, focus, turning, threshold. The five. You think the five is the floor."

"Veil—"

"Nothing prepares you for the next part. Nothing. I was not prepared, and I had a better teacher than you have. It has been a decade and I am not over it." Then he turned his head and looked at me. "Are you ready?"

"Probably not."

"Good. That is the only honest answer, and it will not help you." He nodded at the stem. "The sun is going. You have perhaps forty breaths. Before the beam goes out — put your token on the cradle."

I had it in my fist. I had been holding it since the stair without knowing. I put it in. It fitted the way a bone fits a socket.

The wall came alive. The beam went through the hole in the middle of the token and came out the other side and *opened*. In order. On purpose. Into a disc and a ring and a dark and a ring and a dark, spreading out across the stone, precise as an argument, and every ring of light lay down inside a ring that had been cut into that wall by a hand that has been dust for longer than my people have had a name. Ring for ring. Dark for dark. Out to the rim.

Somebody had known — exactly, to the width of a hair, in a room with no light in it — what that piece of metal would do to a beam of the sun on a day thousand of years after they were buried, and they had cut the answer into the wall and gone away. Of sitting down I remember nothing. I remember the floor being cold.

Because I knew what a shadow was: the shape of a thing that stands in the light. I had taken the disc from the ceiling an hour before and the rings had gone out of the world with it — *a thing had stood in the beam and thrown a shadow, and the shadow had rings in it*. I had let that sentence go past me, because I was in a hurry, and because there is no room in a straight line for rings. Everything I had ever been taught forbade this. A line has a position. That is the whole use of a line — why the Mirror works, why two hundred and fifty-six of them can tell an old man which passage a body crossed at which hour. Everything I had been taught stood on light being a thing that goes from one place to another and can be told where to be. And here was the sun, coming through a hole and around an hole, and lying down on a wall in rings. Like water. I had the token wrong from the day

it was put in my hand, and every man in my office had it wrong with me, and the ones who had come down here and seen this had kept their mouths shut. It was a picture of *light*, and light does what water does.

"There it is," Va-Raedin said, very quietly, somewhere above me. "Yes. That is the face people make."

The beam went out while I was still on the floor. There was no fading; the sun simply moved off the pillar seven floors above us and the room shut. He had a lamp, and lit it, and the little yellow flame made the carved wall look like a decoration again, which I found obscene. He took the token out of the cradle himself and put it into my hand and closed my fingers on it.

"Now listen, because we have very little time and you are of no use to anybody in this condition."

"It spreads," I said. "When it is narrowed. It spreads."

"Yes."

"Two openings would cross. They would cross like the water in the bowl. There would be places with nothing—"

"Yes."

"Behind an obstacle—"

"Yes." It came out of him like a door slamming. Then, level again: "And you will not test one word of it."

I looked up at him.

"You will not touch the cradle again. You will not scrape the paste out of that wall. You will not reproduce any part of this in a washing bowl, a jar, a cup, a channel, or a puddle in the goat pen. You will not ask Faith whether their singing crosses. You will not ask Justice whether two causes may cancel one another. Do you hear the shape of the prohibition?"

I heard it.

Every other Kahir in the Mountain had just become dangerous by relation. Balance water. Faith sound. Shield barriers. Justice causes. Light waves. The Chamber was Light standing in the middle of the Hall and pointing at every other charge in the building and saying: *that too, and that too, and that too.*

"Yes," I said.

"No."

"... I agree."

"Better."

He was already moving — resetting something at the base of the stem, quick and practised and without one moment of reverence, which after what I had just seen felt like a man wiping his boots on scripture. He sealed the Balance jar with new wax out of a fold in his sleeve. On the way up he put the disc back into its seat in the ceiling of the passage with his thumb, in the dark, without looking at it, and the rings came back onto the floor behind us, and he kept his eyes front.

The way out ran elsewhere. He opened a service way behind the third chamber and walked me up a stair that had lamps in it, and handrails, and a smell of cold metal and old water. The road I had bled down had a corridor running beside it the whole way. At the foot of the stair he stopped. Above us the Festival was giving its last answer and five thousand people were getting to their feet, and the floor of their holiest hour had stood open all afternoon with nobody the wiser.

“You will say nothing.”

“To whom?”

“To anyone.”

“Ka-Syphiron—”

“I will speak to Ka-Syphiron.”

“It is mine,” I said. “I found it. I took the disc out of the ceiling and I built the glass and I raised the light out of the water with my own hands. Let me tell him. Let me be the one who—”

I stopped, because I could hear it.

“Finish the sentence,” Va-Raedin said. “No? Then I will. *Let me be the one who is seen.*”

The wall of the passage was very close and very cold.

“You have had the best hour of your life,” he said, “and you have spent the last minute of it asking to be congratulated. That is not a small fault, Sa-Kailan. That is the fault. Everything they will one day do to you will come in through that door, and it will not even have to knock.”

“And what am I now?”

“Wait.”

“For how long?”

“Until the Chamber’s existence no longer belongs to your appetite.”

He climbed two steps and stopped, with his back to me.

“A Candidate learns where light falls,” he said.

“A Veil learns who placed it,” I answered, because I had been saying it since before I could reason.

“No. That is the sentence boys repeat before they know the price of it. A Veil learns that the path he found was laid before he was born, and that finding it binds him before it honours him. That door opens once, and only toward you. There is no Candidate left for you to go back to being.” He went up into the noise.

I spent the day after the Veil’s Chamber doing exactly what I had been told to do. I reported to the northern practice halls at the appointed hour and was given no lesson. A senior attendant set me to copy lens inventories in a side alcove where no one else worked. At second meal I sat with the other candidates, though the talk around me thinned whenever my hand moved too near my cup. No one asked where I had been the day before. They all knew anyway. I waited — for correction, or punishment, or elevation, for anything that would take the thing I had done and make it a sequence. None came. Men and women of Light crossed my path and adjusted by nearly nothing: a pause too short to name, a glance at my hands, a slight lowering of the voice after I had passed. Once, near the mirror stores, two attendants stopped speaking when they saw me.

By evening the waiting had worn on me more than any examination. The summons came after the lamps had been reduced. A girl no older than twelve stood at the entrance to the candidate quarters with a small black token on her open palm. It bore no name, only the sign of Light cut through a circle so narrow that the aperture seemed almost a wound.

“Sa-Kailan of Light,” she said. “You are expected.”

“Where?”

“Behind the old gallery.” Then she closed her fingers over the token, turned, and left.

Behind the old gallery. The place was older than the polished northern halls, and less obedient to the official dignity of Light. Mirrors hung where no teaching arrangement required them; some were cracked and kept anyway. One passage held a copper frame that had been half-melted and then mounted on the wall, as though someone had decided a failure was worth keeping. The gallery itself was long and low. Generations of lamp smoke had climbed the walls and stayed. Sketches had been pinned straight into the stone with copper nails: lens paths, impossible staircases, and three drawings of a goat viewed through increasingly ridiculous arrangements of glass.

On a shelf near the end, a row of cracked lenses rested beside a sign written in an old hand:

DO NOT DISCARD.

FAILURE STILL BENDS LIGHT.

The girl stopped before a narrow door half-hidden behind a hanging cloth so stained with soot that it had ceased pretending to be grey. She knocked once and withdrew before anyone answered.

“Come in, Sa-Kailan,” Ka-Syphiron called from inside.

— Ah, They are carrying the trays up. We eat here today. ... A moment, while the door is busy with them. On the matter *unlit*: I have been turning a thought.

— Turn it aloud, as far as you dare.

— Only a question of your lessons. Your fifth — the trough, the light held under the water. A man might sit a long while at such a surface, doing nothing, looking a fool, and be the only one in the room ready in the breath when the light at last chose to go. *A change in condition*, to borrow your word, is what I am waiting for. Like you and your beam. I think I have found a way, and I am now only waiting for an occasion.

[—]

— Here they are. ... So: we break here and eat, and go on again the day after tomorrow. I should warn you of the plate. The physician reads numbers and cares nothing for a man’s pleasure: white fish, a great deal of green, an egg, a weighed portion of bread, water. Function, he calls it.

— I have eaten worse, for worse reasons.

— No doubt. But I have committed a small treason against the physician. This.

— ... Eww. It smells of the inside of a hoof.

— It is called *Marmite*. My countrymen come in two kinds: those who would die for it, and those who gag at the name. I keep a jar of home at the wrong end of a foreign lake. A scrape on the bread, no more. I have waited days to watch your face do whatever it is about to do.

[—]

— ... Well. That is a great deal of one taste, arriving all at once and refusing to leave. Ask me tomorrow whether I am grateful. And I will tell you I am not.

— The only honest answer there is. Eat.

— Paul. One thing, before I take up the account, since you have set a feast before me and called it a plate. Your world is indecent in its plenty: a pot of this, carried across a lake for a jest, thrown out at the year’s end should the jest turn stale, while a hand in Balance’s green would have wept at the waste and made you answer for it. And here is the thing I cannot fit together. I gave you my whole reading of your kind: that a man

raises his cathedral because he was told *no*, that hunger is your chisel. And yet you sit in a world where nothing is ever ungiven, the pot always full and another behind it, and you build *more* than we ever dreamed — the moving stars, the book of a thousand pages, towers that would shame the Mountain. By all that I know, such plenty should have set you down in the warm water to drown in your own comfort. How does a full man still climb?

— ... That is the largest thing anyone has asked me under this roof, and I will answer it badly. Give me time next we meet to think on it.

— Next we meet then. And I will pay you in kind. I shall tell you of the first feast of my life; it has waited long enough, and you will want it whole.

CHAPTER 7

CHAIN

— The twenty-seventh of March; a little after nine; the sixth of our interviews. Before your account — did you reach the end of *Odyssey*?

— I finished watching it, yes. A man kept twenty years from one small hard island by the sea and the wrath of a god; wandering, and remembering it, and never let to come home. He is one of mine, Paul. I will give him back to you presently, with the mark on him. But I went past him. I went down into your beginnings, and I have slept very little, and I have found a thing, and I am going to set it in front of you; and you will tell me I am reading my own book into yours; and I will tell you it is yours that will not stop reading as mine.

— Then set it down.

— Start with your words — the oldest, the ones you cannot think without. You have *Logos*: the word, the thing spoken and kept. That is Faith entire, the kept Word, in one of your bricks. You have *Kratos*: might, dominion, the hand on the gate and the sword. That is Shield. You have *Kairos*: the right hour, the moment a thing may move and no sooner — that is Justice to the letter. You have *Ananke*: necessity, the weight that must come down somewhere, the cost that must be paid — that is Balance. And you have *Aletheia*. You have put it into your tongue as *truth*. It means the un-hidden: less brightness than the thing fetched up out of concealment. That is Light, Paul. That is my own office, standing in your mouth, and you have named it a virtue. Your people

carry my five offices folded into the words you say before breakfast, and not one of you has ever stood them in a row and looked.

— ... Go on. You have more than words.

— I have your beginnings, and they are worse. A god steals fire and gives it whole to men — undivided, to every hand at once — and for the giving of the whole of it he is chained forever to a rock, and a bird opens him each day. That is my first law and my first crime in a single story: no one hand may hold the whole. You have a monster shut in a pit beneath a mountain, and when he strains at the chain the ground splits and the mountains throw up fire. That is the Beast, held under my own floor, and your people felt him move. And when the woman opens her jar, and every evil in it flies out into your world, one thing stays behind, sealed, and does not leave; and you call it Hope. We call it the Promise, and we keep it under the stone. There is a flood in you as well, and a few saved high on a mountain; there is a father who devours his own children for fear of them; I could go on until the lamp burns out. Your oldest telling even keeps two of my offices coiled together at the start of the world — Time and Necessity, my Justice and my Balance — one body, before anyone prised them apart.

— ...

— Do you see it. You are holding every book of my scripture — Genesis, Blood, Beast, Cataclysm, Promise — scattered through your fire and your monster and your flood and your jar; and you have held it three thousand years and longer, and never once laid the pieces side by side, because you cannot, because you are cursed to keep the pieces and forget the whole: you remember the Mountain and cannot find it; you hear the Gospel and twist it into a hundred sweet hungers. Come now, Paul. You are the Outsiders. You are the murderer's line. He went out of the Oasis with the stolen daughter of Faith, into the open land, and you are what came of them, and every tale you have ever set before me is the broken memory of the house you were driven from. I am not laying my book over yours. I have set them side by side, the way you taught me, and yours will not stop confessing.

— You are to hear both words from me. Now a third. You laid two texts side by side, and you were good at it, and you knew which one would win before you started. Every seam you read, you read the same way: your Mountain the house, mine the exile. Yours first. Mine the copy. Turn one card over and it all runs backward — a late people who took older songs and dressed them up as the source. I do not know which is true. I will not pretend to. But a man who cannot bear *not* to know decides anyway, and after that he reads only the seams that prove him. That is not reading, Va-Kailan. That is a frightened man building a wall. I have met men like that. I had hoped not to meet one in you. ... I am disappointed. Not surprised. Enough for now. You had just come out of your Veil's Chamber, and they kept a night for you. Give me that night.

My reward was a small blackened room that smelled of oil and dust and old paper and mistakes. The room was low-ceilinged and warm, its walls darkened by years of lamp smoke, its shelves so crowded they seemed to survive by mutual pressure. Lenses wrapped in cloth. Brass tubes, trays of powdered glass, a cracked bowl, lengths of wire, mirror shards, sealed jars, two blackened spoons. A small hand-lamp with its flame turned downward into water. And an object that resembled the skeleton of a bird built by someone who had never seen a bird but had heard disturbing rumours of one.

Va-Raedin stood near the table. Ka-Syphiron sat behind it on a low stool with one uneven leg, wearing no ceremonial outer robe, his sleeves rolled to the wrist. A dark mark crossed one finger: soot, or ink, or blood long dried. He looked like a man interrupted in the middle of ruining something interesting.

“Close the door,” he said.

I obeyed. The latch fell into place with a small sound. For several breaths nobody spoke. Ka-Syphiron placed both hands flat on the table.

“Sa-Kailan of Light. Yesterday, by witness of Va-Raedin, you found the Veil’s Chamber.”

“Yes, Keeper.”

“You entered by lesson, error, discipline, insight, and disobedience.”

“Yes, Keeper.”

“You did not break the path behind you.”

“No, Keeper.”

“A Candidate learns where light falls. And a Veil?”

“A Veil learns who placed it.”

“That is the public version. A Veil learns who placed *him*. And tonight you should see that Va-Raedin placed you there as surely as any lamp. Tell me. By what condition does a Candidate of Light become Veil of Light?”

“By finding the Veil’s Chamber.”

“And by what condition does a Veil of Light become Keeper of Light?”

I looked at Va-Raedin. No rescue came.

“By finding the Keeper’s Chamber.”

“Incomplete. A Veil who finds the Keeper’s Chamber has reached the upper path. He has not completed the chain. Light does not pass upward because one man climbs; it passes when the lower chamber is opened again by one he trained. Only then is the chain complete. Faith, not long ago, had two Veils — two who had found the Veil’s Chamber — but none had found the Chamber of the Last

Prayer until recently. When Va-Elun found it, she rose at once to Keeper, because there was already a Veil of Faith beneath her to complete the chain. You know her now as Ka-Elun.”

I turned toward Va-Raedin.

“And did you find it?”

“Yes.”

“When?”

“Six years ago.”

“Six years?”

“Yes.”

“And you waited.”

“I served.”

“Waiting for me?”

“Waiting for the chain to complete.”

I looked down. I had spent one day waiting and found it almost intolerable. He had spent six years ready — correcting boys, holding only what the Mountain permitted, waiting for a candidate worthy of becoming Veil.

“Va-Raedin of Light found what he was required to find,” Ka-Syphiron said. “He trained, withheld, corrected. He endured the indignity of being ready before the Mountain was ready to receive him.” Va-Raedin said nothing. Then the old Keeper stood. He came around the table, the uneven stool complaining behind him, and placed one hand on my shoulder. The hand was warm, dry, and surprisingly heavy.

“Congratulations, Sa-Kailan. You have done a difficult thing without making it unbearable to praise you. That combination is rarer than genius.”

I tried to answer. Nothing came but the start of a smile. He set his other hand on Va-Raedin’s shoulder, and the three of us stood linked beside the table: the Keeper about to be released, the Veil who had waited, the Candidate who had opened the lower door.

“Congratulations, Va-Raedin.”

“Keeper.”

“No. Not Keeper. Not tonight. Tonight we celebrate.”

He bowed his head.

“Thank you.”

Ka-Syphiron released us both and stepped back.

“There. The chain has now been congratulated in all its necessary links. If Justice complains tomorrow that joy was not recorded, we shall say the failure was theirs.”

I laughed once. It came out broken.

Va-Raedin looked at me. “The Keeper has praised you. I will not add to it — praise is oil, and it has drowned better boys than you. You did not fail. Take that instead.”

“Enough,” Ka-Syphiron announced, to no one. “Absolutely enough. If Light spends every important moment proving it can stand still, then Shield has already won civilisation.”

The solemnity fled like a startled bird. He crossed to a wall panel so blackened by smoke it seemed merely dirty until his fingers found three hidden catches. It opened with the reluctant sound of secrecy. Behind it was a hoard: two dark bottles stopped with wax, a tray of small white cups, dried fruit, nuts, a round cheese, bread, strips of salted meat, and small cakes pressed with seeds.

He pointed a soot-marked finger at me. “Clear the table.” Then, to Va-Raedin: “Ray. Those, there.”

Ray, I repeated in my head.

“Keeper,” Va-Raedin said.

“Do not Keeper me. I am arranging a feast.”

“You are impossible.”

“An excellent quality in a Keeper approaching replacement.”

The spread grew, and it was absurd, and it was magnificent — more food than I had ever seen set before ten people without a festival, a funeral, or an inventory mistake. Ka-Syphiron uncorked the first bottle and set a white cup before me. The smell of hydromel rose warm and sweet into the room. Va-Raedin’s expression tightened. “He is nineteen.”

“An age at which a man may discover that honey, water, time, and disobedience can produce civilisation.”

“He is nineteen,” Va-Raedin said again — looking now at the tray of cups. Ka-Syphiron followed his gaze. “Ah.”

“Absolutely not.”

“Absolutely yes. These are for your first Light lesson as Veil.”

I looked from one man to the other. “What is wrong with the cups? May I see?”

Both men paused to look at me. Va-Raedin's face said no with the force of a sealed corridor. Ka-Syphiron's brightened. He lifted one of the small cups and set it before me.

It was fine bone after all, or something like it — white, thick-sided, faintly blue at the foot, worn by many hands. At the bottom, beneath the glaze, a cloudy disc waited like a blind eye. I took it before my courage could find a more careful course. It was heavier than it looked. I tilted it toward the lamp, and the dull pale circle beneath the glaze stirred into a smear of colour, too faint to name, then vanished in the shine.

"A flaw," I said. "Or a mark beneath the eye, perhaps."

Ka-Syphiron looked at Va-Raedin. "You trained this?"

"Under difficult conditions."

"I see."

I turned the cup again, more carefully. "Thick wall. Curved base. The glaze distorts whatever has been set beneath it."

"Better." I had learned to distrust that word.

Ka-Syphiron lifted the bottle. "Look again."

"I am looking."

"And now?"

The hydromel poured. It climbed the white inner wall, trembled, and settled over the rounded base. A figure appeared. I worked out the optics a breath before I saw what the picture was. The smear beneath the glaze gathered itself, through liquid and curvature, into a naked woman, one arm behind her head, the other arranged with a confidence no woman of the Mountain would ever have permitted to be drawn, owned, or used as instructional material before a newly recognised Veil.

"Oh," I said. And then, uselessly, "Oh."

My face burned so fast I felt betrayed by my own blood. Ka-Syphiron struck the table with his palm. "There."

Va-Raedin actually laughed — a rare sight. I stared at the cup, horrified, and let myself be the target of a good joke. Then I pulled myself together.

"Inverse turning," I said. "Instead of scrambling a source, we are rebuilding one."

"Spectacular, is it not?"

"And old," Va-Raedin added.

"Older than several current moral prohibitions." Ka-Syphiron raised his cup. "To Light, and all its mysteries."

We drank. The hydromel was sweet first, then hot, then sharper than I expected. I tried to hold the cough and failed, which produced another round of laughter — and this time even Va-Raedin retreated from it too slowly.

Ka-Syphiron broke the bread with both hands and gave the first piece to Va-Raedin. “To six years.”

Va-Raedin closed his eyes. “No.”

“To six years,” I said.

Va-Raedin looked at me. “You are learning dangerous habits early.”

“Good,” said Ka-Syphiron. “A Veil of Light must learn to disappoint his teacher without becoming useless.”

We ate. I took bread, then cheese, then one dried fig, because restraint still seemed like something I ought to display. Ka-Syphiron saw the gesture and put three more figs on my plate.

“This is madness,” I said.

His face lit. “Yes.”

“That is not a recognised category of feast,” Va-Raedin said.

“It should be. A truly great feast is one at which Balance has not been invited, Justice has not been informed, Shield has not inspected the door, Faith has not decided whether the songs are appropriate, and Light has hidden the cups.”

“Then it is not a feast. It is institutional collapse.”

“Only if discovered.”

The evening loosened. Bread broke; cheese softened near the lamp; nuts wandered across the table; the hidden woman appeared and vanished in the cups. Ka-Syphiron told a story about an attendant who had once tried to classify an obscene cup as a devotional vessel. I laughed until my stomach hurt.

“To Va-Raedin,” the old Keeper said suddenly, softening despite himself. “To readiness, properly humiliated by time.”

Va-Raedin held his gaze, then lifted his cup. “Yes.”

Ka-Syphiron cut three uneven pieces of cheese with a knife far too ceremonial for the task. “You understand what begins now?”

“The office?” I asked.

“The partnership.”

“He will remain junior,” Va-Raedin said.

“Obviously. Partnership, not equality. The northern halls, candidate sequences, dangerous apparatus, cross-Kahir requests — all of it will begin to touch him.”

“You will still be corrected,” he added to me.

“Relentlessly,” Va-Raedin said.

“There. You see the burden.”

I laughed again, and this time Va-Raedin punished it with decorum a breath late.

Ka-Syphiron opened the second bottle — which Va-Raedin allowed without approving — and I found the courage to ask what had troubled me since the previous day.

“Keeper, I have a question.”

“Worse.”

“It concerns Faith.”

“Catastrophic. Continue.”

I looked at the cup, where the woman blurred beneath the hydromel.

“Va-Maera said she knew about what she called *our little training rooms*. She had never entered them, but she knew enough to press on them. And there are other things. Their prayers for despair. Their archangels. The way they speak of voices, silences, thresholds. Va-Maera frightened me because she seemed to know where to press. As if despair had architecture. As if a voice could enter rooms where hands cannot.” Ka-Syphiron set down the bottle and leaned back.

“Cross-Kahir knowledge is a dangerous appetite. Too much, too quickly, convinces a young man that the Mountain is merely a puzzle discourteously divided before his arrival.”

“It is not?”

“No. It is a wound, a machine, a refuge, a prison, a weapon, and occasionally a badly ventilated experiment room with immoral cups.”

He pointed a strip of salted meat at Va-Raedin. “Ray. Do you remember what Ka-Sarem showed you when you became Veil?”

Va-Raedin’s expression altered. “Yes.”

“What?”

“A wheel turning inside glass.”

“By?”

“Steam.”

“Steam?”

“A sealed vessel,” Va-Raedin said. “Water heated beneath it. A narrow tube. A wheel so light it looked useless until vapour touched it. I thought the lesson concerned motion.”

“It concerned pressure,” Ka-Syphiron said. “And restraint.”

“A Balance device?” I asked.

“Yes,” Va-Raedin said.

“Most people take them for bean-counters,” Ka-Syphiron said. “Ledgers, grain, birth allotments, death registers, goat inventories.”

“They are that,” Va-Raedin said.

“Oh, entirely. Let us not rescue them from justice. But at their heart? Balance knows what heat does to milk, what sealed darkness does to grain, what pressure does to vapour, and what poison becomes before medicine, dye, solvent, or regrettable experiment.”

“They can help Light?”

“They already do,” Va-Raedin said.

Ka-Syphiron lifted a sealed jar from the shelf. Inside was a powder so dark it seemed to drink the flame.

“Rare dyes. Glass additives. Oils. Powders that bite light at one colour and spit it back at another. Vapours that reveal a beam because the air itself has been persuaded to misbehave.”

“Balance makes those?”

“Balance prepares the matter. Light studies what matter does when a condition changes. Neither office should confuse assistance with possession.”

“Many compounds useful to Light,” Va-Raedin added, “would kill an inattentive boy before teaching him anything.”

Ka-Syphiron smiled. “You see? This is why we keep attentive boys.”

He lifted my cup and turned it slowly, so the woman at the bottom blurred, vanished, returned beneath the hydromel.

“This particular object, for instance, uses an almost pure Faith principle. It recombines where Light would decompose — though Faith would probably call it resurrection.”

“Generous tonight, Keeper,” Va-Raedin said, disapproving.

Ka-Syphiron tapped the cup on the table. “Faith humiliates the ear as we humiliate the eye.” Another tap. “Echo.” Another. “Delay.” Another. “Stone.” The room returned each sound differently.

“A corridor lengthens a note; a vault divides it; a chamber stores part and returns it late. A prayer may be words addressed to God — I do not settle that tonight — but it may also be a shaped sound moving through stone. A woman sings here; the Mountain answers elsewhere. Faith hears the alteration and reverses it.”

“So their prayers are mechanisms?”

“No. That is the foolish version of the clever answer. Do better.”

I thought. "Their mechanisms pray."

His eyes brightened. "Closer. Have you never noticed that five voices may sound louder than five voices should? Move five singers two steps, and the room seems to join them. The air does not add like jars, Sa-Kailan. Sometimes a chamber is waiting for exactly the rhythm that makes it confess its shape."

"Resonance," Va-Raedin said quietly.

Ka-Syphiron looked at him. "Look who is generous with knowledge now, Ray."

He sat back suddenly. "Speaking of the decomposition of sound and light — aren't you supposed to give him something?"

Va-Raedin became still. "It was not for tonight."

"What a miserable phrase. No wonder you are nearly Keeper."

Va-Raedin ignored him, reached into the inner fold of his robe, and drew out a small object wrapped in grey cloth. I took it carefully. Inside was a triangular piece of clear glass, no longer than my thumb, polished on three faces and chipped at one corner. When I turned it toward the lamp, the flame broke faintly along one edge into a thin wound of colour.

"What do you call this?" I said.

"A prism."

"What does it do?"

"The *what* you will have worked out by morning. The unpierced mystery is the how, and the why."

"For the ceremony?"

"No." His eyes held mine. "For after."

I closed my fingers around it.

"When a beam seems whole," Va-Raedin said, "do not believe it too quickly."

Ka-Syphiron looked away too slowly to hide that the line pleased him.

"For teaching," Va-Raedin went on. "If you remain teachable after having been praised."

"That is not guaranteed," Ka-Syphiron said. "Pride has ruined boys more definitively than hydromel."

He turned my wrist until the lamp struck the prism more narrowly.

"You are right to wonder about Faith. Right to be unsettled by Balance. You will be tempted by Justice. But do not become drunk on other people's locked

doors. Light has enough of its own. There are office mysteries: apparatus, ceremonies, petitions, the training of the young. And there are mysteries still unpierced. Like the memory of light. A question I have spent years failing to understand."

"The memory of light?"

"A poor name for an unopened door. Something none of us has opened."

"It may not be a door," Va-Raedin said.

"Everything interesting denies being a door at first." Ka-Syphiron turned the lamp. "Some lights are a sum — they look single, but break them correctly and many colours are travelling together. Others are almost a single thing. A gas may filter out one colour from the world, and, struck correctly, give back just that one colour."

"As if it remembers it?"

"As if it is permitted nothing else."

Then he smiled. "There. A useless gift. The best kind for a young man with too many useful hungers."

He stood suddenly. "But not all mysteries deserve solemn faces."

He pointed toward the side curtain. "There are office mysteries, unpierced mysteries, and fun mysteries — which irresponsible men preserve until Shield confiscates them."

Va-Raedin's eyes narrowed. "No."

"Ray, your objections have been received and placed beneath the Mountain." He was already moving. He disappeared through the curtain.

The room quieted behind him. For several breaths the old gallery entered: lamp hiss, cooling stone, distant water striking a channel below.

I looked at Va-Raedin. Without Ka-Syphiron's brilliance filling the room, the Veil looked tired, and closer to me than before.

"Six years," I said.

"Yes."

"Why did you never tell me?"

"Because you would have made it part of your hunger. If I had told you, you would have tried to become the boy who completed my chain. That boy would not have found the chamber."

"I thought you were withholding because you did not think me worthy."

"I was withholding because worthiness is often damaged by being named too early." He paused. "You did well."

"I did not understand everything."

“No.”

“I still do not.”

“Good. A Veil who thinks the chamber has been solved because it has been opened is unfit to stand near it.”

He finally ate the bread in his hand. “You are no longer only my student. Not yet my equal. Do not look pleased.”

I smiled despite myself.

“You will not believe this,” I said. “Earlier today, I said *acceptable* to a servant of Light.”

Va-Raedin became very still. “With satisfaction?”

“Sadly, yes.”

“There. The chain closes onto itself. You are already becoming me.”

I made a sound of horror — which was when Ka-Syphiron returned through the curtain, carrying enough contraband to make the room feel guilty.

Va-Raedin looked at the objects in his arms. “I object to all of them.”

“Your objection has standing and may be ignored with respect.”

He set two objects on the table and kept a wooden box beneath it. The first was a small book bound in worn brown hide. The second was a black cylinder mounted on a wooden base. He opened the book. On the first page a drawn woman stood in a long robe; page by page a hand moved to her collar, the collar loosened, the robe slipped from one shoulder. On the fifth, I looked up too quickly.

“Observe.”

He held the pages beneath his thumb and released them fast. The woman undressed — by suggestion, but unmistakably, drawn with the technical care of a serious Light study and none of the solemnity the Mountain usually demanded.

“This is historically important, and is kept for study” Va-Raedin said. He lasted almost one breath before he failed, and Ka-Syphiron laughed.

“And morale,” Ka-Syphiron added.

“For evidence,” Va-Raedin corrected.

He set a third object on the table: a small brass shutter, circular, slotted, blackened near one edge.

“Before the cylinder — a necessary scandal in smaller form.”

Va-Raedin’s expression changed. “The Upfall Lamp.”

“What is the Upfall Lamp?” I asked.

“A falling thread of water,” Va-Raedin said. “A lamp broken into pulses by a turning shutter. If the drops fall at one rhythm and the light strikes them at another, the eye accuses them of slowing. Stopping. Sometimes climbing.”

“That is impossible.”

“So motion can be broken. Observed in fragments,” Ka-Syphiron said. “Mis-assembled by the eye.”

He pushed the shutter aside and turned the black cylinder on its base. “And this one is from five links above us. Look through the slits.”

At first I saw only interruptions: darkness, image, darkness, image. He turned the handle. The drum spun quicker, and the woman inside shattered into repeated glimpses, each broken by blackness. Then the drum found its rhythm. The woman moved. Cloth loosened. A shoulder appeared. The garment slipped. Then the sequence reversed and she dressed again — condemned by Light to undress and redress forever inside a spinning cylinder.

I stepped back. “This is obscene.”

“Yes,” Ka-Syphiron said. “And mechanically excellent.”

“The second quality is the official reason for its preservation,” Va-Raedin added.

“The first,” said Ka-Syphiron, “is why nobody misplaced it.”

Va-Raedin looked at me. “Is he disappointed it is not Va-Sheva?”

I turned violently red. Ka-Syphiron leaned back in laughter as though struck. “Oh. That was cleanly done.”

“He looks as though he is going to be sick,” Ka-Syphiron said, delighted.

“Men are all sick in that regard,” Va-Raedin said.

“Hold what you can of that one, Sa-Kailan, while the holding is cheap. It does not always stay cheap,” Ka-Syphiron said.

And after a long silence, Ka-Syphiron lifted one finger. “Speaking of archangels.”

“Archangels?” I said at once, grateful for any path away from Va-Sheva.

“When embarrassed men have run out of things to say, they come into this world to suspend time in an awkward silence.”

“And the Beast?”

Va-Raedin kept his eyes elsewhere. “I only meant—”

“No,” Ka-Syphiron said softly. “You meant exactly what a boy should mean after too much hydromel and not enough terror. That is not a crime. Only a condition.”

He leaned forward. His face stayed as it was.

“You ask whether I believe in the Beast. Scripture has a shape for it, and we have a story we tell the young. I am one of five who keep the thing itself prisoner beneath the Mountain, held tonight, while we drink, and it would not stay held one season if the five of us agreed to forget it. On your path to Keepership — if the Mountain does not kill you first — you are bound to make at least one chilling discovery: the difference between a mystery that invites the mind and a secret that burdens the hand. Everything you have laughed at tonight — the divided offices, the walls, the portions no one hand may hold — was built to keep it, and for no smaller reason. When your turn comes to carry your portion of that weight, you will speak of it like that no more.”

His gaze drifted, for a fraction too small to accuse, toward the stone beneath our feet. Through it. Then it returned.

“No office talk tonight.”

“But—”

“No. Especially not if the question begins with *but*. But is the hinge on which young men swing themselves into locked rooms.”

Then he clapped both hands once.

“Nothing better to relax an atmosphere than Justice.”

Va-Raedin laughed in disbelief. “You cannot be serious.”

“I am almost never serious in ways people recognise at the proper time.”

He produced the wooden box. Inside were cards: thin painted slips marked in suits and numbers.

“Is this permitted?” I asked.

“By whom? Justice? Certainly not.”

“That is not true,” Va-Raedin said.

Ka-Syphiron considered. “No. It is worse than not true. It is incomplete.”

He dealt. The game was easy to learn. Each hand sought twenty-one without exceeding it. Aces shifted between one and eleven, which I found morally suspicious. Candidate, Veil, and Keeper cards were worth ten. The Mountain won what would elsewhere have been called a tie.

“The Mountain wins ties?”

“Justice dislikes ambiguity.”

“Justice invented ambiguity.”

“Which is why they know how to charge for it.”

We played. I won early and was punished almost immediately. Va-Raedin lasted longer. I was ruined before half the shoe had gone. Eventually he lost as well.

“The Mountain wins,” I said.

"This time. And most times."

"Then why play?"

"That is the correct question asked too early."

He squared the cards. "A Veil of Justice could double his token count during a shoe some of the time. A Keeper could play indefinitely, never ruin, and always accrue."

"That is impossible."

"You have had a busy evening abusing that word. *Impossible* saves lazy men the trouble of distinguishing what cannot happen from what cannot happen to them."

"How?"

"Every hand has a correct action under condition. Perfect play delays ruin. It does not abolish it."

"Then how do they do it?"

He smiled, and touched the discard pile. "I will give you a clue. The revealed cards are the past." He touched the shoe. "The remainder is the future."

"Extremely generous tonight, Keeper," Va-Raedin murmured.

I looked from one to the other.

"If the record of the past is kept perfectly," Ka-Syphiron said, "it alters the decision the future requires — by simple condition. Justice knows this so deeply they have made a morality of it."

He closed the box. "And there. You have now accused Faith of trespassing, interrogated the Beast, lost money you did not have to Justice, and been given a clue too large for your current office."

"I have no office yet."

"Exactly. An excellent time to overburden you."

The smile thinned. He rested one hand on the box.

"And you must not do the common young thing of stealing one idea from another Kahir and mistaking it for the whole doctrine. They teach in layers: lesson one may be true, and lesson three may be why lesson one kills men when applied alone."

"That is not only a Justice warning," Va-Raedin added.

"Sa-Kailan," Ka-Syphiron said. "Be very, very careful."

No joke followed.

"Knowledge divided is structure before it is jealousy. Always older than your impatience. If you look across a wall, know first whether the wall keeps you out,

keeps something in, or prevents two truths from producing a third neither office could survive.”

Ka-Syphiron set one hand on the table, near the closed Justice box.

“Tomorrow, the Mountain will speak what is already true. You will stand where you are called. You will not reach for understanding faster than ceremony permits. Let the Hall be larger than your mind for one morning.”

“Yes, Keeper.”

“And when you are given cloth, lamp, word, silence, or wound, you will receive each as condition, not ornament.”

“Yes.”

Then the old mischief returned, more gently. “And if you must be terrified, try not to do it with your shoulders. It makes the robe hang badly.”

I laughed once, helplessly.

Then Ka-Syphiron said, “All right.” The words closed something. “Sa-Kailan, I have a few things to tell Va-Raedin.”

I had been brought near. Fed. Praised. Warned. Taught beyond my level. Allowed to laugh in the room where tomorrow had already begun.

I rose. For a moment I wanted to say something worthy of the evening, but everything I found would have diminished it. So I bowed — lower than I had bowed on entering. When I straightened, Va-Raedin was watching me. The warmth had left his face; it stayed in the room. He let it reach me only in the guarded way he could manage.

I opened the door. The old gallery waited outside, dim and smoke-blackened. Behind me, the two men waited until the door had nearly closed. I heard one fragment — Ka-Syphiron’s voice, lower than before.

“Here. For tomorrow, and for—”

Then the latch caught, and the rest belonged to the men still waiting to be released or raised. Deeper in the rock the Mountain kept its ordinary hours. In a warm room the oil-press turned, and the cake left when the oil was gone went off in baskets to the lofts and the tanks. Beside it the bone-gatherers boiled their baskets down to broth and glue and needle-stock. The public ceremony began before the Hall filled. One moment I stood in the old gallery, carrying mysteries away. The next, attendants of Light were dressing me in pale robes. The folded white cloth was bound around my wrist. Va-Raedin led me through corridors that had emptied ahead of us. Shield had already closed the side routes. Balance had already marked warmth and lamp oil for the Hall. Justice had already opened the record.

-
- What comes next is the double ascension of light.
 - Ok. Let's stop for today. In the meantime, continue your curriculum, and try to get fitter. Let's stop this machine.
-

CHAPTER 8

LIGHT

— The twenty-ninth of March; the seventh of our interviews; and after dark, which took some arranging — the shutters doubled, the household sent up early, this one lamp lit in the whole of the house. I thought that, given we are about to see a ceremony of light, I should give you one before we begin. It is the smaller of the two, and I have gone to some trouble for it, so bear with an old man playing at priest. Sit there, where the pale screen faces you on the wall. I have set a few things out: this lamp; a card with a narrow slot cut in it; a wedge of good glass, which you already know is called a prism; and a small clean flame, and beside it a dish of common salts. When I put out the lamp, keep your eyes on the screen and tell me what you see.

— Nothing. It is a very complete dark. In the Mountain even the last cell keeps one thread of a lamp somewhere down the passage; a man is never given the whole of the dark, only lent a piece of it. This is darker than anything the Mountain would allow. I see nothing at all.

— Let me open the lamp again. Watch. I take its light, and I let it through the narrow slot, so that it comes to the glass as a single thin blade; and the glass bends each colour of it by that colour's own amount, and lays them all out in a row upon the screen. There. Look at what plain lamplight is made of.

— A band of colour laid along the wall. Red at the one end, and through orange, and yellow, and green, and blue, to a last edge of violet, each running into the next with

no seam anywhere between them — a whole unbroken stripe, and no colour left out of it. The plain lamp gives you the lot, run together in a row.

— Hold that stripe in your eye. Now I put the lamp out. ... And I light this small flame, which has almost no colour of its own; send it through the slot and the glass, and it gives you next to nothing. And now I take a pinch of this — an ordinary salt, nothing you would look at twice — and I give it to the flame. Watch the screen.

— The stripe does not come. Where the whole band of colour was a moment ago there stands one bar. A single hard line of yellow, bright, and narrow, and alone, hung there on the black; and to either side of it, all down the wall where every other colour was, there is nothing. The flame has kept one colour and let the rest fall away.

— A clean flame, now, and a different salt into it. Watch the place where the yellow stood.

— The yellow does not come back. Off to the side, in its own place, a single bar of red, as narrow and as certain as the first, and the rest of the wall dark. Another. ... A bar of green, in a third place, and again the dark on either hand. You give the fire a thing, and the fire answers with a bar; and each thing answers in its own place, and always the same place, and gives that one colour and holds the rest of the wall dark. What am I looking at, Paul? I have cast salt into a flame a hundred times and watched it colour and thought nothing of it. I have never seen the fire made to speak in single lines.

— You are looking at the thing itself, and you already hold the half of it, and have since a certain night. Cast your mind back to the sky I gave you. Remember the very great first: the stars, that are fires so far off that some of the ones we look at each night burned out a thousand years ago and more, their light still crossing the dark toward us, so that the sky a man stands under is a room full of the past. You went very quiet that night, and I was glad of it. Now hold the other half up against it, the half you cared for less because it wore no grandeur — the very small. That this salt, and the flame, and your own hand, are built all the way down of a countless small architecture; and that in each least brick of it, held out from its heart, stand the smaller things we named electrons, and that they stand on steps. This is the whole of it, and it is a simple thing. An electron may stand upon this step, or upon that one, and never in the space between, for there is no place between the steps to stand. When you give the salt to the fire, the heat of the fire throws its electrons up off their steps; and they will not hold there, and they fall back; and every time one falls, it lets go a single fleck of light. But the colour of that fleck is set, exactly and only, by the height of the step it fell — a long fall gives one colour, a shorter fall another, and the same fall gives always the same colour, to the hair. And a given thing has only its own few steps built into it, and so only its own few falls to give, and so it can make only its own few colours and no others in the whole width of the light. That is your bar.

— You have given me the *memory of light*.

— That is the gift, and there was never anything more to it than the step and the fall. It cost me some trouble; I wanted you to have the small true thing in your eye before you gave me the great one. Let me give you the room back now.

— No. Leave it dark; it will serve me. Hand me the matches from the sill. ... There: one flame, and the whole of the rest put out. Now do a thing for me, Paul, before I begin. This room is small, and we are two men in it. Make it one of your cathedrals instead — the tall cold stone, the roof lost somewhere above you in the dark. Put out every light in it but this one. And stand five thousand people in it, shoulder against shoulder, breathing, holding still. Keep that behind your eyes while I speak: that flame, in that dark, and all those souls gathered close around it, waiting. Now I will tell you how the Mountain crowns its Keepers of Light.

The Hall of Ceremony filled before the First hour, and it filled past its own long memory, for a double ascension in Light was the greatest thing the Mountain would show a soul in one lifetime. The old were carried down from their beds. Children stood between their parents' knees. The lower workers came up with their hair still wet from the steam chambers, and the tiers packed shoulder to shoulder and rib to rib until the stone itself seemed to draw breath. And over the whole of it, high on its long wire, the great disk of the Pendulum kept its slow crossing above the forbidden circle at the heart of the Hall, out and back, patient as a tide, closing its round in near three days as it had closed it over every soul that ever knelt beneath it.

They had lit the Hall in Light's own manner, sparingly, from angles a man in the crowd would let his eye slide past. Above the southern descent the Genesis gravure held what light it was allowed: the carved Mountain warm along its ridges, the Oasis in green shadow beneath it, Adam and Eve half-shown, the five children coming and going as the bodies shifted below them. And over all of it, in the carved sky, one small hard grain of fire that has hung above the carved Mountain since the day the carving was cut. The eye of Heaven.

Ka-Syphiron came in carrying the last strong lamp, and the lesser flames became servants to it. He called me down out of my tier by my name. I went to him and knelt, and the floor was cold through my robe, and he laid his hands upon my head, and they were dry and heavy and sure.

“Sa-Kailan of Light,” he said, and the name came back off the walls changed.
“What is the eye for?”

“To find what hides,” I said.

“What is the hand for?”

“To let it lie.”

“What is the tongue for?”

“To keep the dark.”

His hands lifted from my head. “Rise now as Va-Kailan, Veil of Light.” I rose, and the white cloth at my wrist was lawful now, and he turned me by the shoulder and sent me back up to my tier; and I climbed to my place among my people and stood, and the great disk swung on between us.

Then the two of them took their places within the forbidden circle, the great ring of dark stone at the heart of the Hall, forbidden to every foot, that held now only theirs. Ka-Syphiron stood at its far edge, on the god’s side, under the carved sky and the open eye of Heaven, and turned his face to the light. Va-Raedin knelt on one knee at its near edge, on the beast’s side, and turned his face to the deep. And the great disk crossed the ring between them, out and back, and passed close by the old man in his light and the young man in his dark, and passed on.

Then the Hall began to give up its light, and it gave it up the way the sea gives up the shore, slowly, and with an even hand. And a voice took up the Book of Promise out of the failing light, from somewhere below the gravure; and the Hall came in beneath it, five thousand low together, and gave the words back as they had given them at every dawn of their lives.

And the people dwelt beneath the stone, and darkness was above them, and the Mountain covered them; and they remembered the forest, and the rivers, and the open waters that were spoiled. And they wept for the world that had been saved and lost in the same hour. And God heard their mourning beneath the Mountain.

Somewhere behind the crowd the feeds of the lamps were stopped, one upon another, in an order hidden in the packed dark. A high slit above the northern arch went out. A reflector lost its thread, and a whole reach of the Hall closed over.

And God said unto them, Fear not the darkness which I have given thee; for the darkness shall be thy veil, and the stone

shall be thy wall, and the deep waters shall be thy life. Thou shalt dwell within the Mountain, and thy children shall be born beneath the Mountain, and the eye of Heaven shall not find thee.

And the gravure sank by degrees: the Mountain lost its ridges, the Oasis went under, Adam and Eve slipped beneath, and the five children stood a breath longer than the rest, pale in the last slant of the light, and then the dark had them too.

And God said, Keep thou the Mountain, and keep thou the Oasis, and keep thou the Temple. Keep the secrets apart, and let no one hand hold the whole. Let no sign be carried from its chamber, nor proof borne beyond its seal; for a secret held in place may preserve the people, but a secret made to wander shall become fire among them. Let the Keeper of Balance count the waters, and the Keeper of Faith teach the Gospel, and the Keeper of Shield defend the threshold, and the Keeper of Light illuminate the passages, and the Keeper of Justice keep peace between brother and brother.

The eye of Heaven burned last of all, one grain above the drowned Mountain.

And God said, If thou keepest My word, and if thy children keep it after thee, then I shall remember the forest and the rivers that were lost. And the day shall come when the desert shall withdraw, and the waters shall run openly again, and the trees shall rise where sand and ash had lain.

Then a slit closed somewhere far up, and the eye of Heaven went down with the rest.

And in that day the Mountain shall open without fear, and the Beast shall be chained forever in Hell, and the children of the hidden people shall walk beneath Heaven and not be consumed. The people shall be reborn, and the Oasis shall no longer hide in shadow; and the people shall know neither thirst, nor wandering, nor the fear of being seen. And God saw the promise, and behold, it was very good.

And the last of the words went out into the dark, and the Hall was still.

There remained one flame. It stood in Ka-Syphiron's hand, in the throat of his lamp, small as the fire at the tip of a struck taper; and around it the whole Hall stood up enormous, and packed, and black. Five thousand of us stood in

that dark, shoulder to shoulder, and held our silence, and breathed as softly as a body breathes; and the one small fire in the old man's hand had the whole of that vastness, and all those thousands, and all that stillness to hold at bay, and it held them, and held them only just. High above it the great disk crossed on through the black, out and back, felt now in the floor, and the teeth, and the chest.

Then the ceiling answered. A sound came down so low the bone caught it before the ear, and high in the throat of the vault the great weights let themselves go, each after each, and took up their charge; and out of the dark above the Pendulum a dome came down. It came slowly, a vast cap of old black stone lowering itself over the swing, and the two men, and the one flame; and at its crown an eye stood cut clean through the rock, and the wire of the Pendulum ran up through that eye into the dark. And as the dome came down along the wire, the crossing of the great disk began to close. Out, and back, and a little less far; out, and less far again; the swing drawing into itself the lower the stone came, as though the dome were gathering the long years into its own weight as it fell.

And as it came down, Ka-Syphiron spoke across the narrowing swing to the man on his knee.

"Va-Raedin of Light. What does the Keeper carry?"

"The light," Va-Raedin said, over the dark, facing the deep.

The dome came lower, and the swing of the disk drew shorter.

"What does the Keeper hold?"

"The chain."

Lower still, and the crossing of the disk drawn now to a hand's breadth.

"What does the Keeper keep?"

"What must remain dark."

The dome came down upon the floor. The disk had drawn its crossing to a standstill as the stone met the stone, and the eye at the crown carried the last of the flame away inside. The Hall stood in pitch dark. The one light was shut within the stone. The great disk hung on its wire, still. The dark was whole, and the clock of my people had stopped, and time had stopped inside it.

Something moved within the dome. Five thousand of us stood in the stopped dark and listened, and could tell nothing of it. A sound, once. Then a shorter sound. Then the long dark, and the disk hanging still upon its wire, and the held breath of a whole people.

Then the Mountain took the weight of the stone back up into itself, and the dome began to rise. It climbed the wire; and as the eye at its crown lifted clear of the disk, the great Pendulum stirred off its stillness, and moved, a little, and then farther; out, and farther; the crossing lengthening the higher the stone climbed, the clock of my people taking up its long count again from the place the dark had stopped it.

And out of the rising dark beneath the lifting stone came the old man's final words, low, and spent, and just loud enough that most of the Hall might catch it. "Rise now," it said, "as Ka-Raedin, Keeper of Light."

A seam of gold opened along the floor beneath the rising stone, and widened, and the one small flame came up into the world in a living hand. Ka-Raedin stood in it, on the god's side of the swing where the old man had stood, and the flame in his hand burned as small as it had burned before, and around it the packed black Hall stood up as vast as before, and held as many, and held as still. He wore Syphiron's robe, and the shoulders of it were cut for a larger man. In his other hand he held the ceremonial knife, and along its edge, and along his knuckles, and on the stone at his feet, there was blood. And Syphiron lay in the blood on the floor of the Hall, in his underrobe, his chest still, his face bare to the light.

The dome climbed on into the vault and settled home in the ceiling; and above the two of them, the living and the dead, the great disk swung out once more to its full reach, and found again the slow round it had kept since before any soul in that Hall drew breath.

Ka-Raedin lifted the small flame over the body.

"Light is reborn," he said. "The chain holds."

And the Hall gave it back to him, five thousand voices out of the black: "Light is reborn. The chain holds."

And upon the word, the whole Hall took fire at once.

Every plate and every reflector and every hidden throat of light woke in the single instant, and every aperture of the gravure fell open together, and the light came down, and across, and up out of every wall and every angle of the stone all at one time, and went into five thousand pairs of eyes that had held the black so long that it went into them like a blow. The Hall blazed. Mirror threw to mirror and threw again, and gold answered gold down the length of the stone; the carved Mountain, and the green Oasis, and the eye of Heaven stood up all together out of the dark and burned. And in the heart of the blaze stood the new Keeper of Light in the gold robe, the small flame in his one hand and the blood on the other,

and the great disk crossing bright over the whole of it. And the people put their hands across their faces, and wept, and looked again between their fingers, and were dazzled past bearing, and were glad.

— There.

— ... God. All of it, all at once. Give me a moment, Kailan; I am blind for the light of it. Pull the curtains back shut.

— I wanted you to have the great one the way you gave me the small, Paul: whole, and in the eye.

— ... Yes. Yes, all right. Now put some of them out again, before you blind an old man in earnest.

Then the Keepers of the Mountain gathered to the new Keeper of Light, and went out of the Hall, for the thing that follows an ascension. The five arches took them, and closed, and we were left in a Hall with no Keeper in it at all. And after a long while of murmuring and prayer; after they had struck five times on the underside of the world; after the slow and deep answer of God; they returned. And I stood in my place among my people with the new light pouring down over all of us, a Veil of Light three hours old, the white cloth lawful at my wrist, and the great disk swinging its slow round above the whole of us as it had swung at dawn.

CHAPTER 9

HEAVEN

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- The thirty-first of March; the eighth of our interviews; shall we continue?
 - Yes. Just one question. There is something I heard during instruction I want to clarify. The inventor of Kepler's five solids of *God Himself*, you said they were invented not by him, but by another, *Pythagoras*. Which I heard about yesterday. When was he born?
 - About two and a half or three thousand years ago. I do not know it by heart, I would have to check.
 - Two and a half to three thousand is enough. Your kind is late.
 - What do you mean? And why is it making you smile?
 - Never mind what I mean and why I smile. Let us continue.
-

For several days after the martyrdom, I waited for the Mountain to feel different. It stayed the same. Water still came by measure. Children still recited badly in the teaching halls and were corrected by voices patient enough to become cruel. Shield still closed passages without explaining itself. Balance still marked loss and use with the same green dye. Faith still spoke over jars and wounds and dead bees and frightened mothers and old men who had begun to forget the names of their own children. Justice still sat where people wished no one were sitting.

The Mountain had changed my name, recorded my sequence, bound the white cloth to my wrist, and set me beneath Ka-Raedin in the chain of Light. Then it handed me the northern halls.

Syphiron had told me, in the feast among the immoral cups, that the northern halls would begin to touch me. The candidate sequences came to my hand, and the apparatus rosters, and the cross-Kahir requests that Light must answer and file and answer again; the lamp accounts; the quarrels over who might stand where during which rite; the young men to be watched, and graded, and told in the exact measure Va-Raedin had once used on me that their best was acceptable. I rose before the First hour and lay down after the last lamp, and between the two there was no hour that was mine.

And the people went. Sela went first, and most quietly. She had carried the cloths and the little oil and watched me the way the young watch a thing they are working out, with the corner of a smile she could never quite put away. Then one morning she was no longer set to my chamber; and the next, when we passed in a corridor, she lowered her eyes and held to the far wall; and the smile was put away for good.

The candidates I had trained beside stopped speaking when I came into a hall, and gave me the flat obedience a man gives an office. Va-Sheva was Shield, and Shield had its own year, and the doors I might once have found her behind were shut for reasons that had nothing to do with me.

One thing had always been mine, and that was the Mirror. I had stood before it in the dark since I was a candidate of Light — days of it, then weeks, then the years run together — until I knew every beam of it the way a man knows the inside of his own mouth, and had trained my eye to catch the one thread of light that came in where no thread should. In those first months as Veil I went to it, and stood before it, and found that I did not care what it did. The glimmers came, and I let them come. The eye that had been made to catch them looked, and reported, and felt nothing.

Ka-Raedin went on teaching me, because that was his office. One morning he set me at the wave wall to learn what light does when it passes an edge.

“It bends,” I said, giving it back to him. “It bends around the edge, and it spreads. Set a second edge beside the first, and the two spreadings meet, and where they meet they add in some places and cancel in others, and leave a banding of light and dark that no straight ray could make.”

“Interference,” he said.

“Interference. There. That is the whole of it.”

And I let him hear the rest of it: that I did not care. I gave him the banding correctly and felt nothing, and he watched me feel nothing.

“You will learn the next thing after this,” he said.

“No.”

He waited.

“I will not learn the next thing, Keeper. I have done the arithmetic of your chain. Every next thing you set before me is a single step toward one morning, and I have already seen that morning, because you showed it to me under a falling stone. To finish the chain is to be the hand that opens the Keeper above me below the ribs, while he bares himself to it — as your hand did it, and I knelt in my tier and watched. I will not walk toward the morning that hand is mine and the body under it is yours. Find another Veil. Let him take my place, and rise, and hold the knife. I will stay where I am, and you will go on living.”

So I stopped. The lamps had to be trimmed whether or not the hand that trimmed them wished to be alive, and so I trimmed them, graded the candidates, filed the cross-Kahir requests, all of it correct and empty, by rote. I ate alone, or forgot to eat. I let the questions that had once burned behind my teeth go out, one by one, and did not miss their light. I did not go to the Mirror. At night the title lay on me like a stone and I did not sleep; by day I moved through the northern halls the way a lamp is carried through a room, giving out what I was told and wanting nothing.

Ka-Raedin watched all of it, and for a long time said nothing. He had carried the thing himself, the year Ka-Sarem was released and he could not, for all his rank, climb free of it. So he let me go all the way down. Six months he let me. He lightened nothing, corrected nothing, offered nothing, and let the office and the doubt and the ungrieved dead press me flat, until one morning I stood before the small black basin with the cloth in my hand and could not remember why the circle had to be clean, nor whom I cleaned it for, nor whether I would mind if I left it.

That was the morning he came for me.

“Va-Kailan of Light. Put the cloth down. It has waited eleven and a half thousand years; it will keep a year more.”

He took the stool with the uneven leg and sat, and looked at me a while, and then he told me the oldest thing in the office, the thing we pass from one mouth to one ear and never write down.

“What is on you now has a name, boy, though you will find it in no record. We call it the ascension amnesia. It is the grand and ancient sickness of Light, and you

are not the first it has taken, nor the tenth, nor the hundredth. It came for me, and for the one who trained me, back and back as far as the office runs. Syphiron had it the year he could not stop seeing the face of the man he had risen over; the Keeper before him gave him the cure, and Syphiron gave it to me, and I am giving it to you now. The office is built out of the very thing that breaks a man: you are made to see, then shown that everything you saw was the half of it, then handed the knife.”

“I have counted your years. Three a servant. Four and a half a candidate. Six months a Veil. That is eight years of Light — eight years of the dark and the Mirror — and in all of them no one, not I and not Syphiron and not the Mountain, ever once told you that you were allowed to be tired. Give yourself the time. Remember why you liked the light in the first place, before it was a chain, and a knife.”

“I am taking the northern halls off you. All of them, for a year. You will sleep by day, and I will hear no word of complaint about it from any quarter; and if a candidate must be graded, he can wait, or be graded by a man who is not drowning.”

“And what am I to do with the year, Keeper?”

“Nothing.” He almost smiled. “I want you to waste it, end to end, and come to me at the finish of it and tell me why you still love the light.”

He stood.

“One thing more. All those years at the Mirror in the dark, catching the one glimmer in the black — no one has told you why we make a boy do that beyond the surveillance of the Mountain, nor what it is training the eye to do. It is not obvious. It was not obvious to me either. Come up with me this evening, and I will show you, and then I will leave you to it.”

He took me up.

I had not known there was an up. The way to it left the last of the Light passages by a shaft I had cleaned a hundred times and never once thought to climb, and it went up through the living rock by handholds worn smooth and a stair that gave out into a chimney a broad man could not have passed. It was a hard climb, and a cold one, and long.

The Mountain is a cone. Near the very top a great hollow has been cut, or was always there — as though a vast ball had been pressed into the point and lifted away, taking the tip with it and leaving a round bowl scooped into the flat. And in the bowl, at the crown of the Mountain, where Shield never comes, there is an observatory.

It was a low round room open to the heavens, its floor worn smooth by generations of backs that had lain on it, and covered on the top by a dome of metal, glass and windows that could pivot around itself. And set on a mounting of more pivots and brass rings, its long throat pointed up into the dark, stood a thing of metal and glass I had no name for. We have metal, he said, and we have lenses; a people that has both, and a reason to look up, will build one of these sooner or later. Put your eye to it.

"Here," he said. "There is no lesson tonight, nor on any night you do not want one. The heavens are yours to explore. If a question comes to you, bring it to me and I will answer it gladly and without tricks. And if you only wish to look, then look — and find again why you liked the light, before anyone told you what it costs."

Then he took a bottle from inside his robe — hydromel, the same sweet fire Syphiron had poured into my cup the night before the ceremony, the night before I watched him open himself under the stone — and two of the small white cups, and he filled them both, and held one out to me.

"We have not done this," he said. "Neither of us, not once. There has been an office to hold, and a young man to carry, and a Mountain to keep from its fear, and in the middle of all of it no one has said his name aloud and grieved him. So." He raised the cup. "To Syphiron of Light."

"To Syphiron of Light," I said, and my voice broke on the second word of his name.

We drank. Then we drank some more. And then more still. And then the two of us, the Keeper and his Veil, alone in the bowl at the top of the Mountain where Shield did not come and no living soul could tell us not to, set down the cups and wept for the man we had both loved, and both, each in his own way, helped to kill. Neither of us looked away from the other. Neither of us made the other stop. For the first time since the dome came down over the swing, I was not alone inside it.

"Speaking of archangels," I said, and we wept some more.

When it had passed, and the cold had dried our faces, he told me what the place was for.

"Every Light that ever rose has come up here to do the thing you have just done. And to remember, when everything the office has taught you has turned to weight in your hands, the one thing under all of it that stayed only beautiful. The light. What we have always loved."

Then he left me there, as he had promised, with the bottle and the two cups and the whole slow turning of the heavens. And so the year began.

I slept through the daylight and climbed at dusk, and lay on my back in the cold stone bowl at the crown of the Mountain with the long glass beside me. I had grown up under two shafts of borrowed sun and a Hall of lamps, and had never, in any true sense, seen the heavens at all. Now I had the whole of it, every clear night, for a year, and I gave myself to it entirely.

It was past anything the Mountain had ever shown me. There were more stars than there were people in the Hall, more than there were people in the whole of my world, and they did not hold still: the entire field of them turned through the night in one slow patient wheel, all but a single one low in the north, around which the rest of heaven went the way water goes around a stone. I lay and let the field be far too large for me, and did not try to make it smaller.

Then, because I had been made in the dark before the Mirror and could no more stop measuring than stop breathing, I began to measure.

The wheel was not quite true. The one low star in the north, that I had taken for the fixed pin of it, kept a small circle of its own; even it crept, and the true centre of the turning was a point in the empty dark beside it, where no star stood at all. That small wrongness held me more than all the rest. The pattern the stars made among themselves never broke — night upon night, season upon season, the same shapes returned undeformed, the same three points held the same angle to a hair — and so I let Faith keep their monsters and heroes, and named the heavens the only way I trusted: by the angles they kept — stable triangles, sure points I could swing the rest of the heavens against.

And against that fixed lattice, a few things moved.

Five bright points kept no faith with the pattern. Night upon night they wandered along a single slanting road across the others, now quick, now slow, one of them so bright before dawn that I mistook it once for a lamp. The Moon kept no faith either, and kept it differently: it changed its shape and its brightness, moved against the stars faster than anything in the heavens, and so I set it outside the star-field, a nearer thing on business of its own. Under the long glass a single point would open into two that circled one another; a smudge would resolve into a knot of a thousand; the brightest wanderer showed a small round disc, and about the disc four lesser lights that changed their places from one night to the next, as though they were tethered to it and swinging. This star burned faintly red and that one blue-white, and the dark between them, which looked empty, was only too far off to read.

And across the whole of it, from one edge of the dark to the other, ran a pale river of light, so crowded that no eye could pull its grains apart, splitting along its

course and closing again, with dark reaches braided through the bright. I turned the long glass on it, and found no river there at all — only stars, and stars behind those stars, past all counting, a crowd my eye had taken for a mist.

I measured what I could reach, and my people had given me good tools to reach with: the Year-Clock's count, the pendulum's honest beat, the sighting-frames of the practice halls. I measured the width the Moon showed, and the width the sun showed through smoked glass, and found them, to my surprise, nearly the same, and wrote the numbers small, and trusted them.

Some things I could not measure, and reached anyway. The Moon was a round ball, its bright part always turned toward where the sun had gone down or would rise; so I took it that it made no light of its own, and only caught the sun's, and its shapes were the turning of a lit ball before my eye. The stars stood unreachably far: however I shifted along the bowl, or waited half a year and shifted with the whole Mountain, they never budged against each other by the width of a thought. Why the five wanderers slowed and hurried and doubled back along their road I could not solve, and I set it down unsolved.

But the thing that took me hardest was none of these. It was the dark.

I had been raised to know exactly what darkness was. It was the absence of light — the thing the lamps pushed back, the enemy my whole people spent their coal and their mirrors and their eight poor shafts of stolen sun to hold at arm's length. Up in the bowl, night on night, I watched that turn itself over. Out here the dark was the whole of it, the ground of everything, running past all measure in every direction; and the light was a scatter of small bright holes pricked in it, few, and far between, and mostly failing halfway across.

And in the looking, the eye that had gone dead in the northern halls came back to life.

Near the end of the year Ka-Raedin climbed up to me one clear night, and lay down on the cold stone at my side.

For a while neither of us spoke. Then he asked the other thing he had sent me up a year to find — not why I loved the light, but what else I had found.

"Earth is a sphere," I said.

"It is."

I told him the truest turn of the heavens: that the stars come home a little sooner each night than the sun, the same small margin night on night, so that the real turn of the heavens, the one the stars keep, runs a touch short of a day.

He was quiet a moment. "You found that alone, up here, with no one to hand it to you. It is one of this room's oldest secrets, and you already have it."

He took two of the small white cups from inside his robe — the same he had filled the night he first brought me up, a year gone — filled them, gave me one, and we drank to Syphiron again.

“It does not lessen,” he said. “That is the thing no one tells a candidate, because a candidate would not come if he knew. You will carry Syphiron the way you carry your own name; and one day you will stand where I stand, and open yourself under the stone to the one who comes after you, and he will grieve you — and in that same hour you will grieve me, and Syphiron under me, and every name below us, all the way down. It is the longest part of the office, and the last taught, and the one honest thing in it.”

He turned one of the cups in his hand, the small white one with a faded ring of blue about its lip.

“Ka-Sarem of Light taught me this, the year he was released, and told me where the cups came from, so that it would not stop with him. A Keeper of Light called Ka-Noroth, seven before Ka-Sarem, before any Mountain I knew. He loved two things past the office. He loved to paint the heavens — though he could never keep the paint from the damp, so none of it lived. And he loved to paint women, and those he found ways to keep. When his hands grew too old for a brush he turned them away from the wheel of the heavens and made these: a cup for the Keeper, a cup for the Veil, thin enough to break if a man closed his fist on one, so that he would have to be gentle with his grief or lose the vessel of it.”

He set the cup in my hand.

“So you have grieved Syphiron from the cups of a man who loved the heavens, and loved women, and is three hundred years in the ground, and whom you carry now as well, because I have said his name to you. That is what we hand down, Kailan — not the chain. The names, the cups, and the grief that does not end. Drink.”

Then he came to it. “I have a use for what you have become. Come down tomorrow. There is a thing you must be shown, and a thing you must be told before it.”

The thing I must be told he told me at the foot of the shaft, his hand flat on the cold stone as though he swore on it. “I have spoken to Ka-Orun of Justice. What you found up here has earned you the next teaching a Veil is owed — and it is no deep secret of theirs, but a plain shape Justice drills into its servant boys before they are grown. He has set one of his candidates to give it to you — a young man, Sa-Tavan — and asked me nothing about why, because Justice does not ask. Take what Sa-Tavan gives; give him nothing back. He will teach you a shape, and you

will never tell him what the shape is for. You will not name the ground under our feet, nor what turns above it, nor say that you have been up here at all. Light holds a thing Justice does not, and Justice may not have it from you. That is the whole of the condition. It is older than the office, for Justice must be blind, and cannot know the shape of the world. Do you take it?"

I took it.

In a plain Justice schoolroom, of the kind where the servant boys are drilled, stood a square table with its sides raised a hand high, like a tray built to hold sand, and in the tray lay four equal cut stones; each a wedge with one square corner. Two stuck together as a rectangle, horizontally disposed in the top left corner. Two stuck together, vertically from the bottom right corner. Sa-Tavan waited beside it, ink to the second knuckle, a stillness that watched.

He then laid two squares in the empty space: a large one at the bottom left, a smaller one at the top right corner. And the space in the table was fit perfectly. After, he removed them all and laid each wedge's corner in the corner of the table; and each longest point, pointing at the next corner. And the shape that appeared in the middle was a larger square. Which he filled with another stone. And the fit was perfect again. He let me reproduce the demonstration, and after a while, I agreed. The two squares together made the same surface as the big one.

"This is what I have been told to explain to you: the side of the small square, is the same as the wedges' small side; and the side of the medium square is the same side as the wedges' other side. And the side on the opposite corner of the wedge, is the same as the side of the big square." He let it sit for an instant.

"Another thing. Count a tray of mushrooms set in three lines of three, and you count nine — three times three; four lines of four, sixteen; five rows of five, twenty-five. We count surfaces the same on this table: how long on one side, times how long on the other. So what I have shown you is nothing more than the observable fact that three times three added to four times four, nine and sixteen, is equal to twenty-five, which is five times five. Part of a Justice servant's basic teaching. And if you want a riddle for servant boys of Justice, try to write this square's diagonal as a ratio of the size of the other shapes."

"I don't understand why Ka-Raedin thinks that this helps Light."

"They have not told me why, but they have told me to show you this as well." And he turned to the wall, bringing a lamp closer to it, where a circle had been engraved in the stone. The circle was crossed by two lines, vertical and horizontal, both going through the middle of the circle. "The floor and the wall, we call

them.” And a point on the top and right part of the circle had been joined to the centre.

“This is what I have been told to explain to you, once and only once, in a language you would understand: the two shadows of a point on a circle.”

“This line, joining the point on the circle to its centre. Think of it as a stick of wood. If the Sun is high in the heavens, this is its shadow on the floor.” And with a piece of chalk, he drew the shadow of the stick on the horizontal line, the floor.

“And if the sun is very far, rising from here,” he said, pointing to the right of the circle, “then the shadow of the stick on the wall is this.” And he drew on the wall the stick’s shadow on the vertical line, the wall.

“So the first shadow square added to the second shadow square, is the same as the stick square.”

“Good. He gets it. And this is true for any point on the circle. And this is what I am to give to you and no more: If you call the side of the stick’s measure to be one, then the first shadow squared added to the second shadow squared is equal to one. Make of that what you will.” I thanked him for the lesson, and left.

Outside the door Ka-Raedin was waiting. Ka-Orun of Justice pulled the schoolroom shut behind me and set no seal on it — there was nothing in that room a servant boy of his did not handle every day. Neither of them asked what had passed inside.

Then Ka-Raedin walked me to the Hall of Ceremony and left me sitting on Light’s north side, facing the forbidden circle where swung the Pendulum.

“You have it all,” he said. “You have the star in the north. You have the stick. You have the angle of the stick. And today you were given the shape its shadow makes on the wall. Sit here, and think. Do nothing else until you find it, and find it you will.”

He turned to go, and at the threshold turned back. “Do you remember what I told you at the lesson of the fourth shadow?”

“The measure of the light is the measure of the substance,” I said. “Part of a Veil’s curriculum.”

“Just so. And should it ever move you to know why one wanderer in the heavens burns faint and red, and another blue-white, you will first have to learn how the measure of the light becomes the measure of the substance.” He stepped into the dark of the passage. “Stay here until you have found the problem no one has set you — and can say both what it asks and what it answers. Then we will talk about the colours of wanderers.”

I sat down where he had left me, with the star and the stick and the angle and the shadow, watching the Pendulum swing. Back and forth, back and forth.

CHAPTER 10

THRESHOLD

— The second of April; the ninth of our interviews. Before we return to your account — did you read the *Genesis* I translated for you?

— You promised me the first chapter and gave me four; thank you, Paul, though I do not yet know whether it was a kindness.

— I could not sensibly stop before the first murder. But keep one thing in mind as you set them side by side. A shared shape does not tell you which came first. It does not tell you either one is true.

— Your murderer looks like ours. You call him *Cain*, son of Adam; ours is his grandson. The envy, the secret killing, the blood in the ground, the exile, the gate shut behind him — all of it kept, and the Mountain lost. Your God forbids the woman the fruit and swears it will kill her; the serpent tells her the boundary may guard God rather than her — which is my own craft, Paul: a second meaning set beside the first. She looks. She crosses. Her eyes open — and your own God says she has become like one of them, knowing good and evil. My Mountain would call that an ascension. You call it a fall, and the one who opened her eyes you call evil. So tell me: why is your serpent evil?

— Hear what you asked. To weigh whether the serpent's gift was good or evil, I have to use good and evil to do it — and that is the fruit. The story cannot be judged from outside it. He tells them they will not die, and they die — slowly, by what they have done. He opens one hidden thing and puts another in its place, the way Light does.

Her eyes come open on her nakedness, her fear, her separation. It is a crossing. Some crossings do not let you back.

— You are playing a trick on me, Paul — a Faith trick, and a poor escape for a man of science. I need no fruit to judge, only wisdom; I need not be Greek to judge *Eris*, nor to have eaten to judge the serpent, and neither do you. If your *Attenborough* and your *Darwin* are to be believed — and I believe them, for I built the test and it stood — these are only stories, made for a purpose, and it matters nothing which was told first.

— Not a trick. Just one point of view. When a hundred peoples who never met invent the same story — the crossing, the opened eye, the gate that shuts — each is putting a face on a true thing that happened to them all. No serpent spoke. The shape it stands for is real. The tellers call the serpent evil because a story needs something to blame for the door. And the door only opens one way. Judge the serpent as you like. Look at the door, not the serpent.

— ... That is the part I did not want. A forbidden act; widened knowledge; the self split into the one who lives and the one who watches himself live; exile; the home still standing, and shut. I began by reading *Eve* as the first of my kind to practise Light. I ended by finding that her punishment is my life. Your *Cain* was the resemblance I wanted; your *Eve* the one I did not. I have not finished being expelled from my *Eden* — and the next part of my account begins with the reward I was given for crossing a boundary blind.

Ka-Raedin had left me on the north side of the Hall of Ceremony, before the forbidden circle where the great Pendulum swung, and told me to sit and think and do nothing else until I found it. The finding took me weeks, and then weeks past those. I watched the vertical plate of God and the Beast cut the air and cross its mark on the ring below, back and forth, back and forth, and turned the four of them against the swing — the star, the stick, the angle, the second shadow — until one grey morning they came together in my head and stayed.

I went to Ka-Raedin with it whole.

“The Pendulum keeps its own line,” I said. “Once it is set swinging, nothing in the Mountain can turn it; it holds to the heavens. What moves is the ground beneath it. Stand such a thing at the very crown of a spinning ball, and the ground would carry its mark a whole circle round in a single turn of the ball; stand it at the belt, and the mark would never stir. We stand between the two. The share of the turn that reaches the mark is the upright shadow — the second shadow Sa-Tavan drew — of the angle the still star keeps above the north: a star-day divided by the second shadow of the angle of the stick, and no more. I took that angle myself,

through the throat of metals and lenses, as near as the glass would give it, and worked its second shadow to the last figure I could hold. And I have proved it twice — once by the reckoning, and once by the mark's own creep, watched and counted — that the ground carries the swing a full circle round beneath it once in two and three-quarter days. The split of the Hours is the world turning."

He was a long time quiet.

"You found it," he said at last, and spent on the three words a thing he rarely spent. "A year in the cold, and the boy comes down holding the eye, the number, and the stone in one hand at once. Count the men in the Mountain who could follow what you have just said to me; you will run out of fingers on the one hand, and you are the youngest of them by thirty years."

Then he told me what the finding had earned. "The turning of that mark has been kept since before the Mountain counted its years, and Faith keeps it. Va-Maera reads it. She calls its slow swing the direction of God, and she is right in every way but the one that matters. You will carry her your measure of it, and take hers, and the two of you will keep the split of the Hours between you. Justice holds the number and cannot read it; Faith holds the turning and has hung a god on it; you alone hold both ends now, and know what runs between them."

So I was given the Hall of Prayer. I had grown up forbidden its inner ground, and now I had a reason to cross it: to carry Faith my count of the mark, and bring hers back, twice in a week and then oftener. The way to it ran from the Hall of Ceremony, where the Pendulum swung, along the old service spine and down past the southern vents, to the Hall of Prayer on the far side of the Mountain's throat. I walked it with the numbers in my head, back and forth, the way I had once walked to the Mirror.

The way ran past a service vent I had never had cause to walk by.

On the third or fourth crossing, with the hall lamps behind me trimmed down, I caught a thread of light come back out of it — a pale point far inside the stone, where no lamp of the Mountain's had any business to burn.

The new road had set that vent in front of an eye a year under the heavens had trained to catch the one glimmer that comes where none should. On any night of my old life I would have passed its mouth and seen nothing. Now I saw.

I let the first glint pass. I recorded nothing, spoke to no one. The old Sa-Kailan would have gone after the first brightness with a stolen lamp and a heroic justification; I watched for twelve nights instead. The flash failed when high dust crossed the moon. It showed from one position only in the old vent gallery, and only

if I lowered my head to the line where the outside air entered before it became Mountain air.

Then memory supplied the missing shape. As Sa-Kailan, Candidate of Light, with dust in my sandals and Va-Sheva beside me saying softly: *Do not point*. Va-Sheva closing possibilities before danger had a name. A flash may be nothing. A turned marker may be nothing. An old woman out of place may be nothing.

Three nothings close together become a shape. What had once been said to me as a rebuke now sounded like an invitation, and I distrusted it. But in the empty hours of the night, I returned to the glint.

I chose the route only after I could close my eyes and walk it in memory. The eastern lower spine to the old vent gallery; down the maintenance stair past the disused oil shelves; then the old air chamber above the cedar descent, where outside breath moved through stone before it became Mountain air.

So far I had only looked. On the night I chose, the Mountain was quiet after a minor mourning rite. Faith had held the lower Hall late for a child who had died of fever before naming. Such deaths were common enough to pass without shock, but they always altered its sound. The night lamps burned low. The air was dry.

No dust cloud veiled the moon beyond the hidden openings. The glint appeared twice before second-night silence, faint and precise.

I waited until it appeared a third time. Then I went, and carried no blade; a blade would have made me a frightened Veil, pretending the desert was something metal could bargain with. The passage outward yielded to pressure where the lower stone had been shaved thin. Beyond it the Mountain became less human.

Someone had cut handholds and worn them smooth, and carved a line that fingers could find and low light hid. It had none of Light's interpretive softness, none of Balance's measured signs. Cold air came through cracks ahead.

I paused before the final opening. I opened the stone and stepped out.

The night desert was another country from the one I had seen by day — larger, because it showed me almost nothing. The Mountain rose behind me as blackness with weight. I wrapped the mouth cloth against the instinct to breathe too quickly. The air tasted of stone, salt, and distance. The outcrop, when I reached it, looked natural at first.

From below the glint stayed dark. I moved around the stone slowly, searching for wrongness — a surface too smooth, a crack too straight, a place where the dust failed to gather. Shield would build so that no one would think to look for a door at all. I found the polished mineral only after kneeling.

It sat in a shallow hollow no wider than my hand, behind a lip of stone: a mineral plate polished by hand and angled toward the Mountain, lost among pale scratches by day, but at the right lamp or moon angle it caught and returned a single point — a signal only one placed to read it could read. Beside it, almost worn away, was a mark cut into the stone. A threshold line, broken twice, with a small inward notch. Shield.

I felt no triumph. The proper thing was to withdraw and report, and let Keeper answer Keeper — which was also the surest way to have Shield seal the place before I knew what I had seen. I stood in the cold until the choice stopped arguing with itself. I chose to go in and know, whatever it would cost.

The mechanism resisted silently, then gave with a thickness that spoke of long maintenance. Air breathed out from within. Dry. Old. Mineral. Full.

I slipped inside and pulled the stone nearly closed behind me, leaving a finger's width for air and for return.

The passage sloped downward, narrow at first, forcing me sideways, then widened into a cut corridor whose walls bore neither Light markings nor Faith text. Dust lay thin over the floor, enough to show where feet had disturbed it, though few had passed lately. I held my lamp low and moved slowly.

No entry mark, no return mark, no prayer, no measure, no instruction. Only stone and the smell of preserved air. It was a chamber whose first impression was emptiness. Then my lamp found the nearest shelf. Objects.

At first only a few: stones, broken blades, small bowls, fragments of painted surface, a corroded shape that might once have been a tool or an idol. Then the flame widened and more shelves appeared, rising along the walls, tier after tier, receding into darkness. No bodies lay there. No bones arranged for burial. Civilisations had entered here as fragments. They had stayed.

I lifted the lamp to the nearest shelf. Every object was tagged, and every tag was Shield's — the broken-threshold sign at the top, and beneath it an official hand closed to public reading. Shield alone had catalogued this place; Shield alone had ever been meant to stand in it.

The other four Kahirs would have had to be told the room existed before they could so much as fear it. Each tag stated what the object was believed to be, how it had entered, who had handled it, and whether it could be touched, decay, or carry doctrinal danger. Archive, then.

The first object I truly saw was a small bronze figure of a man holding a weapon shaped like three prongs. The body had gone green with age, the beard set in formal curls. Around the base, faint wave marks had been scratched or cast. The

Shield tag gave no name I knew, only its own hand: *water-lord; corruption of the deep-water memory; metal stable, salts present, do not wash.*

| — I know him as Poseidon now. Thanks to your *Iliad*.

Outsiders had taken the memory of deep water and made it a lord of appetite, the wish to command water without counting it.

Next came a dark figure with the head of an animal on the body of a man. Long snout, upright ears, narrow limbs. Black surface, gold traces, eyes shaped with an unsettling calm. Beneath it lay a cloth fragment marked with faded symbols and a small carving of a wrapped human shape, bound head to foot. The Shield tag bore a warning older than the hand that had written it.

The next chamber changed material. Painted stone. Carved panels. A fragment of image preserved behind cloudy glass. I held the lamp high and saw a man with a blade raised over a bound youth. The youth lay on something close to an altar. Above the man's hand, a sign of Heaven: lines descending from cloud or fire. The father's face had been damaged, but the blade remained clear. For several breaths the horror escaped me.

Then the Book of Blood did it for me. Brother against brother. Father against son. Hunger made law. A broken piece of Gospel called whole.

Outsiders had carved a holy story: a father binding his own son to kill him while the animal stood spared beside them, obedience made into a willingness to murder the child before the goat.

The Shield tag below it carried more than the others: *threshold danger; doctrinal contamination; retained for comparative doctrine; image damaged, blade line clear.*

The next image was worse, because the people in it looked tender, and what they were gathered around was cruel. A small metal cross, then a larger one of wood darkened by age. Then a painted fragment of people kneeling before a tortured man fixed upon crossed beams. His head drooped. His ribs showed.

Wounds marked hands, feet, side. Around him the worshippers lifted their faces in reverence. Some wept. Some reached toward him. I stared.

The Mountain had martyrdom — I granted that now; I had seen Syphiron die. I slowed myself. *Veil, not boy. Interpret after seeing.*

I looked again. The worshippers' faces were grieving. To the Outsiders, holiness seemed to go in through torture and come out wearing gold.

Beyond it, on a lower shelf, stood a figure of a woman unlike any gravure in the Mountain. Many arms spread from her body, each hand open or holding some small thing. Many breasts, or ornaments like breasts, covered her chest. Her face was serene and excessive at once. Around her feet were small animal shapes, fruits, weapons, and open hands. There was more of everything on her than the Mountain would grant a man in a year.

Each might have meant something else to the people who made it; whatever reached me came damaged.

The shelves went on past these, older and stranger, more than one lamp and one night could hold, and I let most of them stay dark.

Each shelf carried its chain — object, source, risk, keeping — and one phrase recurred down the tiers like a refrain: *harmless unless taught*.

Time became material. Stone became bronze, bronze became iron, iron became glass, glass became paper, paper became photograph.

The chamber widened at the modern section. Here the shelves became cabinets, some locked, some open. The air was drier, kept by hidden vents. The labels were newer and more dangerous, and all of them Shield's — classification, preservation, restriction, the angle from which a thing might be safely looked at. The handwriting varied from tenure to tenure.

Old corrupted gods could be explained — Shield guarded the threshold, and a threshold needs a guard who has seen what waits beyond it. I could accept that, uneasily. Then I saw the photographs.

The first showed a woman under hard light. Her blonde hair was tied back. Beside her stood a man in desert clothing, his face lined, his posture loose in the way Shield posture loosened only after readiness had entered the bones. Behind them, partly visible, was a rock face I recognised with a sudden bodily certainty. Another place, near the Mountain's outer folds.

The lower white border carried marks in an outsider hand. Beneath them, in careful Shield script, someone had copied two names. Sarah Blackwood. Amastan.

I stared at the woman. Recent enough that the colours still held, that the Mountain's current elders might have been breathing when she was. I had never heard the name, and finding it here, in a Shield drawer, was worse than if I had.

— Sarah Blackwood.

— Sarah Blackwood indeed.

The second photograph showed no face. Only desert, distance, and a terrible flower of light rising from the horizon, too large to be flame and too ordered to be storm. The sky around it had been bleached almost empty. On the lower border, in the same unfamiliar hand, were marks I had never learned to read. One sequence had been copied beneath in Shield script: Reggane, 1960.

The word and the numbers meant nothing to me — a place, a date, a wound the Outsiders had set down because even they had been frightened by what their own hands had made. What that flower was lay beyond me.

The cabinet below held maps, some in outsider lines, some in Shield marks: Mountain folds, dry washes, glint points, hidden sightlines, the Oasis shown by the blank space the routes bent around. And a route leading from the outcrop inward, splitting toward the Labyrinth and, impossibly, toward service routes near the Hall of Ceremony.

I unfolded another map. It bore names in scripts beyond my reading, but three had been copied in Mountain hand: Amastan, Sarah, Ka-Xhian. *Ka* — a Keeper; Shield had recorded the contact with a title.

Lines ran from the names to dates, routes, and small boxed terms: *Breach. Containment. Exchange. Loss. Sealed. Limited disclosure. Threshold Exception. Exchange.* I read the word three times. At the back of the map cabinet lay a Shield record tablet.

I lifted it with both hands.

Compressed, official, closed to public reading. *Contact maintained under Threshold Exception. Outsider asset contained beyond full breach. Sarah Blackwood retained under observation. Ka-Xhian authorised limited disclosure. Horizon note sealed.*

Beyond the modern cabinets a narrow passage led back toward the Mountain, and I followed it with the lamp held low.

The smell reached me before the room did. The archive had been dry mineral; this was older air gone wrong — piss, and sweat, and under both of them the flat iron of blood. The passage opened into a low cell cut from raw stone. A single fixed seat.

Rings set into the rock at the height of a man's wrists and his ankles. A shallow gutter worked into the floor and sloped to a drain. The walls were thick, and the stone drank sound; I clapped once, softly, and the room gave me back nothing.

Someone had called. The stains had gone down into the seams of the floor and dried there black.

Near the foot of the seat, pressed into the stone where the blood had set around it and held it fast, lay a narrow band of woven cloth. I knew it before I let myself know it. I had spent too many hours in the Oasis with nothing to do but look at her.

It was a ribbon from Va-Sheva's hair. There was no mistaking the weave of it, nor the colour, though half the colour had gone down into the dark stain that fixed it to the floor. It was hers. It was in the stone, and it was in the blood. I knelt with the lamp, and I did not touch it.

Past the cell the passage ended at a sealed door, and the door bore one mark only, cut deep and cut old: Shield, and beneath it Shield again, and beneath that a Shield seal I had never been taught, older than Ka-Raedin's tenure, perhaps older than Syphiron's.

Whatever lay behind it, Shield had sealed for Shield, and had never once meant a Veil of Light to be standing in this passage to read the sign at all.

To take anything tagged was breach, and would leave a gap in the count. I needed something slight enough that its absence would pass, and found it in a loose copy fragment at the back of the map bundle — a scrap bearing four entries in Mountain hand: Sarah Blackwood. Amastan. Ka-Xhian. Threshold Exception.

I folded it once and placed it inside the inner seam of my robe. Then I stood in the Tomb — or the Chamber of Thresholds, or whatever Shield named this place when it dared name it at all — and let the full weight of it enter me. I lifted the lamp and looked once more at Sarah Blackwood's face. I lowered the lamp.

I would hold my rage. I would keep away from Va-Sheva — either the hand that had drawn blood in that room or the girl who had left the ribbon, and I lacked the strength that night to learn which. I would keep the evidence in my hands and think.

A word in the wrong place could let them call it all a breach before the truth in it had a chance to hold. I left as carefully as I had entered. Inside my robe, the scrap touched my skin. Sarah Blackwood. Amastan. Ka-Xhian. Threshold Exception.

— You did not interrupt me a single time today.

— No. I did not want to interrupt your story, or distract you from the account. I wanted it clean and true. We have arrived at an important moment of your account. One I was told to expect. From tomorrow Friday, Sarah shall be joining us, it's a long holiday week end; and she is finally available. She tells me she wants to tell you how it all began, and how that picture was taken.

- Why is this day holy? what is special about it ?
 - It has to do with the man you saw on the cross; and it is long and hard to explain.
-

CHAPTER 11

REGGANE

— The third of April; Holy Friday, and the house shut for the Easter days. The machine is running. And you will see, Kailan, that we are three this morning. I did not set the third chair.

— I did. Sit, both of you. It is my house, Mr Morgan; I may take a chair in any room of it, this one included, and I have decided to stop taking it from behind the glass.

— ... So the tea has a face. I was told you would come today. I did not think you would come out where I could see you — you have watched me a month from the dark and never once needed to.

— I have watched you a month from the dark, and it has cost me sleep I could not spare. You have given this machine the bowl, the pendulum, the girl, the drowned, the raising into Light — all of it, from one edge of a desert I have read my whole life from the other — and I have sat behind a pane of glass and wept where no one could tell me not to. I have given you a name across a tea tray and nothing else. That is no longer a fair trade. So I have come round to the door and taken the chair, and I mean to set my half down into your machine, in your hearing, from the beginning, the way you set down yours. You may stop me wherever you like.

— The woman who pays for the tea. That is what your man called you the first week, and I have carried it since like a coin in the pocket — a small lie, and I let it stand, because a small lie shows you where the large one is kept. You are not the woman who pays for the tea. You are the woman in the drawer.

— ... Go on.

— I stood, a whole life ago, in a room beneath my Mountain no living Veil was meant to enter, and I lifted a Shield tablet in both hands, and your face was in it — an outsider's likeness copied into our own hand. *Sarah Blackwood. Retained under observation.* A Keeper called Ka-Xhian had cut a door in the very wall my people knelt before, and let you through it, and written down what it cost, and sealed the word for the cost. Your father turned his nose at my Mountain for thirty years and died with his hand never on it. You are the daughter who put her hand on it. And then you reached into a desert and drew me out of it with aircraft and money and seventeen men, and sat me in a warm room, and set your gentle clever Mr Morgan to take me apart a morning at a time while you watched through the glass. I have wanted a long while to see the shape of that hand. Here it is. Older than I thought.

— Reached in. As though I came over your wall with a knife in my teeth. I never touched your Mountain, boy. I *heard* it. Sixty-six years ago your fathers struck the deep earth five times, evenly, and signed it, and waited for the whole planet to knock back — and I was the one ear in that desert turned the wrong way to catch the signature, while nine better scientists watched the French light a sun. I did not build the engine that shakes the core of the world and then bury it under a book of blood and teach the children to call the test a prayer. Your people did that. I only refused, alone, for sixty-six years, to pretend I had not heard it. Do not sit in my own house and name me the intruder. Your Mountain has been shouting into my instruments since before you drew breath.

— ...

— And the drawer. You lifted a tablet in a room you had broken into, past a seal you were forbidden, and you found me there and call it my crime. You were the one over the wall, Kailan, not I.

— No. We are neither of us clean. And we are not two. Whatever you found, that first time, you kept it and told no one — I am guessing, and I know I am guessing, and I know that I am right, because I stood over my own proof in the dark, the tablet still warm from your face, and the first thing I felt, before fear, before any decent thing, was that no one else alive would ever be let to see it. You and I are one disease, taken from opposite ends of the same desert. Two clevernesses. You had the word for it before I did.

— ... Now you begin to be worth the tea. Two people who spent their lives watching the one corner of the night where nothing was supposed to be, and could not forgive the world for being wrong about it. You were raised inside the secret; I had to steal my way to the rim of it; and you still, even here, believe your side of the sand is the clean one. It is not. But we can quarrel about clean when I am done. I am a ninety three year old woman, and I have little time, and I have learned this last season — from you, in

this house, off no drum of my own — how little a thing kept in my own vault, under my own hand, is worth. I will have my half set down once, in a machine I do not own, in the hearing of the one man alive who can weigh it, while I am still here to say it plainly.

— ... Then sit where I can see you, and keep your hands where the machine can hear them. Begin where it begins.

I was twenty-seven the year the French lit their first bomb in the Sahara, and I was one of perhaps forty people in the world positioned to hear it properly, and I was the only one of the forty who was bored by it.

Understand what a spectacle it was. A country that had lost a war and an empire and most of its dignity within living memory had decided to buy all three back in a single morning with a tower of steel and a sun it made itself, in a corner of a desert it still, for a few more years, called France. Reggane. They put the device on a hundred metres of scaffold, and they filled the ground around it with instruments, and they invited the whole nervous world to listen, and it listened, because a nation that can make its own sun is one you keep an ear on. Gerboise blue, they called it. A blue desert rat.

My husband put me there. He was a physicist of the kind the new French state was collecting like uranium ore in those years — rare, refined at great cost, and handled by men who did not understand him and could not do without him. He believed in the bomb the way other men believe in God: as a thing too large to be moral, and therefore beneath morality, and therefore his to serve without stain. He was clever and vain and, in the one narrow chapel of his cleverness, close to great. I married him for the chapel. I have never pretended otherwise, least of all to him.

What he had that I wanted was a way of thinking I did not yet own. He thought in chains. A single splitting atom is nothing; it would not warm your hands. But it throws two more, and each of those two throws two, and if you have gathered enough of the right stuff close enough together, the nothing becomes, in the space of a breath, the end of a city. The largest thing was only the smallest thing, permitted to answer itself. I took that from him the way you take a tool from a bench when the owner has turned away, and I never gave it back, and it was the most valuable thing I ever stole, and I stole a great deal.

My father had given me the other half without knowing it. Edward Blackwood spent his life moving the buried wealth of the world from where it lay to where it would sell, and the deep Sahara was one of his cellars. Oil in the north. Iron. And,

once the French wanted their own sun, the yellow rock, which he had been quietly gathering the rights to for a decade before anyone official admitted wanting it. My father worked by nose. In his trade that was rarer than science, and more useful. And for the last stretch of his working life his nose had been turned, without profit and against all his instincts, toward an empty quarter of that desert where nothing he touched ever came to anything. He knew there was something out there. He was certain of it the way he was certain of a seam of ore under a hillside, by a pressure behind the sternum that had made him rich. And he chased it for thirty years and a fortune and died having never laid a hand on it. I loved him. I do not think he would have known what to do with it if he had found it. I did.

So. Between them, the two men who made me, I had the chain and the cellar. My husband taught me that the ground could carry the shape of a thing that had happened in it, out and out to any patient enough ear, and that the shape could be read for its cause. Men were only just learning to tell a bomb from an earthquake by the drawing it left on a drum. A whole science was being born in those years for one small dishonest purpose: so that the great powers could catch each other testing in secret. I was inside that science because my husband was, and I was better at the part of it he found tedious, which was the reading. He wanted to make the sun. I wanted to sit in the dark afterward with the drum-paper and learn what the desert had been keeping in its notes.

There is a grammar to that reading, and I had it cold before I was thirty. A natural quake announces itself by its untidiness: it builds, it wanders, it arrives in a long ragged crowd of waves out of step with one another, and never once repeats itself, because the earth keeps no discipline. An explosion is the opposite kind of lie: it is too tidy, all of its force flung out in a single hard shove and nothing after it, a shout with no sentence to follow. Between those two poles a trained reader learns to place almost everything the ground can do: a cliff falling, a mine caving, a heavy truck on a bad road, a door slammed somewhere in the recorder's own building. The one thing a trained reader is never made ready for, because nothing in the honest earth produces it, is a figure that is both tidy and repeated: a small deliberate hand, struck and struck again across the years without one hair of variation. That is something standing on the earth and using it.

— When was this.

— The first bomb? A lifetime ago. Yours. Do the arithmetic later; what matters is that the ear existed, and was turned on your desert, and you did not know an ear could

exist. Your whole peace rested on a thing that had stopped being true before you were born.

The bomb was on the tower and the world was holding its breath, and I was in a tent with a bank of recorders forty kilometres out, and I was, as I have said, bored, because the bomb was the one event in that desert whose shape I could already predict. It would be enormous and it would be simple, and nothing enormous and simple had ever held my eye.

There were nine of us in that tent, and eight of them were better scientists than I was, and every one of the eight spent the last minute of the count with his eyes fixed on the three drums aimed at the tower. When it came, the light came first, through the canvas, a white with no morning anywhere in it. Then the ground, a long low shove that lifted the recorders on their table and set them down again. Then, much later, absurdly, the sound, a flat enormous slap laid against the whole horizon at once. The eight men watched the great strokes climb and break across the three drums, and were moved, I think, in the way men are moved by their own audacity. I kept my eyes on the other drums. The small ones. The ones aimed at the parts of the night where nothing was supposed to be.

And in the hours after, while the great signal was still fading off the drums, there was something else on my papers.

It was small. It was so small that on any ordinary day it would have been thrown out as the tremor of a passing truck or the settling of the recorder's own frame. And it came from the wrong place: from far to the south, out of a stretch of the Tanezrouft where the maps put nothing but distance. And it had a shape I had never seen on a drum before.

An explosion gives one sharp shout; a quake gives a ragged rise and fall. This came in parts. Five of them. Five small clean strokes, evenly weighted, one after another, with a spacing between them that did not vary, and then it stopped, complete, the way a sentence stops. And beneath the five, or wrapped around them, there was a longer, softer return, a swelling and a dying, as though the five small blows had woken something very large and very far away and it had rolled over once in its sleep and settled.

I took the five even strokes for the event, and the long soft roll behind them for the ground settling under the blow — an aftershock, a nothing, the kind of thing a careful reader is trained to set aside. That first night I understood only one thing. A thing that arrives in a fixed number of even strokes, at a fixed spacing, from a place that holds nothing, has been made to do that by a hand.

I did not tell anyone. I did not tell anyone because it was mine. In the space of one drum-length I had found the only new thing in a desert full of men making the loudest old thing there is, and my first clear feeling — before wonder, before fear, before any decent thing — was that no one else in that tent was going to be allowed to see it. I folded the paper along the margin, and I put it inside my coat, and I sat through the rest of that historic night with the greatest secret of the century against my ribs and a face arranged for a woman watching a bomb.

— Forgive me. I am only a fact-checker, and it is my trade to ask the small stupid question. A great camp had come into that desert. Trucks, generators, drilling plant, run by men working through the night. Could your five strokes not have been some engine of their own?

— It is the right question, and I put it to myself for four years before I would let the answer stand. An engine runs; it does not compose a figure and sign it and put down the pen, and then keep silence for four years. And their camp was to the north, at the tower. My small thing came out of the south, out of a quarter where the French had set nothing at all, because there was nothing there they knew to set it on. The machine was older than their camp. It had been running in that ground long before theirs arrived, and would be running long after they left, and it had only been caught because they lit an enormous light beside it, and I was the one person in the desert looking the wrong way.

That was one event, and one event is nothing. One event is a fault of the instrument, a fluke of the rock, a truck you did not know about. I knew that better than anyone, because knowing it is the whole of the discipline. So I did the correct thing, which is also the cruel thing: I waited. I let it be one event, and I built the rest of my life into a shape that would still be standing there, ear turned to that empty quarter, whenever the second one came.

It came four years later, when the French had moved their testing into the mountains of the Hoggar and buried it underground, and the whole apparatus of listening had moved and multiplied with it, and I had married my access into a permanent place inside it. Another shot, another night of great signals. And in the quiet after, from the south, from the same empty quarter, to the width of a hair the same: five even strokes, the same spacing, the same long soft roll waking behind them. I laid the new paper over the old one I had carried for four years,

folded and refolded until it had gone soft, and the two drawings lay on each other the way a face lies on its reflection.

I did not celebrate. I remember precisely what I did: I locked the door of the room I was in, and I was sick, quietly and thoroughly, into a metal bin, and then I washed my face and went back to work. What turned my stomach was the size of the thing. I had spent four years telling myself that the likeliest truth was that I had seen nothing at all, a smudge, a fault, the one error every young reader makes. And the paper in my two hands had just taken that comfort away, and left me alone with the other possibility, the one I had wanted, God help me, more than I had ever wanted anything. I was right. And I have not once, in the sixty-six years since, been let stop being right.

What no one warns you of is the particular grief that comes after being right about a thing like this. It is not grief for the dead the thing could make; that comes later, and it is almost bearable, because you can do arithmetic on it. It is grief for the thing that has no number: that the young are told the world was once innocent of such power, and that this is the kindest of the lies — that given a dark enough gift, some hand, in some century, has always already reached for it, and built it, and buried it in the sand to wait. I had spent my life beside my own century's loud reaching for it. Now I held the proof in two hands that mine was neither the first such reaching nor would it be the last. I did not weep. But that, Kailan, was the hour I stopped believing that men would not.

One reading was an accident. Two, the same to a hair, was a machine. There is no third possibility, and I did not need a third to know what I had, but the world was generous and gave me a third some years on, and a fourth, at long, patient, maddening intervals — always after the loud events, always small, always from the same nothing, always the same five strokes and the same great sleeping roll. Whatever it was, out there, it did not want to be found, and it had achieved that with a voice it used so rarely that only a person who had already decided it was there would ever gather enough of it to be sure. I was that person, and I do not repent of it, and you would not have wanted me to, because the incurious version of me would have folded that first paper into a report, and it would have gone up a chain of men who would have done to your Mountain, in one loud impatient decade, what I have spent sixty-six careful years preventing.

— She wants you to be grateful. Do you hear it? She has just told us she hunted my dead for sixty-six years, and she wants the room to thank her for being unhurried about it.

— I hear it.

— And you write it down anyway.

— I write all of it down. That is the one thing left in this house that is still honest.

The strokes told me a machine existed and roughly where. They could tell me nothing of what it was, or who ran it, and I could not simply walk into an empty quarter of the Sahara and dig, because the empty quarter was a great deal larger than my patience, and because a woman with a fortune and a set of seismic papers announcing that there was a secret installation in the deep desert would have had the papers taken from her within a season by one of several governments and never seen again. So I did what my father would have done, and went to the cellar.

Edward's records were in three languages and no order, forty years of a man moving wealth by handshake and threat and midnight telephone, and I had them shipped to me and I read them the way I read the drums, for the quiet parts. And the quiet parts of my father's business, the failures, the dead ground, all of it, when I laid it on a map, drew a ring. A ring of avoidance. Every route bent around one place. Every survey that touched a certain reach of the Tanezrouft returned corrupted or did not return. A geologist of my father's, a sober Scot who feared nothing that came out of sand, reported that a certain sixty kilometres of the Tanezrouft were to be surveyed from the air and never once on foot; he gave no reason, and drank himself out of my father's service rather than be made to give one. Money went south and became nothing, again and again, across fifteen years; and my father, who could tell you to the franc where every other coin he had spent had gone, could not account for it. It was the single hole in the ledger of the one man I have known who did not permit himself holes. Two guides had refused a certain line for wages that would have bought their villages. And in the margins, in my father's own furious hand, beside three separate failures, one word, underlined the third time hard enough to tear the paper. A name. Not a place. A person.

Amastan.

My father had circled the same emptiness I had, from the other side, with money instead of instruments, and he had come to the same edge and been turned back, and the thing that turned him back was a man. Somewhere between my father's cellar and my drum-papers there was a human door, and it had a name,

and the name was the first warm thing in the cold problem, and I went toward it the way you go toward the one lit window in a dark street.

— Amastan. That is a name of the veiled people. A man of the sand. ... You are telling me the Mountain kept a hand out in the desert the whole time. Men not of us, who knew enough to turn a rich man back three times, and stayed poor enough to be trusted with the knowing. A ring beyond the ring. Shield would not have told us. A Veil is let to believe the desert is the last wall. If we knew there were hands past the wall, we would ask whose, and how bought, and Shield does not want a Veil asking who can be bought.

— Your father asked exactly those questions, and the asking is what turned him back. I asked a smaller one. I have never once been frightened by the existence of a door. Only by the chance that another hand might reach it before mine.

My husband did not come with me the rest of the way, and I should tell you why, since it is the part I am least admired for.

He gave me everything I have described and one thing more: the door into the French machinery of secrets. A man who makes a nation its bomb is owed favours by the men who guard it, and he spent some of them, without asking closely why, on his clever wife who wanted seismic archives and desert logistics and, later, certain quiet arrangements with certain quiet men. He opened those doors for me because I let him believe we were walking through them together. We were not. He thought we were building a house with two doors. I was building a house with one, and putting him outside it a room at a time, so gently and so reasonably that by the end he was grateful for the fresh air.

He died before any of it came to its harvest. The machinery that makes suns is not gentle with the men who serve it closest; he had stood too near too many of his own answers. He went in under a year, badly. I was with him for it. I want that in the record too, beside the rest: that I sat with the man I had hollowed out, and held what was left of his hand, and grieved him honestly, and that neither the hollowing nor the grief cancelled the other. Both are true. I have made my peace with rooms that hold two true things. It is the only religion I have ever been able to keep.

What he left me was his access, which did not lapse for years because the men who owed him were slow to notice he was dead, and one unfinished sentence he had said to me near the end, drugged and wandering, which I will not repeat, except to say that it was about chains, and about how the smallest possible push,

delivered in exactly the right place at exactly the right moment, need supply almost none of the energy of the thing it starts. He had spent his life on that sentence pointed at the atom. He did not live to hear that it was also the truest thing anyone ever said about the five little strokes from the south. I finished the sentence for him.

The man who carried the French half of it after my husband was named Martinez. You will not meet him, so I will be brief and unkind. Roger Martinez came up under my father in the trade and stayed on to serve me, and what he served, under both of us, was never quite Blackwood and never quite France but the narrow overlapping shadow the two throw when they stand close, where the yellow rock is found and the paper is shabby and a certain kind of man is needed to go himself and sign it. Wherever the deep desert had a secret worth a government's while, there was Martinez, with the right introductions and the wrong conscience, holding a door for whichever master arrived first. He gave me protection, and classification, and continuity, and the quiet understanding that a discovery of the kind I was making belongs to the arrangement that lets her survive making it. I took his help for thirty years, and we understood each other perfectly, and I have outlived my usefulness to his masters and he knows it and I know it, which is the reason this house is not as safe as this boy believes it to be.

On the day I am telling you of, Martinez was only the man who could find me a person in a desert. And I gave him a name out of my dead father's margin, and told him to bring me the man who had turned Edward Blackwood back three times: alive, and unfrightened, and above all unbought by anyone else first.

— Notice, before we go on, what the first thing was that I did with the greatest discovery of the age. I took a name out of my dead father's margin, and I hired a man to help me commit the first of a great many crimes against your people. I am not telling you this to be forgiven; I gave that up a long way back, and I have not once missed it. I am telling you so that when I am finished, and it falls to you to decide what is to be done with me, you will not have the excuse of having thought me better than I am. ... But you have had a morning of me now, and I will be paid in kind before I go on. You held my face once, boy — in that drawer, under that lamp, in a room you had no business standing in. Before I hand you the road that put it there, I will know what you did with it the hour you found it. Did you hide me? Or did you carry me straight to your Keepers and hand me in?

— ... You want to know what I did with your face. It is the very next thing I have to tell; it is the door I walked through to arrive in this chair. I carried you against my ribs two days. And then I did the worst thing a careful man can do: I chose the wisest-seeming door in the Mountain, and told myself at every step of the way to it that I was being wise.

CONFESSION

Being dragged into a cell is easy to forgive. What I could never explain is that I chose each door myself, congratulated myself at every one, and arrived at the last still believing I was wise. I carried the scrap two days before I chose the door to receive it.

A boy would have run. The old Sa-Kailan would have run — rushed to Ka-Raedin, or forced Justice to receive what it lacked standing to hear, or gone back to the Tomb, drunk on first discovery, to open the next sealed door.

I did none of those things.

I performed my duties. I supervised two Candidates through an aperture exercise and copied three damaged Light marks into the maintenance record. I checked the dry basins in the Veil's Chamber, restored a loosened shutter, and said nothing when Ka-Raedin watched me longer than usual. I ate what was placed before me and drank what was measured. I slept less than I pretended, and moved through the Mountain with the composure expected of a Veil of Light.

Inside the inner seam of my robe, wrapped in plain cloth, lay the fragment.

Sarah Blackwood. Amastan. Ka-Xhian. Threshold Exception.

I left it where it lay. The words had already entered me. They stood behind my eyes when I cleaned a lamp. They touched the edge of my sleep and turned it before it settled.

On the first day, I arranged the evidence without touching the conclusion.

On the second day, the scrap itself became the fact that frightened me most.

At first it had felt like prudence. Memory alone could be corrected, diminished, or made to resemble fever. If I accused anyone without evidence, they would treat me as a child. The scrap would make them take it seriously.

But the scrap could not be managed the way those things could.

That should have made me destroy it. I kept it. It should have made me lay it before Justice; I refused, for Shield's sealed contradiction brought to Justice without its witness might widen the breach I meant to repair. It should have made me confess to Ka-Raedin; I stayed silent, for Light had found the wound, and closing it was not Light's to do.

There was one correct door.

Va-Sheva.

I examined that conclusion with severity, because Va-Sheva's name had power in me, and I no longer trusted what held power over me. She had been the older girl beyond me, then the woman shaped by office before I had finished being a boy, then the Veil of Shield who made the desert more dangerous because she could read it. As a boy I had wanted her.

But the reasons survived the distrust. She was Shield. She was Veil. She had been at the Oasis when the glint first entered my life. She knew outer markers, silent signals, containment, and thresholds. She could receive what belonged to Shield without dispersing it through the wrong chambers.

I waited until the third afternoon after the Tomb, when Shield rotations changed between the eastern service spine and the lower routes toward the cedar gate. A public petition would have failed — Shield delays or rejects anything that names too much in a line of record. Cornering her in a corridor would have been boyish and dangerous. Instead I used a courtesy permitted between Veils: a route inquiry concerning a repeated exterior reflection near an outer ventilation seam. I phrased it in technical language dull enough for a clerk to file under maintenance overlap. It was true as far as it went.

Va-Sheva came herself.

The meeting place was a narrow observation room between jurisdictions, claimed by neither Light nor Shield. A wall slit looked toward a sealed passage, never into it. The door had no visible bar. A bench stood along one wall, the lamp set above it at an awkward height. Shield liked rooms that could become other rooms quickly.

Va-Sheva entered without escort.

She wore dark duty leather, her hair bound high, her face unsoftened by anything that could be mistaken for private memory. She looked older than she had at the Oasis.

“Va-Kailan,” she said.

“Va-Sheva.”

Her eyes moved over the room before resting on me: wall slit, lamp, floor, hands, robe seam. If she saw where the scrap lay, she gave no sign.

“You requested Shield view on a Light irregularity.”

“Yes.”

“Then speak of the irregularity.”

No warmth. No old remark about boys and eyes.

I chose the first sentence carefully.

“Some exterior glints repeat from beyond permitted routes. Not all are accidental.”

“No.”

The answer was too clean to be an opening.

“I followed one.”

Now she changed. Her breath shortened. Her attention, normally spread across threshold, corridor, body, and air, gathered fully onto me.

“You should speak carefully from here.”

“I know.”

“No,” she said. “You know you should be careful. That is not the same as knowing how.”

The old edge was there, though it no longer made me feel fifteen.

“I found an outer rock,” I said, “marked by Shield. It answered Light — a polished mineral face, a concealed entrance, a passage cut by hands that did not wish to be studied.”

“That sentence already concerns me.”

I looked at her.

“Do you want me to stop?”

“Yes.”

Her honesty struck me.

“Do you order me to stop?”

Something like pain moved beneath her composure.

“No.”

I continued.

"The passage led to a chamber."

"Do not name it."

"I do not know its proper name. I thought *Tomb*."

Her eyes hardened. "That is an invention."

"Then correct me."

"I cannot. Correction would be speech."

I pressed, but without heat.

"The chamber held objects from the outside."

"Many chambers hold many objects."

"Arranged by age. By material. By danger. Some ancient enough to have lost their makers. Some recent enough to accuse the living."

Va-Sheva turned her head slightly toward the door, toward the unseen wardens. I continued before the room closed around silence.

"I saw the false water lord with the trident. The father with the blade over the bound son. The tortured man worshipped on crossed wood."

"Stop."

The word was quiet.

I stopped.

For several breaths there was only the low movement of air through the wall slit.

"You walked through a sealed chamber," she said. "You read what you were not named to read."

"Yes."

The answer was clean.

"You should have come with memory alone," she said.

Va-Sheva looked at me fully.

"What did you remove?"

The question was so direct that a lie would have exposed me on the spot.

"A scrap."

Her face lost colour. Enough.

"What scrap?"

"A copied fragment from a map bundle. Names in Mountain hand."

"Which names?"

To refuse now would make my confession theatrical and useless.

"Sarah Blackwood. Amastan. Ka-Xhian. Threshold Exception."

Va-Sheva closed her eyes once. Only once.

"Where is it?"

“With me. On my body.”

“Show me.”

I reached slowly into the inner seam of my robe. I withdrew the folded cloth, then the scrap, and held it between two fingers.

Va-Sheva left it in my hand. She looked at the scrap as if it were flame.

“You came to the right door, Va-Kailan,” she said. “But you came already holding the fire.”

“I came to Shield.”

“With proof removed from seal.”

“I showed it to no one else.”

“That is good.”

“Then—”

“It is not enough.”

“With memory only, you could have denied me. With suspicion only, redirected me. So the proof was necessary.”

“For you,” she said. “Not for the Mountain.”

“If the chamber is lawful, why is proof of it fatal?”

“Because proof travels.”

“A secret can be guarded,” Va-Sheva said. “A witness can be contained. Proof can be lost, stolen, copied, planted, or found in the wrong sleeve by a child looking for thread.”

“I kept it sealed.”

“You carried it through the Mountain to reach me.”

I had no answer.

She stepped closer and left the scrap where it was.

“Listen. You are Veil of Light — which makes it worse. You do not only hold proof. You make it visible. Hold a mark, and it becomes a door in another’s mind.”

“I came to you so that would not happen.”

“That is not a defence.”

I lowered the scrap slightly.

“I did not come to expose Shield, or to accuse before understanding.”

“I believe you.”

“If Shield can touch Outsiders under seal, there must be a sequence by which abuse is judged. If Ka-Xhian authorised something, someone must know whether it was lawful.”

“Someone does.”

“Who? Justice? Light? Faith?”

She kept silent to each, and then said, “Stop.”

I stopped.

She reached at last and took the scrap from my hand. Her fingers kept clear of mine. She folded the paper back into its cloth without looking again at the words, then placed it inside a small dark case from her belt.

The case closed with a soft double click.

I felt lighter, and, without its weight against my skin, more exposed.

Va-Sheva took one step back.

“The offence is that you carried sight away,” she said. “Seeing was only the door.”

“Will you take me to Ka-Dhavar?”

“I will consult him. Without you. You do not answer yet.”

I studied her.

“Am I accused?”

“Not by me. That is the only answer I can give before my Keeper.”

Va-Sheva turned toward the door, then stopped. Her right hand moved.

It was a small gesture. Too small for alarm, too precise for accident. Two fingers folded beneath the thumb. Wrist turned inward. Hand cut once toward the floor. Palm opened downward.

The two wardens outside the door were meant to stay unseen. But the observation room’s angle caught enough reflection in the opposite wall that I saw one of them shift. Then the second.

Both froze.

They looked at each other. The first warden’s face changed with something close to disbelief. The second’s hand moved halfway toward his chest and stopped.

Va-Sheva kept her eyes on me. She repeated the gesture.

The wardens ran. No question. No confirmation. No sound beyond the sudden hard rhythm of trained feet leaving their posts.

I turned back to her.

“What did you order?”

“A threshold drill,” she said. “Nothing that concerns Light.”

“Those men did not look as if they were training.”

“Then they need more of it.”

“Va-Sheva.”

She met my eyes.

“You have done very serious damage,” she said.

"I will consult Ka-Dhavar. You will speak to no one else — not Ka-Raedin, not Justice, not Faith, not any attendant or clerk or Candidate. You will not return to the chamber. You will remain where Shield places you until Shield has contained the matter."

"Contained me?"

"The matter."

I heard the difference.

"I came to the right door," I said.

"Yes."

"And now the door closes."

"Yes."

If she had been cruel, I would have had something simple to push against. She was not cruel.

"Wait," she said. "Let me handle it."

"Until tomorrow?"

A hesitation so small only Light would see it.

"Until you are called."

I considered refusal, without drama: asking for Ka-Raedin, demanding Justice witness, returning to the northern halls with the dignity of office. But every possible movement now carried the same danger she had named. If I challenged Shield here, in a threshold room, after giving them the scrap, I became exactly what procedure feared.

I had chosen the right door. To reject its first closure because it frightened me would make the choice meaningless.

"I will wait," I said.

The words felt like putting my own hand on the latch from the inside.

Something like grief moved through her and vanished before it could become personal.

"Good."

She opened the door herself. No wardens stood beyond it now. The corridor was empty.

The room was far too comfortable for a place meant to hold me.

"Remain here."

"For how long?"

"Until Shield returns."

I almost smiled.

"That is a very Shield answer."

“Yes.”

She turned to leave.

“Va-Sheva.”

She stopped.

“Did I do wrong by coming to you?”

Her back remained to me for a moment.

“No.”

Then she left and closed the door.

The lock stayed silent.

I sat, then stood and tested the door once.

It opened.

That frightened me.

I stayed where I was.

Shield had placed me in a chamber and inside my own agreement.

Then the first sound came through the stone: metal settling into place, a bar dropped where no public door stood.

I rose.

Another sound answered from another direction. Then a faint change in the air: pressure along the passage, the lamp flame bending toward the door and straightening.

The Mountain was changing state.

I opened the door.

The corridor beyond was no longer empty. Two Shield wardens stood at opposite ends, far enough to seem indifferent, near enough that the corridor had become a container. A Balance clerk moved with a slate, accompanied by a Justice witness carrying a narrow black tablet. They stopped at a family chamber three doors down.

“Bodies,” the Balance clerk said.

A woman inside answered. “Six.”

“Names.”

She gave them. One by one, voices answered from within. The Balance clerk marked. The Justice witness watched. A Shield warden placed a seal across the door’s exterior latch, making exit visible as breach.

Water was counted, and tools — a needle, a blade for cloth, two cooking hooks — shown, witnessed, sealed. Then they moved to the next chamber.

I felt cold spread from my spine outward.

The Lesser Seal.

Faith entered from the far end of the corridor, two attendants in pale robes, speaking softly as they walked.

“Remain in place until release. Let no fear cross the threshold before the body does. Remain in place until release.”

No explanation. Only formula.

A Light attendant arrived behind them and dimmed three wall lamps in sequence. Frozen into low, stable flame.

I looked at the nearer warden. “What is this?”

The warden gave me nothing.

The second deep sound came then, closer, followed by a chain-rattle swallowed in stone. Perhaps I had set it off.

I stepped back into the side chamber and closed the door before anyone ordered me to.

Inside, the room looked exactly as before. Bench. Water jar. Lamp. Sealed niche.

I sat.

I studied the lamp. The flame stood too steady — the air in the room had been altered along with the corridor, hidden vents closed or shifted. If I shouted, the sound might fail. If I spoke, who would hear?

Shield would. No one else who mattered.

The first hand of the Lesser Seal had gone to the Mountain’s passages.

I waited.

Time became difficult. Whether one silence had passed or three, I had no way to tell. The sounds continued, deeper, farther, then nearer again.

No one would know I was here.

When Shield came for me, there was no dramatic arrival.

The lamp dimmed first. I rose at once. The door stayed shut.

The wall niche opened.

At the same moment, the door opened inward and two wardens entered, one low, one high. A fourth dropped from a ceiling seam behind my right shoulder.

I moved once. If I could place one body between myself and the lamp, I might see enough to avoid the first grip.

Shield had accounted for that.

The first hand went to my mouth — cloth, pressure, a thumb beneath the jaw. My head was drawn back and fixed before sound could become speech. My knee

was touched from behind, the floor came up quietly, and someone caught my shoulder before it hit stone.

No shout. No command. No anger.

I tried to draw breath through the gag and found I could.

They covered only the upper lamp, leaving the room in low amber shadow, enough sight to work. One warden opened my robe seam and searched the place where the scrap had been. Empty. Another checked wrists, belt, collar, sandal folds.

Va-Sheva entered last. Of course.

She stood in the doorway, clear of the physical restraint. Her face was pale and controlled, and a black line of seal-dye crossed the back of one hand.

I tried to speak her name through the cloth. It emerged as nothing. She heard it anyway.

"You asked Shield to handle it," she said.

No defence. No apology. No cruelty.

I struggled once, because the sentence had found the one place my composure was still young. The wardens absorbed the movement without tightening more than necessary. Pain appeared, clean and instructive. I stilled.

Va-Sheva came closer. "I told you to wait," she said.

My eyes hardened above the gag.

"You did." Her voice lowered. "That is why you are alive."

Whether that was mercy, threat, or confession escaped me.

She stepped back. The wardens lifted me. My feet touched the floor only enough to seem to walk, my arms bound close beneath a dark outer cloth.

No one saw. The Lesser Seal had cleared the corridors of anyone who might have.

They took me through the wall niche. The passage behind it was narrow, steep, and already occupied by Shield. Bodies stood in darkness at intervals, turning aside only as the group reached them. Small covered lights glowed at floor level, enough for trained feet.

I knew within twenty paces that I had never been in this part of the Mountain, though it ran beside places I had used all my life.

Through stone I heard a family answering Balance count, and a child asking whether the drill would end before morning bread. A woman answered yes, quickly.

I tried to mark turns. Shield denied me that too. In the desert my Light training had let me read the hidden angle of a route. Here the passages had been built so that the angles told me nothing.

At one junction, a Justice witness waited. Someone other than Sa-Tavan. An older woman with a black tablet, white hair braided tight against the skull. She looked at me, the gag, the bindings, Va-Sheva, then marked the tablet.

“Body held,” she said.

“Speech held,” Va-Sheva answered.

“Proof recovered?”

“Recovered before seal.”

“Seal witnessed.”

They continued downward.

This room was made against sound. The walls stood in deep wedges, rank on rank, each faced with pressed felt of wool and hair, no plane square to another, so that a sound had nowhere to return from; the ceiling matched them, and a floor of fine mesh carried my weight over more of the same below. A hidden lamp gave low, sourceless light, and a water recess sat behind a narrow grille. My sandals fell without noise. When I shifted my weight, the small sound of it left me and never came back. There was no angle to use, no seam to study.

Faith had made the quiet and Shield had made the seal. Faith is given the Listening of Stone — the prayer laid to its rhythm, the trembling of the Earth understood — and Faith knows how to take a sound apart until none of it remains. Shield keeps what Faith has silenced.

The whole of it rested on nothing that met the Mountain. I felt the faint give underfoot — a chamber hung clear of the rock, so that no tremor of the corridor and no far turn of Balance water could cross into it. They had cut a piece of the Mountain loose from the Mountain and filled it with the silence they had made.

They sat me on the ledge and removed the bindings from my arms first. Two wardens held position while a third untied the outer cloth. The gag remained. Va-Sheva stood before me.

“Listen,” she said.

I did.

“You are under Shield containment by Lesser Seal. Justice has witnessed recovery of proof and holding of speech. Light will be informed through proper sequence. You will not be questioned until the Seal completes.”

I stared at her. She understood the question.

“Your family is not informed.”

I closed my eyes once despite myself.

"No public scandal," she said. "No corridor rumour. No devotional panic. No one wakes to your name."

She nodded to the warden. Only then was the gag removed.

I held my tongue. My jaw ached. My mouth was dry. Speech, once returned, felt like a dangerous tool set back in my hand while they watched.

When I did speak, my voice was rough but level.

"You did not wait until tomorrow."

"No."

"You never meant to."

"No."

"You used my agreement to keep me still."

"Yes."

I looked around the clean chamber. "And if I had not agreed?"

"The same Seal. More force. More risk. Fewer mercies."

"Mercies."

"Yes."

I laughed once, without humour. "Shield has a difficult relationship with that word."

"Shield has a difficult relationship with all words. That is why we prefer doors."

"What happens now?" I asked.

"A trial."

"Before whom?"

"Those permitted."

"On what charge?"

She took her time.

"Breach of Seal," she said at last. "Bearing of forbidden proof. Unauthorized revelation."

I looked at her for a long time.

"If I defend myself by speaking what I found?"

"Then you repeat the breach."

"And if I do not?"

"Then you stand silent before a danger you cannot name."

She turned to leave.

"Va-Sheva."

She stopped at the invisible seam where the door would open.

"Did you choose death?"

Her face held, but something behind it closed.

“No.”

The answer was no comfort.

“Then what did you choose?”

She looked at me once more.

“Containment before understanding.”

Then, at the invisible seam where the door would open, the office slipped. “*Kay*, I am sorry” she said: only that, the nickname she may have had for me, secretly, stripped of every prefix her whole life had trained her to lay before it. “I am so, so sorry” A tear stood at the rim of her eye, and grew.

And she left; and as she went the drop became a river, and a breath became a sob, and the sob became a flow of sound and wail and sorrow, carried back to me through stone that had been built to carry nothing. It broke my heart, and I did not want it to end. Then the door sealed behind her without visible line.

Then the silence the room was built for closed over me. The last of her went out of the stone, and after it came nothing: no corridor, no water, no far prayer, no breath of the vents. Into the empty place my own body rose. The knock of my heart came first, too loud. Then a thin sea-sound beneath it that was my own blood. Then the dry creak of a joint as I turned my head. With no sound to set me in the room, the floor let go of its certainty, and I put a hand to the felt to keep my feet. However long the Seal took, I would spend it here — with the knock, and the sea, and the creak, and no other company at all.

— ... A room built to give a man back nothing but the sound of himself. Faith made the quiet and Shield made the seal, and between them they left one place in the whole Mountain where a man cannot get behind the size of what he has done. ... You went into it too, Sarah. Not that room — but into the deep of it, past the wall, and you came out with your face in its drawer and your name in its ledger. So they had you, somewhere back there. In a room the sound could not leave, with one of Shield’s own across the table and the long questions coming. That is where you learned to hate us cleanly enough to spend a life on it. Tell me I have it right.

— You have it wrong, and I would have you mark exactly how wrong, because the whole of the difference between us is folded into it. Nobody dragged me anywhere. Nobody had to. I did not break into your Mountain, boy; I was invited through the front of it, with a lamp held low for my feet. And the man waiting on the other side asked me no question at all. He made me an offer. ... You want a soundless room? I will give you one past anything Shield ever sealed. I walked into mine on my own two

feet, and I drew the door shut after me, and I turned the key from the inside, and I have been the one prisoner in it the better part of sixty years, and I called it my life's work. He had a face, the man who held it open for me. He had a name.

— ... Say it.

— Amastan.

CHAPTER 13

INFILTRATION

— Amastan. You made me say the name a moment ago as though it were a small thing, and it is not, and never was. The one man in all that desert who told my father no and made it hold. You shall have him whole now — him, and what I did with him, which is the worst of what I have to set down, and the part I am least ashamed of. Make of that what you please.

Amastan could not be bought, and that is the only interesting thing anyone ever wrote about him, and my father wrote it, in a margin, in a fury, because to Edward Blackwood a man who could not be bought was a fault in the machinery of the world. I read that margin as a daughter and as an heir, and where my father had seen a wall I saw a door, because a man who cannot be bought is guarding something worth more to him than money, and I had spent my whole life learning to find what a person guards.

It took Martinez two years to put a face and a tent to the name. Amastan was of the veiled people, the Kel Tamasheq, whom the maps call Tuareg and who call themselves nothing you are owed. He moved through the deep Tanezrouft the way I move through a drum-paper, reading a country that looked empty to everyone else. He guided when he chose to, refused more often, and had turned back three of my father's expeditions without raising his voice, simply by declining

to take them past a certain line and letting them understand no other man would either. Martinez brought photographs from a distance and reports bought from men who had sat at his fire, and none of it told me what he was guarding, or why a herdsman of the sand would guard it against the richest offers a dying empire could make.

I did not send Martinez to buy him. I had learned that much from my father's failure. I sent word, through three hands, that a woman who read the ground wished to speak with the man who read the sand, about a thing they had both heard in the same desert on the same night and told no one. And then I waited, which is the one art I have never lacked. It took a year. A boy I had never seen left a folded paper with a clerk in Adrar, and on it, in a careful French hand not his own, was a place, and a season, and the single line: *Come without the man from Oran, and without the yellow rock in your mouth.* He meant Martinez, and he meant that I was to come as a reader, with my money left at home. I went.

— You met a man of the sand who would not sell, and you take that for the beginning of your innocence. It is the beginning of nothing. My people have men in the sand — I know that now, though I was never let to learn it at home. Amastan was Shield's. A man Shield put out past the Threshold, generations deep, to be exactly what he was to you: a wall that money breaks against, and a door that opens the one time Shield decides it should. You did not find a crack in my people. You were handed one, by a Keeper, on purpose. Say that part plainly, before you make yourself the clever girl who picked a lock.

— I will say it more plainly than you have. I did not pick the lock. I was let in. I have never once pretended to myself that I took the Mountain by my own wit. I was let in because a man on your side had decided, for reasons of his own that had nothing to do with me, that being let in was worth the risk of me. Everything I built afterward, I built on a door somebody else chose to open. I would like you to hold on to that, because it will matter, at the end, whose hand was really on the door.

He met me at the edge of a country that has no edge. Four days by the last vehicle Martinez was allowed to bring. And at the place where the track gave out, Martinez did the one thing he had never done in thirty years of holding doors for my father and for me: he stopped being a tool for the length of a minute, and was a man. He took my arm — he never touched anyone — and told me, low, under the noise of the drivers, that he had fetched better-loved and better-armed men than me to the edges of worse places and watched those places turn them back alive out

of what he could only call contempt; that whatever kept the folds ahead had kept them since before Rome, and wanted no money, and wanted no talking to; and that past the last rock he could not follow, and would not, for anything I owned. I told him to wait with the car. He said a week, and no more, and that if I did not come out he would put it about that I had died of the heat, because it was tidier, and because — and he said this to the sand, furious at himself for the saying — he had gone and grown a little fond of me, against every rule of the only trade he had. Then the vehicle went back with the Oranian fuming in it, and I went on, two more days on animals, into folds of rock the maps drew as a single brown smear because no one who drew them had ever been permitted close enough to find the seams. I will not give you the route. I have given a great many things away in this telling and I will not give that, partly because I no longer perfectly remember it, and partly because even now, having betrayed everything I am about to betray, there is one thing in me that will not draw that particular map for a machine to keep.

The Mountain, from the outside, is a disappointment, and I understood at once that the disappointment was the whole of the defence. There is no gate, no wall a satellite could photograph and a general could want. There is a great tired shoulder of stone in a place there is no reason to go, and the ways into it are folded into the rock the way a letter is folded into an envelope you have decided not to open, and unless a man of the sand walks you to the exact seam and puts his hand flat on it and waits, you would die of thirst within sight of five thousand souls and never know they were there. I had spent years imagining an installation — machinery, spoil-heaps, the honest ugliness of work. There was none of it. Whatever did the work was under, and old, and silent, and the silence was so total that at the outer folds I felt the first real fear I had allowed myself in twenty years: that I was right, and that the thing I was right about had kept its own counsel since before my language existed.

Amastan put his hand flat against a face of rock no different, that I could see, from a hundred we had passed, and he waited, and did not knock, and did not call, and after a time long enough to teach me my own smallness a seam opened in the stone I had been staring straight at and had not seen. Cool air came out of it that smelled of lamp-oil and wet stone and, faint beneath both, of bread. Bread. Five thousand people were breathing and baking on the other side of a rock I might have leaned against to rest. I have crossed a great many thresholds and bought my way through most of them, and I had never felt anything like this one: the

plain animal knowledge that I was being permitted, that the permission could be withdrawn, and that the withdrawing would cost the other side nothing.

They brought me to a chamber in the outer works that I think Shield keeps for exactly this, made to show a visitor precisely as much as Shield wishes shown and not one lamp more. And in that chamber, seated, was an old man, and the old man was blind.

His eyes had not been taken by age or by sickness. I have seen many kinds of ruin in eyes, and I knew this one: burn. The whites scarred, the lids drawn wrong, the face set in the particular patience of a man who has taught himself, over long years, to sit very still in a dark that will not lift. They called him, in my hearing, only *the one who was Shield*, for he had given the office up by then. But he told me his name himself, because, he said, a man who is about to ask you to keep his people's secret owes you at least his own. He had been Ka-Xhian, Keeper of Shield.

And he had lost his sight, he told me, plainly, the way your boy tells a hard thing, watching a fire in the desert. A fire that was not a fire. A light in the shape of a great cloud that stood taller than his own Mountain, four weeks' walk to the north, that turned the sand to glass and poisoned the wind for a generation. He had gone out himself, as Keeper of Shield, to look at what the Outsiders had learned to make, because Shield's whole office is to look at what the rest of the Mountain is forbidden to, and he had looked too long, or from too near, with eyes that had spent their lives in lamplight and could not bear one glimpse of a man-made sun.

I want you to understand what happened in me when he said it, because it is the nearest thing to a religious experience I have had. I had been at that fire. Not the same day; I have never known whether it was the same shot or a later one, and it does not matter. I had sat forty kilometres from a French sun with a drum-paper on my knees, watching the loud thing and listening for the quiet one. And on the far edge of the same desert, an old blind man had stood and given his eyes to see the very thing I had turned my back on to listen. We had been at the same event, from opposite sides of a wall eleven thousand years thick. He gave his eyes; I gave every ordinary thing a life is furnished with; and now we sat in a stone room at the two ends of the same trade.

— Ka-Xhian.

— Yes.

— He was Keeper of Shield before the line came down to the man I served under. I was told he went blind in the service of the seal, and I let the words mean nothing, as the young do, full of their own office. ... He went out to look at your fire. At the thing you were sitting under. And you sat there, and you turned your back on it so you could hear us knocking. ... The two of you.

— The two of us. I am telling it to a machine and to the last Veil of Light because I have discovered, this week, that I would rather it were known than kept, and you two are the only keepers left who would understand what was kept.

He did not show me much. I want that on the record against the size of what I later did. The old man did not throw open his archive and let me walk out with the Mountain in my pocket. He did the opposite. He showed me exactly enough to make me useful and to keep me hungry, which is what a Keeper of Shield is trained to do, and precisely what I did do, later, to a great many people, including the man I sent to check whether your boy was real.

What he let me understand was a shape. That the Mountain was governed by five, kept apart on purpose so that no single one of them ever held the whole of anything; that they passed their offices by a succession so guarded and so seldom that it left a mark you could hear from a continent away, if you knew to listen, which I did; and that somewhere beneath us was a mechanism, old past their own reckoning, that could do to the whole world what the French fire had done to a stretch of sand. He did not tell me how it worked, or where. He told me only that it was, and that Shield's oldest duty was to watch the outside, because the outside was the one thing that might one day grow strong enough to reach in and take it.

And then we came to the part the later scripture of my own life leaves out, where it came down to a plain cold standoff between two people who each held a knife to the other in the dark. Understand what I had carried into that chamber. I had *found* them, and that alone told him the wall was down: that a thing eleven thousand years hidden could be heard and followed by an Outsider with the right ear and patience, and that I would not be the last to come, only the first, and by no means the cleverest. And I had not come as a lone madwoman he could bury in the sand and forget. I had come as a Blackwood, with records left in three countries against exactly this hour, and a man of my own who would ask loud and expensive questions if I did not come back. He could kill me — he said as much, without heat — but my death would not shut the door I had already proved was open. It would fling it wider. A Blackwood vanished in the deep Sahara is a flare, the one

event most certain to send cruder men to that exact quarter to learn what a rich woman had died reaching for.

So he could not safely kill me; and I, for all my reach, could not safely take what I had found, because I did not yet know how it worked or where. We were each other's problem and each other's only answer. And into that deadlock I laid the one thing on Earth that only I had: that the same instruments and money and patience which had let me find them could be turned the other way about, to keep the rest of the world from finding them. I could hear the outside coming before it arrived, and turn it aside. I was the one hand alive that could hold the outside off the Mountain, precisely because I was the hand that had reached in.

He took a long time over it. I was watching a Keeper of Shield do the thing his whole office exists to make unnecessary: admit an intolerable Outsider into the defence of the Mountain, and lean on the one wall Shield trusts least, the human one. He chose the least of the evils, which is the only choosing his office is ever given. And we both walked out of that dark certain we had contained the other: he, because he held a drawer he could close on me whenever he pleased; I, because I had made myself the thing they could no longer afford to kill. We were both right, and we were both wrong, and the name for the thing we built between us, out of two knives and no trust at all, was Horizon.

He asked three things of me, and I gave my word on all three, there in the dark, and I want them in the record, because I kept two of them the best part of sixty years and I have broken all three this week, sitting in this chair. That I would never bring another Outsider to the folds. That I would never set the way in down in writing, nor in any machine that keeps a voice. And that if the day ever came when I could no longer serve Shield's purpose, I would send word by Amastan's line, withdraw, take the whole of it into my own silence, and leave the Mountain as I had found it, unreached. I meant every word as I said it. I said yes, and yes, and yes. He turned his ruined face toward the sound of my voice as though he could weigh it in his hands, and told me I did not have to mean it; that Shield had never once relied on an Outsider meaning anything; that the Exception protected itself. I did not understand him then. I understand him now, and it is the coldest lesson the old man taught me: he had put a leash on me I would not feel until the day another hand closed on its far end. The gamekeeper he made was, himself, being kept.

— And then he let you be photographed.

— Amastan photographed me. At the outer folds, against a particular face of rock, with the light hard off the pale stone the way it is only for an hour after dawn. I am standing in my field clothes, pale, cut for the heat, my hair tied back, and Amastan beside me in the clothes of the sand, and beneath the border, later, in two hands, someone wrote our two names. It was taken on Ka-Xhian's authority. He could not see it made, but he ordered it, wanting a thing kept in Shield's own archive that proved the Exception had happened: that a Keeper of Shield, his mind clear and his office intact, had let an Outsider stand at the folds and made a bargain with her. Shield does not trust the memories of the living, he told me. Shield trusts the drawer.

— ... I have held that photograph.

— I know you have. It is in his machine already, in your own voice — the archive, the hard light, the two names in a Shield hand that meant nothing to you the night you knelt over them. You gave it to Paul with me sitting in this room, and I heard every word of it. You need not set it down a second time to spare me.

— Setting a thing in a machine and setting it in front of the face it belongs to are not the same act, and you know they are not, or you would not be so quick to spare yourself the second one. ... I did not know your face. I knew two words in a Shield hand under a woman in clothes I had no name for, and I closed the drawer on them and went on believing a while longer, because a boy can carry a thing in his mouth for thirty years and never once taste it. That drawer is one of the reasons there is a here at all. ... You are the woman in the drawer. You have been the woman in the drawer since before I could read, and you knew the drawer was there, and you let me be the one to open it.

— I am the woman in the drawer. I have been the woman in the drawer for longer than you have been alive, waiting, I suppose, for the drawer to be opened by exactly the sort of person who could not survive opening it. I am sorry. I am not often sorry, but I am sorry it was you who opened it, because I know now what it cost, and I did not, then, care what it might.

I left the Mountain with a shape and no substance, a certainty and no proof beyond one photograph I was allowed to copy and a memory I was forbidden to write down, and I left, above all, wanting more, which the blind man intended, and underestimated. I rode back out of those folds already building the thing that would become my life. That is the part that no one believes and that I insist upon: Horizon began as a promise kept.

It began as liaison: a single quiet channel between Blackwood and Amastan, a way for Shield to hear what the outside was doing and for me to be told when I strayed too near. Then monitoring, because I could not help myself; I had a reason, now, to gather every stroke that empty quarter ever made, and I told

myself Shield was safer the more completely I could hear. Then the management of secrecy, because to protect a thing you must know who else is looking at it, and so I kept a census of the world's curiosity about that patch of desert — every geologist, every satellite pass, every rumour in every ministry — and reached out, gently, and turned each a few degrees aside. Then, because a channel that can misdirect a survey can also move a man, routes: ways in and out, cached and tested, in case Shield ever needed to put someone across the Threshold in a hurry, or take someone off it. Then mapping, because you cannot secure what you have not charted, and I told myself the map was for defence. Then the identification of the five, because you cannot protect Keepers you cannot name, and I began, office by office, death by death, knock by knock, to learn who they were and when they changed. Then contingency, because a prudent guardian plans for the worst. And then, one day, I was no longer building a wall around the Mountain. I was building a hand that could reach into it. And the wall and the hand, it turns out, are the same stones, laid in the same order, and only the last stone tells you which you have built.

I will give you one stone, so it is not all bricks and sermon. There was a survey, a real one, a consortium of three companies and two governments, that came within a season of running a deep line straight across the folds under cover of hunting for water. I did not bribe them. Bribery leaves a shape, and a man who is paid to look away can be paid again to look back. I ruined them. I arranged, across two years and through eleven hands, for their funding to develop a doubt, for their lead geologist to receive a flattering offer he could not refuse in Western Australia, for their permits to tangle in a border dispute I quietly helped to warm, and for their backers to read, in a journal of unimpeachable reputation, a careful paper establishing that the whole region was geologically barren and seismically dead. Every piece of it was true, or true enough to survive a check, and none of it could be traced within a thousand miles of a woman in Switzerland, and the survey folded, and not one of its men ever knew they had been turned aside from five thousand living souls by a hand they never saw. For a long stretch of years I was extraordinarily good at it, and the Mountain was safer for my existence. I did not fall. I walked, on a level floor, from the guardian to the thief, and there was no step under my foot to warn me.

— Say the reason. You have walked us all the way up to it and now you are describing bricks. Say why the gamekeeper built a hand.

— I will say the reason I gave myself, and then, because you have earned it, the truer one underneath. The reason I gave myself was a good one — I still cannot fault the logic, which is what makes it so dangerous. Your Mountain's whole terror rests on one word: unanimity. The end of the world needs all five hands, or so the doctrine runs, so that no single madman or captured office can ever bring it. But a thing that needs five hands can be stopped by removing one. If I could reach into the Mountain and take a single Keeper, quietly, at need, then the machine could never be fired, because I would have broken the five, and the world would be safe at last from the thing your people had spent eleven thousand years merely praying about. That is the veto. That is what I told myself I was building: the one insurance policy the human race had never been allowed to hold.

— And the truer one.

— The truer one is that I wanted it. ... I had found the largest secret on the earth, and I could not bear that it was not mine. Not safe. Mine. My father died reaching for that emptiness and I had touched the far side of it, and every stone I laid toward the Mountain I laid because I have never in my life been able to let a thing exist without my hand on it. Call it my father's nose that would not close. Call it the appetite I found in myself at twenty-seven over a bomb. Call it what your scripture would call it, which is the oldest name there is for it and the only honest one. I wanted the whole. I built a machine the length of a life to reach into the one place in the world built to make certain that no one ever could. And I told myself, the entire time, in a voice I half believed, that I was only building a wall.

— Then you are the thing. ... Do you understand what you have just told me. There is one crime in my world, beneath all the others, the crime the Beast itself was set to punish and the reason the five are kept apart and the reason a Keeper opens his own body rather than hold two offices at once. To reach for the whole. To be the one hand. My people drowned a city of the wise for it before there was a Mountain. And you sat in a stone room with a blind man who gave his eyes to keep that hand from ever closing, and you shook it, and you went home, and you spent your life becoming precisely the hand he was blinded to prevent. An enemy at the gate is the lesser fear. You are the thing the gate was built for.

— Yes.

— You do not even argue.

— Why would I argue. I have had the best part of sixty years to find the flaw in what you have just said and I have not found it. I am the one hand. I have always been. The only thing I have left to add, and it is the reason you are alive and in this house and not

dead in a desert, is that being the one hand feels, from the inside, like responsibility. It feels like being the only adult in a house full of frightened children standing around a fire they will not admit is lit. That is the part your scripture leaves out, boy, and it is the part that should frighten you most, because it means the thing your Mountain fears above all others arrives looking like the one person in the room who is willing to be sensible.

I watched the fact-checker while I said the last of it, because I had begun, over four days, to watch him the way I watch a needle: the honest instrument in that house. And what was there, on his face, was a man doing arithmetic he did not want the answer to. I knew the sum, because I had worked it myself, years before, and chosen not to finish it.

— I have a question of my own, and I would like it answered as plainly as you have answered him.

— Ask it, Paul.

— The man who engaged me. The letter, the terms, the account that pays me. The physician who tends him. The archivist who handed me the folder with the two traces already in it, dated in a hand that is not mine. ... How much of the thing that brought me to this house was chance, and how much was you.

— ...

— Answer it.

— None of it was chance, Paul. I do not permit chance in my house. Do you imagine I would leave the one honest man in the building to arrive by accident? You were chosen, and vetted, and brought, and given exactly the folder I wished you to have, and set in front of exactly the man I wished checked, and the two traces were in that folder because I put them there, to see what you would do when you found them. You did the thing I hoped you would do, which is why you are still in the room, and the thing I feared you would do, which is why I am no longer certain the room is mine. You have been a brick and an instrument at once, all week, exactly as I was in a stone chamber a lifetime ago. I am not mocking you. I am telling you that you have just met the wall from the inside, and there is only one useful thing to do on the morning you learn it, and it is the thing I did. You stop asking whose hand built it. You start asking whose hand is on it now.

And it was there, on that sentence, with the boy white and silent and the fact-checker's pencil stopped against the paper, that the house stopped being the safest room any of us had ever sat in.

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- ... Forgive me. Madame. There is a thing off the drums you will want to see.
- Not now.
- Now. It came in eleven minutes ago. The southern array. It is the shape. It is your shape.
- ... Bring it here. ... Set it down. There. Under the lamp.
- ... That is a Keeper rising. That is the knock. I have watched two of them draw themselves and I would know that hand in my sleep. Someone in the Mountain has died, and someone has risen in his place, and it happened while we sat here talking about me.
- No one has risen.
- You cannot know that. You have been gone from the Mountain half a year. A Keeper could sicken and fall and be replaced and you the last to hear of it.
- I could. But the knock does not lie about what it is, and you have just told me it lies about nothing. And I am telling you that in all my life inside those offices, no Keeper of the five was old, or ailing, or near the chain. There was no death waiting. There was no succession due. ... A knock without a death is something wearing a succession's face.
- ... Madame.
- What.
- It is drawing again.
- That is not possible. A rising is one hand, one time. Nothing rises twice in a single hour.
- Look at the drum. It is drawing again. The same five. Now, while we are standing here.
- ... Then it has begun, and this stopped being a debrief the moment it drew twice. Cancel the car for the morning, and every car after it. Sa-Kailan — you have the rest of it still in you, the trial and the road they drove you out on, and I cannot say one word about who is knocking at my mountain until I hold the whole of what you hold. So you will give me the rest of it: tonight, and the nights after it, until there is nothing left in you to give. And then we will go and look at the thing itself.
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CHAPTER 14

TRIAL

What I did in that chamber I invented while I was doing it, one sentence at a time, the way a man crossing black water finds the stones only by the fact that he is still standing. I refuse the question of when I decided to fight, as though there were a moment I chose and a plan I carried out from it. There was none. I never saw the far bank. I saw the next stone, and then the next, and by the time I understood what I was building it had already half-killed me, and there was no unbuilding it.

The Lesser Seal ended in the night, and I knew it had ended only because nothing in my cell changed. All through the dark the stone had spoken — bars dropping, chains tightening, doors sealed and counted and witnessed — and then the sounds reversed, one jurisdiction at a time, the Mountain returned to itself around me. Voices came faintly through stone: a woman asking whether morning bread would be delayed. My cell remained the same.

Proof recovered. Speech held. Body held. Justice had named those three facts over me while I was still bound.

Near the First hour the door opened, and Ka-Dhavar of Shield stood in it. Keepers leave prisoners to wardens. A Keeper comes for a man only when a matter has grown too secret to pass through any hand but his own. He carried no weapon

I could see, and needed none; Shield is the office that has made a study of the body, and he stood in the doorway the way a shut gate stands, without effort. He looked at me a moment. "You will not be bound," he said. "There is nowhere in the Mountain a man runs to," I said, "and no man runs from the five." He weighed the words, decided they would hold, and stepped aside to let me pass.

He took me past every hearing room I knew. The route descended. The warmth of habitation thinned, the polish left the stone, and the lamps became strange — one lighting a wall perfectly and leaving the turn ahead black. Twice we passed close enough to ordinary life to hear it continuing above a man it had already erased.

Then white stone, and the Hall of Prayers. The sight of them assembled stopped me on the threshold. Ka-Elun of Faith at the centre in her plain white and the torn pilgrim's mantle I remembered from her Ascension. Ka-Leth of Balance, broad and grey. Ka-Orun of Justice, still as his own tablet. Ka-Raedin, my Keeper, a hooded hand-lamp in his grip. And apart from the five, only two: Va-Sheva of Shield, who looked past me, and Sa-Tavan of Justice, whom I had knelt beside on the morning we were both named, a Candidate still, too junior by years to stand in such a room. At their feet were packs: water, dried food, folded cloth.

Ka-Elun looked at the lamp in Ka-Raedin's hand. "Keeper of Light," she said softly, "put that away." He held still. "It is hooded." "That is not the same as away. Better Keepers of Light than either of you have entered the Labyrinth believing brightness would make a path obedient. They were recovered by pilgrims who could not read a mirror but could keep breath with stone." Ka-Raedin held the lamp a moment longer than pride should have allowed. Then he set it against the wall, hooded and unlit. "Faith receives," Ka-Elun said, and let it lie.

"You will walk," Ka-Elun told me.

"Guided by whom?"

"By what remains when sight stops governing..."

The wall behind her opened — no seam first, no hinge; a section of carved prayer simply ceased to be wall and became depth, breathing out cold air that smelled of stone and distance. We went down into it in single file: Ka-Elun ahead, then Ka-Leth, then Ka-Raedin at my shoulder, then me, then Va-Sheva, then Sa-Tavan, and Ka-Dhavar last, closing the dark behind us the way he had closed the cell door. The wall sealed, and the Hall of Prayers was gone.

I had thought, in my child's picture of it, that the holy places sat just behind the walls we prayed against. They sit far below. We walked for hours. The way kept clear of stairs — a stair troubles an old Keeper's knee, and a straight flight

can be measured and kept in the head. This was neither: ramp and switchback and long shallow grade, doubling back on itself, descending until my ears changed and the air grew older than any I had breathed. We must have gone the height of the Mountain down, and then some.

Once, early, I asked the question a child asks. "Are we going to the Hall of the Last Prayer?" Ka-Elun came close to laughing. "The Hall of the Last Prayer is a room a Veil of Faith may walk to and come back from. No. The Labyrinth opens onto many hidden places, and most of them have no names a Candidate has been given." She let that settle into the dark. "You are being taken beneath the rooms, Va-Kailan — beneath the reason for them..."

The Labyrinth received us without echo. The cruelty was made of light, and it was aimed at me. The walls were striped. Floor to vanished ceiling, everywhere, ran bands of pale and dark, lamped and cut so that stone and shadow repeated in one endless rhythm. A zebra is hidden by every other zebra's stripes, so that the lion, faced with the moving mass, can lock upon none; paint one with a red mark, and that one dies first. A Light-trained eye, which lives by finding the one edge that differs, would find ten thousand here and starve among them. And still I hunted. After the ninth turn I passed a crack I was sure I had seen before, and my heart rose.

"No," Ka-Elun said, without turning.

"I did not speak."

"You leaned toward certainty."

"There is no crack you have seen before," she said. "There are only cracks that repeat. You may observe, Va-Kailan. You may not follow yourself."

Somewhere below, water spoke behind a wall, and Ka-Elun stopped. "Before the Beast, silence," she said — and the answer came from behind me, low, from the Keepers themselves: "Before silence, prayer. Before prayer, breath. Before breath, fear." A seam opened ahead. I heard it open before I could see anything — a gap in the floor of sound — and there was distance now where there had been none. "Now," she said, "Light may look."

We came into the anti-chamber of the Hall of Cataclysm.

I had believed the Hall of Ceremony large because it had named me. I had known nothing of large.

The Labyrinth opened onto a bridge — a tongue of stone wide enough for thirty men abreast, running level across a gulf of open air to the far wall. Above, the dark climbed higher than the Mountain stands above the sand, and higher again. Below, to either side, the floor fell away into two long pits, and out of them

rose the pillars, scarred and past counting, their heads lost past where the light could climb. Pale mineral veins caught the low light like a buried sky.

Down in the pit to my right lay a city of gold in miniature: towers, walls, streets fine as scratches, half-drowned in the dark stone so the eye failed to tell whether it sank or was being built. Near it, behind a curtain of beaten gold threads, a king whose face had been struck from the authority he still held — crown kept, hands kept, the face chiselled away.

The two long walls were the Mountain itself — the living rock left broken as it had been found, so that the room felt uncovered, a hollow the Mountain had always held.

But the far wall was built, and the bridge ran straight at it, and it was the Gate of the Hall of Cataclysm. Here the Mountain did a strange thing with scale. The chamber was a size beyond any man; the Gate was built to be faced by a single person. It rose only the height of a great tree and spanned only the width of the bridge — a door a human hand might have made, set in a wall far beyond any hand. And every span of it was mechanism. Chains entered it out of the rock, thick as tree-trunks, and climbed into slots above. Five rows of five signs had been cut across its face, figures I failed to read. And low to one side an empty slot — a shaped absence, cut clean and waiting.

And at the centre of all that iron was the gravure, five-and-twenty paces to a side: the same story the two Books would soon read aloud, cut in stone so a man who had heard the reading could look up and watch it happen. The Outsiders under the open eye of Heaven; the Mountain a sealed engine, the five standing apart in five arches; and below everything the Beast, too enormous for form, straining upward out of Hell with its fists at the roots of the Earth, and at the foot of the ruin the people going down into the stone, weeping for a world saved and lost in the same hour.

Five seats faced the accused mark, cut from the chamber's own stone, equal, spaced so no Keeper could easily whisper to another. At the centre lay a flat stone table where objects could be placed so all could see them and no single hand receive them. Nothing lay upon it.

Ka-Dhavar brought me to the mark — a touch at the shoulder, no more; the trust still holding. The Five took their seats, Ka-Orun of Justice standing beside the central stone, his own hands empty, for Justice keeps clear of the record and only speaks into it. And at the wall, only two outside the five: Va-Sheva of Shield, and Sa-Tavan of Justice with the tablet on which the record would be kept. No

family. No wardens. No one else in all that dark. The way in had closed without echo.

“This anti-chamber opens under highest secrecy,” Ka-Orun said, and the words stayed small in the vastness. “No Kahir divulges what belongs solely to its own sealed charge. No Keeper seeks total knowledge. The hearing binds the five without making one hand whole.” I felt the structure close. “Before judgment, the chamber remembers why judgment is divided.”

Faith read both Books entire. The scroll lay open on a low stand before her, and she left it untouched; she knew every word by the body’s memory. Her voice, when she began, was placed so precisely that even the stone seemed required to listen.

“The Book of the Beast,” Ka-Orun said, and Ka-Elun started the reading.

And the curse went forth upon the Outsiders, and they wandered under the eye of Heaven; and the Earth hid them not, neither did the waters keep them, nor the Mountain give them shade. And they multiplied in the open land, and their hunger multiplied with them; and brother rose against brother, and city rose against city, and king rose against king. And they made war without measure, and famine without pity, and prisons without mercy; and they bound the weak, and burned the innocent, and betrayed the hand that fed them.

And God looked upon the Outsiders, and saw the works of their hands; and behold, their cruelty was greater than the curse that had been laid upon them. For they tortured for pleasure, and conquered for pride, and lied with holy words, and slew their children for the hunger of their fathers. And God was wroth, and God said, The evil of the Outsiders is deep, and their hunger hath no end; and if they find the Mountain, they shall not spare the Oasis, nor the Temple, nor the children beneath My shadow.

And God gave unto the Oasis a great defence, and set power in the keepers thereof. Unto the Keeper of Light He gave the Dance of Light, that the hidden ways might be revealed, and the blind stone awakened, and the signs within the holy word made visible to the appointed eye. Unto the Keeper of Balance He gave the Movement of the Waters, that the deep might rise and fall by measure, and that water might become breath, and breath become force. Unto the Keeper of Justice He gave

the Key, the Number, and the Binding of the Chains, that no motion begin before its hour, nor any burden move without order and witness. Unto the Keeper of Shield He gave the Sword and the Seal, that the threshold might be defended, and the Mountain closed against the wrath it had awakened. And unto the Keeper of Faith He gave the Prayer and the Listening of Stone, that the holy word might be spoken in rhythm, and the trembling of the Earth understood.

And God said unto the Keepers, Keep these secrets apart, and let no one hand hold the whole; for the power that defendeth the Oasis may also devour the Earth. And He taught each Keeper his portion, and sealed the rest from him. And the Light knew not the full prayer, and the Faith knew not the hidden sight, and the Balance knew not the final number, and the Justice knew not the deep waters, and the Shield knew not the word that opened what it sealed; and each was strong in his charge, and weak without the others.

And God said, If the Outsiders come again, and if they find the Mountain, and if they lay their hands upon the Temple, then shall the Keepers stand as one and unleash the Beast upon the Earth. And the poisoned waters shall rise, and the volcanoes shall erupt, and the ground shall break beneath the feet of the enemy, and the sea shall climb over their cities; and the Outsiders shall taste the cruelty they gave upon the world. But if the Keepers fail, or if one hand seize the whole, then the Beast shall know neither faithful nor stranger, and Hell shall not distinguish between the guilty and the guarded.

Ka-Elun closed the first scroll. No one moved. Ka-Orun opened the second. "The Book of the Cataclysm," he said. And Ka-Elun read on.

And the Outsiders multiplied in the open land, and their kings became many, and their cruelty became without number; and they remembered the Mountain in dreams, and hated the shade they could not find. And they gathered armies, and forged blades, and raised engines of war, and came with banners and drums and false prayers upon their tongues. And they said, Let us find the Mountain, and take the Oasis, and drink the waters thereof, and break the Temple, and make ourselves gods upon the Earth.

And the Outsiders came unto the desert, and the desert rose against them with thirst and wandering; yet they turned not

back. And they drove the weak before them, and cast down the weary, and slew the beasts that bore them, and drank what was forbidden, and ate what was unclean; and the sun burned them by day, and the cold struck them by night, and still they came. And the desert saw their hearts, and the Mountain heard their footsteps, and the Oasis trembled in the shadow.

And the Keepers stood before the Temple, and each brought forth the secret that had been given unto him. And the Keeper of Shield sealed the threshold, and closed the Mountain against the wrath to come. And the Keeper of Justice set the Key, and counted the Number, and took witness of the five, that no hand should move before the others. And the Keeper of Balance moved the deep waters beneath the Earth, and loosed them by measure into the chambers below. And the Keeper of Faith spoke the Prayer in its appointed rhythm, and listened for the answer of stone. And the Keeper of Light danced the Dance of Light, and the hidden signs were revealed, and the way was made visible. And the five stood apart as one, and no one hand held the whole.

And God remembered His word, and Hell answered. And the deep waters fell into the fire beneath, and the breath of Hell rose in the hidden chambers, and the works of the Mountain began to move. And the Beast beneath the Mountain struck the roots of the Earth with his fists, and the ground broke beneath the feet of the Outsiders. And the prayer travelled through stone, and the weak places of the Earth answered; and the poisoned waters rose, and the volcanoes erupted, and fire came upon the left hand of the army, and the sea rose upon the right hand thereof; and the mountains shook, and the sky was made black with ash, and the Outsiders were burned, and drowned, and crushed, and scattered; and they tasted the cruelty which they had given unto the world.

And when the wrath had passed, the armies of the Outsiders were no more; but the forest was wounded, and the forest was broken, and the open waters were spoiled, and the land around the Mountain became desert. And the people wept for the world that had been saved and lost in the same hour. And God said unto them, Dwell no more in the open, but enter the Mountain, and keep the Temple, and remember the price of being seen. And the Temple was sealed, and the people went beneath the stone.

Ka-Elun closed the second scroll, and no one spoke.

I looked at the gravure. But I had carried it from one sealed hand into the open space of another, and I had carried proof. For the law to condemn me, it needed only to show I had broken the separation. My intent did not matter.

Ka-Orun set out the charges: Breach of Seal, Bearing Forbidden Proof, Unauthorized Revelation in potential and act. "The law judges not only the fire that has burned, but the place where fire was carried." And then the frame that closed the room like a lid: "No cross-Kahir knowledge may be divulged. No sealed name may be spoken. No chamber under seal described beyond category. Any attempt to defend by renewing the breach will be stopped."

"How do I answer what cannot be spoken?" I asked.

"With what may be spoken."

"And if what may be spoken is not enough?"

"Then you begin to understand the charge."

There was no malice in him, and that left me nothing to push against. He read seven facts into the record, and I contested no sequence, because the sequence was true. He turned to Va-Sheva, and she spoke to the centre stone and not to me: that I had disclosed unauthorised movement, entry into a sealed Shield archive, removal of copied proof; that she had recovered it from my hand; that I had remained voluntarily until holding became necessary, and resisted once, under provocation, without force being exceeded. "What danger did you judge?" "Proof travelling by a credible bearer." "Not treason?" "No standing to judge treason." She stepped back.

"There are only two outcomes lawful in this chamber," Ka-Orun said, and the Beast on the wall seemed to lean in to hear it. "Death, or Exception." No acquittal. No correction. My wrong had been sequenced already, in a cell, in the dark.

"You will each speak from your office," Ka-Orun said, "and from nothing else. Not as the friend of the accused, nor as his enemy. As Faith. As Balance. As Shield. As Light." In every ordinary matter Justice speaks last, so that nothing is ratified before it has heard the whole of a thing. But for a sentence of death Justice reverses itself and speaks first — it votes blind, before any other voice can lean upon it, so that no man may ever say a life was argued out of the law, and returns only at the end to say aloud what the five together have made.

"Justice," he said, naming himself, and he stayed at the centre, where Justice always is. "I hold intent and outcome apart, because either alone makes a fool of the law. He did not act as an enemy; he acted as a Veil outside his standing, bearing proof through an unsealed sequence. It calls him what he is — a ruin risk. A small

chance of total loss, carried by a credible man, set against a large comfort in his good intentions. And the law does not trade a total loss for a comfort. There is one answer, and I will not dress it as a kinder one. Death.” He said it without heat, having spent his voice first.

“Faith,” Ka-Orun said.

Ka-Elun rose. She kept her voice low and made the chamber come to her, and the first thing she said she spoke in another’s words. “Let no sign be carried from its chamber, nor proof borne beyond its seal; for a secret held in place may preserve the people, but a secret made to wander shall become fire among them.” She let the words of the Promise stand a moment in the dark. “It is the oldest instruction we keep, older than any office, and he broke the letter of it. The Book does not name that an error. It names it fire. I do not weigh his youth, nor his usefulness. I weigh the pattern — the one thing my office is built to read. He went to Va-Maera. He sought from Faith what Light is not given, and named it curiosity, and Faith remembers. A boy who reaches, is warned, and reaches again has stopped being an accident; he is a shape, and...” She let it settle. “And Faith can carry his death where it could never carry his life. He has been seen, these past seasons, standing long hours in the Hall of Ceremony — devout, we shall say now. A devout young Veil, grieved and seeking, who went into the Labyrinth on a pilgrimage beyond his right, and was lost. We will let them find his body on the fourth day, and grieve him honestly, because grief is easiest when it is true. We will spend his death to redraw the warning at every threshold, so that no child follows him down. Ka-Raedin loses a Veil, and is given reason to drive his next chain harder. Every part of it serves the Mountain.” She lowered her eyes. “Faith supports death.”

At the wall, Sa-Tavan’s stylus had stopped. He had carried in more than the blank tablet of the night’s record; a Candidate of Justice brings the open enquiries a matter may touch, and one of his lay open still — a light seen once from the Oasis ridge, set down years back in a boy’s own word as a mirage, and never closed, for Justice closes nothing until the conditions answer to it.

Faith’s pattern answered it.

Ka-Orun’s eyes went to the tablet, because Justice looks where the record moves. “An enquiry cannot stand open once its conditions are met,” he said, into the record and to no one. “It closes.” Sa-Tavan marked the closing, and the small sound of stylus on stone stood alone in the dark.

Ka-Dhavar had been watching Justice. His eyes came up to me only now. “I know that light,” he said. How he knew, he left unsaid; from where, unsaid also, for under the frame Ka-Orun had set Shield was forbidden it, and Shield let it lie.

“It was no mirage. It was real, and it was seen, and the hand that saw it wrote it false.” He let the dark carry the words their full length.

My own account, in my own giving and years old, closed over me. Va-Sheva had stood beside me on that ridge. She kept her eyes on the centre stone.

“Balance,” Ka-Orun said.

Ka-Leth’s voice was heavier and plainer, the voice of a woman who had spent her life being right about water in rooms full of people who wanted her to be wrong. “I came ready to argue the cost of him. A Veil of Light, lost; a chain broken at the join; a household to be told something, and a Faith to make it bearable — water and labour and trust drawn from stores we drew down only last night for the Seal. I had the column ready.” She turned one hand over, as if letting the figures spill out of it. “But Faith has shown me a death that pays for itself: a grief that mends the very threshold he broke. I can carry the lie. I can number his life. The one quantity here I cannot number is the chain of light — the seeing that has already left him. I cannot measure how far it has run, and I will not price what I cannot measure.” She looked, for the first time, at Ka-Raedin. “I hand it to Light, where it belongs. On everything I can weigh, I weigh with Faith. Death.”

“Shield,” Ka-Orun said.

Ka-Dhavar stayed where he stood; Shield speaks from where it stands. He spoke the way a man reads a measurement aloud. “The danger is a bearer. Beliefs sit still. A dead bearer carries nothing — not down a corridor, not in a weakness, not in a dream. Death contains completely. Exception relocates the danger and asks all five of us to go on watching it for the rest of our lives, and Shield fears the hour the watching lapses, because it always, in the end, lapses. And Balance’s chain of light is not mine either. Shield holds bodies, not what has slipped out from behind their eyes. My position is death. I say it without appetite.”

“Light,” Ka-Orun said.

Ka-Raedin came forward, and I stopped breathing, because whatever he said now would decide whether I lived, and in all the years I had known him he had never softened a true thing to spare anyone. He began with the fact. “He is useful. He is talented past any Veil I have raised — an eye that sees the seam the rest of us walk over. I will not insult this chamber by pretending otherwise; you must know what you are spending. But he has grown beyond my reach, and he was warned before ever he came to me — taught, more than once, that the walls are the architecture of our survival. He heard it, and offended, and was warned again, and offended again. Talent that will not keep inside its wall is a breach that happens to be clever.” He let it stand. “The chain of light you have all handed down the

row — leave it with me. It is Light's to carry, and Light's alone." Only then did he turn, by the smallest degree, toward me. "Va-Kailan of Light. Hear this from me, and do not deduce it later. The Mountain comes first. Then the office. Then the man. In that order, always — and I would be no Keeper if I let the third move the first." He turned back to the centre. "Light concurs. Death."

He had said *useful* to my face and then voted to end me.

Ka-Orun laid both hands on the centre stone, where no proof lay, and returned, last, to speak aloud what the five had made. "It is one voice," he said. "Va-Kailan of Light, Veil under Ka-Raedin: the five are agreed. You are stripped of the name and the standing of your office. You are condemned to death. On the fourth day from this, the Labyrinth will give your body up to the pilgrims who go seeking you, and the Mountain will grieve a devout boy it believes it lost, and the grief will be true and it will be a lie, both at once, for as long as the Mountain stands." The Beast held its carved silence above him. "The sentence is spoken. It is not yet carried out. By the old right of the condemned before this chamber, you may contest your judgement — not the fact of what you did, which is sequenced and closed, but the judgement itself. Speak, if you will. Do you contest your judgement?"

I let the silence run one beat too long, the way Va-Raedin had trained me to leave part of a lamp's throw dark on purpose.

"No," I said. "I do not contest my judgement. I contest the court."

Nothing in Ka-Orun's face moved. "The court is lawfully seated," he said.

"Is it?"

Ka-Orun let me speak. To stop a man who had promised to name nothing would have looked like fear.

"We are taught," I said, "that this is the highest law, above every office — that the power which defends the Oasis may also devour it, and so no one hand may hold it. I concede that five hands may see the good of the Mountain differently, even oppositely at times. But let us assume, all of us, that each hand here loves the Mountain. May I assume that?"

A pause. Ka-Elun inclined her head the width of a breath. "You may assume it."

"Then I speak in the fullest hypothesis, and reveal nothing. Suppose a Keeper — I name none — had committed the highest treason imaginable against the Mountain. Not a breach. Not an error of appetite such as mine. The highest treason. Would we not want the Mountain healed of it?"

Faith answered first, because Faith was the one to answer a question of meaning left standing in a holy room. “We would.” Ka-Elun’s voice was quiet. “Agreed.”

“Balance.”

Ka-Leth’s hands stayed clasped. “A bad entry left in the ledger throws off every sum after it. Yes.”

“Light.”

Ka-Raedin looked at the gravure, at the five chains that stood clear of one another. “Necessary,” he said. One word. He knew already what I was building, and let me build it.

“Shield.”

Ka-Dhavar was still. I watched him weigh the two roads: to agree, and hand me the principle; to object, and be the one Keeper on the record arguing that a treason against the Mountain might be tolerable. “You may try to vote,” I said, before he could find a third road, “that high treason among us is a thing the Mountain can carry. But it will not help your case in the trial to come.” His jaw moved by the smallest amount.

“Agreed,” Ka-Dhavar said.

“Justice,” I said, and I kept it for last on purpose.

Ka-Orun took the longest of all, and I watched him see where the road led and choose to walk it anyway, because refusing the principle would have meant refusing the law he served. “This is highly irregular,” he said. “But the principle stands. High treason against the Mountain would be ground for emergency interruption to any ordinary sequence, including this one.”

Five. I had five agreements, and in that chamber five agreements were nearly enough to bind them.

“As Va-Kailan of Light, Veil under Ka-Raedin, Keeper of Light,” I said, and I kept my voice as level as the black lake, “I declare that a Keeper accused of high treason against the Mountain is not fit to sit in a sealed hearing.”

Nobody answered.

“I declare this trial suspended. Its judgement suspended.”

“Suspended,” Ka-Orun said, and whether he was recording me or warning me escaped me, and it made no difference, because the word was now in the tablet either way.

“My office is restored, for the matter now before us.”

“Temporarily,” said Ka-Orun.

“Temporarily,” I agreed.

“There is one here,” I said, “who is neither a Keeper nor a witness I have summoned. Sa-Tavan of Justice keeps the record. What comes next is a matter of high treason and of sequence between Keepers. It is beyond a Candidate’s office to hold, and it cannot be written by a hand that will still be walking the ordinary Mountain tomorrow. He cannot remain.”

I let the pause run long enough to give the words the force of law.

“Sa-Tavan of Justice, you are dismissed.”

I set it in front of Ka-Orun, and waited. And Ka-Orun — who could have refused, and broken my construction with the refusal — looked at his Candidate for a long moment, weighed the cost of removing his own record against letting it be made, and chose.

“Sa-Tavan,” he said. “Withdraw. Record nothing of this. Speak of it to no one, under the Promise, while you live.”

Sa-Tavan’s face, in the low light, was the face of a young man who has understood that he has been handed a thing he can neither open nor set down. He gathered the tablet on which he had written nothing and withdrew — to the outer threshold and no step past it, because no one walks the Labyrinth alone.

Ka-Elun spoke to Sa-Tavan.

“Out of earshot,” she said, “I will know.”

He went.

But I had gone too far to be governed by what could be heard. I turned to the centre stone, and to the five seats, and to the man in the seat nearest the great door.

“I accuse Ka-Dhavar, Keeper of Shield, of high treason against the Mountain.”

The Beast strained in its carved silence. No one moved.

“I summon Va-Sheva of Shield to serve as Shield’s witness.”

She came forward from the wall — Shield’s own Veil, called to stand against Shield’s own Keeper — and she kept her eyes front.

Somewhere to my left, low, one of them said it. “You trained this?” The words were meant for Ka-Raedin, and they came out sounding like awe. And Ka-Raedin, who never once softened a true thing, answered without looking at any of us. “With ease,” he said. “He is too smart for his own good.” It was aimed at my teacher and landed on me; and in the worst hour of my life it was the nearest to pride I had ever heard him permit.

I had made my accusation. I had summoned my witness. There was nothing left to do but let the Keeper of Shield answer — and I believed, in the last moment before he did, that I had him.

Ka-Dhavar answered before I could prosecute him — before I could lay out my proof, before I could name what I had seen. From the moment I named him I said nothing more in that chamber. I had torn the procedure down to make myself the prosecutor, and the accused took even that from me, by telling the truth before I could reach for it.

“The outside is not the story the children are given,” he said. “The desert is not empty. If you still picture our encounters as Shield against a caravan of lost traders, set that picture down; it is long outdated. Far to the north, beneath the sand, there is a black substance in a quantity beyond any count Balance has ever kept, and the Outsiders hunger for it exactly as the Book says — they have made war upon one another for it, city against city, king against king. Their prospectors have crossed the Threshold for forty years, nearer each season, digging, measuring, laying their ears against the ground.” He paused. “Eight-and-thirty years ago they lit a fire in the desert that was not a fire. A light in the shape of a mushroom taller than the Mountain. It turned the sand to glass, and poisoned the wind for a generation. Four weeks’ walk, exactly north of here. In a town the Outsiders call Reggane. Faith surely has a record of it.”

“Why,” Ka-Leth said slowly, to no one, “would Faith keep a record of a fire in the desert, far to the north?”

“Because the last great seal in living memory was on that very day. Presented as a drill. Because the fire burnt so hot and bright, that Xhian — formerly Ka-Xhian, Keeper of Shield — lost his sight observing it in person. Because with the fire came an earth-shaking sound too great for Faith to miss and go on calling itself Faith.”

He let the silence take hold, and when Faith did not break it, he went on.

“The science and technology that serves their cruelty has gone far beyond our understanding and our reach — possibly a few centuries ago.”

Reggane, 1960. I had seen the picture of it in the sealed archive, and understood nothing of it.

“Shield does not sit behind the seal and wait for the wrath to arrive at the gate,” Ka-Dhavar said. “Shield goes out. Shield watches. Reconnaissance is necessary — men who walk among the Outsiders and return. We have had word, this very season, that powerful men from every quarter of the open world are joining their strength to find us. They map the desert. They observe it from above.”

“What do you mean from above?” Ka-Leth asked.

“They have set eyes around the Earth,” Ka-Dhavar said. “Machines that circle it and do not fall, and read the sand from the sky.”

Something crossed Ka-Elun’s face that she stopped before it finished.

“Around the Earth,” Ka-Orun said.

He said it the way a man repeats a word in a tongue he has never spoken. The chamber turned toward Justice, and I watched the most precise mind in the Mountain arrive, one careful step at a time, at the edge of a thing it lacked.

“What do you mean, around the Earth,” Ka-Orun said. “The Earth has no — the Earth has no around.” And then to prove it, recited a passage from the Book of Genesis.

*And God set the Earth between Heaven and Hell, that the
living should walk between the eye above and the fire beneath*

”And He has” Ka-Elun answered.

No one answered at once. And then Ka-Leth of Balance, who has spent her life outside in the cold hours pulling water and counting stars, laughed — one short breath of a laugh, helpless, before she could stop it — and said, half to Shield, half to the black lake, “How is a man that clever, and that blind, all at once.”

The laugh died in the saying.

Ka-Orun, Keeper of the Number and the Key and the Binding of the Chains, had never once looked up. His office had built a mathematics deep enough to hold the Mountain’s fate in a column of figures, and never learned the shape of the world it judged, because that shape lay outside its charge.

And the others could see. Shield knew — it watched the stars and predicted the eclipses. Light knew — no eye Light had trained could miss the curve of a shadow crossing the moon. Balance knew, for the reason Ka-Leth’s laugh had already confessed. And Faith knew best of all.

Because the Pendulum is Faith’s.

In the Hall of Ceremony hangs the Thread, and at the end of it the disk that crosses and crosses and slowly turns its road across the floor until, after nearly three days, it comes back to itself. I had knelt beneath it since before I could speak, as every child does — a patient, faultless proof that the Earth beneath us turns. For eleven thousand years my people had honoured the swinging disk and forbidden anyone to say what it proved. And Justice, who judged us all, had knelt beneath that answer every year of its life without once understanding what it knelt to.

And Ka-Orun was petrified.

I had watched the Keeper of Justice pronounce a sentence of death without a change in his breathing. I watched him now go still in another way entirely —

the stillness of a man who has felt the floor of the world shift under a foot he had believed was set on stone.

I looked at Va-Sheva.

She had crossed the floor of Shield and turned her back on the office that made her, for me — and had been granted no word at all; Ka-Dhavar had answered himself, and the accusation dissolved in his own mouth before she could serve it. Her face held my eyes while the ground I had opened closed over us both.

There was no tablet for Ka-Orun to set down.

He had sent his record out of the room an hour before, when he dismissed Sa-Tavan; nothing of this night would be written. He decided.

Ka-Orun had spent forty years inside the record, and almost everything in it was small — a miscounted measure, a stolen ration, a struck child. Petty wrong had never frightened him; he always knew its shape and what it would cost to set right. But another kind of matter enters the record perhaps a handful of times in eleven thousand years: no precedent, too large and too little understood, a confluence of unknowns the machine fails to price. Almost every one had ended in catastrophe. He was looking at one now, and fearing it, he sealed it, and hoped the seal would outlast him.

“A thing has been done in this chamber tonight,” he said, “that has not been done in the memory of the record. Shield has opened, before five hands at once, a seal it has never opened before any. And Justice has been handed, in open chamber, a thing its office was never given to hold. I know only this: a precedent has been made. A single will has forced five offices into one room and made them speak across the walls between them. That alone, whatever the truth of any accusation, is more than the balance of the Mountain can carry.” He looked at me without hatred, which I had stopped hoping for and now received as the cruelest thing in the room. “I would rather bury a true accusation than let this move one step further.”

“I do not question a sequence I do not yet understand,” Ka-Raedin said.

“The accusation against Shield is closed,” Ka-Orun said. “It is not named false. It is set beyond pursuit. Shield’s motive is received: the threat is real, the watching is necessary, and necessity is not treason.” He turned to me. “The accuser may speak, if he has anything further to lay before the chamber.”

“Then hear this,” I said, and heard my own voice reach the way a falling man reaches for a wall. “The manner of his answer is the proof of it. He did not meet my accusation — he drowned it, opening before all five of you knowledge no

single office may hold, so that the horror of the crossing would swallow the smaller matter of his treason, and force you to close the hearing. I say the closing is itself the crime, and I accuse him of it.”

“No.” There was no anger in Ka-Orun’s voice, and that was worse. “We will not open a trial inside a trial inside another trial, each one cracked to bury the last. That is the thrashing of a condemned man who has felt the water climb to his mouth. I have watched it many times from this seat, and it has never once uncovered a truth. The matter is closed. Your four days are not lengthened by it.”

He was right, and in a way he never intended. I had nothing further, and said nothing.

“Then the matter of high treason is sealed,” Ka-Orun said. “The suspension is lifted. The original hearing resumes.”

My office fell off me a second time. This time I had taken it off myself.

Every fact I carried was true. I had set out to show them a traitor. I had shown them that one hand could reach across five and hold, for a single evening, what five were sworn to keep forever apart — and a wall they had watched a boy cross was one they could never trust again. They could not afford to hate me, nor to keep me, nor to kill me in the ordinary way. I was left holding one loose thread no one in the room had thought to cut, because no one knew I held it.

I had four days. I had no office, no witness, no accusation left standing on its feet. What I had was a single fact I was never meant to own, and a night’s worth of having heard, from each of them, exactly how they meant to be rid of me — and in that, exactly what each of them wanted. So I stopped trying to take anything from them, and began to give.

I spoke softly — softly enough that five people who had agreed to kill me had to lean in to hear.

“I do not contest that I am a danger,” I said. “I contest the waste of me. Hear it from each of your offices, since you judged me from them.” I turned to Faith. “You named me devout, Keeper, and meant it for a shroud. Let it be a fact instead. Everything I did, I did in the belief that the Mountain was betrayed and could be healed — never once against it; and you who read patterns know that the shape of me points inward, at the Mountain.” To Balance: “You will spend nothing of your stores on me. Not water, not grain, not one hand set to watch me. I will cost the cistern nothing it would feel.” To Justice: “I regret the precedent. I forced five

offices into one room, and I know now what that cost, and I would carry it back out of the world if I could. But a thing that cannot be buried can still be spent — outward, away, instead of festering here.” To Light — to Ka-Raedin — I said only: “You called me an eye that sees the seam others walk over. An eye is no use in a grave. It is no use, either, in the one sealed room where there is nothing left to look at.”

And then to Shield, and the whole night narrowed to the width of the next sentence.

“You go out,” I said. “You have always gone out. Men of Shield walk among the Outsiders and come back, and keep what they must keep, and the name they do it under is Horizon.”

I had built the word the way I built everything that ruined me — from the edge of a record, the shape of a route, a silence held one beat too long. And the proof that I had it right was that no one asked me what I meant. The chamber went still with the stillness of five people learning at once that a secret each of them had kept had been kept, too, by a boy.

“Now that it has been spoken in this room,” I went on, before the stillness could close against me, “it is no longer a secret you must kill me to keep. It is a secret you can use me to serve. Send me out — not as a Veil; you have stripped that, and rightly — send me as what I have proven I cannot help being: a finder. Let me do for Shield the one thing I cannot stop doing — go among them and learn the true size of what is coming, and whether the betrayal I believed I saw runs anywhere real, or clears, as here tonight it has begun to clear. I will go with an open heart, and bring back nothing but what is true.” I looked to the empty place where the record should have sat. “Let Va-Sheva be the ear I speak into. Whatever I find, she carries to the five — in my words, unaltered, for your judgement and never mine. I do not ask to be trusted. I ask to be made useful at a distance no danger of me can cross back over.”

It was an office the Mountain lacked; no law provided for it. No one had come down into that dark expecting a third thing — beyond death, and beyond the Exception as it had ever been used — a door the condemned built for himself while they watched. And that was why it held: I offered to become the thing Shield’s whole craft is made of — a man who goes out and comes back changed — on terms that cost Shield nothing and watched itself.

“Around the earth,” Ka-Orun said once, softly, to no one. Then, to the chamber: “This is — this is nowhere in the law.”

“No,” said Ka-Raedin. “It is in the Mountain’s interest, and the Mountain’s interest is the thing the law was raised to serve, not the reverse. I told the boy, not an hour past, the order of it — the Mountain first, then the office, then the man. I will not unsay it now, merely because the same order that would have killed him has turned, and asks instead that he be used.”

I won it in silence. I had said what I had; the rest was theirs. I watched it move between them without a vote called — decided in a silence just short of speech — and then Ka-Orun, who alone had standing to speak it, spoke it aloud, because I had contested my judgement and the old right demanded an answer.

“The sentence of death is stayed,” he said, “and its cover kept whole. To the Mountain you are the devout boy the Labyrinth took; on the fourth day they will grieve you, and you will let them, and never once, while you live, will you send them word that the grief is misspent. What you are from this breath has no name in any Book. You go out under Shield, by the door we do not name above the deep, and you send back nothing but the truth, through Va-Sheva, until the five release you or the desert does.” “You asked to be made useful at a distance. The Mountain grants you the distance. Do not mistake it for a pardon. It is the longest leash the law has ever paid out, and it is a leash still.”

The sentence was set. By the oldest form of the court a Keeper may lay one word into the record before the condemned is taken up, and all five chose to.

Ka-Raedin did not rise to it. “You are sending light out by the narrowest door in the Mountain, and asking it to stay a line. I am the one keeper here who knows what light does with a narrow door, and I am sworn not to teach it in an open room. Hear only this: there is no door narrow enough, and his path, sent so far, will not leave the Mountain untouched. Do not read my silence for consent.”

Ka-Elun spoke next, who had already spent her voice for my death; she looked at the stone and not at me. “You weigh his distance; I weigh his rhythm. No tread is so plain that it keeps one beat only — every step a man walks is many beats laid together, and one of them, however faint, is the Mountain’s own. Give him a year, and he walks that beat ten thousand times. The Book teaches what the small thing does when it returns and returns upon the stone’s own note: it is not the weight of the blow that wakes the deep, but its coming again in time. Hear only this — he has a step, and the Mountain has a note, and I have never known the one that did not carry the other. Do not read my silence for consent.”

Then Ka-Leth, who keeps the water and the count, turned a hand over as she spoke, the way she does when a column will not come out even. “You would put him outside to keep the inside clean. I keep the books of clean and unclean, and

they answer to one law: the sum never falls. Order swept from one room is paid for with more disorder in the next, and the next is always the larger. Spend this man outward, and the disorder you spend will not die out there. It gathers. It warms. It leans back on the door you pushed it through. There is no away for it. And it mounts fastest where you bury it. Do not read my silence for consent.”

Then Ka-Dhavar, who had brought me to the mark with a hand still at my shoulder, spoke from where he stood, the way Shield speaks. “You have each spoken of what he is. I will speak of what a seal is. I have set every seal the Mountain owns, and learned the one thing my office may never say in daylight: not one of them is tight. A wall that passes a whisper a day passes the whole account in a year. And what is known has already copied itself — take the man, and the knowing has gone on ahead of him, into every mouth it touched. I asked for the one seal that holds. You chose instead to keep the door open and turn it toward the outside. Hear only this: there is no shut door, only a slow one. Do not read my silence for consent.”

Then Ka-Orun, who not a breath before had handed me my life, gave the last word, and this one I could only half-follow. His gaze had gone past all of us, to the black air, as though he read something written there. “I never let myself know the world was a sphere,” he said. “But I know that much about spheres. A road in a closed world is a knot not yet pulled tight. Any road walked back upon itself makes a loop; and I am told of worlds where a loop rides a throat worn clean through the whole and can never be drawn shut, and of worlds where it can, always, to a single point. We are handing this man a year and open country, and forgetting the oldest thing my house buried: that if every loop he can walk draws shut then the world is one shape and no other, however you crush it or stretch it, whatever its hills and its distances. Finite. Seamless. The only one. And a seamless world keeps no outside. A man who walks far enough draws the last road shut, and holds the whole of us in the closing.”

And nobody understood. No one asked him what he meant. I think no one else in that dark could have. I carried the sound of it out with me without the sense of it.

I had come down into that chamber a condemned Veil. I left it going outward, toward the surface, taken in the same hour into the service of the office I had come to destroy. I had recruited myself, out of my own ruin, into the one operation whose name I was never meant to learn.

Ka-Raedin came to me before the transfer, close enough that no one could mistake it for public instruction.

“You are alive,” he said.

“Yes, Keeper.”

“You will be tempted to think that being useful is the same as being forgiven. It is the opposite. You have bought yourself time, and nothing else — time to become capable of carrying what you forced yourself to see.” The faintest edge moved at his mouth and stopped there. “Go and be the eye. It is Shield’s answer to you now. It is also, and will remain... Light’s.” And he went back to his seat beneath the dark aperture and never looked at me again.

Ka-Elun stopped me where the ways parted — the others’ road climbing back the way we had come, and mine going out by some other seam, toward the surface and the sky I had been raised to fear. “Do not make a gospel of what has happened to you,” she said.

“No, Keeper.”

“That will be harder than silence. You have a martyr’s material now, and a preacher’s tongue, and neither the office nor the innocence to be trusted with either. Carry the truth. Do not preach it.” She almost, for one breath, looked as though she pitied me, and then Faith took it back into itself. “The Beast knows neither faithful nor stranger. Neither, now, does your story. Keep it apart from other men.” And she turned, and Faith took the dark with her.

Va-Sheva walked me the last stretch — only her, for there had never been any wardens in this. When no witness stood near enough to make the words formal, I said the thing I had left.

“I made your crossing worthless.”

“Yes,” she said. She kept it hard, and I loved her for keeping it hard. She was the one person left who would tell me the truth.

“And now they have made you my keeper instead.”

“Now I am the thread they have let you keep,” she said. “Do not test what it will bear.”

“Were death and Exception always the only two?”

She looked at me then, fully, for the first time since the chamber. “Yes,” she said. “There were only ever two. You made the third yourself, tonight, out of nothing they knew they had left lying about. I have kept Shield’s secrets my whole life. I never once saw one of them turned into a door.”

We reached a passage new to me. The air in it was colder, less of Mountain, more of sealed routes and long distance; whatever way they meant to send me out ran upward, toward the sky. She waited.

“Will they truly believe I am dead?”

“They will grieve you on the fourth day,” she said. “The grief will be real. That is what makes it hold.” I was walking into the longest Exception the record had never written down. I stepped forward, and no one dragged me. I walked to it on my own feet, the way I had walked to all of it — carrying the trust myself, because that was the only way it could be carried.

There is a machine on the table, a little wheel of tape that circles and circles and only listens.

I still feel the cold when it turns.

Half the Mountain knew the shape of the world and said nothing, and lived out their lives in peace. They tried to destroy me for the one unforgivable thing — for taking what five hands were sworn to hold apart and forcing it, for the length of a single evening, into one room. And when even that failed them, they sent the danger of me out into the very country it had come from: the land of the men whose eyes ride around the Earth, a world that keeps no secret past a season. I bought myself a longer road and called it living, and I would do it again. It is the crack that was always in me.

I have held it ever since.

It feels like no kind of winning.

— ... No kind of winning. But you walked out of that Hall alive, on a leash, and the leash ran out here — into the open country of the world, into my air. And here is the piece your account cannot see, because you were inside it: every time your Mountain did the very thing it had just tried to kill you for coming near — every time one of your five went under the chain and a new hand closed on the office — it made a sound. And I was out here in the cold, catching it. ... I have kept the register of your dead and your risen off a drum, in a case, longer than you have been alive, and never once looked upon a face. It is the most patient business I was ever in. A door that opens once in a generation, and a woman who would not stop watching it.

— You say the knock as though I should flinch from it. It is a rite — the most guarded thing my people own, worked under a floor no Veil is ever shown. You cannot have

heard it. No ear reaches the Mountain. That is not a saying. It is the first thing, the thing every other thing we believe is stacked upon.

— ... Then that is where we stop, and that is what we have out, before you give me another mile of your road. Because that drum has not rested since the night it drew twice, and I will not sit and take the rest of your account while you still believe you were kneeling to something no ear alive could reach.

CHAPTER 15

KNOCKS

— She has stopped my account again — twice now in a single telling. A man sets down his whole life a morning at a time, and cannot reach the end of it for the hand she keeps laying flat across the page.

— She stopped it for cause, and this time the cause is as much mine as hers. She gave the word knock back to me across the table, and I have not been able to lie down under it since. So it will be had out before I give the rest of the road. Only understand: it is not the house asking now, and it is not her. It is me. I have carried it up here in the dark to be rid of it. It is mine.

— You came in with the machine under your arm and not the folder, and you have not sat down. You have learned to say a thing and its opposite in one breath, which is new in you this week, and a man only does that when he is about to reach for something he has not been given leave to hold. I watched Veils do it before they asked me for an office above their own. ... There is nowhere for either of us to be this morning, and a machine in the next room that will not stop saying so. Ask.

— Twice in your life you watched a Keeper rise. The Faith woman, when you were a boy of fifteen. Your own teacher's Keeper, four years on, the old man in the lowered box. You gave me both mornings whole. The disk on its thread, the wound made holy at the throat. You spared me nothing anywhere else.

— I spared you nothing that was mine to give.

— Then let me tell you what you handed me without seeming to know its price. The five strokes under the deepest floor, the long wait, the great slow thing that answered and lifted the whole Hall on one breath. You counted them for me. And then you did the thing your people trained into you: you called it a rite, let it be holy, and stopped there. I am going to ask the one question your account could not reach, because no soul inside those walls could. That sound you felt come up through the soles of your feet — where do you imagine it stopped?

— Stopped? In the stone. Where every sound in the Mountain stops. It is worked under the deepest floor we have, behind a door that stands on no route a Veil is ever given — no candidate follows the five through it, no witness, no record I ever saw. Whatever they do back there, they do a short while, and come out, and the stone keeps it, the way it keeps everything. That is all I know of where it went.

— How short a while.

— A silence. Two. Long enough to feel the wrongness of the waiting and no longer. It is Keeper work. A rite of readiness. That is all a Veil is told, and a Veil who asks for more is told he will learn it on the morning he holds the office, or die without it.

— And in eleven thousand years no Veil ever forced the door.

— Force it to where? A bold boy breaks into a locked room on a dare. This one is simply not on the map you are handed. A Veil is given the whole Mountain, pressed into him over years until he could walk the dark and never touch a wall. And this one door is left off that map so completely that a Veil does not even feel the shape of its absence. I felt it. It is my flaw and always was. I stood in a passage where the map promised only rock, and knew there was a room back there, the way you know a word has been left out of a sentence spoken in the dark. And I said nothing, because a Veil who tells the elders he can feel a room that is not on the map is a Veil the elders begin to watch.

— And you never held the office.

— No.

— So you do not know what they do behind the door.

— No. ... Only what I gave you in the account, too proud of the giving to see the size of it. Both times, after the door shut on the five, the Mountain answered them.

— Answered. Say what you mean by the word.

— A sound. Under the floor, and late, after the Hall had half emptied and no one minded the quiet. A sound you would miss unless you were a boy with nothing left to do but be frightened and count the pillars. A knock. One knock, and then a shape to it, small parts, one after another, evenly set, and then done. The second time, dust came down off a seam in the pillar above me, and I looked for a servant to blame and found none. I was small enough still to stand among the feet of the elders, and I felt

it come up through the soles of me before I heard it in the air. Five times the stone pressed up against my feet, evenly, without hurry, and then let go, and an old woman beside me said the blessing for the settling of the Mountain and laid her palm flat on the pillar. I knew it for no settling; I had counted it; a settling does not count. But I took her blessing for my own, and let the made thing be a holy thing.

— A knock. With a shape to it. Small parts, in order.

— Yes.

— The same shape both times.

— ... I was a boy the first time and a grieving man the second. I would not swear to it in your court. It felt like the same fist on the same door. ... Why does a man paid to count whether I am real care what the ground does under a rite no Veil is ever shown?

— Because the ground kept a copy.

[—]

— I have no fine language for this, so I will give you the plainest thing I own. When something happens in the earth, it runs out through the rock in every direction at once, and if you set a patient enough instrument a long way off, the shaking arrives there, days or seconds later, and the instrument draws it. A line, on a slowly turning drum. You have watched your Pendulum draw one circle on a floor across the better part of three days. This is the same art turned the other way about: the ground drawing its own signature on a page across a few seconds.

— And from the line you read the size of the blow.

— That is what most men read from it, and why the work is so easy to do badly. The size is the least of it. ... Here. A footstep, through a wall. You are shut in one room; a man walks through the next; you never see his face. You can hear the size of him, whether he is heavy or light. But that is not how you know it is your brother in there and not a stranger. You know your brother by the rhythm. The little drag on the third step from a knee he broke as a boy. The size tells you a man is walking. The shape tells you which man.

— ... A gong.

— Go on.

— You have a gong. Faith keeps one and strikes the hours on it. Ten attendants strike that gong across a year and no two blows are the same. One leans on the rim and flattens the note. One is frightened of the elders and strikes it soft, apologising to the bronze. The gong does not change. The blow is the hand. ... And the Bowl. You will have heard me name the Bowl of the Last Prayer, with its Ear and its Mouth. You speak into the Ear, and if you give it the one true note it gives that note straight back off the Mouth, whole; and if you give it a false note it gives you nothing, only silence. It cares nothing for how loud you are, only whether the note is the note. ... You are telling

me the ground is a bowl. That it gives the same shape back to the same blow. And that a man set far enough off, with an ear patient enough, could learn one blow from another.

— I am telling you that nothing in nature repeats itself exactly. A quake is never twice the same quake; the earth has no such discipline. So when a signature comes in twice, and I mean cut for cut, in the very same order and the very same spacing, a man who has listened to the ground for a living stops believing he is hearing the earth. He begins to believe he is hearing a machine. Only a machine does a thing the same way twice.

— How far. How far off can an ear sit and still catch a thing so small.

— That is the wrong question, and the first one every general asks me. Not how far. How quiet, and how patient, and how certain you already are that there is a thing to be heard. A loud event any fool catches at a distance. A small one, precisely made, arriving where nothing should be arriving at all, is caught by one person only: the one who decided it was there before she had a single proof, and then bent a life around the waiting until she was right. ... And there is a reason nobody else was ever going to stumble over it, which cost me thirty years to work out and which I find, on the whole, the most frightening thing I know about your people. They fire it into a hole. Not against the rock — into a great empty room cut for the purpose. Set a charge against solid stone and the stone takes the whole blow and hands it on to the entire world; hang the same charge in the middle of a void and most of what it makes goes into shoving air and warming a wall, and only a thin part of it ever leaks away into the ground. My own trade learned that trick in the fifties and used it to hide bombs from women like me. Your Mountain has been doing it since before Ur. Whatever comes up out of that desert arrives as a whisper, and a whisper is beneath the notice of every array on this Earth — unless somebody has happened to set a good instrument forty kilometres off for an entirely different reason, on the one morning in a century when it mattered, and then spent the remainder of her life refusing to put it down.

— Then your machine did not find it.

— A person always finds it. The machine only keeps her honest. ... And I begin to think you have already guessed whose life that was.

— ... Then a man who had your drawings, and enough of them, could do far more than know the Mountain is there. He could count us. Every one of these knocks is a Keeper dead and a Keeper risen in his place. Give a patient man enough of them, across enough years, and he holds the roll of every succession in all five offices. How often we change hands. How long a Keeper stands before the chain takes him under. He would know the rhythm of our dying and never once have looked on a face.

— He would.

— And more than that. You said the knock does not change. The same small parts, the same spacing, always. So it is not the ceremony that makes the sound, because

the ceremony changes; the hall warmer or colder, the crowd larger, the hands on the gong ten different hands. The knock does not change. Which means the men are only standing over it. The knock is the thing they serve, saying the one word it has, under the floor, to prove it still answers when a new hand is laid on it.

— You were a boy of fifteen the first time. And you were burying your teacher the second.

— I was Veil of Light. I was trained past every other man in that Hall to know the one thing: when a thing set before me had been set there on purpose, to be seen or to be missed. And the one time it truly mattered, I heard a machine speak its own name in the dark under my feet, and knew it for a made thing, and knelt to it, and never once thought to ask how far the sound carried.

[—]

— Your people kept a rite so close that no Veil in eleven thousand years was let through its door. And every time they performed it, the ground carried the knock out from under the Hall, out under the desert, and the desert did not stop it.

— Someone drew it.

— Someone drew it. ... I was given a folder when I was sent here. A thin thing at my level; I am trusted with little. It holds what a fact-checker needs to catch a man in a lie about the ground his people stand on: a few traces, a few dates typed down the margin, and one instruction, to see whether the drowned people's mountain had ever announced itself in a way the outside record could confirm. I took it for a test of you. I laid it aside for four days because you never gave me a lie to catch. Look. This is the morning the Faith woman rose, give or take a season, reckoned off your fifteenth year. This is the morning your teacher's Keeper rose, four years on. And these two are the lines the house holds nearest to those mornings.

— ...

— Take your time. I am not the man who can read the last of it off the page. I know enough to be dangerous with it. But even I can see a matched pair when it is set in front of me.

— ... They are the same.

— They are close. I have told you I am not the one who can tell you how close.

— Then who is.

[—]

— Paul. You were engaged to establish that this man is who he says he is. Nothing beyond it.

— I established it. The first afternoon, near enough.

— And then you kept walking.

— I had the knock from his own account — the five strokes, the wait, the great slow answer, whole, the way he gave me everything. What he could not give me, what no soul raised inside those walls could, was whether the sound stopped at the stone. So I went in the night to see whether the ground outside had heard it too. That is the work you hired me for, done a little further than you asked.

— A little further than I asked. ... Give me the two you built. Yes. And now these. They were drawn by a better instrument than ever made yours, and kept better since, for longer than you have stood upright. Lay them over his. One to one. ... There. That is the fit of a key in a lock cut for it.

— That is not possible. No one is outside the desert. No one hears the Mountain. That is not doctrine, woman, that is the first thing, the thing that stands under every other thing, the ground the ground stands on.

— It is the oldest thing your people believe, and the least true of them, and I am sorry to be the one holding the proof in her hand. I do not sound sorry. I have held it too long to sound like anything. Every time your five went behind their door and did their small exact thing in the dark, the whole earth carried it. For a very long age no one out here had an ear fine enough to catch it, or reason to turn such an ear on an empty quarter of the Sahara. And then, once, someone had both.

— ... I have stood my whole life with my back to that wall. We all have. A child of the Mountain is taught it before he is taught to count: the desert keeps us, no ear alive reaches the Mountain. Every hard thing my people ever did, they did leaning their whole weight on that one wall. And you are telling me the wall was never there. That while a Keeper opened his own body to hold the world shut, and a boy wept under a pillar, and a woman I loved taught herself to be glad inside a cage, there was a woman in a cold country with our secret hung out drying on a line.

— I am telling you exactly that.

— How long have you had this.

— Longer than you have been alive.

— ... These two are mine. Do you understand what you are holding. These are my mornings. This is the woman I watched wounded at the throat when I was a boy. This is the old man I watched climb into a stone box and die on purpose while I stood under the pillar of Light and wept. And you have them here, on a strip of paper, in a case, in a house in Switzerland.

— I have every one your Mountain ever made. Your Keepers do not die often, and that mercy is what made the thing findable in the end: something very small, repeated exactly, at long and patient intervals, out of a place the maps all swear holds nothing but distance. A machine running slow. A machine so sure of its own silence between the strokes that it never thought anyone had learned to wait the silence out.

— You have gathered these. Not one of them. Every one. ... A person does not spend a lifetime collecting each stroke of a slow machine to satisfy herself the machine is there. You were sure of that by the second stroke. You gather them to learn the machine. Its habits. The one hour it is weakest.

— And when is a thing weakest. Say it, since you are so quick this morning.

— When it changes hands. Your knock is the sound of the Mountain changing hands, the one morning in a generation when the grip on an office is loosest, when the five are apart behind their door and the new hand has not yet closed on the thing. And you have kept the calendar of that exact morning, in the dark, in a case, for longer than I have drawn breath.

— ...

— And you keep me here in your house, and set this man to open me on the table like a fish, and lay my own two mornings out in front of me, and you do it to hold your calendar up against a man who stood in the rooms while it was being written. Fear does not come into it, nor honour. A wonder is what you would call me. What I am to you is the one correction you have waited an age to make to your instrument.

— You are both of those things, and I have never found the two hard to carry in the same hand. It is the only gift I was born with. I built everything else out of it.

— I was engaged to hold a record against a man, and see whether the man would break. For four days I have been holding the man against the record.

— Now you are quick as well. It is a poor week for me, Paul, when the help begins to think.

— ... What did you do. When you found it.

— There was a fire in the desert, once, when I was young. The largest fire men had yet learned to make, and the whole nervous world bent an ear toward that desert to hear it fall. And underneath the fire, very small, in the wrong place, arriving the wrong way and long after it should have finished, there was something else. Everyone in that desert was listening to the bomb. ... I was listening to the thing hiding behind it. That is how I found the Mountain.

— ... Then you have given him the one thing no soul inside those walls could. ... Kailan. You talked yourself off a death and onto the longest leash their law had ever paid out, and they opened the door. That is the sentence she broke off in your mouth an hour ago. Take it up from there — where did the door put you?

— ... You know where it put me. Out here. Onto the horizon of my own Mountain, which was the only word my people ever had for the country I am sitting in. ... I will tell it from the well they walked me out through in the dark, the night they took my name off me.

CHAPTER 16

HORIZON

The escape is what a listener wants first: the desert, the metal bird, the open water beyond a window.

First they erased me.

I stood in the sealed route beneath the hearing chamber while Justice removed me from the ordinary sequence of the Mountain. The public form of it passed without me, if public was the right word for a statement spoken before five witnesses no family would join. I heard only the lower version, given by the white-haired Justice witness while Shield prepared the transfer.

“Va-Kailan of Light ceases ordinary standing.”

The witness kept her eyes on the tablet as she read.

“Office consequence passes to Light under Keeper management. Household consequence passes to Faith under sealed wording. Material consequence passes to Balance. Movement consequence passes to Shield. Sequence consequence remains with Justice. The name is held from common use.”

Held.

Alive. Erased. Held.

A name in the Mountain was ration, bed, task, prayer line, family place, burial ledger.

I looked at the dark cord Va-Sheva had tied below the covered white knot on my wrist. My Veil mark remained beneath Shield cloth.

“Will my mother be told I am dead?” I asked.

The witness turned one line on the tablet.

“Faith will give the household a form sufficient for survival.”

“That is not an answer.”

“It is the lawful answer.”

Va-Sheva stood three paces away, silent. No weapon showed on her. No explanation either.

“What form?” I asked.

The Justice witness looked at me then.

“One they can repeat without committing breach.”

I regretted the question. My mother would receive words she could survive. My father would read the missing details better than most men, and it would ruin him. My household would wonder whether to grieve death, disgrace, selection, or disappearance.

The transfer passed no public gate.

Shield took me through routes that had no childhood memory attached to them. Below the hearing chamber, below the old water lines, below even the places where workers joked that the Mountain had no further patience for stairs, the passages became narrower and less finished. Some were cut by tool, some enlarged from natural seams, some so low that even Va-Sheva had to bend. The air moved strangely there: thin, dry streams from cracks the official maps omitted.

Balance had prepared a transfer pack. It contained nothing sentimental. Dried fruit. Salted strips. Two water skins. A folded robe of rougher cloth. A mouth covering. Sand wraps. A packet of bitter paste against thirst. A list of measures tied to the pack with green thread.

I noticed a second pack on one warden’s back.

“Is that mine too?”

Va-Sheva answered without turning. “No. That is what Shield carries because Balance assumes you may become useless.”

I almost smiled. It sounded like her.

Justice stopped us at three points. Each time the witness marked my body, route, transfer condition, and silence. No one asked whether I wished to continue.

At the last interior threshold, Faith waited. A single attendant of middle age with a covered face and a bowl of water in both hands. She was a stranger to me, or had been chosen because she could appear so. The water in the bowl held still.

She spoke no scripture. That omission hurt. Instead she said, “What leaves under seal leaves under God.”

I lowered my head. “What returns under seal returns only if God permits return.”

I looked up. The attendant touched water to my forehead, then to the covered knot at my wrist, then to the dark cord Shield had tied beneath it.

“What is held from the people is not hidden from God.”

Her hands withdrew. The blessing ended there.

The final Shield door opened outward.

Night waited.

— They have finished with you. Then give me the road out — all of it, in order. The desert, the well, the water. I have kept you from your bed four nights for this account, and myself from a summer I mean to get back to — there is a boy at home, my sister’s, that I have promised two years running to teach to swim, and I should like to keep it this year while the water is still warm. I would not stop this one door short of where it ends.

— It ends badly.

— Most roads out of a home do. Then walk it, and do not spare the turns.

The desert entered first as cold. Then height. Then smell: mineral, dry scrub, something faintly animal beyond the prepared route. I stepped out beneath the Mountain’s shadow for the second time in my life, and this time without prayer access. The sky above me was full of stars. No vault. No ceiling. Nothing to teach the eye where to stop.

I hated it less this time. That frightened me.

The party moved before dawn. Va-Sheva led until the first ridge, then gave command to a Shield warden whose face had been wrapped so fully that only his eyes remained. Behind us came two more wardens and the Justice witness. No Faith. No Balance. Their parts had been completed at the threshold.

For a while the Mountain remained behind us, blacker than night. Then the path folded, and it vanished. I stopped. A warden touched my shoulder. I turned back, but there was nothing to see. The Mountain had kept its place.

"Move," Va-Sheva said. I moved.

At first the journey was silence, cold, and pain in the feet. The sand wraps helped a little. My body was trained for stone, stairs, controlled routes, measured heat. The desert turned ankles, stole direction, widened distance, and made every ridge into a false promise.

When dawn came, Shield put us under stone. A cut in the rock barely deep enough for bodies and packs. A cloth of desert colour was drawn across the outer edge and pinned with stones. Inside the cut there was only breath, heat, thirst, and waiting.

I was given two mouthfuls of water. I wanted more and kept silent.

Va-Sheva sat near the opening, looking outward through a gap in the cloth. Dust had settled along the line of her cheek. Outside light found her face and made it older.

"Is this still the Mountain?" I asked.

"No."

"Is it still Shield?"

"Yes."

The day passed in fragments. The cloth breathed outward and inward with small changes in air. Once, a warden moved to adjust a stone and froze for three full breaths before finishing. Something had passed beyond the cut, unseen by me. No one told me what it had been.

Near evening, Va-Sheva gave me a strip of salted meat. I took it.

"Did you know," I asked, "before I showed you the scrap?"

She kept her eyes on the gap. "You are asking which part."

"Yes."

"I knew there were outer holdings."

"Holdings."

"Yes."

"Archives?"

She said nothing.

"Contacts?"

Still nothing.

"Sarah Blackwood?"

Her face changed so little I almost missed it. "You may not say that name again on this route."

"But you know it."

"I said you may not say it again."

The old anger rose in me, but it found no easy shape. She knew something, held under seal.

"I thought knowing would make things clearer," I said.

"Light lies to its children. Shield lies differently."

I looked at her. "How does Shield lie?"

"We tell ours that if they train enough, they will see danger before it harms what they love."

"And that is false?"

She turned from the cloth gap then. "It is true often enough to destroy them."

At dusk we moved again.

The second night brought us farther from the Mountain than I knew how to measure. Shield used the stars without naming them to me. The path avoided easier ground, choosing hard shelves and stone ridges where footprints broke or vanished. Once we lay flat while a distant engine passed beyond a ridge, a sound so alien that I first thought it some desert animal too large for scripture.

"What is it?" I whispered.

Va-Sheva's hand closed once in warning. I obeyed. The engine faded. Only later, when we moved again, she said, "Vehicle."

The word belonged to no chamber I knew. "Outsider?"

"Yes."

"Did it see us?"

"No."

I believed her because I had to, and the dependence angered me.

Before the third dawn, the route ended at a dry well. Stones fallen, lip cracked, rope long gone. A dead thorn tree leaned over it like a warning no one maintained. Shield circled the place before approaching. Va-Sheva inspected the inner wall with two fingers, found something, and pressed.

From below came a hollow answer. A message travelling through old depth. We waited.

After a long while, a voice from inside the well spoke in a language strange to me. One of the wardens answered in the same language. The stone at the base shifted.

Horizon began as a hole beneath a dead well. That disappointed me.

The passage below the well was wider than Shield's desert route, cooler, and prepared for repeated movement. Its walls were reinforced with outsider materials: metal ribs, smooth white panels, rubber-smelling seals, small glass bulbs that gave steady light without flame. I stopped before the first one despite myself.

"No lamp," I said.

A man standing inside the passage laughed softly. "Not in your sense."

The language was Mountain speech, but bent differently, as if each word had crossed water and returned changed. The man was tall, broad-shouldered, perhaps in his early forties. He wore desert-coloured clothes unlike Shield leather, cut so a man could move fast in them. His face was lined by sun and discipline. A short blade sat at his belt beside stranger tools of metal and black material. He looked at the wardens, then at Va-Sheva, then at me.

"Jean-Charles," Va-Sheva said.

The man crossed the passage before the wardens could set themselves around it. From inside his coat he drew a small flat box, bright, tied with a ribbon the colour of nothing in the desert, and held it out to her. "Pistachio and rose," he said. "They travelled badly. Eat them tonight or they die."

She took the box, and her face opened.

I had spent years setting myself in front of that face and waiting for it to open like that. It never had. It opened now, for a man from outside the Mountain, over a handful of coloured sugar that would spoil by morning. The discipline went out of her shoulders. She said his name again, and the rank had gone out of it. She stepped into him for the length of one breath, her brow against his jaw, and then the room came back to her and she stepped away.

I said nothing. The wardens filled the space, and the route went on around me.

Jean-Charles looked at me and switched into more careful Mountain speech. "So this is him."

"This is the transfer," Va-Sheva said.

"Of course." He stepped aside. "Welcome to the part of the world that pretends it is not also a cave."

I said nothing.

Jean-Charles smiled as if my silence amused him. "Good. Still alive inside the head, then."

He said it warmly, and his eyes finished what they had begun the moment I came up out of the well. They went over my hands, my feet, the place a blade would ride if I wore one, and put me away somewhere for later. The warmth was not false. It was also an instrument, and he did not once set it down while he used it.

Va-Sheva said, "He is under Exception."

"I know."

"Do not test him for sport."

“I never test for sport.”

We moved deeper.

At the first inner chamber, the Justice witness handed a sealed packet to a woman waiting beside a metal table. The woman had pale hair cut shorter than any Mountain woman’s, and eyes that assessed without asking permission. She wore the grey of outsider cloth, nothing of the Candidates in it: jacket, trousers, boots, a narrow cord at the throat bearing no Kahir sign. She had the composure of someone who belonged to another hierarchy entirely.

“Elise,” Jean-Charles said.

The woman ignored him and took the packet.

Va-Sheva addressed her formally. “Va-Elise.”

Va-Elise broke the outer seal under the witness’s eyes, read the first page, left the second, and signed a mark on a smooth white sheet. Ink from a tube. Paper too perfect.

“Body received under Shield-Horizon transfer,” she said. “Speech restricted. Return unpresumed. Name held. Public standing ceased.”

The Justice witness answered, “Sequence delivered.”

Va-Elise looked at me for the first time. “You understand your old name is not for ordinary use here.”

“No.”

“Good. Then listen. Va-Kailan belongs to the Mountain record. Kailan belongs to what you were before rank. Outside tongues will damage it immediately. For operational use, you will be Kylian. Within Horizon classification, because you are under instruction, not command, you are Sa-Kylian.”

The demotion entered more deeply than I expected. “Candidate?”

“Provisional Candidate.”

“I was Veil of Light.”

Va-Elise’s expression held. “In the Mountain. Under a title now sealed from common use. Here you do not know how a door opens, how a telephone betrays location, how a church arranges memory, how a passport creates a person, or how an Outsider smiles while measuring whether you are useful. Candidate is generous.”

Jean-Charles murmured, “She likes to welcome people warmly.”

Va-Elise let that pass.

“She should not be contradicted,” Va-Sheva said to me.

I — no, Sa-Kylian, if the new grammar had already begun — looked at the table. On it: folded clothes, dark shoes, a small book waiting for my image, metal

keys, a plastic card, a map in colours too precise to be a gravure. Beside them lay a pair of spectacles with clear lenses.

"I do not need those," I said.

Va-Elise followed my gaze. "Correction is what they are for elsewhere. Here they are for concealment."

"Of what?"

"Attention. People look differently at men with spectacles."

I looked at Jean-Charles. The man nodded gravely. "Sadly true."

Va-Sheva removed the dark cord from my wrist. The cord only. She gave it to Va-Elise, who placed it inside a small envelope and marked the time.

"Am I still under Shield?" I asked.

Va-Elise answered before Va-Sheva could. "You are under Horizon custody by Shield transfer and Justice sequence."

"What is Horizon?"

"A line you cannot reach by walking toward it."

Jean-Charles smiled.

Va-Elise continued, "That is the poetic answer. The practical answer is: the structure that keeps certain Mountain facts from dying inside it and certain outside facts from entering uncontained."

"Another Kahir?"

"No."

Va-Sheva said, "Do not try to fit it into five hands."

That frightened me more than the dead well. The five hands had explained the world with a shape my mind could inhabit.

"Who commands it?"

Va-Elise closed the packet. "For now, Ka-Sarah."

Sarah. The name returned before I could prevent it. The word Horizon sealed near her name. I said nothing.

Va-Elise saw enough. "You will meet her when you are clean, dressed, fed, and no longer looking as if every object in the room is a theological insult."

"They are."

Jean-Charles laughed. Va-Elise's mouth moved by a fraction. "Good. He is not stupid."

Va-Sheva said, "No."

They gave me water, food, and clothes.

The clothes humiliated me past their ugliness. Trousers, shirt, jacket, under-clothes shaped without modest ritual, hard-soled shoes. They made me feel both exposed and disguised.

Va-Sheva stayed away while I changed.

When I returned, Jean-Charles looked me over and said, "Almost human."

I stared.

"In the outside sense," he added.

"That does not improve it."

"No. But you understood the insult. Progress."

Va-Elise handed me the spectacles. I put them on. The clear lenses caught the electric bulbs and placed small false lights at the edge of my sight. "I hate them," I said.

"They suit you," Jean-Charles said.

Va-Sheva entered then, saw me, and stopped. She nearly smiled. I caught it, and the kindness wounded me.

"You look like an Outsider scholar," she said.

"I have been called worse today."

"Yes."

Va-Elise became suddenly occupied with the packet. Jean-Charles inspected a tool that required no inspection.

Va-Sheva came closer. "This is where Shield leaves you."

"You leave me."

"Yes."

"Do you return to the Mountain?"

"Yes."

"Will you tell them I reached Horizon?"

"No."

"Will Ka-Raedin know?"

"Through sequence. Not through me."

"And my family?"

She said nothing. I looked away first. She had often looked away first when we were younger, because she always had somewhere to be, and it was never anywhere she let me follow. This time I looked away to keep from asking for something neither of us could lawfully give.

"You did not choose death," I said.

"No."

"You chose this."

"I chose the only containment that left you breathing."

"That is not the same as choosing me." The sentence escaped before discipline could stop it.

Va-Sheva received it without visible movement. Va-Elise kept her eyes down.

Va-Sheva answered quietly. "No."

I nodded once. "Then thank you for choosing breathing."

Her face changed then. Pain, almost. Or something her office kept her from showing. "You are alive," she said.

"So I keep being told."

"Believe it slowly." Her hand moved toward the covered knot at my wrist, then stopped short of touching it. She stepped back. Then she left.

No embrace. No private token. No promise. The door closed behind her.

I stood in outsider clothes beneath electric light.

— You know them. You told me what you are; so you know these names.

— I know them. Jean-Charles is exactly as tiresome as you found him. Elise has not warmed once in all the years I have worked beside her.

— And her. Ka-Sarah.

— The account first. Finish the road — bring yourself into the house above the water, and give me the first time you saw her.

Instruction came before Ka-Sarah. It happened in a room. A telephone. A camera. A printed newspaper. A map of the world, obscene in size. A passport with a blank place where my image would be placed. Va-Elise taught quickly and without pity. Jean-Charles interrupted only to translate the practical stupidity of things.

"A car is a small room that moves faster than a horse," he said.

"I know what a vehicle is now."

"No. You know the word. You do not yet know that roads are rivers made of decisions."

Va-Elise said, "That one is actually useful. Remember it."

They moved me again before dawn. This time by vehicle. The first engine vibration made me grip the seat hard enough for Jean-Charles to notice. "You are safer than you feel."

"That is not a meaningful category."

"Good answer."

We crossed dark land, then roads, then places where outside lights multiplied without order. People moving without visible permission. A world mad with doors and no wardens at them. I said little.

The journey after that became a sequence of enclosed transitions: vehicle, hidden room, aircraft, vehicle again, another room. The aircraft was the worst. To be above the earth, between Heaven and ground, held inside a metal body full of strangers who trusted height as if it were lawful — that broke something ordinary in me. Jean-Charles sat beside me and said only, "Do not look down until I say." For once I obeyed without resentment.

We came to Switzerland.

I learned the name of the country from a newspaper before I learned how cold its air would feel.

Switzerland kept nothing of the desert. Mountains without secrecy, water without Covenant, houses exposed to sky as if sky were harmless, churches with towers that rose into the open where the Mountain would have buried them below ground. Snow remained on distant peaks though the lower ground had begun to soften. The air smelled of water, metal, pine, bread, and strangers.

They placed me in a house above a lake. A house. The windows opened. The doors had locks I could understand and others beyond me. Water came by turning a metal handle. Light came by touching a switch. No one prayed when it appeared.

For three days I barely slept. On the fourth, Ka-Sarah received me.

She was older than the photograph, and recognising her still made me dizzy. Her hair had gone mostly white, gathered at the back of her head. Her face carried age without surrendering command. She wore dark wool where a Mountain woman would have worn robes, and a small gold cross at her throat, discreet enough that its very discretion felt like a threat. Her eyes were blue-grey, cold, amused, tired.

The room where she waited had books on three walls, a map of North Africa behind glass, and a window overlooking the lake. She sat with her back partly to the open view, as if no sane person would treat light from outside as a tactical error.

Va-Elise stood beside the door. Jean-Charles near the window. No Va-Sheva.

I stood, and none of my training told me how to greet her.

Ka-Sarah observed me with open interest. "It is not every decade that Horizon receives a Candidate," she said. "An ex-Veil, no less. How extravagant of Shield."

She said it lightly and well. "I was Veil of Light," I said.

"Yes," she said. "That is what ex means."

I disliked her at once. That seemed to please her.

"You are Sarah Blackwood."

"I was Sarah Blackwood before most of the men who feared me learned how to spell it. Here, you may call me Ka-Sarah."

"Keeper of Horizon?"

"Among other inconveniences."

"Horizon is not a Kahir."

"No. But Kahir grammar is hard to remove from children raised in caves."

Jean-Charles looked out the window with the expression of a man enjoying weather.

Ka-Sarah gestured to the chair before her. "Sit. You are making exile look theatrical."

I sat. She studied me over folded hands.

"You have seen a room you were not meant to see, survived a trial that had excellent reasons to kill you, crossed the desert, flown over Europe without screaming, and now wear spectacles intended to make you look harmless. An eventful week."

"Why am I here?"

"Because dead boys tell us less."

"I am not a boy."

"No. That appears to be part of the difficulty."

She opened a file on the table. Paper, photographs, copied Mountain marks. They had already turned my life into outside paperwork.

"You are under Exception. That means you are alive by procedure, not by freedom. Do not confuse the two. You will not leave this property without permission. You will not speak of the Mountain to anyone outside authorised Horizon structure. You will not attempt to contact your family, Ka-Raedin, Va-Sheva, or any Mountain office. You will not return toward the desert. You will not handle maps without supervision. You will not use telephones. You will not keep private writing materials until we decide whether your mind can hold paper responsibly."

I almost laughed at that.

"And," Ka-Sarah said, "you will not enter churches."

"Why?"

Her eyes sharpened. "Because you are too full of broken scripture, and churches are machines for arranging memory in public. You are not ready to stand inside one without either worshipping, condemning, or stealing from it."

I thought of the tortured man on crossed wood. The father's blade. The many-handed mother. I thought of Va-Maera saying that a valve disproved nothing of God.

"You wear a cross," I said.

Ka-Sarah touched it lightly. "Yes."

"Are you one of them?"

"One of whom?"

"Outsiders."

She smiled then. "My dear boy, from where you sit, everyone is."

I had no answer. She closed the file.

"You think you have been taken beyond the Mountain. You have not. You have been moved to the Mountain's horizon — the place where its shadow meets the world it refuses to name properly. You are not free. You are not dead. You are not yet useful."

"And if I refuse it?"

"Then Shield was right and Justice was merciful for too long."

There was no cruelty in her voice.

I looked past her, through the window, toward the lake. Open water under an open sky, boats crossing in full view.

"What do you want from me?" I asked.

"For now? To survive the outside without turning every object into theology."

"And after that?"

Ka-Sarah leaned back. "After that, perhaps you will tell us what Light saw before Shield buried you."

"You already know."

"No," she said. "We know what Shield could afford to transfer. We know what Justice could lawfully write. We know what Light is probably hiding from itself. We do not know what you saw."

Something in me eased, and I distrusted the relief at once.

Ka-Sarah saw that too. "Good," she said. "You are learning."

I almost hated her for using the word in Ka-Raedin's rhythm.

She stood, and the interview was over because she had decided it was. "One more thing, Sa-Kylian. The Mountain will feel purer from here. Do not believe that. Distance flatters prisons and homelands equally."

Then she left me with Va-Elise and Jean-Charles, in a room full of books forbidden me, under a sky no one had measured for me.

No one spoke for a while. Then Jean-Charles said, "Well. That went beautifully."

"It did not."

"No," Jean-Charles said. "But she did not have anyone shot, which in this house counts as hospitality."

Va-Elise said, "Do not make him think that is a joke."

Jean-Charles considered this. "Half a joke."

The absurdity reached me late, when my misery slipped for a moment and let it through.

They fed me after that. Bread with a crust that broke under the hand. Cheese sharp enough to make my jaw tighten. An apple, cut into quarters because Va-Elise had decided I had yet to earn the small knife placed beside the plate. Water in a glass so clear it looked like a trick of Light.

I waited for the prayer. None came.

Jean-Charles lifted his own glass. "Measured," he said, and there was a grin under the word.

Va-Elise looked at him. "Do not."

"Witnessed," Jean-Charles added, and set the glass down against the table.

They were the words a Mountain hand says over the first cup and the sealed jar, and he had said them the way an Outsider says a thing he finds quaint. The bread stopped halfway to my mouth. Whatever showed on my face, he read it before I could put it away, and the grin left him at once.

"Sorry," he said. No ceremony in the apology either. "Bad joke. I did not know it still had teeth in it."

Va-Elise watched and said nothing.

"Eat," Jean-Charles said. "We do not make ceremony of breakfast in this house. It is the one mercy of the place." He ate. The room went on. The two words lay on the table between us like spilled salt no one would trouble to sweep.

After the meal, Va-Elise placed a narrow book on the table before me. Its cover was plain grey. The title had been written twice: once in an outside language beyond my reading, and once in careful Mountain hand.

On Light, Lenses, and the Conduct of Images.

I left it where it lay. "What is this?"

"An optics manual," Va-Elise said.

"I can see that."

"Then why ask?"

"Because I do not understand why it is being given to me."

Jean-Charles leaned back in his chair. "Because Horizon is cruel in more imaginative ways than Shield."

Va-Elise ignored him. "It has been translated into Noxiux where translation was possible. Where it was not possible, we left the outside term and added notes."

I looked at the book as if it might accuse me. "Am I permitted to read it?"

"Under supervision."

"Of course."

"You were Veil of Light," Va-Elise said. "That is precisely why we do not intend to leave you alone with a book that explains what Light has not yet named."

It offended me. It also steadied me.

I opened the cover. The first page showed a drawing of a lens, drawn as if anyone might study it, improve it, misunderstand it in public. That freedom struck me as obscene, and I found it almost beautiful anyway.

Va-Elise watched me read the first diagram. "You are protected here," she said.

I kept my eyes on the page. "Not imprisoned?"

"Do not force comfort to lie."

Jean-Charles said, "Protected with locks."

"That is imprisonment."

"Sometimes," Va-Elise said. "Sometimes it is architecture admitting what danger has already made true."

I turned one page. The next drawing showed light entering water. My hand stopped. Va-Elise saw that too. "We will begin there tomorrow."

Tomorrow. The word entered the room quietly, and it frightened me in a way kindness never had.

That night I lay in a bed too soft and listened to the house breathe. No hidden pipes. No stone heartbeat. No distant gate chain. A car passed below the road. Somewhere in the walls, an electrical system hummed with a steadiness I distrusted.

I had been Kailan. Then Sa-Kailan. Then Va-Kailan. Now Sa-Kylian. A Candidate again, though Light had no part in it.

I touched the place on my wrist where the white Veil knot had been covered. Horizon had wrapped it beneath an ordinary sleeve.

I thought of Va-Sheva returning through desert and stone to a Mountain that would continue without me.

On the table beside the bed lay the optics manual. The curtains stayed open until I asked, because Va-Elise had said, “First learn what windows do.”

But the window was there. I sat up and looked through it. Houses stood along the far shore with their lights exposed, and no Mountain shadow covered them.

The whole dark shore could watch me as plainly as I watched it.

Out in that strange geography there was already a man named Paul Morgan.

But light entered from outside.

— That is the end of it. There is no more Mountain to give you. From the well to this house is the whole of the road, and the rest you have watched with your own eyes.

— ... No. There is not. You have given a good account, all of it, and by the letter of what you signed you are free of us now. ... And I would send you up to your bed, if that drum in the next room would let any of us rest.

— It has not stopped. Not since the night it drew twice, and it draws now, while we sit here — the same five, every eleven minutes, patient as a clock. ... You had me hold its shape against everything I carried out of the Mountain, Madame, and it is a Keeper rising; of that I am certain past doubting. But a Keeper rises only when a Keeper dies. And no Keeper of my five has died since the night your men carried me out of that desert. The offices I left were young; there was no death waiting in any of them.

— Then we have a rising, and no one has risen. ... Say which half is the lie, Kailan — because that drum will not stop drawing until one of us does.

CHAPTER 17

Mock

— Then it is not a rising.

— It is a rising. I have stood in the room where that shape is made. I would know it with my hands cut off.

— It is the shape of a rising, and it is not a rising, because nothing you have ever told me rises twice inside an hour, and it is going to draw a third. Watch the drum. There. No Keeper of yours died three times before this lamp was lit. Something is making your Mountain say the word. Over, and over, and it is not tiring.

— Madame. The interval is holding. Eleven minutes, near enough, between one and the next. It does not vary.

— Of course it does not vary. A death does not keep an appointment. A machine keeps an appointment. ... Bring me the drill cabinet. All of it. The whole run, back to the first paper I ever folded, and the great seals with them. Now, please; and quietly.

— I do not understand what I am looking at, and it is my trade to say so out loud. You have told me for two days this shape is one of his Keepers dying, and another taking the office. Now it comes every eleven minutes. Keepers are not dying every eleven minutes. So the shape is lying about what made it. What makes a true thing lie?

— A forgery makes a true thing lie. Someone out there has learned the one note this Mountain answers to, and is striking it, and standing back, and writing down the answer.

The machine kept turning while she said that, so I will tell the rest of that night the way it came to me, because after that hour there was no longer a man in a chair and a man with a question between us. There was a house waking in the dark, and five thousand souls four weeks' walk to the south who did not know that somebody had found their door and begun to knock upon it.

They brought the cabinet, and she laid the papers out under the long lamp, sixty-six years of them, and set beside them the new sheet the drums had drawn while we argued, and she read them the way I had watched her read me: fast, and cold. Paul stood at her shoulder. I stood where I could see her face and not the drums. Hers, which had not moved once in a week of confessing to a lifetime of theft against my people, moved now.

"These," she said, and her hand was flat on the old folded papers, "are the true ones. Every one of them small, and rare, and years apart, and each one a death. And this" — the new sheet — "wants to be their brother, and it is not. Look at the tail of it. A true knock strikes and the Mountain answers once, deep, and rolls over, and sleeps. This one strikes and the answer does not come from under. It comes from everywhere at once. They made it around the Mountain."

Paul said the thing I could not, being no reader of their drawings. "Around it. You mean the source is outside. Not in the Hall."

"I mean," she said, "that someone has put a machine on the desert floor that shakes the ground on purpose and listens for the way the Mountain gives it back. Then they move the machine and do it again, from a new place. And again. Eleven minutes to strike, and read, and haul the thing a mile, and strike again." She straightened. "It is called sounding. You throw a known noise at a thing you cannot see into, and the echo draws you its insides. It is how I have mapped a hundred ore-bodies I never laid an eye on." She looked, then, like a woman to whom something had been done. "Someone is mapping the inside of your Mountain by making it ring."

I understood it in the only shape I had for it, the Bowl of the Last Prayer. I had thought it holy and small. Now a stranger had sat down before the Ear of the whole Mountain, singing it the notes it would answer, to draw himself a map of every gallery and stair and hidden water and, though he could not know it, of the one chamber that must never be sung to at all.

Because that is the part that stopped my breath, and I said it aloud into that room full of clever frightened people. The note they had found, the shape that wore the face of a rising — it was a rising. It was the very note the five strike, behind their door, on the morning a Keeper takes the office, the note the mechanism

beneath us is tuned to answer, because answering it is what the mechanism is for. Every Ascension in eleven thousand years has been a controlled and holy sounding of the one string you must never pluck idly, struck by the only hands trained to strike it and then still it. And now a stranger with a machine, who thought he was mapping ore, had found that string by accident, and was plucking it every eleven minutes, standing back to admire the echo, with no hand near the mechanism to still what he was waking.

-
- Say the danger in one sentence, so that I have it clean on the record, whatever the record is now for.
 - The danger is that the door they are knocking on to draw their little map is the door of the thing that ends the world, and that knocking is how you open it.
-

She did not leave it at the one sentence, because Paul asked the question that lives under it, which was how long, and she would not soften it to be kind. “I do not know,” she said, “because no one has ever been ignorant enough to try it, so no one has measured it. A thing built this way does not weaken and then fail. It gathers — but only if the strokes fall in step, each new blow landing while the last one’s swing is still standing in the stone. Eleven minutes is his pace, the surveyor’s, chosen to map and not to wake; struck at that rhythm the stone shrugs the blow off between one and the next, and he draws his little chart and rouses nothing. But he will not stay at eleven minutes.” She put her finger back on the lattice of shot-points. “He will try a hundred spacings, because that is what mapping is; and somewhere in the hundred he will strike, by accident or by reading these same papers I am reading, at the one interval the Mountain itself keeps — the long, exact one the true marks are spaced to — and he will strike it again in step, and again, and that is the day the swing stops dying between his blows and begins to stand. Understand what that is and what it is not. His little charges cannot loose the thing; that takes the five, and an engine down in the dark he will never find. What his rhythm can do is *wake* it — set the sleeping mode ringing where a listening ear can hear it answer. And a weapon that has answered a stranger’s knock has told the stranger three things at once: that it is real, and where its heart lies, and that it can be reached. He will have no notion that the map he is perfecting is the map of the inside of a bomb.”

The house came apart into work after that, and I stood in the middle of it and watched people I had thought were furniture become an army. Jean-Charles came

in with paper still warm in his hand, and he was not smiling, which frightened me more than the drums had, because in all the weeks since he carried me out of the desert he had never once stopped smiling.

"It is worse than the ground," he said, and laid the warm paper down over the drum-sheets. They were pictures taken from very high up, from above the weather, but these were of nothing, of the pale empty folds of the only country I had ever called the world. And on the nothing there were things that did not belong to it. A camp, laid out in the straight and thoughtless lines of the outside. Vehicles I had no name for, squat and heavy, that Sarah named for me in a voice gone flat: "Vibrator trucks. Those four are the source." Towers of a kind. A drilling rig. And around all of it, in a ring, smaller shapes she named more slowly still. "Those are not surveyors. Surveyors do not travel with those. That is a perimeter. Someone has put a soldier's fence around a scientist's camp." And along the second ridge, the one my people had always trusted because no road reached it, more shapes yet, dug in, patient, facing inward.

Then she went very quiet, and put one finger on the picture, on the lattice of little marked points where the trucks were set to do their sounding, and she said, in a voice I had not heard her use, a voice with the cold gone out of it and something much worse in its place: "I drew that grid."

No one spoke.

"That is my lattice. That is the spacing I worked out, the one that gets you the deepest return off a body that size without wasting a season on it, the little private way I mark a shot-point, never taught to more than four living men. Someone in that camp learned to survey at my knee, or at the knee of a man who did." She took her finger off the picture as though it had burned her. "No one stumbles onto that string. This is my own hand, come loose from me, and gone south without me, and knocking."

— Who.

— I will not know for certain until I have a name, and I do not give names I am not certain of, even to you. But I will tell you the shape, because you have earned it. There is a part of the French state that has wanted this desert for as long as my family has worked it, and has spent sixty-six years being politely fed the crumbs I chose to drop. Martinez fed them for me. Martinez is old, and I have outlived my use to the people he truly serves, and a tool that has outlived its use gets copied, and then discarded, and never thanked. I find, to my surprise, that I do not hate him for it. He is a man who

spent seventy years holding doors for whoever came through them first, too old now to learn another trade, and when the state told him to hold one last door and let it shut on me, he did the only thing his whole life had fitted him to do. He warned me once, thirty years ago, at the edge of this same desert — a warning is the most a man like Martinez was ever able to afford. And then, this last time, he held the door. Lately my careful crumbs stopped being enough for them, and they took the loaf. They have my grids, and, I must assume, much of what Horizon knew, because Horizon is old too, and old houses leak. And they have decided, being soldiers and not scholars, that the way to open a locked mountain is to knock on it until it answers, and they have no idea, none, that the thing they are teaching to answer is the thing I spent my whole life making certain no single hand could ever reach.

— ... And I will say one thing more that I did not plan to say tonight. For sixty-six years I watched this alone and never once caught it, because catching it wanted two ears I did not have. It wanted a man raised inside the thing, who could stand under that knock and be honest enough to call it a made thing and not a god — that is you, Kailan, and you did it years before you sat in my chair, on a drum you never knew I kept. And it wanted an outsider with no stake and a good machine, to lay your morning against mine and see that one hand had drawn them both. That is you, Mr Morgan. I built my whole life so that no two people would ever hold enough of this between them to see it whole; and you did it at my own tea table inside a month. I ought to be furious.

— And you are not.

— No. I am something I have not been in a long time, and I have decided, tonight, not to be ashamed of it. We are, the three of us, for the first time and most likely the last, on one side of a thing. Try not to get us all killed proving it.

I have wondered since whether she told the truth in that room, or whether she was only trying to take back a machine stolen from her by cruder men. I have decided it does not matter a hundred times, and it has never stayed decided.

Paul found me at the window a little later, while she was in the next room speaking down a telephone in a language I did not own, and he kept his voice low, the fact-checker's habit still on him. "We are about to cross a desert on the orders of the one person who has told us, to our faces, that she wants the thing under it for herself. You have understood that."

"I have understood it."

"And?"

"And she is the only soul who can put us there, and she wants the soldiers off my Mountain as fiercely as we do, for reasons that are bad. I have spent my life among people whose reasons were good. My own council's reasons were spotless, and they erased me with them, and they are about to let the world end without a

mark on their conscience. I will take the bad reasons that point the right way, and I will watch the hand on the door, exactly as she taught me to.”

Paul was quiet a moment. “That is either the wisest thing you have said all week,” he said, “or it is precisely how she takes everyone.”

“Yes,” I said. “It is both at once. That is what she is.”

What is certain is that she gave them. She turned from the pictures and she was the cold woman again, and she began to spend the house the way her father had spent cities.

“Jean-Charles.” He straightened. “The parts of Horizon that are still mine, that never touched Martinez, that do not know his masters exist. Wake them. All of them. I want every route into that quarter that the camp does not know it does not control, and I want the ones it thinks it controls closed behind us as we pass. You have run the network against smugglers and competitors. Run it now against soldiers using my maps. They will not expect the maps to fight back.”

“And the boy,” Jean-Charles said, with a glance at me that had the old warmth in it and a new grief under the warmth. “You are sending the boy.”

“I am not sending him. Look at him. He was going the moment the second knock drew.”

She was right, and it shamed me that a stranger had read it off me before I had. I had spent my whole account explaining to a machine why I could never go home, why there was no place in the Mountain for a man who had pulled the cord he was told to leave. And none of it weighed anything against the pictures on the table. My people did not know. The five sat behind their walls keeping the one secret from each other, and not one of them had thought to look up, because looking up was Shield’s work and Shield had been broken on the day I broke it. Someone had to carry the word in.

“They made me a finder,” I said, mostly to myself. “They invented a mission, so that my leaving would have a lawful shape. A Veil sent out to find whether the Enemy Within was real. I took it for a lie to be rid of me.” I looked up. “And it was. But it was a lawful lie. I am the one man who can walk to that Threshold and be, by their own word, on an errand they decreed. I have findings to report. God forgive me, I have findings.”

“They will kill you,” Jean-Charles said. He said it gently, the way you say a true thing to a friend who has already made up his mind. “You told me yourself what your people do to a Veil who comes back after they have erased him. There is no door in that Mountain that opens inward for you. They opened one to push you out. They will not open it to let you back in, only to put you in the ground.”

"I know what they do," I said. "I am going because of what they do. A people who will kill a man for coming home have forgotten how to be warned. Someone has to walk in past the fear, and I am the only man alive who was born to that fear and is already standing outside it."

And beneath the reasons I gave the room, where I did not let my eyes go while they watched me, there was the reason I gave no one. Va-Sheva was behind that door. She had chosen it over me, with a box of foolish coloured sweets going soft on the table between us; she had walked back into the Mountain that unmade me because it was the only cage that left me breathing, and she was there now, under a ridge full of dug-in men and a knock arming a bomb. I had spent a week telling this house I could never go home. I had not once reckoned on home being the place where the last person who had loved me was standing directly over the fuse.

"And I cannot get in alone," I said, and I turned to Paul. "A Veil they have erased has no door. The Threshold does not open to knowledge; it opens to a mark, set into the hand, that the stone itself is made to know. On the night we walked out under the tree, and I pricked your palm, and named you Va-Paul of an order I had invented that same afternoon, you took it for a captive's game, and I let you, because the sane half of me took it for one too. But I did not invent the mark. The order I invented. The mark is old and real, and I set into your hand the one Shield sign I knew that a Threshold is built to answer, because I cannot make even a game without building a door into it. I told you it would carry you one day into the Mountain. I did not believe there would ever be a day. There is a day. It is this one. The key to my people's last gate is pricked into the hand of a man who came to Switzerland to check a fact."

Paul looked down at his own hand as though it had been lent to him for the evening.

Then it was Paul's turn, and his road there was the hardest. He stood in a room where his employer had just confessed to being the danger and was proposing to lead the rescue, and every rule of his small honest trade told him to stay behind the glass and keep writing.

"My work is the record," he said slowly. "That is the one thing in this house I have been sure of. If I go, I am no longer a man keeping a record. I am a man in the thing the record is about." He was quiet a moment. "But a record delivered to no one is paper. If they reach the Mountain before this reaches anyone who can act, then everything on these reels is only a record of how the world ended. ... And I do not want to be the man who stayed behind the glass to protect the purity of his notes while the thing in the notes was killed."

"Then stop protecting it," Sarah said, not unkindly. "Bring it with you."

He looked at the great machine that held my whole life on its spools, and he reached over and stopped it, and he handled it like an object, which it had never once been to him. He drew the reels and boxed them. And then he took from a drawer a smaller machine, a travelling one, and put it in his coat, and in doing it he stopped being the man behind the glass and became the last narrator of this account, the one who would carry it out of the room and into the sand. The interview did not end that night; it only stood up, put on its coat, and walked out into the weather it had been describing.

Va-Elise came for us before the light. She had given me my outside name in that same house, reading me a list of everything I did not know while a country I could not find slid past the window. Now she carried papers of another kind: names that were not our names, and the routes that went with them, and the small flat book of a woman who moves people across borders. She looked at me and did not smile either, and said only, "You will be three different men before the desert. Learn them on the way."

She had built it as a chain of small ordinary journeys, no single link strange enough to be remembered afterward: a charter out of a private field, a change of aircraft in a place where no official hand ever opens a bag, the family's own helicopter that crossed those hills a dozen times in a week, and then the one stretch that no cleverness could make ordinary, the last of it on animals, into folds of rock that stood on no map, the men who drew the maps never let near enough to find the seams. Amastan's line would meet us at the folds, she said, or what remained of it; the old blind man was long dead, but a door of the kind Shield spends generations making does not die with the man who is it. It teaches a son, and the son a son, and the desert keeps the office the way the Mountain keeps its own.

I looked once, going out, at the glass. The long dark pane they had watched me through when I was a specimen and not yet a man to them. I could see the room in it now, emptied, the lamp still burning over the drums, the chairs pushed back, the shape of a week of my confession still hanging in the air of it. And beyond my own reflection, faintly, the pale beginning of the day over the lake. Then Jean-Charles put his hand on my shoulder, the way he had in the desert when I was a bundle under a cloth, and he said, "Come, man. We do not make ceremony of leaving, in this house," which was a kindness, and a lie, because he was making one, and I let him, and we went out to where the machine that would carry us south was already turning its blades against the last of the dark.

CHAPTER 18

RETURN

I was three men before I was myself again. Va-Elise had given me the three the way she had once given me a name. I wore each for a stretch of the road and shed him where she had marked: a tired functionary flying south out of a private field, a mineral company's translator changing aircraft in a shed where no hand touches a bag, a nobody in a helicopter that had crossed those hills so often nobody looked up. Paul learned his own three beside me and was bad at them, being an honest man, though he had begun, somewhere over the sea, to do the thing I did: watch the people who are watching you.

And then the ordinary journeys ran out, as Sarah had promised they would, and there was the desert, and there was no more cleverness to be had from it. A man met us at the last road with animals and two others and a face wrapped against the light, young, of the veiled people. When Sarah spoke a name to him he did not answer to it but to the silence after it. Amastan was thirty years dead. This was the office that had outlived the man, a son of a son. He did not tell us his name and we did not ask. He took us up off the last road into folds of rock no map has drawn.

We travelled at night, mostly, and lay up through the day under cloth the colour of the ground. A desert crossing is thirst measured out by the mouthful, animals tended before men, a great deal of waiting. Sarah would not complain of any of it, and told me she had crossed worse ground for worse reasons and never once let a desert see her tired. But she was ninety-three, and the desert did not care what she would not let it see. By the third night she could not mount without the young

man's hands, and took them without a word, with a face that dared me to remark on it. Once I woke in the white noon to find Paul holding a cup to her mouth because her own hand shook too badly to keep the water in it, the two of them conducting the whole of it in silence so that it might not quite have happened. The young man shortened the marches after that, by a little, unasked; and Sarah let him. She knew the cost of that crossing to the mouthful, as she knew everything. She had reckoned she might not have another in her. She had come anyway. Once, when Paul went down on a scree in the dark and swore in his northern tongue, the young man put out a hand and steadied him without turning his head, the way you steady a thing you have been made responsible for and do not love. It brought us to the folds with our water nearly gone.

I will not pretend I felt nothing, coming back into that country with a false name in my mouth. Somewhere ahead of us, under a shoulder of stone, five thousand people were breathing who believed that no one alive knew they were there, and I was riding toward them with two Outsiders and a machine that had recorded my confession, to tell them the one thing their whole world was built to make unsayable.

We came on the first of it two days out from the folds, and it was one of Sarah's own.

She had told me there were stations, small and buried, manned by two or three: the far nerve-ends of the thing she had spent a lifetime growing. Men who watched the drums and the borders and the fuel, who reported north and turned a survey aside when one strayed. They were bored, as she had taught them to be, because boredom was the sound of the work going well. The young man of the sand took us to it without being asked, and I understood from the set of his shoulders that he had already been, and had wanted her to see.

The door of it stood open to the desert, which she said no door of hers had ever done. Inside, the instruments were still running: the drums still turned, the styli still drew, the little machine that made its own power still ticked in the corner. And on the paper coming off the nearest drum was the shape I had learned to dread in a Swiss house: the five even strokes, patient, arriving out of the ground while we stood there. The sounding cared nothing for the men who had kept this station. There was blood, on the floor and on the edge of the table and dried black in the heat, and no one there to have shed it, no bodies, nothing to bury. On the table a message lay half-written in a hand that had stopped in the middle of a word, the pencil still in the trough of the page where it had rolled. Someone had burned

a box of paper in the corner and done it badly, so that the middles of the sheets survived, curled and brown. Sarah knelt and turned them with one finger. She did not let any of us see her face while she did it.

"They were taken," she said at last, standing, her voice scoured flat. "Not killed. Taken. You do not burn your own papers and leave three men dead; you burn them because you are being made to leave and have a moment to deny them the drawer. And there are no bodies because bodies are of no use to them and living men are. My people know this desert, this quarter, these routes, my methods, my notation. Whoever has them now has all of that, in a room somewhere, being asked questions." She looked at the drum still drawing its patient poison. "I built a nervous system for this Mountain. And someone has begun, very methodically, to pull it out of the body while it still feels."

She had found something else in the half-burned papers; I saw it pass into her coat before any of us could ask, and she did not speak of it in that station, nor for a long while after. She told me, when there was a later, what it had been: a duty roster in the station's own careful hand, charred at the edges, listing a resupply that had come up from the south three weeks before the place fell, by a quarter and a route that only a handful of hands had ever been trusted to hold. Her network had been opened from the inside, with a key, by one of the very few she had ever cut a key for.

I did not have the whole of him that night, only the shape of the thing, and the one detail in it that could not be borne: that the only living hand which could walk us back in through the ring was, on the evidence folded into Sarah's coat, most likely the same hand that had helped to draw it.

Sarah suspected it in the station — I am certain of that from the way she folded the paper away and did not once look at him for the rest of that night — and she could prove nothing, and she said nothing, because we were two days from the Mountain and he was our only road in. The one soul in the world that a suspicion like that would unmake was climbing toward us through the stone with a lamp, and a thing unproved could not be handed her on a stair in the middle of an assault. So she carried it, with nowhere to set it down and no way yet to be sure of it.

Paul had the small machine out. He held it low, and he did not narrate to it or explain himself to it; he only let it hear the room, the tick of the instruments, the wind in the open door, Sarah's scoured voice.

We saw the camp on the fourth day, from the high broken ground the young man brought us to before dawn. I lay on cold rock beside a woman older than my

grandmother would have been and a fact-checker, and looked down at the thing that had come for my people. The first feeling it gave me, before the fear, was a kind of vertigo of recognition. I had lived inside its shape. It was built like the Mountain.

From above, Sarah said, they had eyes we could not see, and she named them by their signs: the dish on its mount that spoke to something over the weather, the pattern of the camp that assumed it was watched from the sky by its own side. Twice while we lay there something crossed the sky very high, a fleck with no sound to it that caught the early light. She said it was theirs, and that it would come again on a schedule she could have written out on the rock, and that every line and shadow in the camp had been arranged to be invisible to every eye in the world except the one that owned that fleck. It was, she said, the most costly kind of secret, the kind one state keeps from all the others; and they were spending it, all of it, on my Mountain. On the ridges, in the throats of the approaches, there were men dug in and facing inward, and instruments on tripods that were not for looking at the sky. She read the placement of every one aloud in a low even voice: what it could hear, what it waited for something to walk across. And below all of it, in the flat pan before the folds, were the trucks I had seen in the high pictures, the squat heavy ones that struck the ground, and beside them the rig, and around it the beginnings of a hole going down. Sarah told us the depth it was reaching for, because she had drawn the map it was reaching into, and she knew to the metre where the voids were, the galleries, the vents, the throat of the Hall itself.

"Above, around, below," she said. "That is how men close around a body, and they have closed it. They mean to know the whole of it, the skin and the bones and the soft parts, before they open it. They have no intention of destroying this Mountain. You do not spend this to destroy a thing; you drop one bomb on it, as my husband would have, and go home. This is the kind you mount when what is inside the thing is worth more than the thing, and you want it whole, and alive, and yours."

She read the particular parts of it to us then the way a physician reads a shadow on a plate to the family, quietly. The truck on the western ridge was there to cover an old drovers' track that comes to the Oasis from the north, the one Shield had let fall out of memory because no Outsider had ever found it; someone had told them exactly where to look for it. The deep borehole, the one with the rig over it, was aimed at a point she named a little west of the Hall and lower. She went grey giving me the reason. It was aimed at the water, at the great hidden reserve Balance kept against the lean years. A besieger who means to take a place alive must first

find its water. And the tents at the centre, ringed twice, with their own generators and marked vehicles built to carry a man lying flat, were a hospital. The sight of a hospital in that camp frightened her more than the guns, because you do not raise a hospital to raid a mine. You raise one when you expect to take prisoners you must keep alive, and to spend your own men in the taking, and to be there a long, long while.

Paul asked her, in a whisper, the fact-checker to the last of it, how she could be so certain of any of this from a mile off in poor light. She said she was certain because she had stood in a hundred camps built to that same pattern, on the buying side of them, and because a camp is a sentence, and because, God forgive her, a good half of this one was written in her own hand. Then, to the ground and not to us: "Some part of me wanted it found," she said. "The whole time. So that it would be over. So that I would not have to be the only one left holding it." "Well. It is found. And this is what found looks like." And she said nothing else for an hour.

And here is what I could not stop seeing, and finally said to Paul's machine in the dark because I could not carry it alone. The camp was divided as we are divided. The men who drilled did not speak to the men who guarded; the men who read the instruments sat apart from the men who spoke to the sky, and none went near the tents where, Sarah said, the questions were being asked of her taken people. Each knew his own piece and was walled from the rest, so that if you took one man you took only a corner. They had built, for the stealing of my people's secret, the exact instrument my people had built to keep it: a machine of parts that trust no single part with everything. We had done it out of terror, so that no one hand could ever end the world. They had done it out of thrift, so that no one hand could ever betray the operation. The same wall.

Jean-Charles had gone down in the dark and come back before the light, and he did not tell us how, and he brought two things up out of the camp with him. One was a man, gagged and bound, furious and very frightened: an ordinary man of the outside. He was a guard from the edge who had wandered a few metres too far into the dark to make water and met the smiling Frenchman who had once carried me under a cloth. The other was a flat hard case of documents and a black instrument for speaking across distance. Sarah took the case from him and opened it on the rock and went through it fast. I watched her come to a single page and stop.

"There," she said, and turned it so Paul's machine could see it though the machine could not read. "That mark. Top corner. That belongs to a compartment of the French strategic service, the heir to every arrangement my father and Martinez ever made in this desert, and it has put its own quiet mark on a page that pretends to be about minerals." She set the page down with a care that was worse than throwing it. "I have my answer. The rogue operation I hoped to find — some greedy contractor gone off the leash that I might have called off with a telephone — does not exist. This is the state. This is the loaf, and the men who took it from me have decided the yellow rock was never the prize. The prize is the thing under the rock. They know there is a mechanism. They do not know what it is. And they are drilling toward it, on my grid, with my methods, and they will reach it, because I taught the world how."

While she was still setting the page down, the black instrument woke of its own accord. A light came up on its face and it spoke, small and tinny, a young man's voice in French, bored and beginning to be worried, wanting to know why post nine had missed its check, saying that if Farid had crawled in behind a rock to sleep again he could answer for it to the sergeant himself this time. Jean-Charles laid his hand flat over the thing until the light died. Farid, then. The man bound at our feet had a name, and a post number, and a friend on a cold ridge who had covered for him one call longer than he should have; and a sergeant somewhere who would be angry in the ordinary way of sergeants; and not one of them — not the man we had taken, nor the boy calling after him, nor the sergeant — had been told they were camped three hundred metres above the end of the world. I had spent a week in a warm room beside a lake teaching a machine that the outside was a species. Here was the outside, in the dark, asking after a man who had gone off to make water and not come back, in a voice like any of ours.

The bound man made a sound behind his gag. Jean-Charles crouched by him, and did not hurt him, and said something low in French. The man went still and listened. Jean-Charles turned back to us and said, "He will talk. He is a fence-sitter, a man who thinks he is guarding a mine. He will tell us what little he has been given. The trouble will be that it is little."

He gave Jean-Charles very little, and he gave it slowly, and none of it was worth anything by itself, because he was a man kept as ignorant as the enemy could contrive; and that ignorance, laid out, was the thing that told me everything. He knew his own watch and the two beside it and no other. He had been told it was a mineral survey of the highest secrecy. He knew there were people in the ground ahead of them — primitives, a lost tribe, to be handled without loss of life — and

I marked the word as it came across, because *primitive* is the exact word my own scripture keeps for the outside, aimed the other way. He knew his sappers had strange orders they grumbled over — *intact, everything intact, break nothing* — and he did not know why, and had not been let to know why.

I asked Jean-Charles to put three questions to him, not for their answers but for the walls they would strike. Who told you to take no life. A different officer than the one who set the charges. Who is allowed to say the digging may stop. A cell you have never seen. Who among you may speak to the men on the far ridge. No one; they are a separate command.

“They mean to take the five alive,” I said, and Sarah opened her eyes, because it was mine to see and I had seen it. “Not five men they can name. Five *functions* — the ones the work cannot proceed without, marked by what each one does and not by any face. They have understood that the machine is worked by five hands that no single hand may join, and they mean to seize the whole set living and make it answer to a new one. They want the key with the keepers still hanging on the ring. It is the one crime the Beast was built to make impossible, and they are three hundred metres from committing it, and they do not even know that is what they are doing.”

He looked at me then, and the grief was in his face again under the competence. “The route is open. There is a seam the young man knows that their sensors do not yet cover, on the far side, and it will close within the day when they finish the ring. We go now, or we do not go.”

Va-Sheva met us inside the skin of the Mountain. I had thought, all the way up the last dark seam, about what I would do when I saw her, and in the event I did nothing, because she gave me nothing to do it to. She was standing in a low stone chamber I half remembered, in the plain grey of Shield, with two wardens behind her and a lamp between us. She looked at me the way Shield is trained to look, at the spaces around a person and not the person, weighing what I had brought in before she would let herself weigh me.

I had carried out of this Mountain the memory of a woman coming apart in a cell, and I had feared that I was riding back to finish breaking her by arriving. Whatever she had done in the half-year since she chose the cage over me, she had done it fully. The hands were steady. The voice, when it came, was an office speaking.

“You were sent out to find whether the enemy within was real,” she said. “Shield’s own writ, sealed by the council that could not agree to keep you. You

come back with two Outsiders, one of them the maker of the very network that hunts us, and a machine that has recorded God knows what, up a seam no Veil is shown, in the middle hour of an attack this Mountain does not yet know it is under." A silence. "By every law I hold, I should have you killed at this lamp, and them with you, and the seam sealed behind your bodies."

"Then do it," I said, "or hear me, but decide now, because the woman beside me can tell you the depth of the hole they are drilling and the day it reaches the Hall, and no one else alive can, and every breath you spend deciding is a breath she is not spending saving your people."

She looked at Sarah, and Sarah looked back, two women who had each spent a lifetime holding a wall. Something passed between them that had no warmth in it and a great deal of recognition. And Va-Sheva said, to me, not to her, "Jean-Charles vouches for the breach."

"He does."

"I trust his hands. I have worked beside them." She had never told me that; there was a whole history in it I would never now have time to learn. "I do not trust hers, and I am about to have to." She gave a low command to a warden, and looked back at me. For one breath only the office slipped. What showed under it was something worse than grief and steadier: the look of a person who has already grieved a thing all the way to the end and put it away where it can no longer be used against them. "I contained you to keep you breathing," she said. "I did not do it so that you could bring the breathing back inside the wall. That was cruel of you. We will not speak of it again. Follow, and touch nothing, and keep your Outsiders between us."

She led us up through Shield's own ways, narrow and unlovely and cut for defence and for nothing else. As we climbed she spent no breath on me and every breath on the thing in hand, throwing questions back over her shoulder that only Sarah could answer. In the shape of the questions I heard how badly Shield already knew it was losing. How deep. How many. How long since the drilling had begun. Whether a borehole could be fouled from within, or turned, or heard coming in time to clear the galleries beneath it. Sarah answered every one, flat and fast and without a flinch, an enemy of this Mountain telling its Shield exactly how she would take the place if she stood in the camp instead of the corridor, because she was the one who had taught the camp how.

"The council will have to hear all of it," Va-Sheva said, and did not slow on the stair. "You. Her. The machine. Justice will not move a hand's breadth without

the whole of it laid out in order, and in this Mountain nothing moves at all until Justice has moved first. They cast you out with one voice, all five agreed. And now I am to carry you back into the sealed hall, and set an Outsider at your side, and the woman who built our death at her other side, and ask the five to believe the three of you. On the night the walls begin to come down.”

Once, where the stair turned and the others were out of hearing, she spoke without turning her head. “Is it true, what the containment cost you. Va-Elise wrote to me that you did not speak for eleven days.” I told her that it was true. “Good,” she said, and there was no cruelty in it; it was Shield; it was a woman confirming that a wall had held under load. “Then it worked. You are breathing. I was right to do it. And I will not forgive myself for having been right, for as long as I have left to live. Do not make me say more than that. I have a Mountain to lose tonight, and I cannot lose you as well and be of any use to it.” And she went on up the stair.

She took us by the back galleries, the grey defended ones that no festival ever sees, but there was a single place where the route crossed an open stair above the common wards, and for the length of that one crossing I saw my people again. It was an ordinary evening down there. Lamps at the food-stalls. A line of small children being walked somewhere in pairs by a woman with a switch she plainly never used. Two men arguing without heat over the price of something in a basket. And the smell of the evening bread came up warm around us, the same bread that had risen in this Mountain every evening for eleven thousand years and would go on rising, every soul down there believed, for eleven thousand more. I stood on the stair above them with an Outsider’s false papers in my coat and the news of their ending in my mouth, and I could have shouted it down to them, and it would have saved not one of them, because they had been raised from birth to be unable to hear it. Va-Sheva did not let me stop walking. “They do not know,” she said, very low, at my shoulder. “And they will not learn it from you, tonight, on a stair. Walk.” So I walked, and the warm smell of the bread came up after us and thinned as we climbed and was gone.

We had not gone much further when the Mountain took the first blow.

It came up through the stone into the soles of my feet and the bones of my jaw, one deep flat blow with nothing of the knock in it. Dust came down from a seam overhead the way it had come down once over a boy who told himself the

Mountain was settling. One of the wardens put a hand to the wall. Somewhere off through the rock there was a long grinding sound, and then a nearer one, sharper, the particular sound of worked stone failing along a line men had cut true a hundred generations ago.

Sarah had gone rigid, her head turned, reading it. "That was not a sounding," she said. "That was a charge. They have put an explosive down one of the boreholes and fired it, close, to break a way in, or to see what breaks." She looked at Va-Sheva. "What is there? On the north-western arc, shallow, near the surface. What did they just reach?"

And Va-Sheva, who watched the spaces between things and always had, was already moving toward the sound, her voice gone hard with the first real fear I had heard in it, throwing the answer back over her shoulder as she went.

"Faith," she said. "That is a Faith passage. That is the road to the Hall."

And she was gone into the dark toward it, Jean-Charles a pace behind her with a warden, Sarah after them already calling for a lamp and a plan of the north-western arc. For one breath only Paul and I stood still in the emptying chamber. I put my hand flat on the cold stone of the Mountain that had made me and unmade me and would now be opened by the very outside I had spent a week describing to a machine in a warm room beside a lake. Under my palm the stone was moving. Not much. A tremor, deep and slow and wrong, the settling of a thing that had never in eleven thousand years had any cause to settle. Paul touched my arm, the recorder still turning in his other hand, catching the grind of the wounded rock for whoever might one day need to know exactly how the end began. And we ran toward the lamps, and toward the sound, and toward my people, who believed they could never be reached.

CHAPTER 19

SEAL

They convened the five in the sealed hearing-chamber below the Hall, the round low room with the single lamp and the five seats cut into the living rock that I had never expected to see, because a Veil does not see it. A Veil waits outside while the offices decide what is too large for one office. I saw it because I was the thing being decided. They brought me in between two Shield wardens with my hands bound, which was law, and Paul and Sarah unbound, which was not, which was Va-Sheva's doing.

The chamber was smaller than the fear of it. All my life the sealed hearing had been a place the size of God in my imagining, and it was in truth a round room a strong man could cross in ten strides. That smallness was the fear of it: everything my world was had ever been decided by five people close enough to touch. The lamp between them was the token-flame that Faith keeps, and it threw the Keepers' shadows up the curved wall. The shadows shifted whenever the Mountain was struck, a deep flat knock coming up through the floor into the soles of my bound feet.

The five were older than the last time I had stood before them, and one I had helped to make. Ka-Raedin of Light sat under the dark aperture that is Light's, my Keeper, the man whose ascension I had watched from beneath the pillar, in whose office I had served until I pulled the cord I was told to leave. He would not look at me: his star witness against the end of the world was the greatest heretic his

office had produced in living memory, and every word I spoke made him weaker, and he needed those words more than any of them.

Ka-Orun of Justice spoke first, because in that chamber Justice always speaks first and last, and everything true happens between. "You were sent out under seal," he said, "to determine whether the Enemy Within was real. The council that sent you could not lawfully agree to end you, and so it agreed to use you, and it wrote you an errand, and put you out of the Threshold with it in your mouth. That errand still stands. It has never been revoked, because no one believed there would ever be a finding to revoke it for." He let that sit. "Make your finding."

And now I stood in the one room that could not unsay its own seal, and the enemy the errand had invented was four weeks' walk become four hundred metres, and drilling.

I made my finding. I kept it plain, the way Paul had taught me, and I gave them the camp: the trucks that struck the ground, the rig and the hole going down, the men dug in on the ridges facing inward, the eye in the sky that owned it. I gave them the drovers' road Shield had let fall from memory and the enemy had come to straight, as though handed a map. I told them the shape of the danger without yet its source, because its source stood at my shoulder in Outsider's clothes and I wanted the Mountain to fear the danger before it hated the woman.

They made me give it twice, and the second time in the words of measurement, because a Keeper does not move on a story, he moves on a quantity. How many men. I did not know; hundreds, and more coming. How deep the hole. Sarah answered that one, to the metre, and the number went round the five faces and altered every one, because it had a date fastened to it: the day the hole would reach the Hall. I watched Ka-Leth of Balance do the arithmetic behind her eyes and go entirely still. What could the eye see. Everything, I told them, that was not underground. And Ka-Dhavar of Shield said, low, that this was the first war in the Mountain's history in which the enemy could see the top of the board while the Mountain saw only the one square it stood on; and no one answered.

Ka-Dhavar of Shield believed me before I finished, because Shield had felt it for a season already, in the small wrong tremors, in the outer stations gone silent, in the sense every good watchman has of being watched. "I have said this table was under an eye for two years," he said, "and I was told I was seeing shapes in the dark, which is Shield's disease. I take no pleasure in the shapes having faces now." He was the only one of the five who did not seem afraid, because he had done his being-afraid in private, over years, while the others slept behind the seal.

Ka-Raedin of Light would not take my finding on my word, and it cost him to be right. "Light does not act on a witness's fear," he said, still not looking at me. "Light acts on a thing seen twice, by two, and verified. This man has given us a picture, and a picture is a claim. I have built my whole office on the difference between a claim and a proof, and I will not spend the Mountain on the word of" — and here he stopped, and chose the wound — "on the word of the finest mind my office ever ruined. Show me the proof, and I am with you before Justice finishes speaking. Give me only his fear, and I am the last door that holds."

Ka-Leth of Balance did not argue whether the enemy was real. Balance never argues whether; Balance argues how much, and how long. "Say it is all true," she said, heavy and slow. "Then I am already counting. Sealing buys us a slower arithmetic with a worse end if help does not come, and no help is coming, because there is no one to come. I do not need to know whether we can shut the door. I need to know what we eat behind it, and for how long, and what is left of us when the stores run out."

And Ka-Elun of Faith, who was old now, older than the woman I had watched wounded at the throat, read it through the one instrument Faith trusts, the Mountain itself. "The stone is answering wrong," she said, and her voice was the same voice that had blessed a thousand mornings, gone thin. "I have listened to this Mountain speak for seventy years. It has one long slow sentence it says, that I was taught to hear before I was taught to read, and for a season now there has been another voice under it, striking, and the stone flinching, and answering, and I told myself it was the Mountain settling." She looked at me, and she knew me, the boy from under the pillar. "You heard it too. As a child. You always had the ear, and Light took you instead of Faith, and I have wondered since whether that was the first mistake."

Ka-Raedin pressed me for proof, and I had only a heretic, an enemy, and a device, which he said were three reasons to doubt and not one to believe; and he was right, with the rightness of a man refusing to leave a rising flood until someone proves the water is water. Only Shield and Faith spoke as though it were already upon us; the other three still held, for a few minutes more, the luxury of debating whether the roof was coming down while it came.

It was Ka-Leth of Balance who forced the first hard thing open, because Balance always must. "Say we seal," she said. "Then hear what sealing is, since no one else at this table will say it. We have air for the whole population, turned and cleaned, for a long while but not without end. The living water is deep, but not endless. And the other water, the great reserve, is ballast, and the day we broach

it for thirst is the day we unbalance the very thing it was laid down to balance. I have grain and oil and salt fish against the lean years, and I know them to the sack, and I can feed five thousand souls behind a shut door for a measured time, and at the end of that time, if no help has come, and none is coming, we do not open the door onto a rescued world; we open it, if at all, onto whatever the outside has become while we lay buried, or we are a tomb that took a long while to fill." She turned her heavy face to Justice. "I do not argue against the Seal. I tell you only that there is no safe answer left in this Mountain tonight. There is only which terrible thing we choose on purpose."

It was Justice who turned the room toward Sarah, because Justice had heard, in my careful finding, the shape of the thing I was walking around.

"You have told us what is at the gate," Ka-Orun said. "You have not told us how it found the gate. A thing eleven thousand years hidden is not stumbled upon by soldiers with a drill. Someone drew them the map. And you have brought into this chamber, unbound, against every law I hold, two people of the outside, and you have set one of them at your shoulder as though her word were worth a Veil's, and I will now ask the question you have been arranging the room to keep me from asking. Who is she."

I could have answered; I had it ready, the whole of it. But Paul spoke first, from where he stood with the little machine still turning in his coat.

"She will tell it herself," Paul said, "or it is worth nothing. It only counts from the mouth that lived it. Ask her. And Keeper — when she answers, listen the way you would listen to an enemy who has decided to stop lying. That is the only honest you are going to get from her."

So they asked her, and she told them, and I will not set it all down again, because you have had it from her already. But it was a different thing to watch her say it into that chamber, to the faces of the people whose secret she had spent her life stealing. She did not perform it. Paul and I had to draw each admission from her by name, because left to herself she would have given them the architecture and spared them the appetite. And it was the appetite they needed to believe: that she had found them by listening; that she had built a sixty-year machine to reach into the one place made to keep any hand from reaching in, and told herself, the whole time, that she was building a wall.

"Tell them why the blind Keeper let you in," I said, "and do not dress it as mercy to the Mountain." And she said, "He let me in because Shield needed eyes on a world that had just learned to make a sun, and I could give him those eyes, and he

was blind and out of better doors.” “And what did you take that he did not offer.” “Everything he did not nail down. And one or two things he did.” “And when you left him,” Paul said, quiet and relentless, “what did you want.” She was silent a moment, and then she gave them the true thing. “More,” she said. “I wanted more. I have wanted the whole of it every day of my life since, and the single reason I am on your side of this table tonight is that a hand worse than mine closed on it first.”

Ka-Leth of Balance made a low sound in her chest. “You let an Outsider say the word *whole* in this chamber,” she said to Justice, “and did not have her struck down where she stands.” “I let her say it,” Ka-Orun answered, “because she is the finding: the thing the Beast was made against, telling us there is now a worse one at the gate. Strike her down and we blind ourselves to the only mind that has ever mapped the mind that hunts us. Justice keeps her breathing. Justice will reckon what she is owed on the day there is a world left to owe her in.”

Va-Sheva spoke then, once, from where she stood along the wall, because a Veil does not speak in the sealed chamber unless an office bids her, and Ka-Dhavar of Shield bid her. “I brought them in,” she said. “The breach is mine. I will answer for it after, if there is an after. I vouch for the hands of the Outsider they call Jean-Charles. Worked beside them, against smugglers. They did not once reach for the thing they stood next to. I do not vouch for the woman. Only this of her: everything she has told this chamber, I have set against what Shield already knew, and it has not failed one test. That is worse than if it had.” She stepped back to the stone.

“And the men at the gate,” Ka-Orun said, when she had finished. “Are they your hand.”

“They were,” she said. “They are the loaf that grew from my crumbs. They have my grids, my methods, my notation, and the parts of Horizon that leaked. They are not under my control, and I will not insult this chamber by pretending I came here to save you out of the goodness of a heart I have never claimed to own. I came because they took the thing from me, and because a woman who has spent her life making certain no one hand could hold the whole cannot, at the end of it, bear to watch the whole taken by a hand worse than her own.” She looked at the five of them, one to the next. “Hate me at your leisure. You do not have the leisure now. I am the only person alive who can tell you what they will do next, because it is what I would do, and we are, God help us all, the same animal.”

The proof Light demanded came up out of the dark while she was still speaking, carried by a Shield warden and set on the stone before Ka-Orun: the flat hard case Jean-Charles had taken off the desert, and the black instrument for speaking across distance, and the single page with the mark in its corner.

Paul authenticated it, because his whole trade was whether a thing is what it claims to be. He did it slowly and without drama, showing them the marks a forgery does not carry, the countersignatures, the small stupid true details no one inventing a thing thinks to invent. And Sarah read the operational vocabulary aloud, and translated each into what it meant.

There was a cell for the drilling, a cell for the reading of what it struck, a cell for the men on the ridges, and a cell walled from all the others for what the orders called the assets. And the assets were people, and the people were us. There was a schedule for the taking, and a protocol, a whole careful page of it, for keeping taken persons alive and lucid under questioning. And there was a line she read to them twice that set aside resources for the preservation of the primary control personnel, five in number. And a second line for the securing of the central asset intact and the prevention of its actuation by the incumbent operators. "The incumbent operators," she said, and let it lie in the chamber a moment. "That is what they have called you, in a room in a language none of you will ever hear. It is the phrase a man uses for a hand he intends to lift off a machine and replace with his own."

The plan did not order the Mountain destroyed. They knew, then, that there was an activation, and feared it, and meant to hold the thing in the one state where only they could work it.

Ka-Orun did not rule then, though the room leaned toward it. He set both hands flat on the stone and was quiet long enough that I understood he had walked up against the one thing his office could not do.

"I can find the condition met," he said at last. "I cannot find it met alone, and I cannot find it met by five, and you will hear why. To rule the Beast lawful I must weigh the whole of it at once: what the enemy is and intends, and how long the stores would hold behind a Seal, and whether the engine can still be aimed and worked at all, and the law and sequence of the firing, and the timing that Faith alone can hear. Five things. And no one of us may lawfully hold more than his own. Shield may not be told Balance's count, nor Balance be shown Light's aiming. That stands older than custom; it is the founding law, the very thing the Beast was built to keep — that no single hand ever hold the whole, not even to save it. I am

asked, on the last night, to make the largest ruling the record has ever held, and the law forbids me the one vantage from which it could honestly be made.”

“Then the law has beaten us,” Ka-Leth said, “over nothing, at the end.”

“The law has a door in it, cut for exactly this, and opened only twice before my time.” Ka-Orun’s voice did not rise. “The Threshold Exception. When a danger from outside cannot be met without knowledge that no office within may lawfully gather, the Mountain may admit a thing across the Threshold to hold what the offices may not: not a Keeper, not a Veil, not a sixth hand upon the machine — a witness. One who belongs to no Kahir, holds no key, turns no valve, gives no order, and may therefore be told everything precisely because he can do nothing with it. Shield opened that door once, a lifetime past, to let an Outsider map the sky above us.” Now he looked at Sarah, and then away. “Tonight I open it wider than it has ever been opened. I know the price of it. I open it anyway, because the alternative is to lose the world by procedure.”

And then Shield did a thing I had forgotten I had made possible. Va-Sheva crossed to Paul, took his right hand, and turned the palm up to the lamp. And there, under the grime of the crossing, was a small white scar her office knew and mine had never been taught — the Shield sign a Threshold is built to answer, that I had pricked into him under a tree in another country and named a captive’s game. “A Veil of Light set this,” she said, and it was not a question, and there was a whole scandal folded into the flatness of her voice, for a Veil of Light has no right to the sign. She let the hand go. “The law says the Threshold opens to a mark set into the hand,” she said to Justice. “It is set. Not for the tunnels — he came in by the seam like a thief, as we all did. For this hour, and no other. He has carried our last door in his palm since before he believed we were real.” And I watched Ka-Orun look from the scar to me.

He turned to Paul, and the whole chamber turned with him. “You. You belong to no office of mine; you hold no lever of this place and never shall; and you have spent a week doing the one thing my record was built to do and does badly: take accounts that will not touch and lay them side by side until the truth stands up between them. I will have each of my Keepers tell you, alone, the one thing his office may tell no other. You will hold all five. You will tell me how they fit. And by your holding — not by mine, for mine is forbidden — I will be able to rule. You will act on none of it. You will decide nothing. You will carry the whole across the space between us, because you are the single creature in this room the law permits to carry it. Will you take it?”

Paul was quiet a moment — the man who had come to check whether one impossible person was real, asked now to hold an impossible world. “I will hold it,” he said. “I will touch nothing. But hear what you are making, Keeper, before you make it. The instant I hold your five, I am the most dangerous object in this Mountain, because I will be the only one in it who holds the whole — the exact thing you have killed men for eleven thousand years to prevent. You are trusting the wall you built against your own hands to hold against a stranger’s. Tonight.” “I know what I am making,” Ka-Orun said. “I am making the thing my office was always going to need and was always forbidden to keep. Do it anyway.”

So they deposed to him, one at a time, the way the record takes a witness, in the flinching dark, and Paul held the small machine low and did not once look up. Shield gave him the enemy: the disposition above, the ring, the hour it would close. Balance gave him the count: the stores, the two waters, the last day of each. Light — Ka-Raedin, who an hour before would spend nothing on my word — gave him the deep surfaces, and whether the thing could still be aimed true through the roots of the world. Justice gave him the law of the firing, and the one abort, and the stroke past which there is no abort. And Ka-Elun of Faith, still alive then, gave him the last fragment and the strangest: the timing, the phase, the way the returning stroke must be heard and answered, the note beneath the note. The whole of what Faith alone had ever been trusted to carry, set into the ear of an Outsider because there was, that night, no other ear the law would suffer it into. And Paul held all five, and the machine turned.

Then Ka-Orun asked him the one question — how the five fit — and Paul did not answer it. He set the little machine on the stone where they could all see it turning. He said that he had spent a week listening to clever people explain why a thing was necessary, and that necessary was a word that did its worst work in rooms where nobody had bothered to count the roads out. “I hold your five,” he said. “I am the only one here who does. So I am going to walk every road I can see out of this Mountain, and you are going to close them in front of me, one at a time, out loud, with reasons. If you cannot close one of them, then it is open, and what you are about to do is murder with paperwork.”

“Balance,” he said. “The simplest road. We go down tonight and we break it. Flood the deep chamber, wreck the throat, put the engine past any hand alive, theirs or yours. They came for a working machine. Give them a ruin and they have crossed a desert for nothing.”

Ka-Leth of Balance did not take offence at being asked, which I have thought about since. "You are picturing an engine standing in a room," she said. "It stands nowhere. It is the deep water and the deep heat and the throat and the gates, and that water is the water five thousand people drink, and that heat is the only reason a sealed city does not freeze in a season. Break the engine and you have broken the well and the hearth in the same stroke. We would sit behind a shut door in the dark, counting the last of the stores, and the men above would dig down at their leisure into a Mountain too weak to refuse them anything."

"Then leave the water alone," Paul said, and he did not sit down. "The aim. You have told me this thing only strikes where it strikes because the Mountain sits where it sits, and that Light has spent eleven thousand years keeping the count of exactly where that is. So go down tonight and destroy the count. Break the sunk marks, cut the sight-lines, burn the tables, take a hammer to every fixed point in the galleries. They keep their well and their hearth and five thousand people drinking, and what the enemy inherits is a machine that nobody alive can prove is pointed at anything."

Ka-Raedin of Light had said nothing since he was given his second witness. He said, "You have been listening better than most of my Veils ever did. That is my office you have just described, and you are right that it is the soft place in it." He turned his hands over on the stone. "Hear why it fails. A position is a fact about the world, and the world goes on holding it after we have burned every paper we own. The marks only carry the count; they do not make it. Break all of them tonight and the Mountain still sits precisely where it sat this morning, and any patient man can take the position again from the beginning — the sky cannot be broken, and the sun still comes down that shaft once a year and trues the mark at the bottom of it whatever we do." He let that sit. "I have a Veil who could retake it in one cold night with his two hands and tell you to the pace where we stand. He is in this chamber in irons. If a boy we broke can do it with a lamp, a state with instruments and a season and the whole Mountain to work in can do it better."

"Then fire it," Paul said, "and aim it at nothing. You have a whole ocean. You have two poles no one lives on. If the thing must go off to be kept from them, send it into empty water and drown a reef instead of a world."

Ka-Raedin did not turn from the stone. "You are picturing a barrel to point. There is none. I do not aim the Beast; the Earth aims it. It goes out through the core to the one place on the far skin of the world exactly opposite where this Mountain stands. I cannot send it into an empty sea, because the sea it falls into was chosen when the Mountain was set. The Mountain was set where it stands

so that the far end of its blow would come down on a seam already broken open beneath the ocean, inside a ring of fire that wants only a push to fail. It was made to be the one weapon that could never be pointed anywhere harmless, and made so on purpose, so that no frightened Keeper on no last night could ever make it a small mercy. The aim is older than every office in this room. We cannot move the Mountain by morning.”

“Then the hands,” Paul said. “Their orders name five people. Preserve the primary control personnel. So take the five out of their reach — scatter them through the deep wards, hide them, and if it truly comes to the end of the world, this Mountain has killed Keepers before and called it law. No operators, no firing. They hold a machine nobody can work.”

“For a season,” Ka-Dhavar of Shield said. “Each office is a line, Mr Morgan. Every one has taught a child what it knows since before your species learned to plant. Kill the five and you buy a year. You leave them the Mountain, the wards, the scripture that is a working manual set to hymns, and all the time in the world to find the next boy who can hear the stone. And you will have done their disarming for them.”

“Then out,” Paul said. “All of you. Tonight, through the outer folds, before the ring closes.”

Balance answered that one with a number, because Balance answers everything with a number. Five thousand souls, of whom near a third were children or too old to walk a desert, into open sand, inside a ring of soldiers who had an eye in the sky and a road already mapped. And Shield finished it, quietly. “And the first of us they photograph in the open,” Ka-Dhavar said, “ends the secret more completely than the drill ever could.”

It was Sarah who offered the last road, and she offered it standing, and she offered the only thing she had ever had that was worth more than her money. “Then use me,” she said. “I can have this on every desk in six countries by Thursday, with proof and provenance: my own sixty-six years of instrument records, my name on it, which still means something in rooms that matter. A thing the whole world is looking at cannot be quietly taken by one service in a desert. Make it too famous to seize. I will spend everything I have and everything I am, and I will go to prison for the way I got it, and gladly.”

And Ka-Orun of Justice answered her, and did it without cruelty, which made it worse. “And what arrives, in the six countries, on Friday.” He waited until she had it. “You are the argument against yourself, madam. You are one woman, with one fortune and one ear, and you heard us once by accident and spent sixty-six

years reaching in. You are the gentlest thing that has ever come at us. Multiply yourself by every state that reads your Thursday paper. You would be firing the starting gun on a race and calling it a crowd to hide in, and the prize is a machine that ends worlds, and the winner would be whoever is least troubled by how they get it. Your disclosure is our capture, with more hands on it and no law over any of them.”

Sarah did not argue. I watched her take it, and set it down.

“Negotiate,” Paul said, quieter now. “Give them something. A part.”

“With whom,” Ka-Dhavar said. “You read their own paper to us. They are built as we are, in cells that are not told of one another. There is no man out there with the standing to accept a bargain, only men with orders. And a part is what we have spent eleven thousand years refusing to give any single hand, including our own. There is no small piece of this.”

“And there is no one over the men with orders who will hear you, either,” Sarah said. She had not spoken since Justice named her the finding, and she spoke now from the wall, without moving into the light. “I know, because I have already asked him. Weeks ago — before ever I went to fetch this boy and his account — when I first understood whose hand had come loose on my grid, I went up my own old ladder as far as it climbs. Past Martinez, who told me it had stopped being mine to call off, if it had ever been. Past the quiet room they keep for people like me, five men at a table who let me talk for an hour and promised me nothing. To the one man in Paris with the standing to lift a telephone and end it in a sentence. I told him what they were knocking on — plainly, in the language he would believe — on the chance that a man who truly grasped it would be frightened enough to stop.”

“He was not frightened. He was worse; he was reasonable. He told me — and I have not been able to set it down since — that no people alive, having learned that a thing able to end the world had sat unanswerable under the sand for eleven thousand years, ruled by no law any of them had a hand in, telling no one, could be asked to learn that and go back to sleep, and leave the ending of everything in a hand they could not see and had not chosen and could never reach. That I of all women should understand him, having heard it once myself and spent sixty-six years reaching in, and called that reaching my life’s work. That they were only the many, where I had been the one. That you cannot ask a species to kneel to a god it did not elect. And that whatever came now was on the Mountain that had made itself unanswerable, and on me who had kept its secret — and not on the men who had finally heard the knock and would not lie back down under it.”

She looked, for the first time, at the five. "He was not a monster. I have dealt with monsters; they are easier. He was a decent, clever, frightened man doing for his people the exact thing you are about to do for yours, and he was as right as you are, and there was no more give in him than there is in this chamber. That is the door you would have me knock on again. I have knocked on it. It is this door, opening the other way."

"Then wait," Paul said. "For better evidence. For them to make a mistake."

"The hole reaches the Hall in eleven days," Ka-Leth said. "Justice has told you where the last abort lies. After that stroke there is no stopping it, and it falls well before the eleventh day. You are asking me to spend the only nights we have on the hope that a competent enemy becomes incompetent."

"Then none of it matters," Paul said, "because they have already seen it. Their drill has struck your galleries; their readers have the shape of it; for all you know a man on that ridge has already said it into a wire, and it is halfway to a capital tonight. You would end the world to keep a secret that left the building a week ago."

"The secret that we exist left the building the hour the drill first bit," Ka-Dhavar said. "That one we cannot call back, and I have not once pretended in this chamber that we could; my office has a saying for it, that there is no shut door, only a slow one. But hear their own orders, the page read out here an hour ago: take the operators alive, secure the mechanism intact, prevent its actuation. That is not the order a man writes when he holds the weapon. It is the order a man writes when he has found the door and knows the key is still on the inside of it. They have the fact of us. They do not have the working of us — the aim, the phase, the timed firing that lives in five heads and one Mountain and nowhere else on the earth — and tonight is the last night it can be kept from walking out into the one hand that has crossed a world to take it. We do not fire to keep a secret; the secret is lost. We fire to deny a weapon. They are different killings, Mr Morgan, and only the second is still ours to make."

"Then buy time with it," Paul said. "Everything you have shown me tonight can buy a season, a year, a hundred years — so buy them. Wreck the deep, drown the engine, put the five who can work it beyond any reach, theirs or your own, and take the aim and the phase down into the dark with you. Do all of it at once and mean it. Perhaps the working of you dies in the ruin. Perhaps the ruin sets them back a lifetime. You do not know, and neither do I. But not one harbour on the far side of the world burns tonight, and that is a thing you can still choose."

"It might hold," Ka-Raedin said, and it cost him, because it was the first road all night that could not simply be shut. "I will not tell you it cannot. I will give you the shape of the wager, since the reckoning is my office. One chance in five, at my most honest, that the working of us dies in that ruin and never rises. Four in five that a state which has come this far digs the aim back out of the rubble, or takes it fresh off the sky that cannot be broken, as a boy of mine once took it in a single cold night — and holds it then in one hand, with no law over that hand and a hundred years of grievance to spend. That is what you are asking us to weigh: the one denial we are certain of, tonight, against the hope that the ablest enemy we have ever faced stays a fool for a century."

Paul stood a while with his hands on the stone, and before he could speak Ka-Leth of Balance did a thing no one had asked of her. "Put the number in the record, Sa-Tavan," she said, "and put my name against it, because counting is what I am for and I will be the one who counted this." She did not look at Paul. "We are five thousand and eleven souls behind this door tonight; I have the roll in my own hand and I know every figure in it. Out there they are three thousand millions, or four, or some number past the end of my arithmetic, and every one of them eats, and sleeps, and is owed something by somebody. That is the trade. I have turned it over for nine days and I can make it come out no other way, and I want it written on the tablet that I knew the size of it when I said yes." Then she did look up. "You asked us whether we had counted, Mr Morgan. We counted. It does not help."

"Then I have nothing," he said at last, and he said it to the machine as much as to them, so that it would be on the reel. "Let the record show that the roads were counted, and that a man from outside counted them, and that they were closed one by one by people who did not want them closed. And let it show that I think you are about to do the worst thing that has ever been done, and that the one road I found that did not end the world, they weighed, and set down, and I cannot swear to you they were wrong." And then he answered Ka-Orun's question in the flat plain voice he kept for true things, and the answer the five had built between them came to a single sentence: that there was one other road — Ka-Raedin's wager — and that they would not take it. They chose instead the thing that was certain, which was the fire, and the millions it would fall on. What I have turned over every year since is not whether there was another road; there was. It is whether the refusing of it was the courage the hour demanded or the last and largest cowardice the Mountain ever taught its keepers, and I will die not knowing. Only then did Justice rule.

"There it is," Ka-Orun said, into the silence, and his voice had the flatness of a man who has stopped weighing and begun to rule. "Hear the distinction, all of you, because everything now turns on it, and Justice will state it once. An enemy who comes to destroy the Mountain is a thing Shield may fight. We have always been ready to be destroyed; the Book is half made of it; a Mountain that falls keeps its secret in the falling. But this enemy has not come to destroy us. It has come to take the five, and the mechanism, and the key, and to hold in a single hand the thing this entire world was built across eleven thousand years to make certain no single hand could ever hold. And an enemy who comes to possess the whole cannot be fought, and cannot be endured, and above all cannot be allowed to leave. There is only one lawful answer to a hand closing on the whole, and it is the answer the Beast was made to be."

Sa-Tavan of Justice, who had set my exile into the record with the same hand, took up the clay and set it down too, every word, pressing the marks into the wet tablet that Justice keeps because Justice trusts no memory living, not even its own. And I stood bound and watched a man I had known write out, calmly, in an unhurried hand, the lawful reasons for the ending of the world.

The charge that killed Ka-Elun came while Justice was still speaking. I have wondered ever since whether the enemy timed it, whether some reader in that camp had found an acoustic road into the Hall and fired down it precisely then, or whether it was only the blind arithmetic of the drilling arriving where it had always been going to arrive. What I know is that there was a blow unlike the others, sharper and nearer and up. A sound came down the Faith passage into the chamber with none of the grinding of stone on stone in it: stone letting go of stone along a line cut true a hundred generations before any of us. And then the roof of the passage above the old woman's seat came down.

Shield was moving before the dust, Va-Sheva first, throwing herself and two wardens at the collapse. I was moving too, my bound hands useless. A corner of the same fall caught Paul's leg where he crouched over the machine; he went down, made no sound, and kept the reel turning. We got stone off her, and it was not enough. Ka-Elun of Faith, who had risen wounded at the throat before a boy who never forgot it, who had the ear that heard the enemy's voice under the Mountain's own, lay in the ruin of the road to her own Hall. She was not afraid. She looked for me in the dust, and found me, and I put my bound hands against the side of her face. And she said, so low that only I and the machine in Paul's coat could have caught it, "You should have been Faith." And then she was gone, and

the office of Faith went partway with her. Va-Maera, the Veil of Faith, who had been at her side, was dragged living from the same stone, the hearing gone out of both ears for good and her mind sunk, for those days, too deep to reach. There was no one left in the whole Mountain who could then do the thing Faith does, which is to listen to the stone and know the note and say it back.

I had watched her rise into her office when I was fifteen and believed my brightness made me good; I watched her leave it under a fallen roof with the outside pouring in through the wound.

And Ka-Raedin of Light, who an hour before had asked me for a thing seen twice by two, stood in the dust of the fallen passage and looked up at the outside light coming down grey through the wound. And he said, to no one, in a voice with the whole of the office gone out of it, "There is my second witness."

Justice did not stop for grief. Ka-Orun did not look at where she lay; he could not have looked and still ruled.

"Faith is down," Ka-Orun said, when the dust had thinned and she had been covered. "Hear what that means, and I will speak plainly, for there is no time now for long forms. The Mountain is found. Faith, the office that listens, is struck out of the five at the very hour we need it most, and cannot be restored in the time we have. Ordinary defence cannot give us back our secret; a secret once found by a state is not made unfound by killing the men in one desert, for the state remains, and the knowledge remains, and will come again with better drills until it has us. There is no wall we can raise that returns us to the world we had this morning." He rose, which in that chamber Justice does only once. "Therefore I find the condition met. The whole is threatened with capture by a single hand. The lawful answer is the Cataclysm, and I rule it lawful, and I set the record of my ruling in Sa-Tavan's tablet, that whoever survives the world may know it was done by law and not by panic. Shield. Raise the Greater Seal."

Ka-Dhavar of Shield, who had believed longest and feared longest and taken no pleasure in being right, bowed his head once and gave the order that closes a world.

I had never seen the Greater Seal and I pray the earth I never see its like again. It is the Mountain deciding to become solid, gates dropping in sequence down every route from the deep Hall to the far Threshold, each one a slab the height of three men falling into a throat cut to hold it, the sound of them going down

running away from us into the dark like a giant pulling the world shut behind him. Shield had drilled it for eleven thousand years and never done it in earnest, and the wardens moved through it white and perfect. Va-Sheva stood at the centre of the sequence calling the gates down in an order she had learned before she could read. It was the most terrible competence I have ever watched, and I loved her for it.

And below us, through the closing galleries, the Mountain that did not know was learning. You cannot drop the gates of the Greater Seal in a living city and keep it quiet, and the people heard it, and did the things people do. Some ran toward the deep wards where the drills everyone had half-believed were only drills had taught them to shelter. Some ran the wrong way, toward gates already down, and beat their hands against the cold slabs, and were gathered up by wardens and turned back weeping. A bell that had rung nothing but the hours for a thousand years began to ring a thing that was not the hours. And under all of it, in the common wards where the evening bread had been rising an hour before, five thousand people were coming to understand that the thing at the bottom of every prayer they had ever been made to say was no longer a story told to frighten children into obedience.

There was one gate they held. The far one, the last before the outer folds, and they held it past the moment the sequence called for it, because Jean-Charles was still outside it. He had gone out into the breaking desert in the last hour, alone, and none of us who lived ever learned with certainty what he did out there or why. He came back through the closing dark at a dead run and made the gate with a hand's breadth to spare, and the great slab came down behind him and sealed on the desert and on the enemy and on the sky. He was filthy and torn and empty-handed. Whether he had gone back to strike a last blow at the seizure cell, or to warn it, or to try to reach it and been shut out by it, or only to stand once more under an open sky he had helped to close, he did not say, then or ever; and a man may run toward the last shutting door of the world for reasons that do not survive being spoken. He stood in the sudden stone silence with the dust settling on him and looked at me, and did not smile, and said, "I am the last thing that will ever come in from out there. Whatever we are now, we are all of it there is going to be."

Va-Sheva did not embrace him, because it was not their way, but she laid her hand flat on his chest for the length of one breath, over the heart, the way Shield counts a living man, and said, "Then you are Mountain now, until you die. There is nothing else left to be." And Jean-Charles took that the way a man takes an office he did not ask for and cannot give back, and nodded once.

Only Sarah could not look at the two of them. She alone already suspected whose hand had unlatched the door the enemy had walked through, and could not yet prove it, and she let Va-Sheva name him Mountain regardless, because there was a Mountain to save that night and no room in it yet for what the naming would one day cost.

We went up, after, to where the Hall opens and the Pendulum still swung, to a high slot cut for the Festival light, the one place from which you can see the last of the day. The offices went to it without speaking, the survivors of them, to watch the world they had just chosen to leave.

The Seal had closed every route but not yet the crown. Through the crown, far up, there was still a line of the outside, a thin bright wound of evening sky over the desert, the last of the world we were built to hide from and had, this once, in the end, been found by. And as we watched, Shield closed the crown. It came across slow, a shield of stone drawn over the last slot the way you draw a lid, and the line of sky narrowed, and narrowed, gold going to a thread, a thread going to a thought of gold, and then the stone met the stone and there was no more outside at all, anywhere, for any of us, and there would not be for ninety days. And the Pendulum swung on through the dark exactly as it had swung that morning, patient, indifferent, drawing its slow circle on the floor as though nothing had happened, as though five thousand people had not just been sealed alive inside a bomb with the men who were about to fire it, as though the world above were not, even now, being made ready to end.

Paul's machine was still turning. I could hear it in the new and total silence: the small patient turning of the reel, the one outside thing we had sealed in here with us, drawing faithfully down onto its spool the sound of a Pendulum and five thousand held breaths and one bound heretic's. It kept the record of the first hour of the end for a reader we had no reason left to believe would ever exist. I found that I was glad of it. If we were to be the last of it all, I wanted there to be a witness, even a blind and turning one, even if the only eyes that ever read it were our own in the dark.

CHAPTER 20

BEAST

The Hall of Cataclysm is not the Hall of Ceremony. I had lived my whole life in the Mountain and never known there was a second hall, lower, older. I came to it with my hands unbound, because a man cannot do what they needed me to do with his hands tied. Being unbound felt worse than the rope, because it meant they had decided to use me.

It lay beneath the deep reserve, past a Shield gate that Ka-Dhavar opened with a thing he wore against his own skin and a word he said to no one. It opened into a chamber shaped like the inside of a bell and colder than any place I have stood, because the heat of the Mountain, all of it, the fire that cooked the bread and warmed the wards, was gathered and sent elsewhere here, down, into the floor. The floor of the Hall of Cataclysm was warm as a living thing while the air above it froze. And down the middle of it fell a single great shaft, a throat cut straight through the floor of the world. Up out of the dark overhead, above the throat, hung the mouth of a chamber I could not see the roof of, a black square vastness the size of a district that was, they told me, empty, and was not meant to be filled but this once. Around the throat, at the five points of a star, stood five stations, each raised a little and set into a shielded recess behind a window of polished stone that looked down upon the fall. So that the five who worked it could see the throat, the water when it came, one another across it, every hand at every station, and which hand hesitated and which withdrew. The offices had come to the Hall apart, each by his own route and his own door, and stood now together, in one room,

in plain sight of one another, which I had been raised to believe the five never were. The four surviving Keepers stood at four of the five stations. Where the fifth should have stood, at Faith's place, there was only a low stone bowl on a plinth and a fitting for an instrument that no longer had an operator. The operator was dead under a fallen roof, and her Veil was breathing in a cot somewhere with his skull broken and his ears gone.

We had been sealed nine days when they brought me down. Nine days of the Mountain learning to be a tomb: the wards rationed, the air turned and turned again, the wounded from the Faith passage laid in rows. And above us, muffled by the whole thickness of the Seal, the patient thud of an enemy who did not yet understand that the door they were drilling through had a worse thing behind it than any treasure. Nine days for the four surviving Keepers to arrive, one argument at a time, at the place they now stood.

"We cannot fire it," Ka-Leth of Balance said, "and we cannot fail to fire it, and I have been standing here for an hour unable to move for the truth of both." She turned her heavy face to me. "The Beast needs five. It has always needed five. The machine is cut that way in the stone, deeper than any custom. The fifth office is the one that listens, and the one that listens is dead."

They told me what the Beast was by making me help build the firing of it, which is the only way anyone was ever taught it, because there is no book of it; a book could be taken.

Balance is the water and the fire. Far below the Hall, deeper than the reserve of the living water, there is the other reserve, the great one, the one Ka-Leth had called ballast in the hearing and would not let anyone drink. And below even that there is the heat, the deep heat the whole Mountain steals its warmth from, rock hot enough to cook stone. Balance's work is to let the great water down onto the deep heat, in amounts it meters to the drop. The water where it touches the heat never has time to boil; it flashes, becomes steam in an instant, and the steam has nowhere to go but where Balance sends it, down a throat cut for it, a hammer-blow of pressure driven into the roots of the world. For a drill, Balance meters a little charge onto the fire and the floor jumps once, and the priests count five and stop. For the firing, the black chamber that hangs empty over the throat — a hollow the size of a district, kept dry its whole existence for this one use — is filled from the side reserve, then shut behind, and the whole of it let go at once, down the shaft, past the five stone windows, in plain sight of the five who loose it, onto the deep fire. That is a payload; and there are five of them in a full firing,

the machine taking its first breath by stored strength and every breath after from the fire itself. Ka-Leth stood at a bank of stone wheels and gates worn smooth by eleven thousand years of hands.

The fire is nowhere near the floor we were standing on, and that is the only reason any of us saw the morning. He took me to the rail at the lip of the throat and made me look down it until looking stopped meaning anything. The place where the water meets the heat lies miles below the Hall, at the foot of a shaft that runs on past the last worked stone into rock no eye has ever been down to see. "Were it near," he said, "we should be having no conversation at all, and this Mountain would be a bowl in the sand with a story attached to it."

He told me the other thing at the bank of wheels, flatly, the way Balance tells everything. The heat runs out. There is a great slow bank of it down there, laid up across a stretch of time he had no number for, and every stroke we sent into it would quench a piece that would come back warm in nobody's lifetime. "You are picturing a hearth," he said. "Picture a debt. That fire has been saving itself since before there was a people here to want it, and tonight we spend the whole of it in an hour and a half. Write that down, whatever else you write. There is one firing in this machine. After tonight it is a cold hole in the ground, and it will be warm again when it is warm again, which is a length of time I have no use for and no name for, and neither will my grandchildren's grandchildren." He said it the way a quartermaster says a thing, and I took it down as arithmetic. It was eighty days before I learned what I had been told.

She made me learn the first valve with my own hand before she would trust my word at the eye, because, she said, a hand that has never felt the water fight the stone has no business timing it. He set my palm on the great worn wheel and had me crack it a hair. It bucked under my hand like a live animal, the deep water wanting up and out. It took all my weight to hold it to a hair. Ka-Leth watched me shake against it. "Now picture holding that steady, to the drop, for an hour, while the floor tries to throw you off it," he said, "and you will understand why Balance is the office we give to the patient and the strong, and never once in eleven thousand years to the clever. Clever men open valves too far. You will not touch these again. But now you know what your one word is going to cost the man who obeys it."

Light is where the blow goes.

Ka-Raedin took me to the Light station of that Hall and showed me the rest: everything I had been taught in the Veil's Chamber — the red glass, the token-hole,

the way a beam bends and spreads and comes back together at a place you can choose — had been the children's version of this.

Because a blow driven into rock does not stay a single blow. It spreads out through the body of the Earth in every direction, weakening as it goes. And then the world does the thing no hand could do for it: a part of that spreading, having gone its separate ways through the whole thickness of the world and its molten heart, finds its way back together, of its own accord, toward the one place exactly opposite where it began. It is a smeared and partial gathering; what reaches the far pole reaches it weakened, and that it reaches strong enough to matter at all is a thing of the standing-place, and I will come to that. The Earth does the aiming. No glass I ever cut could bend a thing the size of a continent. What a hand can do is choose where to stand when it lets go.

That was the choosing, and it was made once, before a single gallery was cut, so that the far pole of the blow would fall where the crust was already broken. Light's whole office is to keep that choosing true. The ground travels — a hand's breadth in a lifetime, thirty paces in a century, nothing a man would notice and everything across an age. And so Light measures, and measures again, and carries the number down eleven thousand years, so that the Mountain knows to the pace where it is standing and what lies under the far side of the world from it. In the Veil's Chamber they had let me call that a devotion. Ka-Raedin showed me the sight-lines and the sunk marks and the long tables of the count.

"You bent light in a chamber to teach a boy his office," Ka-Raedin said, and he looked at me directly, which he had not once done since I came back. "We bend the Earth's own shaking through the Earth's own core, to a single point on the far skin of the world. You were taught the toy of it, and you were the best with the toy any of us had seen, which is why they feared you, and why I am about to need you." He held the lamp between us a moment. "I told your trial that light put out by a narrow door does not stay a line — that your path, thrown so far, would come back and interfere with the Mountain — and I would not say in an open room what I meant by it. I meant this hour. Here you are, come the whole way round, standing where the interference gathers, the one hand left that can read it: the Mountain put you out to keep you off the machine, and now... the machine is yours."

And he needed me sooner than either of us wished. Light's count is only ever as good as the marks it was taken from, and nine days of the enemy's patient hammering had shifted or buried half the sunk marks of the upper galleries — the fixed points from which eleven thousand years of measuring had been carried

forward, hand to hand, without a break. Ka-Raedin took me down a stair behind the station to the master mark, a plug of dark stone set into the living rock with sight-lines cut away from it in five directions, and showed me that two of the five no longer agreed with the tables. From those marks alone we could no longer say whether the Mountain stood where the record said it stood; and if it did not, then everything Light had ever certified about the far side of the world was a number somebody had once believed.

We could not re-cut eleven thousand years in a night. What we could do was take the position again, from the beginning, by another road: the three sight-lines that had survived, and the equinox mark down the Archive shaft that the sun itself trues once a year and no hammering can move, and the old tables to check us as we went. It was my art, the exact and only art I had been the best of my generation at and been broken for. I did it in the cold with Ka-Raedin holding the lamp and reading me the figures. And at the end of it I could tell him, with my own two hands' work standing behind it, that the Mountain sat where the record said it sat, within a pace. When the last line closed, a sign at the foot of the master mark caught the lamp and threw it back green, which is the Mountain's oldest way of saying yes, and my Keeper let out a breath I think he had been holding for nine days.

And then there was Faith's place, empty, and everything stopped there. I had learned Balance and Light, and I could see, even I could see, that neither was any use without what the dead woman had done.

For the blow, once let go, comes back. It goes down into the world and part of it returns, an echo, up through the rock to the Hall, and that returning echo is the whole secret of the weapon. A single blow, however well placed, does nothing whatever to the far side of the world. What the blows do, they do to the deep place directly beneath us. The first breaks it open — cracks the hot rock across, drives water into the cracks, and makes of a solid floor a thing that is shattered and flooded and under pressure. The second finds that broken ground and opens it wider, and the third wider still, so that every blow has more to work with than the one before it and speaks into the body of the Earth with a larger mouth. The last of the five is the only one that matters, and it matters because the four before it dug its throat.

And they can only be added if each new load is let fall while the deep place is still open from the last, in the short span before the weight of the world closes the rock on itself again. Faith's work, the dead woman's work, was to listen to the

returning echo through a stone tuned to hear it, and to know from the shape of what came back whether the deep place was still open, and to name the one instant to tell Balance to let the next load fall. She was the metronome of the end of the world. And she was dead.

“It is called the prayer,” Ka-Raedin said, “because that is how it was taught, as a listening and an answering, and a Faith is trained from a child to feel the phase of it the way you and I feel a held breath. There is no one left who can feel it. And without it we have four offices and a bank of valves and no way on Earth to time the strokes, and an untimed Beast is a mountain shaking itself to rubble over its own children for no purpose at all.”

Sarah had been silent since we came down into the cold. She spoke now, from the dark at the edge of the lamplight, where she had been standing with Paul, the two Outsiders, in the one place in the world no Outsider was ever meant to stand.

“Play me the echo,” she said. “On your stone. Let me hear one stroke and its return. I have spent sixty-six years listening to exactly this and calling it my life’s work, and I never once knew it had a name, or a hall, or a dead priestess. Play it for me.”

They did not want to. I watched four Keepers balk at the blasphemy of letting an Outsider woman lay her ear against the listening stone of Faith, and I watched Justice overrule them, because Justice had already ruled, in the hearing, that the world’s ending was lawful, and a man who has permitted the greater blasphemy cannot in conscience forbid the lesser one that might make it work.

So Ka-Leth let a single drop fall, the smallest stroke the machine could make. The floor jumped once under us, and a sound went down and away into the world. Sarah stood with her hand and her ear against the Faith stone and waited. The echo came home, and I watched the whole of her life arrive in her face at once.

“That is it,” she said, and her voice had gone somewhere I had not heard it go. “That is the five strokes. That is the thing under the bomb. That is what I heard at Reggane at twenty-seven and have chased across sixty-six years. It was this. It was always this. It was a mountain full of frightened priests, testing that the end of the world still answered when they knocked, and stopping, always, always, after five, before the swing could build.” She turned her face toward the four Keepers, and there were no tears in it, which was worse. “Your drills. Your holy little drills, every time a Keeper died and a new one had to be shown the machine still worked. I built my whole self out of the echo of your caution. And now you need someone to do the thing your caution was invented to prevent, which is to not stop after

five.” She took her hand off the stone. “I can hear the phase. God forgive me, I have the best ear for it left alive. I can time your strokes. I can be your dead woman.”

Sarah could hear the phase, the living seismic return, better than any of them. But she could not read the stone the way a Faith read it, could not tell the true return from the Mountain’s own noise, from the enemy’s charges still landing above us, from the structure’s groaning, because a Faith spent a lifetime learning the one voice of this one Mountain and Sarah had spent hers learning the general grammar of all ground everywhere. She had the ear and not the tongue.

Paul had the tongue, and he had it because Ka-Elun had put it into him with her own mouth before the roof took her. In the sealed hearing, the fragment Faith deposited into him was this: the timing itself, the sequence, the how-long-to-wait and the how-to-know-the-true-call, which had never once been written, because a book can be taken. It had lived as the liturgy, the words a Faith is taught as a child and says over every drill of a life without ever being told that the psalm is an operating manual for the end of the world. She had recited it into Paul’s turning machine plainly, an old woman handing a heavy thing across before her arms failed; and an hour later the roof came down on her, and the last living tongue that knew what the words meant was a fact-checker’s. So it fell to Paul, whose whole trade was reading what a text says under what it claims to say, to hold Faith’s deposited prayer against the half-knowledge of the low under-priests and turn each holy verse back into the instruction it had been. *When the stone answers in the third measure, and not before, let fall.* He translated the end of the world out of scripture into arithmetic, in the cold, by lamplight.

It did not work the first time, or the third. We built the composite the way you build anything in a hurry out of parts that were never meant to fit: badly, and with blood. Once, an hour into it, Paul said through his teeth, to no one, that he thought his leg was broken. Sarah did not take her hand from the stone. “There are two hundred and fifteen bones in the body, Mr Morgan,” she said. “That is one.” He went back to the words. The first true stroke and return we tried, Sarah called the phase off the living wave and Paul called it off the liturgy, and the two calls did not agree, a whole measure apart. I had to choose between them in the half-second the machine allowed, and I chose the ear over the tongue, and told Ka-Leth to let fall. The stroke arrived against the return instead of with it and cancelled it, and an hour of built swing bled out of the Mountain in a long sick groan. Ka-Leth looked at me with no anger at all and said only, “That is why we stop at five,” and we began again. The second time I chose the tongue over the ear and was wrong

the other way. It was Sarah who found the fix, because Sarah had spent sixty-six years learning to tell a true signal from noise, and that, in the end, was the missing office: the judgement standing between the ear and the tongue, the thing a Faith did without ever knowing she did it. "Give me the stone and give me the words both," she said, "and stop trying to choose. The words tell me which returns to listen for. The stone tells me when. They are only right together." And after that the three of us were one instrument, an ear and a tongue and an eye. It broke the founding law of my people, the three of us holding between us the whole that no one hand could hold, and it was beautiful.

And neither of them could see the whole, could hold Balance and Light and the return and the sequence all at once, in one mind, and see how the pieces moved against each other. That, it turned out, was what they needed me for. They had hands enough; they needed an eye — one that could hold Paul's translated sequence and Sarah's living ear and Ka-Raedin's geometry and Ka-Leth's valves in the one place at the one time, and see where they had to meet, and say the word that made them meet.

And I want the next thing set down with more care than anything else in this account, because here my people's terror had built a wall that held. I saw the whole. I did not hold it. Look at where the hands were. Shield kept the token against my palm, so that I could not have fired with one hand if I had gone mad on the spot. Justice kept the word before every single stroke, and gave it or withheld it. Balance kept the valves, and no drop fell but by Ka-Leth's own hand. The thing that eleven thousand years of walls and terror and murdered heretics had been built to prevent — one hand that sees the whole, and holds the key, and gives the word, and turns the valve, all at once and alone — did not come to exist that night, not even at the end of the world. That I saw and did not hold — that Ka-Leth's hand was on the valve and Ka-Dhavar's on the token and mine on nothing — is what has let me live with having been in that room.

"Do you understand what you are asking me to become," I said to Ka-Raedin, my own Keeper, the man whose office I had broken.

"Yes," he said. "I have understood it since the roof fell on Faith. It has to be one mind, and it has to be a mind that knows all five offices, and there is exactly one such mind in the history of the Mountain, and we exiled it into the desert, and it has come home on the one night we cannot do without it." He did not look away this time. "You were right, is the thing I have not been able to say. All those years ago. You pulled the cord because you saw it. That a wall of ignorance holds only until it is tested. I helped to break you for it. And tonight the wall is being tested,

and the only thing that can save the people behind it is the sight we punished you for having. Be the eye. God and the Beast forgive us both. Be the eye.”

I have wondered since what I truly felt in the moment I agreed, and the honest answer is the one I am least proud of: that under the horror there was a small, clean, terrible relief. All my life my sight had been named a sickness, the flaw I was broken for. And here, at the end of everything, the sickness had become the last hope of five thousand souls, and the men who had punished me for it stood begging me to use it, and I was glad, and ashamed of it. I said yes to save my people. I also said yes because it felt, once and once only in my whole life, like being given leave to be the thing I am.

Justice set the terms, because nothing irreversible happens in that Mountain without Justice standing over it counting.

Ka-Orun took his place at the Justice station, and Sa-Tavan beside him with the wet clay. Ka-Dhavar of Shield opened the two custodies, the two keys that must turn together, his own and the token that had been Light’s since before the Mountain had a name. And Justice laid down the law of the firing, which was the last mercy left in the machine.

“Every stroke is permitted separately,” Ka-Orun said. “Not the firing. Each stroke. Balance does not let a single drop fall until I say the word, and I do not say the word until Shield confirms the last stroke was contained, and Sa-Tavan writes each one as it is committed, so that there is a record of exactly where the point of no return was crossed and by whose word, because a thing done by law is done in the light even when the light is going out. And there is an abort. Until a stroke I will name, Shield can shut the throat and vent the pressure and we walk away from it, shaken, alive, a Mountain that came to the edge and stepped back. After that stroke there is no walking away, because after that stroke enough of the swing is built that it will complete itself through the far side of the world whether we strike again or not. I will tell you when we reach that stroke. And then I will ask, once, whether we go on. And then we will not be able to unask it.”

Shield’s work through all of it was the work no one watches, which is keeping it from killing the wrong people first. Every stroke we sent down recoiled up; a hammer that drives a nail is also driven back into the hand, and the hand, here, was a mountain full of five thousand souls. Ka-Dhavar had spent his nine days moving the wards, ward by ward, off the lines where the recoil would run, into the deep shielded galleries. Va-Sheva stood at the throat of the Hall with the abort under her palm and a living map in her head of where each stroke’s recoil would land and

whether anyone was still standing on it. Twice in the early strokes she raised her hand, and Ka-Orun stayed the word. We waited in the ringing cold while a warden cleared a gallery that someone had crept back into, an old man after a forgotten thing, a child who had run the wrong way in the dark. Only when the line was empty did she lower her hand and let us go on ending the world with no one hurt in the small local way of it.

We began with drops.

It is the thing no one who imagines the end of the world imagines: that it starts so small, so patiently, drop and wait, drop and wait, an old woman at a bank of valves, and another with her ear to a stone, and a heretic in the middle saying *now*, and *now*, and *not yet*. All the while the enemy's charges thudded down from above at their own blind rhythm and the two rhythms had nothing to do with each other, and the Hall shook for reasons no one could always tell apart.

The first strokes did nothing that I could feel beyond the jump of the floor. Sarah listened, and told me the phase, and I held it against Paul's sequence, and told Ka-Leth the instant, and Ka-Leth let the next drop fall. Ka-Orun said the word before each one, and Sa-Tavan wrote each one down, and Shield stood ready at the throat to abort. Drop. Wait. Listen. *Now*. Drop. And somewhere far below and far away the swing began, very slightly, to build.

I could feel it before any instrument showed it, because I was the eye. The returns began to come home a little stronger than the strokes that made them, which is the sign that the swing was catching, each blow arriving to a rock already moving the right way and adding to it. Sarah felt it in her stone and looked at me, and I nodded, and she said, low, "It is building. It is actually building. I spent my life proving this was real and I never once let myself believe I would feel it." There was in her voice the thing that had ruined her at twenty-seven, the terrible joy of being right. I felt it move in myself, the awful pleasure of the whole machine answering to my one word, and I have never been so afraid of anything as I was of that pleasure, in myself.

Past the fifth stroke the drills had always stopped. We went past it — not yet firing, only proving: striking small, and listening, past five and past ten, until the ear and the tongue and the eye moved as one. And so, when the great loads fell, the aim would already be true and the phase already caught. It was the first blasphemy,

to go past five; the second, the great one, was still overhead in the dark, waiting in the dry chamber to be let fall.

I felt the Mountain change under us. The whole body of the place took on a low sustained note, a ringing that held between the strokes now, and grew, because now the returns were strong enough to keep the rock moving on their own between one blow and the next. Balance held to the small charges still, for this was proving and not yet the firing, but struck them nearer their true weight now, each a heavier drop than the last. Ka-Leth's face ran with sweat in the cold, and her hands never once shook. Dust came down from the bell of the roof in a steady fall. A Shield warden was sick against the wall and went back to his post. Va-Sheva stood at Shield's throat with her hand on the abort and her eyes on Ka-Orun and did not move.

Once, deep in the proving, the swing tried to run away from us. A return came home larger than it had any right to be, fed by something we had not put into it, and for three strokes the thing built faster than Paul's sequence said it could, the water metering out one measure and the swing taking three, an animal that had begun to eat on its own. I felt it through the whole machine as a wrongness, a horse taking the bit, and I called a hold, and Ka-Orun stayed the word. We let three returns come home with no stroke to feed them, to watch whether the swing would fall back the way an unfed swing must. It did not. And I understood what was feeding it. The enemy. Their charges, still landing above us at their own blind rhythm, had by pure evil chance begun to arrive in phase with our work, adding their small violence to our great one, so that the two rhythms which had nothing to do with each other had started, at the worst possible hour, to agree. The men drilling down to take the mechanism whole were, without knowing it, helping us to fire it. I said so aloud, and Sa-Tavan wrote it into the record in his good unhurried hand. Ka-Orun did the cold arithmetic again and moved the hour of the first load nearer than the old reckoning had set it, because the longer we proved, the more the enemy's blind hammering built beneath our proving. And no one in that room argued, because every one of us had felt the horse take the bit.

And all the while, above the sealed Hall, the Mountain we were doing it for felt every stroke and did not know what it felt. I learned afterward how the dark had gone for the five thousand: that they had felt the floor jump, over and over, in fear at first, and then, because people cannot stay afraid forever, in a kind of dreadful worship. Someone in the deep wards had begun to count the strokes aloud, the way Faith had counted every drill in living memory, and the count had spread, ward to ward, until the whole buried city was marking each jump of the

floor with a single number said together in the dark, not knowing that this time the count would not stop at five, not knowing they had become the choir of their own ending. Knowing only that the stone was speaking, and that their people had always, always answered the stone. Va-Sheva heard it come down faint through the Seal, the whole Mountain saying a number into the black. I watched it reach her at her post, and I watched her decide not to let it reach her, and go on holding the abort with a level hand.

And the enemy, above us, chose that hour to break through into a high gallery, because of course they did. There was a new sound, nearer, human, and a runner came down white-faced to Ka-Dhavar and said the words *they are in the upper Faith wards*. And I saw Jean-Charles, who had been standing at the Hall's own door with a Shield blade he had no traditional right to hold, look at Va-Sheva once, and she gave him a warden and a nod. He went up into the Mountain to hold a stair against soldiers so that the four offices and their heretic could go on ending the world in peace. I did not see him again for a long time. I did not know, striking the world in that cold bell of a room, whether he was alive above me or dead.

The fighting came closer while we worked. A second runner, and then no more runners, which was worse, and then a sound down the Hall's own approach that was boots and not stone. Ka-Dhavar sent his last two wardens up from the Hall door to meet it, so that the door of the end of the world stood guarded by nothing but an old blind arithmetic and a woman's raised hand. I learned afterward what it had cost above us. Jean-Charles held the third stair of the Faith wards for the better part of an hour, with a handful of wardens and a boy who ran messages and a barricade built of the Mountain's own furniture, against soldiers who had trained for this. The world was already committed, and holding the stair could save none of it back. He held it because if the enemy reached the Hall before the last stroke they might, in their greed to take the thing whole, do the one thing that could still ruin it: seize a Keeper, break the sequence at the final minute and leave the Beast half-fired, a wound in the world that killed the Mountain and spared the men who came for it. He did not know that was why the stair mattered. He only knew it was his to hold. And I was three hundred feet beneath him telling a tired old man when to let water fall, and neither of us could reach the other. Every one of us alone at his own valve, doing the one thing set in front of him, trusting the dark to be full of others doing theirs.

"The first great load is the one," Ka-Orun said.

Everything stopped, except the ringing of the Mountain, which could not stop now, which hung in the air and the stone and the teeth.

“Hear me, because Sa-Tavan is writing it and it must be true on the tablet. The load I now permit is the last thing we can call back. If Balance looses the first great load, the swing that returns from it will be large enough to complete itself through the core of the world without our help, and the machine will take the four that follow from the fire whether we will them or no. We will have committed it. Everything after this drop happens on the far skin of the world by itself, and cannot be stopped by any hand, mine or theirs or God’s.” He looked, not at me, but at the four offices, one by one, the living ones, and last and longest at the empty place where Faith should have stood. “I will ask once. We are permitted this. The law is met; the whole is threatened with capture; there is no lesser answer that restores the secret. But permitted is not commanded. I am Justice, and I can find a thing lawful and still stay my own hand. So I ask the five of us, who are four, and the three of the outside who have become our fifth: do we loose them.”

I have been asked, since, by the only people left who could ask it, whether there was a debate. Whether anyone argued. Whether some voice cried out to stop, to find another way, to trust that the soldiers might not, after all, reach the mechanism.

There was no debate among the five of us who were four. We had done all our debating in a warm room and a sealed hall and a lifetime each of coming to this. Ka-Leth of Balance said, “The measure is whole.” Ka-Raedin of Light said, “The path is true.” Ka-Dhavar of Shield said, “The Mountain is held.” Va-Sheva took her hand off the abort, which was its own vote, and folded it into her other hand. Sarah said nothing at all, and looked at me, and I understood that she was leaving the last of it to the one of us whose Mountain it truly was. And Paul, the witness, did the one thing his office allowed him, and he did it without rising, in the flat voice he kept for true things. “Let the reel show,” he said, “that an outsider sat in this room and said it aloud: that the far side of the world is full of people who never heard the word Mountain — harbours, wards of the sick, children being put to bed under a sky you are about to aim at them — and that not one of them ever came looking for you. I cannot stop this, and I was not brought here to stop it. I will only not have it written, after, that the cost went into the ground unnamed.” No office was bound to answer him, and none did. Then he held his little machine up a fraction, so that it would catch the rest of it clearly.

And I, who had been made the eye that saw the whole and owned no part of it, gave the last of the answers Justice had asked for, saying at last the word the seeing had brought all our hands to.

"Let them fall," I said.

Ka-Orun said the word. Ka-Dhavar drew the two custodies together and Ka-Leth drew back the great gate, and the first of the five loads went out of the chamber and down the throat, in plain sight of us all, a whole district's weight of water falling as one thing past the five stone windows onto the deep fire. And once it had entered the Earth the machine was committed, and took the rest from the fire itself, load after load at the phase we had built, the steam of each fall lifting the next behind it, so that we loosed the first and stood inside the finishing of the rest.

I have tried many times to say what the last stroke was like, and I will not manage it now. The floor did not jump. The floor *left*. For a moment that had no length the whole Hall of Cataclysm was in the air, all of us, the lamps, the wet tablet, the cold, and then the world caught us again, and what reached us was the absence of every other sound, a silence so total and so vast. And into that silence the Mountain poured its whole gathered heat and water and patience in one long exhalation down into the roots of the Earth, and the swing we had built let go, and went down through the core of the world, and there was nothing any hand could do any more, ours or theirs, forever.

For a while after the last stroke no one in the Hall moved or spoke. The ringing that had hung in the stone through the whole firing was gone, spent, sent down into the world, and its absence was the loudest thing I have ever failed to hear. The lamps had guttered in the great exhalation, and someone trimmed them, slowly, and the small ordinary sound of a wick being trued was almost past bearing, the sound of a person doing a small careful living thing in the first minute of the end of everything. Ka-Orun set down the last of the reckoning. Sa-Tavan pressed the final mark into the wet clay and laid the stylus beside it, square, the way you set down a tool you know you will not need again. And I stood in the middle of the four offices whose every work I had held in one sight at once, and felt the seeing drain out of me and leave me a single tired man in a cold room. And I have never been so grateful to be small again, nor so certain that I would never be entirely small again.

Then we waited. And this is the part the Mountain's own children were never told, because they were never meant to be alive to wait it: that after you fire the Beast, nothing happens, for a long time, because the far side of the world is very far away, and the thing we had sent had to cross the whole thickness of a planet and its molten heart before it arrived, and rebuilt itself, and did what it had been aimed across eleven thousand years to do.

Sarah stood at the Faith stone with her hand against it, and she was the one who would know first, because she was the ear. And the rest of us watched her, four Keepers and two Veils and a witness and a heretic, watched an old Outsider woman waiting for the far side of the world to answer.

One last interval, Sarah said, one more turn of the same long wait the strokes had kept between them, no more than that, for the thing to cross the core and rebuild itself and arrive. It was the longest twenty minutes there will ever be, and there was nothing to do in it but breathe, and no one could think of anything the right size to say. Ka-Leth closed her valves one by one, slowly, the way you put a great animal to sleep, and then sat down on the floor of the Hall of Cataclysm, an old woman at the end of her office, and put her face into her two hands, dry-eyed, only resting the weight of her head as though the neck could no longer hold it. Ka-Raedin went and stood in the empty place where Faith should have been, which no Keeper of Light had ever done. Sarah did not move from the stone. And Paul was beside me in the dark, and he had started the little machine again, quietly, and I asked him why, when there was nothing to hear. "There is always something to hear," he said. "And if anyone is ever going to know what a wait like this was, they will need to know that mostly it was quiet, and that a tired old woman sat down on the floor. Not the fire. The old woman sitting down."

Once in that waiting Sarah spoke to me, without turning from the stone. "You felt it," she said. "When it was building. When it answered your word. You felt what I felt at the bomb, at twenty-seven." I said that I had. "Now you know," she said. "Now you know it was never wickedness in me. It was the best feeling there is: the whole of a great thing moving because you understood it and it did not. That is the thing your Mountain should have taught, instead of teaching fear. That the reaching for the whole feels exactly like being alive; and that is why no wall of terror was ever going to hold it; and why, in the end, they were right to build a Beast instead of a wall, because you cannot frighten a person out of the one pleasure that feels to them like the meaning of their life. You can only make certain that the day a hand closes on the whole is the day the whole is taken away from everyone." She took her palm off the stone a moment, and laid it back. "I

have wanted, before I died, to say that to one living person who would understand it. I did not think it would turn out to be a boy from the inside of the very thing I spent my life trying to steal.”

It came as a line. Faith’s instrument, the one with no operator, drew it by itself off the returning wave: a single long stroke climbing the drum higher than any mark any living Keeper had ever seen. It came from the exact far pole of the shot, with nothing of below us or around us in it, arriving home after its long crossing to tell Sarah, who alone could read what it meant, that the far crust had answered; that the thing we aimed had struck the roots of the Earth where the Earth was already weakest. What she read past that — that a rupture of such a size, along such a ring, would set a made winter walking across the world above us — was inference, and she said so, even then; no instrument in that hall could show it, and no one living would ever stand on the far skin of the world to confirm it. But she had spent her life learning to read exactly this, and none of us doubted her.

“It is done,” Sarah said, and took her hand off the stone at last. She looked at it, her own hand, as though it belonged to someone she had spent her life hunting and had, in the end, caught, and become. “It is done. We have struck the far side of the world.”

And then, a long moment after, we felt our own shot come all the way home, up through the floor of the Hall, arriving as a slow swell, the whole ground lifting under us the way the deck of a ship lifts on a sea, and settling, once. We were feeling the Earth itself ring, the entire planet struck like the bell it is and answering in a note so low and so long that no ear could hold it, only a body. Somewhere on the far skin of the world, at the one point exactly opposite us, the note had already become fire, and wave, and a darkness climbing into the sky. How long that darkness would take to come down again — a year, Sarah reckoned, and very likely more — was a thing none of us sealed in that stone would ever be given the means to measure.

The Mountain moved beneath us, once, settling into the new shape of a planet that had just been rung, and then was still. And Paul, whose machine had heard all of it, reached over and, for the second time in my knowing of him, stopped it, because there was nothing left, that hour, worth the reel. And in the silence after the machine there was no sound at all from the world outside, no charge, no drill, no soldier, no sky, nothing, because the outside had, a little while ago, without knowing it, without ever being told, begun to end.

CHAPTER 21

VIGIL

The enemy above us took four more days to die, and we knew it the way we knew everything now, at a remove, through instruments and stone.

Their charges stopped first. On the second day after the firing the patient thudding that had been the roof of our lives for a season simply was not there any more. Shield's listeners reported nothing where the drilling had been. Then, over the days after, they reported the other sounds, the ground itself moving in ways it had never moved in any record Balance kept, long shudders rolling through the region from far off. It was the first hem of the wave we had sent around the world, coming back to us the near way, through the crust, ahead of the slow way it would come through the sky. We did not see it end. We heard the ground take it. Sarah stood at the Faith stone she had made her own and listened to the returns and said, on the fourth day, without any triumph in her at all, "The camp is gone. The ground opened where the camp was, and closed. They are under." And that was the last the world ever knew of the men who came to own the Mountain, that they were buried by the first small yawn of the thing they had come to steal, four hundred metres from the door they never opened.

Jean-Charles came down out of the upper wards on the fifth day, alive, which I had not let myself expect, having last seen him climb a stair to hold it against soldiers with the world already ending under his feet. He was not the man who had bought a grieving woman sweets and made a joke of breakfast. He had held his stair until the charges stopped, and then until the ground itself began to move.

When there was no enemy left to hold it against, he had helped Shield carry the wounded and the dead down out of the broken passages. He had been doing that, without sleep, for four days. He found me in the deep. He did not smile, did not embrace me, only stood a moment and set his hand on my shoulder the way he had in the desert when I was a bundle under a cloth, and said, "We are alive, man. Those of us that are. I have decided to be glad of it later, when there is a later. For now there are people to carry." And he went to carry them.

I had never understood, until I watched it save us, that the piped light, the turned air, the two reserves of water, the deep stolen heat, every miracle I had been taught to call God's mercy, was one machine with one purpose: to keep five thousand people alive inside a sealed stone through the end of a world.

Ninety days. That was the lock, and no one argued it. The arithmetic was Balance's and Shield's together, closed to argument: the time the air could be turned and cleaned and turned again without the outside; the time the stores would feed us; the time the world above needed to do the worst of its convulsing before a person could stand in it without being killed by the sky. Ninety days sealed, and then Shield would crack a single high vent and taste what the world had become, and we would learn whether ninety had been enough or whether we had bought ourselves only a longer grave.

I will not pretend the ninety days were one thing. A day is a day even at the end of the world; you wake, and you are hungry, and something must be done. We had been raised on the Beast as the end of endings, the unthinkable, the wrath. And here we were, on the far side of having loosed it, boiling lentils.

They moved the children first, in the early days, down out of the upper wards where the Faith passage had broken and the cold came through, into the deep districts. It was done without panic. The Mountain had drilled the moving of children for eleven thousand years and called it a festival game. When the true day came the children thought, many of them, that it was the game again, and went down singing the song that was, I understood now, the evacuation order set to a tune so that no child would ever be too frightened to obey it.

There were water-listeners. I had passed them my whole life and thought them a minor holy order, old men and women who put their ears to the great pipes and murmured. They were the gauges. In the sealed months they never left the pipes. In shifts, they listened to the balance of the two reserves, the living water

and the great ballast, calling the levels to Balance's clerks in a chant that was half prayer and half number. When the draught changed, when Shield closed a district and the air had to be sent a new way, the water-listeners heard the pressure shift first and sang it. The vent-keepers answered, turning the Mountain's breath down new throats with wheels worn smooth by numberless hands before theirs. There were ashkeepers, whose whole office, I had thought, was to tend the shrine of the last burning. On the fortieth day the high vents began to bring down ash, fine and grey and from nowhere any wind we owned, the first of the outside arriving as dust. The ashkeepers knew what to do with it. Their liturgy, their useless holy liturgy about the grey that falls when the world is punished, turned out to be an instruction manual for filtering volcanic ash out of an air supply, written by a man who had known, a ten thousand years ago, exactly what the sky would do.

I watched an old woman I had known as a child, who had scolded me once for running in the Balance halls, sit through the whole ninety days doing the thing she had always done, which was the accounting of the salt fish. So many barrels drawn, so many remaining, the number carried and checked and carried. She did it through the end of the world with the same pursed exactness she had done it through every ordinary year. I thought her, at first, the most limited creature I had ever seen, and by the end something close to the point of us. The Mountain was full of her.

A child was born in the deep wards on the fiftieth day, because bodies keep their own calendar and do not consult the sky. The news of it went through the sealed Mountain faster than any of Sarah's silences, ward to ward, a child, a child born. I watched people who had spent a season marking the end of everything stop, and turn toward the rumour of her, and be, for one afternoon, helplessly glad. They named her for the season, which was the season of the dark. I thought that a grim weight to hang on a new person, until Va-Sheva told me the name meant the ones who are born to carry a light through it. There had been a girl of that name in every generation any record held. The Mountain had a name ready for a child born into the dark. I did not think, that afternoon, to wonder why a people who believed themselves eternal and safe would keep, in every generation, ready, a name for the child born at the end of the world.

They gave me work, in the end, because a man with idle hands in a sealed crisis is a danger and a grief to himself. Va-Sheva judged, correctly, that the eye which had fired the Beast needed, more than anyone in the Mountain, to be made small and useful again. They put me on the vents, under an old vent-keeper named Sa-Orin who neither knew nor cared what I had done in the Hall of Cataclysm and cared

a great deal whether I turned the wheel he pointed at the instant he pointed at it. And I turned wheels, in shifts, in the dark, sending the Mountain's breath down whatever throat the water-listeners' chant told Sa-Orin to send it, and it was the first honest work of my life, whose entire meaning was that other people breathed because I did it.

The outside failed slowly, and we read it like a sickness in a body we could not see.

We had no window and we wanted none, but the Mountain has senses finer than eyes, and through them the world sent us its dying in pieces we had to assemble. The seismic returns, first, the ground telling Sarah and Faith's stone that the far catastrophe had run on past the blow itself into a cascade. One region of the broken crust setting off the next around the whole ring of fire, for days, for weeks, the Earth working through what we had started at its own slow pace and in its own order. Then the ash, on the fortieth day, which meant eruption somewhere upwind on a scale that could darken a sky. Then the cold, which we felt as a change in the deep heat's labour, the Mountain having to spend more of its stolen fire to keep us warm because the world it borrowed against had gone frigid above. And then the silences, which were the worst, because they were where knowledge should have been. Sarah had left, buried in the estate and the network and a dozen dead drops, ways of hearing the outside that had nothing to do with the Mountain, and Va-Elise had carried some slender thread of them in with her. In the early days a very little still came, faint, delayed, a signal that a station somewhere still lived, a coded nothing that meant only *someone is still there*. And one by one those went out. Not dramatically. They simply stopped arriving, on their days, at their hours, the way letters stop from a friend who has died before anyone thought to write you the news. By the sixtieth day there were no more. The outside had stopped sending, because there was less and less of an outside left to send.

Her own threads gave only that coded pulse. The open air gave more, in the early weeks, and Sarah listened to all of it and read the worst of it to me, because, she said, I had aimed at these people and owed them the knowing of what I had aimed at. There was the states' traffic, loudest and least human, cyphered and clipped, one government asking another across a dying continent whether the thing in the southern desert had been theirs, being told no, disbelieving the answer. There was the soldiers' band, the men who had stood on the ridges above us, going quiet channel by channel as the ground took them. And under both, on a civil

frequency anyone with a wire could catch, a woman's voice somewhere north of the sea read over and again, in three languages, the same short list of names and a place where the children carried out of a flooded town could be found by anyone still coming to look. Her voice held the first hour. It broke in the third. And then that thread too, on its day, at its hour, stopped, and Sarah marked it down with the others, and we did not speak of the woman again.

"That was Geneva," Sarah said once, of a silence, flatly, the way you would name a thing on a list. "That thread came through Geneva. If it is gone, Geneva is gone, or dark, or drowned." She did not weep. I never saw her weep. But she began, around the sixtieth day, to sit for long stretches with her hand on the Faith stone and listen to nothing, to the not-arriving, and I think that was her weeping.

Once, of a particular silence, she said a name I had heard only from her, the man who had carried the French half of the arrangement her whole life and had lately helped his masters decide they no longer needed her. "And that will have been Martinez, or the desk above him," she said, without heat. "They took my grids in the spring and had no further use for the old man who fetched them, and I doubt they thanked him before the sky came down on whatever room they had put him out to pasture in. He spent sixty years holding a door open for whichever master came first, and in the end he held it open for the thing that killed them both. I told him once that a tool outlives its use and is discarded. I did not think I would live to watch the discarding done by a mountain." She took her hand off the stone. "Do not mistake that for grief. I have none to spare for Roger. I only find I dislike being proved right about a man on the day the whole world proves me right at once."

I have tried, since, to grieve the whole of it, and I cannot, and the failing is the most frightening thing I carried out of the sealed dark. One voice I could grieve: the woman reading the children's names until her own gave out; Geneva, because Sarah had made it a word and a place; one thread, one silence with a face behind it. These I could hold, and they broke me. But behind each thread was a city, and behind the city a country, and behind that the whole round of the warm world; and when I set my grief against that number it slid off, the way a hand slides off wet stone. I wept for a stranger's voice and felt nothing I could name for the billion behind her, and the billion was the true weight, and I could not lift it. This is not a mercy in us. It is the thing the whole crime stands on: that a man will end what he cannot feel, and no living mind can feel a number; that one death is a grief a person can carry, and a multitude is only an arithmetic. I had been the eye that fired it, and I could not so much as mourn it to its size. That was the day I

stopped trusting my own horror to prove I was any different, underneath, from anyone who could do such a thing.

Ka-Leth of Balance kept a different account in those days, beside her stores, and would show it to no one. I saw it only once, over her shoulder: a list, in her careful hand, of the things the Mountain used that could never be made again inside it, and beside each one a number, the years or the decades it would last. Steel. Certain salts. The fine wire that Light needs. The medicines. And at the bottom, in a hand gone smaller, one line with no number beside it that I did not, then, understand: *the seed comes up a little wronger every reset, and the blood, and no register I keep will buy that back*. She was reckoning, I understood, past the ninety days to the ninety years, and the ninety after that, and past even those to a debt that fell due in no lifetime she would ever have to answer for. It was the long slow arithmetic of a people who might now have to be, for a very great while, the whole of what was left, with no outside to trade with, or steal from, or be rescued by. She never once spoke of it.

The guilt did not come in a storm, at once. It came the way the ash came, slowly, from nowhere you could point to, settling on everything.

Mine was the plainest, and I said it to Paul's machine early, so it would be on the record before I lost the courage: that I had helped to fire it. There was the surface of it: I had come home and, in coming, been the eye they needed. There was the deeper thing, that the counterfeit knocking that drew the enemy in might never have reached this pitch if I had never let a fact-checker walk me down into a mountain. I had spent the book of my life insisting I was a victim of my people's cruelty. And I had come back and been the hand that turned the key.

Hers was larger and she never once tried to make it smaller. Sarah had built, over sixty-six years, the very apparatus that provoked the attack; her grids, her methods, her network, leaked and inherited, had drawn a state to this door. The sounding that woke the Mountain to its danger was played on an instrument she had, in a sense, invented. And now she had stood in the Hall of Cataclysm and been the ear that timed the strokes that ended the world she came from. "Do not comfort me," she said to me, once, when I began to. "I have earned every gram of this and I would be insulted to be talked out of it. I spent my life reaching for the largest thing there was, and I closed my hand on it, and the closing burned down everything else. That is the thing I am, and I will not have it called a tragedy that happened to me. I only ask one mercy of you, boy, and it is the same one I asked of the five: that when you decide what is to be done with what we now hold, you

do not let me be the only one who holds it. I have learned, too late to matter to anyone but the next world, that the whole in one hand is the whole crime, even when the hand is sorry.”

The Keepers carried theirs each in the shape of his office. Ka-Dhavar of Shield, who had raised the Seal and given the order that closed the world, grew very quiet and very gentle. He spent his spare hours among the wounded and the frightened, as though he could pay down what he had done one comforted person at a time. Ka-Raedin of Light, my own Keeper, could no longer bear to look at the deep machinery, and gave more and more of his office to me, his heretic, his eye, hating that the one man who could stand to see the whole of it was me. And Ka-Orun of Justice went hunting, night after night, through his own records, for the place where the law had failed, for some sentence he might have read otherwise that would have let a lawful Mountain do a smaller thing. He never found it, because there was none, and the not-finding was breaking him. The Mountain had spent eleven thousand years teaching its children that they were the ones the world would one day come to destroy. It had never taught us what to be on the morning we learned it was the other way round.

And Paul kept recording. I kept close to him through that ashen stretch. “Speaking of archangels,” he said once, at the end of a long and dark silence. I asked him, on one of the grey days, how he could bear it, the careful witnessing of an atrocity that had already succeeded, the obscene tidiness of getting it all down. He was quiet a while. “Because the alternative is what was done to your people,” he said. “Someone stood where I am standing, eleven thousand years ago, and decided that the truth of a terrible thing should be hidden, dressed up, made into scripture, so that the people who lived inside it would never know what had been done to them or in their name. That is the original crime here. Not the Beast. The lie about the Beast. I am the opposite of that man. I am making certain that whatever else happens, this one will not be a secret. That the people who come after, if any come after, will not have to be lied to. It is the only clean thing I know how to do. I am going to do it until the reel runs out.”

Va-Sheva’s reckoning I was not shown, because she showed it to no one, and to me least of all. She ran Shield’s half of the survival through the whole ninety days, the districts and the vents and the moving of the frightened, and she did it without a wasted motion. If she woke in the dark with the count of the dead in her mouth, she did it where no one could see. Once, deep in the season, I found her alone at a closed vent with her hand flat on the cold iron of it, in the posture I had watched her use to count a living man. I thought she was listening for the

outside, and she said, without turning, “I am not listening for anything. There is nothing left out there to listen for. I am standing here because it is the one place in this Mountain where no one will come to ask me a question, and I needed, for the length of one turned glass, to not be asked one.” I left her the turned glass.

Shield does not only defend a Mountain; it reckons, afterward, how the Mountain came to need defending. Va-Sheva ran that reckoning through the ninety days alongside the survival, because it was hers to run and because her office required her to walk toward the thing the rest of us were walking away from. She was auditing the breach. She wanted to know, the way Shield always wants to know, by what road the outside had come to the one door in the world it was never meant to find. The road, followed patiently, in the sealed dark, with the rigour her whole life had made of her, came home to a hand she had cut a key for herself.

I already carried the fact of it. Sarah had given it to me weeks before, in the dark, unable to go on holding it wholly alone — that the hand which turned the key had been Jean-Charles’s. What I did not carry, and could not have guessed, was what Va-Sheva would do with the same knowledge on the day her own office finally laid it in her palm. She told me after, in as few words as she ever gave anything, that she had spent three nights certain she had made an error in the tracing, because a wall does not often fail at the exact place its keeper has promised herself it cannot. And a fourth night certain she had not. He had come to her, years before, because a Veil of Shield who stood at the Horizon threshold was the finest door into the Mountain the outside had ever been offered. He had opened it the way he opened everything. Through it his service had taken the routes that brought a state to the folds. She held the proof of it in her own hand, in her own office, in the season after she had laid that same hand flat on his chest and named him Mountain.

And here is the truest single act I ever watched a person perform. It is the exact move that a ten thousand years of Mountain was built out of the refusal to make. She did not open him. She had the means — Shield is very good at opening people — and she had the grief and the right, if anyone ever had them. She did not use them. She did not go to him and demand to know how much he had chosen and how much he had been ordered, when the feeling in him had turned real, whether at the last he had tried to give his masters less than they asked. She let all of it stand unmeasured. Because to take the one question — *did you love me, or was I only a door* — and wring an answer from him would be to decide, forever, that he had been only a door; and she found, at the end of her audit, that she would sooner carry the not-knowing than manufacture the certainty. She chose the man over

the verdict. She kept him Mountain. She never once asked him the question, and never once let it go, and carried the two of them, unreconciled, to the end of her life.

I thought it weakness, the first time I saw the shape of it, the way I had once thought the salt-fish woman limited. I know now it was the strongest thing in that Mountain, stronger than the Beast.

On the sixtieth day, the Mountain opened a door that was on no map, and it was the Beast that opened it, not any hand.

We were in the deep, Sarah and Paul and I, with Ka-Orun of Justice. Justice had taken to keeping the two Outsiders near him, having decided, in the way of a man whose whole life is the weighing of things, that the safest place for a danger you cannot destroy is under your own eye. And the ground moved, once, the way it had been moving less and less as the far cascade wore itself out, a long low return rolling home through the crust from the antipode of the world. But this return did something the others had not. Deep in the rock below us there was a sound of stone releasing stone, deliberate, mechanical. A counterweight was falling, hung, we would learn, to be tripped by exactly this, by the last strong return of a completed firing and by nothing else. The door it held could be opened once, and only once, and only by a Mountain that had actually fired the Beast to the end.

Ka-Orun went white. I had seen the man rule the world's ending without his voice shaking, and a door opening turned him to a frightened old man, because the door was worse to him than the Cataclysm. The Cataclysm was in his law. This was not. "There is nothing there," he said. "I hold the— I hold the whole record of this Mountain. Every door. Every seal. Every chamber that has ever— there is nothing in that quarter of the deep but rock. I have the record. I have the record." And Sarah, who knew better than any of us what it is to learn that your record has a hole in it exactly where you were most certain it was whole, said to him, not unkindly, "Then your record was edited. Someone who came before you took that door out of it. Come and see what your office was not allowed to know."

The door stood open in the stone, a black seam where an hour before there had been a wall. Cold came out of it, and a smell of great age and dry paper and something mineral under that. Beyond it a stair went down into a dark that our lamps would not reach the bottom of. Ka-Orun of Justice, keeper of the complete and unbroken record of eleven thousand years, stood at the top of a stair his office had never known existed, and could not make himself take the first step.

It was Paul who went first, with the little machine already turning. I went after him, because the door had opened for the Mountain that fired the Beast and I was the eye that had fired it. If anyone alive had the right or the curse to read what waited at the bottom of that stair, it was me. And behind us, after a long moment, we heard Justice begin, slowly, to come down into the record he had never been permitted to keep.

I set my hand on the cold jamb of the door as I passed through it, the way I had set it against the Mountain's skin the night the first blow fell. The stone of the jamb was not like the stone of the Mountain. It had been cut differently, by different hands, to a different standard, older and finer and more certain of itself. I had no word yet for what that meant. I would have it by the bottom of the stair. We were about to walk out of the Mountain my people built and into the Mountain that another hand had built, and they were not the same Mountain at all. Everything I had been raised to call eternal and God-given had once been a set of drawings on a table in front of a living man, who had left his name, and his reasons, and his defence of himself, at the foot of a stair that only the ending of a world could open.

CHAPTER 22

CLOCK

The stair went down a long way, and at the bottom of it there was not a library.

I had expected a library. Paul had expected a library. We had come down braced for shelves, for the smell of a great many books. What waited at the bottom was a machine, and it was moving.

We stood on the last step and did not go down into it at first, the four of us. Shield's lamps found the near part of it and lost the far part in a dark that swallowed light the way deep water does. And there was a sound, very low, under the cold, a sound I had heard my whole life and never once been able to place. I placed it now with a lurch in the chest: it was the almost-nothing the wards call the breath of God, and it was this. This room. This slow turning. The machine that had been running under every prayer I had ever said, a mile of stone above me, every day of my life.

The chamber was not vast; that was the first surprise, after the endlessness of the stair. It was small, and dry, and cold with the deep cold, and it held one thing. Where Shield's lamps found it there stood a column of gears — gears upon gears upon gears, brass and a white stone worn to the shine of bone, the small wheels near the floor and the great ones climbing away up into the dark, each meshed into the next and the next into the one above. The lowest wheel of all turned as I watched, steadily, quick enough that the eye could follow it; and it drove the wheel beside it, which moved so much slower I had to hold my breath to catch it move at all; and that drove the one above, which did not seem to move; and the

one above that stood, to any watching in a human life, perfectly still. And I knew the thing. I had held it in my two hands as a boy, no larger than a lamp, the second gift the Outsider ever gave me: gears within gears within gears, the teeth carefully numbered, so that a fast turning at the bottom became, at the top, a hand that crossed a face once in a very long while. He had told me to keep it, to study. I had studied it a season and thought I had understood it. Here was the thing the toy had been a drawing of, grown to the size of the secret it kept, and turning under my Mountain since before my Mountain had a name.

“It is a clock,” Sarah said, in the flat voice she used when a thing was too large to be said any other way. She had gone straight to it, the way she went to any instrument, and was reading the faces of the wheels the way you read a gauge. “It does not count the hours. It counts the years, and it counts them the one honest way, which is to write the number down on a face where it cannot be argued with.” She moved her hand along the great slow dials near the top, not quite touching them. “Look at how they carry. Each wheel turns the one above it once, after it has itself gone round so many times — and it is not ten; count the teeth and the carry is twelve. They counted in twelves. So this face is years, and this is twelves of years, and this is twelves of twelves, and up and up. You do not count anything here. You read it, the way you read the distance a cart has rolled off the drum on its own axle. Anyone who can multiply can have the whole age of this Mountain off these faces in the time it takes to say it.”

Paul had come up beside her, and I watched his face do a thing I had seen it do only once or twice, the small private lighting of a man who has met, at the bottom of the world, an old friend. “I gave you this,” he said to me, not looking away from the wheels. “A child’s copy of exactly this.” He read the faces, his lips moving, and it did not take him two days, nor two hours. It took him the better part of a minute. Then he did it again, because it was not an answer a man takes the first time. “It is not eleven thousand years,” he said, very quietly. “It was never eleven thousand years.”

“And before you let yourself hope it is a fraud,” Sarah said — to me, because she had seen the hope move in my face, the hope that a liar had merely wound it wrong — “the wheel does not stand alone. It is trued.” She looked up. Far overhead, through a shaft bored with the patience of my people, there was a thread of the outside night, and a single faint star stood in the mouth of it. “That shaft was cut dead onto a star, at the one moment each year the star stands at the top of its arc. Once a year the star sits true in the shaft, and the clock is asked whether it

has kept the count, and mended if it has slipped a tooth. Your Light kept a watch on that star and called it the Eye of God.” She was quiet a moment. “And the star is no longer true in the shaft. It has crept off the cut line by exactly the amount the slow roll of the world’s own axis should carry a star across such a span. A liar can turn a wheel. A liar cannot roll the sky. The wheel and the sky agree, and they are not saying eleven thousand years.”

“Say it,” I said to her, because she had reached the number and would not speak it, and Sarah Blackwood unable to speak a number was a thing I had not seen. “Say it. I have been told a lie my whole life and I would rather have the truth from you than the lie from my fathers.”

“A hundred and forty-five thousand years,” she said. “Give or take what such a number gives or takes. Your eleven thousand are the reading on the last wheel and no more; the rest of them were turning, and true, and waiting to be read, the whole time your fathers knelt in front of them and called them the working face of God.” She stepped back from it. “That is the part I cannot get past. He did not hide it. It would have been nothing to him, a mind that could do this, to bury the count where no one could reach it. Instead he stood it in the open and wrote the truth on it in a number a bright child could read in a minute, and no child read it for a hundred thousand years. He made it holy. A thing you are told is holy is a thing you have agreed, in advance, never to look at.”

“It is worse than being late,” Paul said, meaning to comfort her and doing the opposite. “Everything we know out there rests on the idea that there was nothing before a certain shallow floor: that minds able to build this could not have existed, that the deep past was empty of us. And the deep past was full. There was a civilisation down here that could aim an earthquake through the core of the Earth before my ancestors had a word for the moon, and it left a clock any child could read, and made certain no child would ever be let to read it.”

I had learned deep time once before, from an Outsider, before I ever met one. In the first days of my captivity, when Paul was still only a voice on a machine to me, I had been shown a man in a red cap who took me down a canyon wall in pictures, layer under layer. He told me that a rock lying low is a rock lying old, and that the floor was older than my whole scripture and older again than that. *These immense periods of time baffle the imagination*, the man had said, and I had thought, in my pride, you don’t say, I who sat among the ten who mattered in

a world eleven thousand years old. I had taken it as a wonder about the Earth, a thing about rocks and dead beasts, far from me, safely far.

Now I stood at the bottom of my own canyon, and every turn of every wheel was a year my people had counted and hidden in plain sight, and it stood no distance from me at all. It was the machine I had prayed to. The immense period of time that baffled the imagination was the length of the lie I had been raised inside. Everything — the rock, the beast, the Mountain, the god — has a floor, and a first day, and a maker who numbered the teeth; and if you go down far enough you will find it, and it will have been made.

But the great faces of the years were not the only reckoning on the column. Low on it, apart, geared to the same works but seated on its own small iron drum, there was a second counter, and it was Ka-Orun of Justice who found it, because it is Justice's nature to look for the record inside the record. It did not count years. It counted endings. A stiff wheel marked not with numbers but with a single deep figure — the one I had seen at the heart of the Cataclysm gravure, the mark for the Beast — and it stood advanced some way round its drum. Sarah put her hands into the works a moment and came out grave. "It carries one notch each firing," she said. "Tripped by the same last returning stroke that opened the door to you on the sixtieth day. This one does not lie either. It only counts."

Ka-Orun read the little drum in silence. Then he read it aloud, once, in a voice I had not heard him use. "Six," he said. "It stands at six."

Six. The Mountain had not stood in peace for a hundred and forty-five thousand years; it had ended the world five times, and stood now in the ash of the sixth. Each time it had ridden the ending out in the sealed dark, come up, let the world climb back, and waited; and when the climbed-back world found it and reached for it again, it had ended the world again, and wound its own memory — never the clock, the clock it left running and true, only the memory — back to nothing. It had taught each new set of children that the world was eleven thousand years old and had never ended and never would, so that they would carry the terror pure, and never know they were the sixth to carry it.

"The Sixth Cycle Archive," Paul said, and I heard the whole book of it close in his voice, every strange phrase we had passed and not understood. "Not the sixth room of an archive. The archive of the sixth cycle. There have been five. We are the sixth. It is written on the door, and no one down here was ever let to read the door."

We stood with the fact of the six a long time. It was Sarah who said the thing that made it unbearable, because Sarah had spent her whole life at the far end of exactly this and could see the shape of the whole. "Do you understand what six means," she said. "It does not only mean it has happened before. It means it works. Six times a world has climbed all the way up from a made winter to a thing that could build a drill and a satellite and a state, and five times you have knocked it down to ash, and the sixth is falling now. Everything my kind ever built, every city, every book, every bomb, was one climb of the six. And unless something changes in this room, in us, tonight, there will be a seventh, that climbs a hundred thousand years out of the ash we have just made, and finds this door, and trips that little wheel to seven, and never once knows it was the seventh, exactly as you did not know you were the sixth." She laid one finger on the iron drum. "That is the machine. Six firings, and the same tooth coming round each time. It is a wheel. We are a spoke. And it means to turn forever."

Then Sarah said one thing more, quieter. She had set our six endings against a record I had never heard of. The outside keeps a year-count of its own, she told me, in the ice of the far south and the mud of the deep sea, layer on cold layer going back further than even this machine. She alone in that room could read it. And only a few of our endings, she said, matched a cold century her science had never been able to explain. The rest of the world's winters, its great dyings, its scattered drowned ruins, were the world's own, and owed us nothing. *Do not let this become the answer to everything*, she said. *Your Mountain is the hidden hand behind a handful of bad centuries that the rest of us blamed on comets and gods, and no more of human history than that, and it is monstrous enough. Whoever built this, his whole sickness was that he could not let a thing be the size it was. Do not you take it up now, standing here with a hundred and forty-five thousand years under you and the whole of the dark inviting you to make yourself the centre of it.*

Va-Sheva had come down with Jean-Charles, because Shield does not leave four Keepers and two Outsiders alone at the bottom of the world with a machine that ends it. She had listened to Sarah's wheel and her spoke without a movement of her face. When Sarah finished she said one thing only, in the flat Shield voice, and it was the most frightened I ever heard her. "Then Shield has watched the wrong direction for a hundred thousand years. We have watched the desert. We have watched the outside. And what turns the wheel was never out there at all. It is in this room, and in us, and in the plain fact that we will do it again." She looked at the drum that stood at six. "Shield cannot seal against Shield." And Jean-Charles,

who had held a stair at the ending of one world and now stood at the foot of the record of six, said nothing whatever.

I have said that each office carried its guilt in its own shape. Justice's shape was standing at six on a little iron drum, and it was worse than any of ours. I watched it break Ka-Orun.

Because Justice is the complete record. That is the office: that Justice remembers everything, edits nothing, keeps the true and unbroken account against which every act is weighed, so that no one in the Mountain can ever be judged by a lie or spared by a forgetting. That was the creed, and Ka-Orun had broken it with his own hand not a season past, at the dark bottom of my own trial. He had held an open enquiry into a real light a boy had been made to write false, and when its conditions were met he had closed it, because the truth of it belonged to a sealed charge and the Mountain came first. He had heard Shield say the world was round and answered that the Earth has no around, and recited scripture at the sky rather than learn it. And at the last he had turned to his own Candidate, the one hand in the room whose whole office was to get the true thing down, and said: record nothing of this; speak of it to no one while you live. He had cut a hole in the permanent record to keep a secret, and called it lawful, and by the law he had been right. He had ruled the ending of the world lawful, that same season, out of the completeness of a record he had himself just learned to edit. And now he stood in a chamber his office had never been permitted to know existed, in front of a counter his own fathers had kept honestly for a hundred and forty-five thousand years while they lied to him about the one figure on it that mattered — and he understood, before the rest of us, the worst thing in the room, which was that they were not other men. They were him. His office had been, all that time, the proudest instrument of the very erasure it was sworn against, and he had taken up the tool the first hour a truth grew too large for the Mountain to hold. It had passed the deception down, judge to judge, each one certain he held the whole, each one holding a hole, each one having, at least once, cut the hole himself and named it the law.

"I ruled it lawful," he said. He said it to the drum, not to us. "I stood over the Hall of Cataclysm and I found the condition met and I let the drop fall. Because I knew. Because I am Justice, and Justice — Justice knows." He stopped. "And I knew nothing. I did not know I was the sixth. The sixth judge, handed the same case, told it was the first. Perhaps they all ruled as I ruled. Perhaps the ruling is part of it, the same as the drop and the turning wheel: a thing built to come out the

same way every time it is fed. The machine decides. Justice is only the office that is made to feel it decided. And I have kept it fed. I closed a boy's true light and called it law. I told my own record to write nothing and called it law. I have cut the very hole my fathers cut, with this same hand, in the same season I ruled the world could end — and I did not feel it as a lie. I felt it as my office. That is the thing I cannot get past: that the erasing did not feel like erasing. It felt like Justice." He put his hand flat on the iron drum, over the six. "All my life I was certain. A thing done by law was done in the light. And I have found the room where they keep the light, and it was locked, and my own fathers locked it, and taught me the dark was the whole of the day."

And then, because he was Justice to the last of himself, he took out the wet clay of his office and began to record it there in the cold: the twelves and the reading of the faces, the drum that stood at six, the five hidden endings and the sixth we had just made. He wrote down, in his own hand, into the permanent record, the proof that his own office had lied for a hundred thousand years; and he wrote his own closings in beside them — the boy's light he had shut, the record he had ordered a Candidate not to keep — so that no Justice who came after him could ever inherit the clean version, or pretend the erasing had only ever been his fathers' work and never his own. "If I am only the office that is made to feel it decided," he said, pressing the marks into the clay, "then let me at least decide the one thing the machine did not build me to decide, which is to write down that I was fooled. Let the seventh judge, if a seventh is ever made, inherit this much: that he is not the first. It is more than one of my fathers gave me."

It was on the clock itself, on the oldest part of it, that I found the man.

For around the base of the great column, where the first and slowest wheels were seated into the rock, there was writing. I had taken it, as the others took it, for the maker's marks — the numbering of the teeth, the dry accounting a millwright leaves on his own work — or for the foundation liturgy, the oldest and least meaningful of the holy marks, the drone under the doctrine. Sarah and Paul could not read it. The script was a tongue no living mouth had spoken, drifted so far from Mountain speech across the cycles that even Paul, who could hear a language change under his hands, could only say it was the root of everything above it and nothing he could translate. So they turned back to the faces and the drum, and I was left alone with the base of the machine, and with the marks, and with my one gift, which is the seeing of what has been placed on purpose.

And I saw it. Among the maker's marks, threaded through them, carried down through an age of copying by hands that thought they were preserving a meaningless holy base and were in fact preserving a smuggled thing, there was a change of voice. The marks are a numbering; they have no I in them; a maker's marks never do, meant to sound as though the work made itself. And here, in a slightly different hand, ordered by a hidden rule that only showed itself once you stopped reading it as accounting and started reading it as a thing a person had arranged, there was an I. Someone was speaking. Someone had hidden himself in the dry marks at the foot of the god, and had waited a hundred and forty-five thousand years for a reader with an eye trained to see what is put in front of him on purpose. It was the exact eye my people had spent that whole time trying to breed and beat and exile out of existence. They had failed, once, in me, on the one night it was needed.

I read the first sentence of the I aloud, and it was not holy, which was the surest sign it was true: it carried the one thing scripture never carries, a person wanting something. *Let it be recorded, by the one who will not be recorded elsewhere, that what follows was chosen and not received; that a mind stood behind it; and that the mind was mine.* Paul made a sound. Sarah made none. Sarah had gone entirely still, the stillness of a hunter who has followed a track for sixty-six years and come, at the end of it, to a glass standing where the animal should have been. "He is defending himself," she said, very quietly. "The first words in a hundred thousand years to come out from under the god, and they are a defence. He knew. He knew it was wrong, or that it would be named wrong, and he wrote this to argue his case to whoever finally dug him out. He built the Mountain to keep the secret, and then he could not bear to be the secret, so he hid himself where no believer would ever look, and left his confession for the only reader who could reach it: an unbeliever with a trained eye. And he signed it as the first of a line."

"There is a man in here," I said, into the cold. They gathered around me by the lamps, four Keepers and two Veils and a witness and a woman who had chased this her whole life, and I read them the first words of the I under the god, where the man who built the Mountain had signed his work and told the future who he was.

He gave himself no title, and no name of the kind a man is given; he gave himself one word out of the root-tongue, cold and exact — and my eye, trained past every other in that room to catch what a hand sets down on purpose, caught the trick of it before my mind did. The word read the same struck from the first stroke or the last. It was a mirror stood upright in the stone, an ending and a

beginning cut into the one figure. And I understood, kneeling there, what he had made it say. He had set himself at the seam of the world: the last of the Old Kind, the people he had been born among, that was thinning off the earth in his lifetime as the Many crowded it out; and the first of the new kind he had made in the dark to stand where the old had stood.

Ravar.

But the signature was the end of what was written there, not the beginning. The hidden I gave its name and no more. The account it promised was not in the marks, not on the clock, not anywhere a lamp in that room could find; the last of its smuggled lines said only that what he had to say he had set apart, and below, for the one reader who could come at it, and that the way to it was not a way that could be told.

I found the way because I could see what the others could not. I will not pretend I understood it. It was in the light — some turn, or grain, or flaw in the manner the lamp fell across the deepest stone at the foot of the column, that my eye caught and could not let go of, and that no other eye in the room could find at all: not Sarah's, not Paul's, not Ka-Raedin's, who had been the best of the office of light for forty years. I had no name for it then and I have none now. I think I could see it only because I had spent a single season in the outside world being taught to doubt the very thing a Mountain eye is trained never to doubt. I looked at it until I knew, without knowing how, what it asked of me; and I did the small thing it asked; and a seam that no keeper in a hundred thousand years had known was a seam gave, and a door came away from the wall, and behind it a stair went down.

Down, below the clock, below the floor I had taken for the floor of the world. Ka-Raedin put his hand on my arm, and took it away again, and did not come. None of them came, at the first. They understood, the way you understand a thing in the body before the mind will have it, that this last door was cut for one reader, and that I was, by some accident a hundred thousand years in the making, the one. So I went down into it alone, with a lamp, and the deep cold came up the stair to meet me; and at the bottom there was a small room, and the room was a shrine, and on every wall of it, cut deep and patient and waiting through five endings of the world, was the account of the man who had made us all. I did not call up to them. After a while I heard them come down the stair behind me, one at a time, Ka-Raedin first and Sarah last, because a thing cut on a wall and kept through five endings of the world is not a thing that any of us was going to read alone.

CHAPTER 23

RAVAR

A man tells the truth only at the bottom of the world,
where the dark and the deep have taken every ear but his.
I have come down to that bottom, and set the truth down here
by the one whose name no book hereafter is to keep.

This I did not inherit; this I did, with my two hands.
A mind once stood here, and stood well, and now is gone.
We were the summit of the earth, the warm land and the cold;
we had named the lights of heaven, and set them in our songs.

Our dead went down still holding the small things they had loved.
Our tools were older than any man's own memory.
We wrote little; we kept the whole world alive in men;
and in that keeping lay the one flaw of us all.

A house of loyal skulls stays loyal only while they last.
We were losing, and I was the first to say the word.
No war had come: no blade, no siege, no king thrown down.
No one struck us; we were undone by an open door.

For there is a warmer kind of man than we had been,
more numerous, and lower, and their fires never go out;

and a people is not held by its walls, nor by its gods,
but by whether its daughters stay, and whose the children are.

And ours would not stay. They went at dusk to the low fires,
to a wider room, where a woman might be more than one thing;
no one drove them, no one carried them; they went in gladness,
and bred into the warm kind, and our summit thinned in theirs.

Whole cities, enough to fill a sea, burned to the ground
over one choice the chooser could not, after, explain;
and we would sooner blame a goddess than name it a whim.
And there is a mercy that has forgotten how to count.

It spends the last warmth of a house on the very guest
who came in from the cold to burn it; and we had that mercy,
and we called it goodness, and it was the shape of our end.
A virtue that cannot outlive its practice is no virtue.

My father saw it first, and gave the older answer:
a people never lives by being loved; break them.
He held the metal and the men, the gold to do it,
and had feared longer than I; long fear turns to iron.

I said no: their slaughter would be forever our stain,
and a thing so bloodily won is never worth the winning.
We argued the years away across one table,
and I won cleanly, and it did no good at all.

Her name was Ithe. I set it against my own rule,
for a record missing the true thing is the lie twice.
She was of my rank, my people, raised as I was raised,
the most complete soul I have known, and never praised.

She carried my child; my house would go on through her.
And an enemy of mine wanted that line ended.
They reached her unhappy: bought, or frightened, or lied to.
There was a woman of the old craft, who kept the poisons.

She knew a body's seasons, and the drawing-out.
Ithe went to her. The child was ended in a night.
Did she choose it, hating the door-less room I built?

Or was she a blameless lamp they bore through the dark?

I had the means that morning to learn the truth of her,
whether she wept in the choosing, or only in the cold.

I had the means to know the truth. I did not ask.

I did not ask her.

Desire is the one power large enough to end an age,
and it comes to us already wearing the face of fate,
so that no one, ever, is made to answer for it;
and I would not be the one to make her answer for it.

And the warm and mine might yet lie down and go on.
And I'd argue it all again, alone, my father dead,
and change nothing. So I did not ask. I let her stand
guilty; I asked her nothing; and all the world said guilt.

The enemy who reached my child had reached my father;
they killed him in a well-loved pass, but lightly held.
I stood above his body and said only: you were right.
And under the grief, deep in it, there lay a relief.

It was mine alone: the war he wanted died with him.
I had Ithe put to death. I gave the word, and watched.
I told myself I killed the guilt. I killed the question.
For the dead cannot be asked; I had chosen not to.

So I turned to the one I could still reach: the craft-woman;
I burned her, and it warmed me; we could not let this go.
then every woman of that craft, in every valley,
I took and burned; the first fire I set, and set it in her name.

You cannot burn a knowing from the world; it is taught again.
Another woman learns it, another fire, another year.
What cannot be destroyed can still be broken up,
and kept so that no one hand may hold the whole again.

He was dead, and all he held came to me alone:
the metal and the men, the buried knowledge, the estate.
I, who refused his war, held all he would have used,

and I raised no army; an army, in the end, loses.

His answer had been a war. Mine would be a story,
and a story, told long enough, outlasts every army.
I gathered those who knew the stone, and those who knew the springs,
and those who knew the lights, and the making of hard things.

And soldiers too, for a work so dear must wall its mouth;
and I emptied my father's house, and turned its face south.
And I took children. Set that down. It is the worst seed.
A place to outlast its own making must be young.

It must be peopled with those told a thing was always so.
I said that they were saved, and they were; and also this:
they were the first of a new kind of people on the earth,
raised to tend a thing they must never grasp, and kneel to it.

The road south took the better part of a year; I lost them
to the heat, to the sand, to the slow leak of a dead land.
Each loss I set down in a reckoning, and did not mourn.
We passed the last green, the last water mine had drunk.

We passed the last mark of a people, and reached the waste,
a waste beyond the wanting of any living thing.
A man swallowed whole returns not the one who went down;
the deep keeps a part of him, and hands the rest a purpose.

He never chose it. The waste swallowed me, and gave me back
a maker, a task in his hands he had not asked to hold.
My engineers began to tell me, in frightened voices,
that no such place was on the earth, in any land.

I answered with a cold thing I had long held true:
a closed world holds, in the end, but two kinds of road —
the loop a man may draw shut to a single point,
and the loop that rides a hole forever, never shuts.

I drew mine tighter across the dead land, and could not tell
whether the line would close at last upon the place I sought,
or catch on a hole in the world where I had set my hope.
I hunted a thing that may not stand on the whole earth.

And still I would not turn; I had gone blind to every road

that bent, or ended, or came back short of itself.

I went into the desert believing I would save them,
and in that I told no lie: my people were undone.

And someone, truly, had reached into my house and killed.
Both things were true. Grief was not the source, it was the amplifier:
the wound had learned to speak in sentences, each one true;
and a grief that tells you only true things, you follow.

We found it the third year out; I knew before my men.
For I had left the hunting ground that men desire,
and turned to ground no man goes near; the earth gave in.
It offered nothing, and its nothing was first defence.

No green, no game, no road, no reason, a shoulder of stone,
and a killing width of distance on every side.
It lay far out in a waste that murders men by breadth,
and gave nothing to warm folk going south, who never turned.

Then, under the nothing, my water-men, season on season,
laid slender rods against the stone; the stone gave up
its buried secrets; the first was water, so much water
my chief sat on the rock, face in hands, made no sound.

More water than a siege drinks, enough to hold a people;
years passed before I said aloud what the water was for.
And heat beneath it, the old deep heat, a patient fire,
shallow to reach, never fed; sealed folk would not freeze.

And ways: there were faults, voids, and the promise of more,
of more to be cut, till a new world hung down the rock.
Three years on a road that killed my people, called me mad,
and at the end I had the thing, glad past all I dared want.

We laughed like boys in cool shade, and every rod said yes;
a man the world lays tools before feels chosen in his bones.
And nothing in my long life since has matched that one year.
I saw the other thing too, deep in a shaft, by lamplight.

The deep fire never dies; water flashed on it steams;
steam sent down a throat through the world becomes a hand,

flat hand on the turning world's beating heart, to press it.
My engineer, not knowing my mind, told the force he'd raise.

The ground gave my people's living; in the same grey stone,
the means to do to all the warm earth the thing done to mine,
and worse, all at once, and hidden from every watching eye:
one gift, that fed a house and could unmake a world.

And I told myself, in that same bright year, a lie:
that this hand I had learned to lay upon the world
was a hand I would hold still, and never learn to close;
that it would only ever be a thing of defence.

Do not take the building for a wonder; those who came
called it the masonry of God; that is the first lie.
It was labour, and mine: the greatest ever raised,
gathered in one place, done by the living, one by one.

The road ran long and killing, and I went down it whole,
and I bore the work across the most of my life.
It cost; I paid in the one coin such things are bought with,
the lives of others; I kept the account, and it is long.

We learned the work by failing; the first great press,
built to prove the deep hand answered, killed its builders.
They died for what none knew: what water, flashed to steam
inside a shut and airless place, will do to men.

I stood at the gallery mouth and watched them borne out,
the broken rest; I kept my face still, and said nothing.
I did not halt the work; I went and fixed the drawings.
A fault beneath a stair took off a hundred in an hour.

A wall let go one night, a shift drowned, and we lost ten years.
We never learned to meter water till enough men died;
I did not wait upon their dying; every gain was bought,
and I was the one who bought it; and I stood firm.

You will want a single number; I have one, for I kept count,
kept it true; the one plain virtue I claim with no lie.
More than forty thousand came down that road while I breathed,

and fewer than a third would climb it back into the day.

Some twenty-seven thousand stayed in the rock they cut,
in flood, in fall, in steam, in the slow grind of the land,
a land that wanted nothing from us, nothing at all;
and each of them is a line in the ledger I still keep.

I built the greatest refuge, to keep my people whole,
and built it on a floor made of their bones, and did not slow.
When a chief came white with word of another hundred lost,
I asked him first whether the work they died upon still held.

I watched the hour his love died; I let him cease, said nothing,
and turned my eyes to the cold drawings; he went; I stayed.
Then I did the thing that let them work to that end, never rise:
I saw to it that not one of them could wholly understand.

No team of the hundred could hold two pieces at once.
Only my few knew the well, the sun-ways, the drainage, gates
were one engine, and the engine a single weapon,
aimed to be driven down through the deep core of the Earth.

I did not first divide it against a foe outside;
I divided it against the hands within, so that no man,
alone, could hold enough at once to see what he had made,
and, understanding it whole, set it down, turn, refuse.

Five works there were, five teams, and over each a head;
the whole split among the five, ungathered, unspoken.
I saw, even then, that I must die, and this my work
must run past me, longer than a name is kept, and stand.

So, before my end, I did what turns a day's work
into a people, and outlives its maker far:
I ceased to call the teams by teams; and from that day
I made them teams no longer — I made them the lines.

To each line a discipline, to mask its true labour;
the discipline grew real knowledge, freely taught, deep, all true.
So the cage I built around them, wall and door and bar,
was fashioned, every part, of true and living light.

I made of Faith an ear, and of Light an eye, that could
fall on any man at any hour, and needed not to fall:
for a people that can be heard and seen whenever I please
will hear and see itself for me, and keep its own cell shut.

I gave to every hand its place, its use, its rung, its wall,
and let no hand be more than these: a man became his office,
his name a rank, his worth a task, his hidden self a door
that opened only where I stood, and nowhere of his own.

And Justice I set to weigh them — not their quarrels alone,
but the yield of every hand, its diligence, its falling-short;
so each was measured always, in the open and within,
and a thing weighed often enough soon learns to weigh itself.

Two of the five I bound to the halves of my own wound:
the deed I gave to men, the law and the leave to end;
the body I gave to women, the rhythm, the match, the birth,
so the hand that took their choosing wore a mother's face.

I did not ask them to be good; goodness I could not make.
I made the kneeling pay: the devout I fed and kept,
and let the doubter thin; so each one guarded my god
not for the love of him, but for the bread it bought.

Truths, the whole, and each separate piece a naked truth;
I set the truths in a ring round a hole I taught was God.
At the lip of it I taught the kneeling soul a holy dread,
built into the teaching for one purpose, and no other.

So a curious mind would flinch from the one question,
at the hour it ripened, fit to ask; I taught well, and true.
Not one of them, in all the long line, has known he did it;
of all I made and hid in this Mountain, that is my proudest.

Then I did the thing that beats beneath all the rest,
for a sound reason, and the soundness is the worst:
the engine I had made bore one deep flaw of my kind,
it must live by living hands, and a hand turns to dust.
Call five unsteady hands a throne, the throne a weapon,

give them forty quiet years, and five afraid, praying priests
 who had forgot they were engineers, above an engine
 that none could run. I built a test and hid it well.

I wrapped the test in deep devotion, and I made it law:
 at each succession, when one Keeper died, another rose,
 the five would draw in secret close, to work a hidden thing
 I dressed for them as prayer; they came to call it covenant.

Beneath the words of prayer there lay a firing, one small firing,
 large enough to prove the engine answered when it was told,
 and small enough to leave the world above it all unharmed,
 and left the whole world up above unknowing of the blow.

A few drops of water on the deep fire, done five times;
 the long slow wait between is due, and must be given whole;
 the engine knows one measure only, and no other beat,
 for one stroke off its measure tells a listener nothing.

I called it readiness, and said God confirms His Keeper,
 and said it did no more; but in the secret truth, one hour,
 within that hour my patient engine reached down through the deep,
 and there within its own dark deep confirmed itself.

The first time in my life, to prove the thing, I stood in the Hall
 I built to hold and shape that toll, and heard the Earth reply;
 it was the most beautiful and worst thing I have made —
 I gave my cold machine a heart, to beat beneath the sand.

The machine and its offices were the easy part;
 the hard was the one thing no later folk could invent,
 being the offspring. Trained hands hold a living craft
 few lives; an age on, they forget its use, and it is gone.

I had not paid my father's end, forty thousand dead
 in rock, to raise a thing that dies in six brief lives;
 so I set to stop the clock. One road only would serve:
 I built a people to be the keeping of it all.

I built their very selves to be the keeping, so none
 could stop. The children I took were all of three kinds:

our own kept seed, some bought, and some I gathered up
off the failing land; and each I raised inside a lie.

The Mountain, in the lie, had always stood where I built it;
the offices were holy, where I had written down
a duty, a plain roster of plain men; and the engine
a living god, where these my hands had made a weapon.

I wrote a past and aged it, so the newest child, turning,
would find fresh proof that all was old past any counting,
and never doubt his days a late leaf on a tree
whose reckoning of years was lost past all recall.

Among the first I set some actors who knew the truth,
who agreed, for love, fear, promise, to spend their lives
in feigning faith. The next, who watched, came to believe
unfeigned, and grew by watching into a faith made true.

And by the third, no least pretence was left alive;
they knew it wholly, without a seam, the easy way
a young child knows the sky: given, and never asked.
Alone, in the build's worst nights, I carved the Genesis.

Its aim was plain: to make the whole outside a horror;
and it came easier than I could wish: deliberate insertion was possible.
should want the world outside, I took one true thing, turned
it once, a single quarter, the one turn a good lie needs.

The one true thing was a murder, a real thing anchors
each lie, and I set it deep in the oldest of the ages:
the slain man was a brother, loved and envied; the killer's
line I gave the open land, cursed, many, green shade denied.

Into it I set a woman too, taken as spoil
the hour the man fled; and in the stone I cut her out
as blameless as a stolen lamp, a thing that had been done
to her, and never by her, so purely was she carved.

And what I filed away from the marble was the truth
that lay beneath her, which I have set down above:
that she went, or was led; that I did not ask, but could;
that I killed her for it, and burned the craft in her name.

So in the carving I let it go, and let her stand
 a pure and simple loss; I drowned her choosing in the grave,
 the grave my father lay in; and I have watched the Keepers
 read her to trembling boys, an evening's whole world's word.

I will not explain each stone; the later people
 bowed down to these, and made a fetish of them; not so I.
 I will not feed it. A few I give, and only these,
 for you who knelt to them, are owed this reckoning.

The great disk swinging in the Hall, which my late children
 take for the working face of God at weight upon the world,
 and name the mover of the Hours, and dread, and kneel before,
 is a clock, and free of any god, and it fires nothing.

Its weights are wound and wound again, and it never stops;
 and because it never stops, the buried clock below
 never stops its count of the years. The men who tend it
 keep the whole machine alive, and think they keep a prayer.

I dressed its needful emptiness as the sacred void,
 the hole they name their God, that the people keep it clear;
 they kneel about an emptiness that must stay open,
 and the long worship, year on year, keeps the throat free.

Two gravures I set in the stone: one dawn above the kneeling,
 a painted dawn that never broke, the promise that is the lie;
 and one, the Cataclysm, hung below where the Trials are judged,
 honest, in open sight, read as prophecy and left unread.

This deep room, clock and ledgers, one door firing frees,
 I built the last of all, and told no soul, not the five;
 by slow degrees, three lives, it sank beneath the failing
 memory of the offices, and grew a stranger thing.

Justice, to this hour, knows not it once knew this place;
 a hidden heart within a hidden body, kept in dark,
 in patient dark an age, for you.

Why keep a written record, when what I was lay hidden?

I have wondered at it; more than one answer is true,
and the true answers I find give each other the lie.
I kept it first, in hope to be one day known and seen.

It is the least of reasons, the one that shames me most.
For I had made sure no soul within the work would know
a mind had once been there; and then I found I could not
endure to vanish in it, and leave no heir behind.

I wanted one to see the hand; vanity outlasts grief;
and across the unbridged abyss of ages, here you are.
And I kept it, too, to defend myself; when first I wrote,
I still supposed a reader who had seen all I had seen.

The clear-eyed reader coming at last to this door
will be of the kind who uses the door to cast me off;
and this I have found: I mind its coming far less now
than through the long years I had told myself I would.

I believed a made thing keeps the shape its maker gave,
as clay keeps the thumb; that is the pride of every maker.
But a made thing is an alloy of the flaw that poured it,
and no hand, having made a monster, knows what it will do.

And last, the cause I could not own till both were written:
beneath it all, I wanted a door. Beneath the lord and plan,
beneath the old wound, there stood a man who knew too well
a thing that never can be stopped should never have been made.

He was a man who could not quite bring himself, in the end,
to build an engine that offered no way back out.
And so I hid a way out; I laid the truth at the bottom,
behind a door that only the fired weapon can unlock.

So it falls to a far age that took the weapon up in need;
and among them, only to an eye trained to make out
what was set, on purpose, in the dark – the very eye
my system was designed to breed away, and could not.

I am an age long dead by the hour that you read this,
and yet it was I who built the door. Whatever else,
whatever of me you weigh and settle in the end,

hold hard, above all else, to this one thing alone.

Here, at the deep bottom of the worst and darkest thing
that ever has been made by any living hand,
its maker, before he goes, has left one door in the dark,
and left that one last door standing open, for you.

The end of the long build was the cruellest of all,
and I did it cleanly, for I had grown too old,
had lost the power to feel the thing that I spent,
and gone so wholly cold I did not flinch at it.

The thousands whose hands had cut the great work from stone
could not be loosed to bear its pieces to the world;
for knowledge divided stays safe only divided,
and hands set free will always seek their fellows out.

Grown old and scattered far apart, yet those hands would meet,
and drink, and set the kept-apart pieces back to one.
What I did to keep them from that meeting made me tremble;
and that I will not write, not now and not ever.

Some of them went out, sworn hard and scattered and watched;
and some stayed on to labour in the sealed new world,
and these were told they always, always lived below;
and some among them would not go, and never went.

That account is long; I kept it, as I kept the rest,
and it is the worst and longest page that I own;
I have set it well apart from this confession here;
I do not ask you read it; only leave it alone.

Believe this much of me, and only this, and no more:
I could not lay the doing of it on my own hand,
and in my quailing did it through other men's hands,
and turned my face away from what my hand had willed.

They were gone by then, one way or the other, all,
and the great gates shut at last against the waiting world,
though the sealing of them would wait an age past mine.
The gates, though, held; and none would pass them any more.

Inside there lived a whole people, a few thousand souls:
the kept seed of the work, the children they had raised,
and the ageing actors, each one grown old at his part,
and these were all that breathed within the sealed new world.

On the first grey morning of the newly sealed world,
they woke, and rose, and went about their offices,
and said their prayers, and knelt around the forbidden ground,
the empty ground that none of them might ever tread.

The children born below from then knew nothing of a world
that stood above them in the light, nor could be found there
by any walker of the world; and they in their turn
would teach their children so, and hand the lie down whole.

I stood among them, old and finished, and I did it,
and watched the lie draw its first breath among them there,
and I saw that it was good, in the grey morning light.
God, God forgive me now for everything I had done.

It was the most beautiful thing that I have ever seen:
a whole new world, awoken in the early grey light,
a whole new world at dawn that fully believed itself
to have always been, and never once to have begun.

And yet I would not trust it on faith, but had to see:
the weapon speak, the world go under, the clock reset,
the room I built bring the Mountain back from its own ash.

I woke the Beast myself, once, with my own hand, and ended
the world above, to be certain that it could be ended;
the sky went to ash; the sealed few rode the long cold out,
and the reset ran as I had written it, and did not fail.

My liturgy came to pass. The children woke to the day
I made for them, and were told the world had always been so.
And the great Archive, at the last, was only what I built:
a room, a clock, a way back; nothing holy; and it held.

Now I know it will run without me, and need me no more,
forever; and so I will do the thing none will believe.

I will rise from this room, and walk out of the Mountain's mouth,
alone, into the world that I have ended, on my feet.

I will go to see with my own eyes what I have done,
and go down, at the last, into the deep, and face it.
I set this here, that whoever comes will know it of me:
the maker will not stay to be worshipped in his own dark.

He will go out into the ash he made, and not look away.
I was Ravar, last and first, the maker of you all;
my father the outside killed; my child the outside took,
through the hand of the one I loved, unasked, then killed.

I penned a people in a room, and after many years the wall became the horizon,
and the lock became the law; what had been taught them young they named
the sense of things, and what lay past their teaching seemed absurd before it
wrong.

You too were given measures long before you learned to weigh; and now you read
my little grief, and know how small it was. Be careful of that smallness. I have
watched an age go down through choices thought private while their furthest
consequences lay unseen.

Condemn me if you must; I do not bargain with the word. But before the judg-
ment settles, turn the measure in your hand. Ask what taught you which loss
is private, which may shake a world, and where the wall was laid that made
the difference seem plain.

I chose certainty, and would, so wounded, choose it again.
Go far slower than you mean to, with your cold verdict.
For in the setting-down of all of this, I have come
the one thing I built all of the Mountain never to say.

The Beast is not the fire, nor the water, nor the stone.
I made it in my own image; it is me; and it is loosed;
and I will walk its ruin now, at last, as what I am.
I am the Beast.

CHAPTER 24

WHOLE

When a thing is finished being read there is a silence that belongs to it, and we gave Ravar his, in the cold of the shrine, with the last wall read and the great clock turning far above us up the stair. And then the silence ended, the way all of them do, because someone has to be the one to say what happens now. It fell to me. I was the one he had built the door for.

But we did not leave him at once. A confession, when it is finished, asks for an answer, and a dead man cut on a wall cannot be denied it any more gently than a living one. So we gave it to him, each in turn, into the cold, knowing he could not hear and saying it anyway; and I have set down what we said, because it was the nearest thing to a trial the man will ever have.

Paul spoke first, because he had read the whole of it with the fact-checker's ache in his face. "He had a real wound," he said. "That is the horror of it: every line is nearly true. A father truly murdered, a child truly taken — and with all of it true, he refused to check the one fact that might have kept the wound the size it was. He put the question to the whole world and would not put it to the one woman. A man who would sooner build a hundred-thousand-year machine than ask a question he is afraid of the answer to is not a philosopher. He is a man running from a room, and this is the size of the room."

Sarah spoke to the wall, as though the man cut in it could be made to hear one thing. "You said desire is the one power large enough to end an age, and cunning

enough to wear the face of fate, so that no one is ever made to answer for it. I have been that thing, for sixty-six years, so take the flaw in it from an expert. I answered. I reached for the largest thing there was and closed my hand on it and burned down everything else, and not once have I told myself a goddess made me, or fate, or my blood. You wanted certainty, and you were wrong, and you dressed it as a doom laid on you by the nature of women. There is no fate — only a choice a hand could not bear to own, and hung on the sky, and knelt to; you built a mountain of it. I am a woman. I chose. It was mine. That is the one sentence you could not say, and it is the only sentence that would have saved you.”

Va-Sheva did not speak to the wall. She spoke to me, in the flat Shield voice, and it was the hardest thing said in that room. “He tells you that mercy forgot how to count; that a kindness which cannot tell a stranger from an enemy is only a slow way of agreeing to disappear. And you want to believe him, because a man reached you through your own love the way one reached his house. So hear it from the one he would have named the wound. I was a made thing; I was raised in his cage and told it was the sky, exactly as you were. And here is the thing he built the whole Mountain so that no child of his would ever say: you become real the first hour you answer for yourself, and not for the hand that made you. I chose Jean-Charles. Not the Many; not a species reaching through me; a man, particular past any generalising. I chose him, and I answer for it, and you do not get to take that from me to mend yourself.”

And I said the last of it, because it was mine to say, and because I had felt his shape trying to close over my hand the whole way down the stair. “He made us,” I said. “That is the truest thing on the wall. He made a people to be things that could never answer, so that his machine would run without a mind to trouble it. But a made thing can still refuse the shape it was made for. He cut the door for a reader who would understand him and forgive him by doing the same. I understand him. I will not do the same. That is the whole of my answer, and it is smaller than his crime, and it does not reach back and lighten by one soul what he did, and it is the one thing he raised a hundred thousand years of Mountain to prevent, and could not.”

We were ready to leave him, at last. Before we did, I said a thing to Paul that I could have said to none of the others, because only Paul would let it stay as small and as strange as it was. “Do you know what he makes me think of, this Ravar? Your Basquiat. The dinosaur king, in the corridor at the house. I cannot tell you why.” And Paul, who had made me explain every word I ever gave him, looked a long moment at the wall, and let it stand.

We had done what the machine was built to make us do, correctly, by law, for the sixth time. The Mountain would do now what it had done the five times before, which was to close over the truth of it and go on. We had not broken the wheel that night; we had turned it, like the five hands before us. The offices would go back into their walls. The deep truth — the six cycles, Ravar, the hand of the five — would sink again out of the daylight. Ka-Orun's tablet, the one he had cut with his own hand beside the deep clock to tell the seventh judge that he was not the first, would not be destroyed; the Mountain does not destroy a thing a Keeper has set in the permanent record. It would be worse than destroyed. It would be kept. Within three generations a Justice who had never been taught what it was would find it too holy to read and too old to move, and set a lamp before it, and fold it into the liturgy of his office as a thing recited and never understood, exactly as Ravar had folded the Cataclysm into a prophecy so that the diagram at the heart of the Mountain could hang in the open and never once be read. The children would be taught that the world was young and the Beast a story and the Mountain eternal and God's, exactly as I had been taught.

The only thing still ours to decide was whether the truth would be allowed to die with the forgetting, as it had died five times before — or whether, this once, for the first time in a hundred thousand years, a little of it would be let out the door before the door swung shut. And one thing harder than that, which came to us later: whether the machine behind the door would be left exactly as we had found it, or whether we would spend our one open hour taking something out of it that forgetting could not put back.

It is one thing to answer a dead man on a wall, out loud, in front of the others, with the true words ready to hand. It is another to keep those words true afterward, in the dark of your own chest, alone, for the rest of a life. I felt Ravar working in me before I understood what he was doing, and I set it down as a warning, because it does not look dangerous at all. It looks like grief.

He had left me more than a confession. He had left me a shape, a way of turning a wound into a world, and it fitted my hand because it had been made for my hand, a hundred thousand years before, by a man of exactly my kind carrying exactly my hurt. And I felt it offer itself. Because I too had been left. I had stood in a country I could not find and watched a woman I had spent years revering step, for the length of one breath, into a man from the outside, and be, in that breath, more than the one finished thing I had required her to be, and glad. And here, in Ravar's hand, was the doctrine that made sense of it, that raised it up off the floor of my private

humiliation and set it among the fates of peoples. That this is what they do, the warm ones; that they reach us through our loves; that where Va-Sheva seemed to have chosen a man, a species had claimed her; and that my hurt was therefore a wound in the body of my people, and a reason.

It would have been the easiest thing I have ever done, to pick up Ravar's shape and put my grief inside it and let the grief become a doctrine. Ravar's doctrine would not ache the way my grief ached; it would take the pain out of my own chest and set it somewhere I did not have to feel it. He built the Mountain to house a pain he could not otherwise carry. I understood, sitting there, that I was one decision away from doing the same on whatever scale was left to me.

Ravar had a woman taken from him by the enemy's hand and called it the nature of a species. And I had loved her, and I could not love her and use her as evidence both.

She came to me, near the end of the ninety days, because I had asked her to. I had meant to do a thing I am ashamed of: make her explain it, account for it, give me the reason in a form I could hold, as though I were owed one. She knew before I opened my mouth. She always knew; it was her office and her nature both.

"You want me to explain him to you," she said. "Or to explain you to yourself by way of him. I will not do either." She sat, not close. "I loved you. I want that said plainly, once, because I will not have you spend the rest of your life able to doubt it. I loved you, and I contained you to keep you breathing, and I grieved you while I did it. None of that is the same as choosing to stand the rest of my life beside you. You have always folded the loving and the choosing into one, and required that if a person loved you they must choose you. It is the thing you share with the man in the ledgers. It is the thing I could not live inside."

"And Jean-Charles," I said, because I could not help it, because Ravar was still in me, reaching. "You know now what he did. You held the proof in your own hand."

"I know what he did," she said, "and I have chosen not to know why. He is a man I chose. That is the whole of the sentence. I will not open him to find out in what order he did the terrible thing and the brave thing and the loving; I would rather carry the not-knowing than manufacture the verdict." She stood. "Do not make my life into your reason. I am not a reason. The choosing is mine, and you do not get to have it."

She had made hers first, and harder, for a living man she had to go on seeing every day. I let her go.

There remained the account — Ravar's confession, the mechanism, the year-clock, the six seams, all of it in one place with the door still open — and the question of what a Mountain does with the one thing it was built never to let anybody hold. It was Sarah who answered it, as an enemy, which was the only way it could be answered, and she made us know it.

She was the one living Outsider who could read what she held. Everything she had spent sixty-six years reaching for was, at last, hers to take. The made winter walking across the world above us was the price of the reaching, and she carried that too, without once trying to set it down.

"You are all waiting to see what I will do," she said, on the last day of the ninety, with the offices gathered and Paul's stacked record between us and the door still open on the turning machine. "You are right to be afraid. I have spent my whole life becoming the person who takes this, and the habit of a life does not die because the life has learned better. I will not ask you to trust that I have changed. I have not. I want it exactly as much as I ever did. So I will do the one thing that works without my having to have become good." She laid her palm flat on the record. "And do not flatter me by imagining there is a world up there still to deter. I have listened to it go quiet for ninety days on your own instruments. There are no rivals left to warn off this desert; there is scarcely a state left standing to send one. That is not the wall I am offering you. Hear the real one, because it is worse and it is stronger. Whatever climbs back up out of the ash you have made — and something always has, five times over, or we would not be standing here — will do again exactly what you did: forget, invent a kindly story, and be governed by a lie it cannot see. That is the only enemy left, and it is a hundred thousand years away and unarmed, and it is the one your machine cannot kill. So you will give this to me, and I will carry it out and lodge it where the next world will trip over it while it is still young enough to be changed by it. There is no war left to deter. There is only the forgetting to break, once, before the survivors write their own Genesis over the top of yours. A secret buried with you is a weapon for the seventh cycle. A secret loose in the open, in the hand of the one Outsider mad enough to have spent a life reaching for it, is a letter to whoever comes next. That is the whole of what I have to sell you, and I am the only one alive who can carry it, and you know both of those things, which is why you will say yes."

The deciding was hard and slow. It divided the offices the way every true thing divided them, because this had to be the Mountain's, made against its own every instinct, or it would not hold. Shield could not bear it; Ka-Dhavar had kept the secret with his life, and every bone in him cried that a secret shared with the world is a secret lost. Balance counted, and could no longer make the old way come out safe against a world that had found us once and would rebuild and find us again. And Justice, Ka-Orun, who had learned in the high dark what it costs to inherit a lie, ruled last, and ruled two things: that the account would go out, once, with Sarah Blackwood; and that the Mountain would keep its own. When he ruled it he reached back to his own words, which I had never seen Justice do. "I told a sealed chamber once," he said, "that a man who walks far enough draws the last road shut and comes home holding the whole, and that a seamless world keeps no outside. I set it down as the reason we could let nothing out. I have lived to watch it come true, and to learn that it cuts both ways: there is no outside to hide this in either. The road has drawn shut and left a seam, and through the seam one account will go, by my ruling — because a world with no outside cannot bury forever what it knows, and I would rather be the hand that chose the opening than the one that is opened by force."

That was the ruling on the memory. There was a second, harder one on the machine, and it was Ka-Leth who would not let us walk past it. A record changes nothing a hand cannot change back, she said, in her flat way. We could carve the whole truth into the Archive and hand its twin to Sarah and lie down proud of ourselves, and a Justice four cycles on would read it as scripture and fire the seventh Beast with Ravar's confession folded into the liturgy as a hymn. If we wanted the next firing to be a thing a Mountain had to choose and could not merely inherit, a record would not be enough; we would have to look, while the door stood open and five people who understood the machine were still alive, at whether a hand could take anything from it that a frightened future could not simply pick back up.

We could take out very little, and that is the part I have had to make my peace with. The Beast is the Mountain. The deep water that would drown a hemisphere is the water the city drinks; the heat that would break a continent is the heat that keeps five thousand people from freezing; the throat that carries the blow down is the throat that carries our air. Pull the engine and you kill the parish to spite the weapon. Balance laid the numbers out and they came out the way they always came out: to disarm the Mountain in a season was to end it in a season, by a slower

road. So the reset had to happen. The water had to run and the wards had to close and the offices had to go back into their walls and divide the knowledge again, because dividing the knowledge is also how the water is kept clean and the air kept moving. Life and fire were poured into one vessel a hundred thousand years ago, and no hand in ninety days could unpour them.

So the machine would go on entire, and there was nothing we could subtract from it to make the next hand safer. The one thing that had nearly been subtracted, the enemy had done for us, and we spent our open hour undoing it rather than finishing it. Faith had all but died in the firing. Ka-Elun was gone, and the timing she alone had carried — the phase, the note beneath the note, the reading of the returning stroke that no reckoning off the stars can rebuild — had been poured, the night we fired, into the only ear the law would suffer it into, which was Paul's. But the Veil of Faith had not died with her Keeper. Va-Maera had been dragged living from the same fall of stone, deaf in both ears for good and broken in the body, and for a while sunk too far in the hurt to speak; and she had come back. She would never hear the Mountain again — Faith's own listening was burned out of her — but her mind was her own, and she held the whole of the craft save the one fragment the roof had knocked loose into an Outsider's keeping. So Paul gave it back. Not out, to the world, where the danger begged for it and the law forbade it; but in, to Va-Maera, in the cold, the one place it could go and still be Faith. She rose from Veil to Keeper with an Outsider's returned gift in her; and though a deaf woman cannot hear the note, she can teach a hearing child what to listen for, and tell a true call from a false one, and stand behind the next Veil and the Keeper after her until the ear is trained that hers can no longer be. Faith would pass, whole, down the inside of the Mountain, and the secret went neither into the stone nor out into the world.

So we built no lock into the machine, because there was none to build that would not also strangle the people the machine keeps breathing. We left instead the only safeguard a truthful hand can leave: the truth itself — cut whole into the Archive for the next one who ever comes down the stair, and carried whole out of the folds in Sarah's copy for the world above — and the wager, thin as it is, that a Mountain shown exactly what it is might, once, choose to be something other than what it was built to be. The stone account can be read as scripture by a Justice with no wish to understand it; Sarah's copy can be lost, or seized, or sold by a granddaughter with her appetite and none of her strange restraint. We did not make the seventh firing impossible. We left the world above a chance to prevent it, and made certain that if it came nevertheless, the Mountain could never again

bury what it had done beneath necessity, or theology, or lost history — and we accepted that not one of us would live to learn whether it would be enough. It is the nearest thing to hope the Mountain has made in a hundred thousand years, and it is very nearly nothing, and it was the most we could do without killing the people we were trying to save.

For the Mountain kept its own. That was the other half of the ruling, and it is the half the world will never hold, and it cost us the best of us to make.

The counterweight had told us the Archive opened once, and only once, and only to a Mountain that had fired the Beast to the end. With the reset it would close again and not open until the next hand fired the next Beast. Whatever was to be kept at the centre had to be finished and left inside before the door shut, in a form an age and a made winter could not eat. Tape perishes and paper burns; so it had to be cut into the stone of the shrine itself, beside Ravar's own account, in the one place the next one down the stair would ever come. You cannot carve a mountain's heart in a workshop and carry it back in; it had to be done there, in situ, and it was the work of many weeks to set that much down true in rock. And the door could be held open only as long as the reset could be held off, which Balance had fixed to the hour and would not move — the air, the stores, and the final closing of the wards all fell due on the one day, and the shutting of the Archive was a single motion of that same reset, not to be paused and never to be reopened. So the cutting would run to the last hour the door could be held, and the hand that did it would still be inside when the door came down.

There was only one hand it could be. Not a Keeper's: for a Keeper to carve the whole into the permanent record would be Ravar's own crime committed again in stone, one hand holding the whole forever, and Justice would sooner have let the truth die. Not mine: I was of the Mountain and bound by the same law, and I was needed alive besides, to carry Sarah's copy up out of the folds and to be the witness that any of it had happened. Only Paul held no office and could do nothing with the whole but remember it and cut it true — the very reason the five had deposed it into him in the sealed dark — and only Paul had spent a life learning to set a true thing down exactly as it was. To have another cut it to his dictation would only make a second hand that held the whole, and the law would close on that one as it closed on his. It had to be Paul who held the chisel.

There was a shorter road, and I made myself set it in front of him before he could shut it in his own head. Cut the core of it only — the diagram, the six cycles, Ravar's hand and his own laid against it — and no more; leave the rest to Sarah's

copy in the world above; and Ka-Dhavar would bring him out through the wards a day clear of the reset, alive. He heard me to the end. He did not throw the rope back unlooked-at, and I have loved him since for the length of time he held it in his hand. “Her copy is in the world,” he said, “and the world loses things. It burns them, and buys them, and tidies them. The stone one is the copy still here when hers is gone, and it is read by one man, once, at the bottom of the worst day of his life, hunting a reason not to do again what was done to him. Leave it half-cut and I have handed the next Ravar the gaps to raise his wall in. It has to be whole. Whole is the eleven days, and the eleven days are the door shutting on me. That is not the machine choosing. It is me. Do not let anyone write it down, after, as the machine.” And no one unsaid it, and that was the debate.

I will not dress what he did as a martyrdom, because he refused, to the last, to let me, and I owe him the refusal. He was afraid, and said so, in the flat honest voice he had kept all week for true things: that he did not want to die in a cold room at the bottom of the world; that he had a life he had meant to go back to — a narrow flat full of books in a northern city, a nephew he had promised to teach to swim, a standing Thursday game of chess with Urs over a bottle they both pretended to like — the ordinary unfinished business of a man who had always assumed there would be more Thursdays. He consented to finish it whole, with the shorter road lying open in front of him to the very last, and he never once reached for it. He chose it with his eyes open and his fear in plain sight. “Someone stood in this room a hundred thousand years ago,” he said, “and sealed the truth away to keep a lie alive. I should like the last thing I do to be the exact opposite, in the same room. It is the cleanest thing I know how to do, and I have wanted, all my life, to do one clean thing.”

He worked eleven days at the end, with Sarah’s copy already made and boxed for the world above and only the Mountain’s own left to cut. I brought him food he mostly did not eat, and turned the pages of his own account back to him when his hands shook too badly to hold them. On the last day, when the offices came down to close the Archive, it was I who set my hands to the counterweight beside Ka-Dhavar, because Paul asked it of me. He had asked me once, in a house by a lake, to take him one day into the Mountain. I had sworn only that I would try, and had warned him that I could not answer for what the Mountain would do with an outsider who had seen its whole. It closed on him, the way it had always closed on any hand that held the whole. He put his hand flat against mine on the cold stone through the closing gap, the way Va-Sheva counts a living man. He was still afraid, and he did not pretend otherwise, and he said, “Get it to Sarah. All of

it. Do not let them tidy me out of it,” and then the stone met the stone, and the last outsider ever to see the whole of us was alone with it in the dark, finishing.

Here the hand that wrote this account changes, and I owe you the telling of it. Everything before this page is the account Paul made for the world — the one you are holding — assembled as he gathered it, in a room by a lake, a fact-checker asking a man he had been paid to disbelieve to describe a morning. He is sealed in the stone below now, finishing the Mountain’s own copy, and could not carry his own to its end; so the last of it falls to me. I set these pages down not for the Mountain, which keeps its record in the dark and will forget my hand into it, but for the outside — to go up, in time, by the road that has carried every other thing across that threshold, and be laid at the end of what he made, so the account he made for the world should have a true ending, and reach at last the one hand he asked me to put it in. But before that ending, and before the morning his account opens on, before any of it, on the first leaf, in Paul’s own hand, there is a dedication. It is not to me, and it is not to the Mountain. I did not understand the whole of it until I had watched Sarah carry the box up out of the folds and not once look back. It reads:

*To Sarah Blackwood.
 You entered because we could not keep you out.
 You leave because we have chosen to let you go.
 Between those two acts lies the peace of our kinds.*

She left as she had come: on animals, by a seam in the rock that is on no map, with a man of the sand walking ahead of her. But the first time the Mountain had opened because it could not keep her out; this time it opened because it had chosen to let her go. She did not thank us. She did not promise us anything. She was the enemy to the last. What she would do with the account in the world — guard it, spend it, hold it over the powers that had discarded her, sell the shape of her own legend with it — she did not say, and I did not ask. It was hers now, and we hung no condition on it, because we had all of us, at last, had enough of leashes.

The forest came back, and Sarah set it coming before she left. I did not see it; by the time it had risen I was long since sealed into the ordinary dark of the reset Mountain, turning wheels on the vents; but the ashkeepers charted it, season by season, at the high slots. It came slowly, and it came thin. Not the second year,

nor the fifth: it was years before the charts showed more than a grey-green stain creeping out of the poisoned ground of the Threshold, and longer still before there was anything a child would have called a tree. Poisoned ground gives back what it gives back grudgingly, and late. They had not come up out of nothing. On her way out of that desert Sarah had turned her oldest road to it: the buried water and the seed-caches she had spent a lifetime dropping across a country she once meant to own, and the guides of Amastan's line to open them and tend the ground season on season — the one road still moving after every state road and border and satellite had gone dark, and the one the enemy's rolled-up map had never held, because she had kept it off every ledger but her own. A dead desert brought quietly back to green and then left alone was the whole of what she asked of it, and she was patient enough, and hidden enough, and rich enough, to have it long after she herself was gone from the world. Faith read the greening and did what Faith is for. Faith stood beneath the gravure and told the people the promise was kept: that the wrath had passed, that God had remembered the forest and the rivers that were lost and made the desert withdraw, exactly as the Book had sworn He would in the day the Beast was chained again. And the people wept, and believed, and were not wrong to. The forest was real, and the mercy was real, and the only thing hidden from them was the shabby human shape of the hand that carried the seed. The hand was Sarah's; she set it moving on her way out and did not live to see most of what it raised. Whether that makes it any less God's is the one question the Mountain leaves where it leaves all the others it cannot afford to answer: open, in the dark, under a hymn.

I lost Va-Sheva, and I did not turn the losing into a doctrine, and I did not build a Mountain to house it, and I let her choice be the size it was. And I let the whole leave my hand. I had been made the eye that saw it. The offices were tired and grieving, and would have let me keep the seeing and become the one who understands, the necessary hand, the new Ravar with better intentions. I gave it away instead — to Sarah, for the world, and to Paul, for the stone — and kept for myself no more of it than any other Veil. Ravar could nearly have written that sentence; he wrote something like it, at the bottom, in the one door he left. The difference between us is only that I meant it, and that I had been shown, by a woman at a vent and a man at a valve, how it was done.

That difference is real, and I distrust the comfort I take in it. It changes what comes after me. Whatever I refused to become in the days since, I was the eye at the centre of the firing, the hand that read the phase and said the word that sent each

load down into the far side of the world. I broke the continuation. I did not break the crime. I broke the next turn of the wheel — the griever who makes himself the god — and left the ending itself exactly where it fell: Ravar's sixth, and mine.

And the Mountain reset, as it had reset five times before. Ending is the rule of this world, and the going-on is only its exception, granted seldom and kept never; five times the slate had been scoured to the rock, and five times something had crept back up out of the ash to write on it again, and forget the scouring, and take its brief turn for the whole of time. It is the order of things, and I had set my hand to the wheel and helped it come round once more. The offices went back down into their walls. Faith was vindicated. The machinery hid itself again, granting the fire and keeping, as it has always kept, the why and the who and the how-many. The Mountain emerged from its own catastrophe more certain of itself than it went in, exactly as it was built to. I watched it happen, and I let it, because five thousand people who have just survived the end of the world cannot be asked to survive the truth of it in the same season.

For the truth got out. Somewhere in the world above, in a house that noticed Sarah Blackwood's return, the complete account of us now exists, entire, in the open. And at the very centre of the Mountain, cut into the stone beside Ravar's confession, in a dead man's careful hand, it exists again, whole and true, waiting for the next one who fires the Beast and comes down the stair. He will find, where I found a jealous god's lie dressed as scripture, the actual size of the thing he has inherited, and Paul's plain witness beside it, and the knowledge that the design is a design and can be refused. I do not know whether it will be enough. Ravar built with terror because he judged truth the weaker mortar, and he may have been right. Perhaps the world above will forget us before it can do anything with what it holds. Perhaps the next heretic will read the whole of it and think *enough*, as I did, and let a little more light in; or perhaps he will read it and do what Ravar did, and build the wall higher. I will not be there. I have done the one thing that was mine to do, which was to make certain that he will have the choice, and know that it is one.

And the Pendulum swings again.

I have stood beneath it, in the reconsecrated Hall, among the kneeling people who take it for the face of God weighing the world, and watched the great disk cross, and turn, and cross, resuming over us the slow patient count it kept on the morning I was named, before I knew it was the beating heart of the clock beneath us, dressed as a prayer. It swings for the reasons it has always swung: because the machine lives, because the prison holds, because the Beast beneath us waits,

chained, for the sixth cycle to become the seventh. And it swings, this once, over a people one of whose number let the truth of it walk out the door into the world, so that the dark is no longer perfectly sealed, and a thing has changed that had never changed before.

Keep your distance. Live.

The Mountain.